

ANTON YASNITSKY AND RENÉ VAN DER VEER

**REVISIONIST
REVOLUTION
IN
VYGOTSKY
STUDIES**



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*Edited by Anton Yasnitsky and
René van der Veer*

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Gott ist tot.

Friedrich Nietzsche

Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image, or any likeness of any thing that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth. Thou shalt not bow down thyself to them, nor serve them ...

Exodus 20:4–5

Science is rooted in the will to truth. With the will to truth it stands or falls. Lower the standard even slightly and science becomes diseased at the core. Not only science, but man. The will to truth, pure and unadulterated, is among the essential conditions of his existence; if the standard is compromised he easily becomes a kind of tragic caricature of himself.

Max Wertheimer

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FOREWORD: HOW TO RECONSTRUCT DECONSTRUCTIONS

Alex Kozulin

The book in front of us is provocative, one may say deliberately provocative. The authors basically claim that almost all that we have read about Lev Vygotsky and his theory is a result of hero worshipping resulting in the cult of Vygotsky. The aim of the authors is to debunk this cult and weed out numerous historical and textual mistakes associated with the “Vygotskian narrative.” By pursuing this goal the authors turn their book into something not only provocative, but also potentially dangerous to themselves: their attempt to deconstruct the “Vygotskian narrative” could easily backfire. If Vygotskian theory is no more than the product of hero worshipping, then readers might start wondering what prompted the authors to spend practically their entire careers studying this theory instead of abandoning it altogether?

By now it should already be clear that by opening this book the reader enters a highly contested territory. As to how to proceed in such a territory, the best advice is to learn ... from the authors. As the authors do not take any historical fact, opinion, or connection for granted, then the reader should also read this book with a critical eye. Moreover, while the authors’ goal was to deconstruct the existing “Vygotskian narrative,” the reader may actually use this book to construct a Vygotskian narrative of their own on a higher conceptual level.

The main tool brought by the authors to the job of deconstructing the Vygotskian cult is a very rich and detailed social and ideological analysis of the relevant periods of Soviet history. The authors have identified and described the following factors of Soviet life as crucial for understanding the mechanics of Soviet academic life and its reflection in various texts: centralization and control, clique mentality, ritualism, the gap between theory and practice, intellectual isolationism, cultism, and hagiographies. By articulating these factors the authors have greatly enriched our understanding of the contexts in which Soviet psychologists, educators, and clinicians actually worked.

There is no doubt that the Soviet system was highly centralized, with central government in Moscow deciding practically every aspect of everyday life, economy, education, and science. The case of psychology, however, is a special one. While every reasonably big city in the Soviet Union had its own School of Medicine and Institute of Technology, thus providing a modicum of diversity, for practically the entire period described in this book there were only two places in Russia where psychology could be studied – Moscow and Leningrad (St. Petersburg). It is not surprising, therefore, that just by occupying the position of Head of the Department (or School) of Psychology at Moscow University, people like Sergei Rubinstein or Alexei Leontiev could exercise unprecedented control over the ways in which academic research was conducted and books or articles were selected for publication. The world of academic psychology was very small and as a result very crowded. In this congested academic environment each group of researchers felt almost by definition threatened by other groups. One may guess that the formation and maintenance of scientific cliques, vividly described by the authors, had a lot to do with this absence of academic “space.” The considerable gap between theory and practice, with psychology since the mid-1930s confined to the academic sphere, only added to this congestion.

Two additional aspects, intellectual isolationism and cultism, deserve a more detailed discussion. For quite obvious political reasons a free exchange of psychological ideas with Western colleagues was practically impossible during the Stalin era and often mortally dangerous for anyone attempting such a desperate action. In this sense, in the period from the mid-1930s to the mid-1950s, Soviet psychology was indeed intellectually isolated. It is also true that in the immediate post-World War II period, in parallel to a supreme cult of Stalin a system of lower-level cults was created, so that in each area of life a “great man” was selected as an emblematic representative of Russian science, art, industry, etc. For a while Ivan Pavlov was selected for such a role in the field of behavioral sciences. The question, however, remains to what extent this atmosphere of isolationism and cultism was relevant to Vygotskian hero worshipping, which definitely was not created in the 1940s.

The readers may engage in their own revisionist interpretation of the above factors. Such a “revision of revisionist history” may actually lead to a higher level of conceptual understanding. For example, it might be important to explore to what extent centralization and control in academic areas was rooted in a pattern of Russian intellectual life much older and deeper than “Stalinist science.” There are, very roughly, two opposite models of intellectual life – a centralized French model, with Paris and its universities serving as an uncontested intellectual center situated in close proximity to the state bureaucracy, and a decentralized German and American model that allowed first-rate universities and publishing houses to grow in small towns with much less connection to state bureaucracy. Even before the Communist Revolution Russia had adopted the French centralized model; Russian academic and intellectual life has always been concentrated in Moscow and St. Petersburg and depended on state bureaucracy. In this sense, “Stalinist science”

just strengthened the pre-existing model that apparently continues to dominate in Russia even after the fall of Communism.

In what concerns the existence of various warring clans and cliques within Soviet psychology, this phenomenon can be interpreted as an exaggerated version of a quite normal, one would even say positive phenomenon – the tradition of scientific schools. As one can speak about a school of Gestalt psychology, Freudian psychoanalysis, or Piagetian epistemology, it is possible to talk about the followers of Ivan Pavlov forming a school that was very different from that of Vladimir Bekhterev, or a school of Alexei Leontiev as distinct from that of Daniel Elkonin. Scientific schools, seen less and less nowadays, reflected not only the “mentor–novice” model of the transmission of knowledge, but also an intellectual commitment to a certain set of theoretical principles that should be defended against competing approaches. While positive in itself, this scientific school mentality could easily regress to clanishness when the only chance for a successful academic career is associated with the patronage of the powerful head of “your” school. The conflicting narratives of Soviet psychologists belonging to different schools or cliques sometimes create a very confusing picture. As demonstrated in Chapter 2, even during Vygotsky’s lifetime his “school” was far from monolithic. Later on different constellations of Vygotsky’s colleagues and students started forming their own separate groups. To an outside observer all these groups could appear to be “Vygotskian,” but this did not prevent them from competing with each other or presenting their own group as the only genuine followers of Vygotsky’s approach.

While deconstructing and reconstructing various conflicting narratives, the readers should keep in mind that many of these narratives remained unrecorded. Even in such “establishment” research groups as those of Alexander Luria or Daniel Elkonin, much of the discussion occurred during informal seminars conducted in the living-room or kitchen of their apartments and was never listed among the official university courses. The impact of these seminars on the next generation of scholars was very significant, but only a fraction of the discussions later appeared in print and often in a form highly distorted by the authors’ self-censorship. One may thus speak about two coexistent intellectual traditions: The written one embodied in the official corpus of texts that appeared in the journal *Voprosy Psikhologii* (Problems of Psychology) and various psychology monographs, and the oral one, based on informal seminars conducted by various research groups. Sometimes the gap between these two streams was so wide that one could easily imagine them taking place in two different countries. Many of the informal seminars were based on materials (foreign books, old articles, current research protocols) available only to the group leader and unavailable in any library.

In addition to the intricacies of Soviet intellectual life, the authors provide us with an informative case study of the relationships between Vygotskians and their Western colleagues; more specifically with the school of Gestalt psychology. German Gestalt psychologist Kurt Koffka was not only knowledgeable about the work of the Vygotsky–Luria group, but actually participated in their expedition to Central Asia in the early 1930s. From the material presented in Chapter 8 it

becomes clear that the Vygotskians and Koffka sought and found very different results in this expedition. Koffka, who adhered to the main theoretical premises of the Gestalt school, was interested in discovering the universal principles of human perception. For him, the expedition to Central Asia provided an opportunity to identify those elements of perception that are not affected by cultural differences. The goal of the Vygotsky–Luria group was very different. They wanted to use the unique situation in Central Asia as a basis for a “quasi-historical” experiment. They reasoned that people of the same ethnic origin and initial lifestyle may display cognitive processes characteristic of different historical periods depending on their current status – either still preserving a traditional lifestyle and pre-literate culture, or already being involved in more modern occupations and lifestyle, or not only acquiring modern occupation but also receiving a formal education via the literacy courses for adults. The study included a broad range of cognitive processes, perception being just one of them. Koffka focused specifically on the case of visual illusions and claimed that the majority of participants, irrespective of their current occupational and educational status, demonstrate such illusions that confirm Gestalt claims of the universality of some perceptual patterns. The Vygotsky–Luria group evaluated the entire range of cognitive functions and concluded that occupational and educational status is decisive in shaping cognitive processes, including in some cases visual illusions. The above story, if properly reconstructed, may lead us beyond the question of the relationships between the Gestalt school and Vygotskians and show how “the same” findings acquire a very different meaning depending on the overall theoretical perspective of various researchers.

Readers will also benefit from a detailed discussion about the publication and translation problems associated with Vygotsky’s texts. One may identify three types of such problems: the first is related to the fact that even during his lifetime Vygotsky was unable or unwilling to publish some of his major works, such as his book *Psychology of art*. As a result, even though these works were published later, we will never know if they appeared in the form that their author wished. In the posthumous publications organized by Vygotsky’s followers, various of Vygotsky’s texts were “glued” together, sometimes certain portions of the text or references were deleted, and sometimes the texts were “adjusted,” apparently for easier understanding by the reader. The last point becomes crucial when translations are considered, and this is a second problem. Vygotsky’s texts are not easy even in Russian, and they definitely do not render themselves easier in translation. As mentioned elsewhere in this book, German Gestalt psychologists who immigrated to the USA in the 1930s were quite aware that the American audience was not ready for their theoretical discourse as it was formulated in German. So they “adjusted” this discourse in the English texts prepared for their new audience. It is not surprising, therefore, that American followers of Vygotsky also considered it necessary to “adjust” his discourse to what they considered acceptable to readers at that time (the 1960s and 1970s). The third, and much deeper, problem that leads us beyond the Vygotskian story is the fact that in the age of Google Translate we tend to forget that there is a considerable gap between the

semantic fields of different languages. When Vygotsky wrote about “obuchenie” (learning/teaching) his Russian readers placed this concept in a very different semantic and associative field than either “teaching” or “learning” conjured in the mind of a native English-speaker. So, in this sense, only complete bilingualists may have an opportunity to understand with some certainty what Vygotsky had in mind when he wrote about “smysl” and what Bruner understood when he commented about Vygotsky’s use of the concept of “sense.”

So, when the reader closes this book I hope they may feel that not everything has been “lost in translation” and that there is much more to Vygotsky’s theory than “hero worshipping” or the clannishness of his followers. The reader of this book holds some very rich material, including some only recently uncovered archival documents; what the reader may do with this material is to go beyond deconstruction and construct their own Vygotskian narratives.

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PART I

Contexts and people

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1

THE ARCHETYPE OF SOVIET PSYCHOLOGY

From the Stalinism of the 1930s to the
“Stalinist science” of our time

Anton Yasnitsky

Russian psychology emerged against the rich philosophical, artistic, and scientific background of Russian culture of the *fin de siècle* and was institutionalized as a scientific discipline virtually at the same time as academic psychology took root in the West. Yet, in the first decades of its development psychology in Russia can be best described as a more or less successful adaptation of Western tradition. Perhaps the only original contribution of Russian scholars to international psychological scholarship was their teaching on the “conditional reflexes” that was developed by two major research groups associated with Ivan Pavlov and Vladimir Bekhterev. The state of the art in psychology in Imperial Russia (i.e. before 1917) is, perhaps, best understood within a continuum between two extremes that do not belong to the domain of scientific research proper, yet largely determine its existence in the concrete historical, social, and cultural context. The two extremes are, on the one hand, philosophy, and, on the other hand, human industry, broadly understood as a range of social activities geared towards the attainment of material gains. Given that psychology as a scientific discipline is the inseparable unity of theory and empirical studies – laboratory-experimental (*in vitro*) and applied (*in vivo*) – the continuum can be structured into several strata that may be represented as “philosophy – general psychological theory – empirical research – social practice” (see Table 1.1).

Psychology in late Imperial Russia manifested itself as three fairly distinct disciplines and related kinds of social agency.

First: Speculative academic psychology, typically based in university departments of philosophy and extremely critical towards any empirical psychology whatsoever. In fact, despite proclaimed interest in “psychology” the advocates of this approach were professional philosophers or philosophizing intellectuals in a wide range of other intellectual/practical spheres from social and human sciences to non-scientific enterprises such as the arts, theology, or psychiatric practice.

TABLE 1.1 Structural components of a scientific discipline in social context

1. Philosophy				
2. General (psychological) theory				
3. Empirical research:				
• laboratory-experimental		• applied		
4. Human industry and social practice:				
• medicine and health care	• education and child-rearing	• industry proper and labor	• military affairs and defense	• propaganda and public relations

Second: Empirical psychology that widely used the methods of laboratory experiment of a natural-scientific type for the investigation of the so-called “lower” psychological processes and at the same time frequently allowed for theoretical speculations on explanations of the “higher” psychological processes and phenomena – the “spiritual,” superindividual, cultural, or naturally organismic ones – that the advocates of this approach did not believe are accessible by the methods of “purely scientific,” positivist quantitative research. Therefore, the two typical frameworks for these speculations were vitalism or spiritualism that postulated the primacy of “life” and “spirit” as fundamental explanatory principles of these theories.

Third: Applied psychology that primarily aimed at solving practical tasks outside the academic domain proper and was directly related to social practices, predominantly in the spheres of education and health care. Occasionally, the representatives of this strand could occupy university chairs and be involved in traditional academia, but regardless of their possible participation in theoretical discussions and laboratory studies, their definite priority was transformative agency in some segment or another of social practice.

Therefore, although Russian psychology on the threshold of 1917 seems to have been well represented by a few intellectuals in a wide range of national institutions and organizations, in fact there were very fragmented and often rival psychologies of three types, not to mention competitive groupings, cliques, and clans within each of these types. The gap between the three “psychologies” was enormous and required a truly revolutionary shift in the professional consciousness, self-identity, and social practice of psychologists. Russian psychology as a unified scientific discipline with original conceptions and innovative methods for their implementation owes virtually all its achievements to the Soviet era and, primarily, to the turbulent period of the 1920s–1930s, when the foundations of “Soviet psychology” as we know it today were laid.

Psychoneurological disciplines in the Soviet Union in the 1920s

The revolutions in February and October of 1917 dramatically changed the entire structure of Russian society and gave access to power, administration, and social advancement to large sections of the population of the country, such as the Jewish

minority in the Russian Empire, who had fairly limited opportunities for education or state-funded positions before the October uprising and the Bolsheviks' ascent to power. Quite characteristic in this respect are the careers of Lev Vygotsky and Alexander Luria, for whom access to university education before the revolution would mean the need to overcome the 3 percent Jewish quota and, furthermore, the random ballot during the candidate selection process, in contrast to the open and freely available governmental positions of various kinds possible after the Bolshevik revolution. Bolsheviks had a high regard for science and technology as the vehicles of social modernization and progressive transformation of national industry and the economy (Kojevnikov, 2004; Krementsov, 1997). Besides, the issue of official recognition of the USSR was one of the national priorities of the new state, and the impact of "cultural diplomacy" – including international scientific exchange – on the reputation of the country and propaganda for the Soviet project of radical social transformation can hardly be overestimated (David-Fox, 2012). The example of the only Russian Nobel Prize winner as of 1917, Ivan Pavlov, is quite telling: not only did the Bolsheviks persuade him not to leave the country after the revolution, they also provided him with favorable conditions for living and working that eventually turned him from profound criticism of the new regime to moderately enthusiastic support for Bolshevik rule (Todes, 1995, 2014).

The decade of the 1920s can without any exaggeration be described as a period of intensive growth – even flourishing – for Russian psychology. It was then that the new generation of young intellectuals and activists emerged, inspired by Nietzschean ideas of radical revaluation of the entire social structure including the promise of a new science of man and its decisive role in revolutionary transformation of the world. Thus, one of the key tasks of the post-revolutionary era was utopian "remolding of man," the creation of a new type of people, who will master their nature and uncover the yet unknown potential of human beings.¹ These ideas were grounded in the pervasive post-revolutionary belief in the possibility of virtually unlimited personal growth and an active, creative attitude to the world. This is why the public discourse of Soviet science, fiction, and media often returns to the topics of the specifically human characteristics that distinguish *homo sapiens* from other species, the nature of humans and the ways to overcome it, and the specific non-natural, i.e. cultural, laws of human development that are not inherited and genetically predetermined, but are formed by means of society, art, and culture.

By the mid-1920s a four-level structure of the social organization of Soviet psychology and allied sciences formed. This structure tied together philosophy and practice and comprised: (1) Marxist philosophy and dialectical materialism as the philosophical foundation of general psychology; (2) general psychology as a high-level scientific theory; (3) applied psychological disciplines (for instance, pedology or psychotechnics, roughly equivalent to child studies and industrial and vocational psychology, respectively); and (4) social institutes and practices (medicine, education, industry, etc.) (see Table 1.2; for convenience experimental psychology of the laboratory type is not represented). Some of these theoretical and applied disciplines originated in the West and were imported by Russian scholars

TABLE 1.2 Disciplines of Soviet psychology in the 1920s

Philosophy				
General (psychological) theory:				
psychology, reflexology, reactology				
Applied empirical studies:				
psychotherapy, defectology, pedology, psychohygiene, psychotechnics				
Human industry and social practice:				
• medicine and health care	• education and child-rearing	• industry proper and labor	• military affairs and defense	• propaganda and public relations

and practitioners from abroad before the Bolshevik revolution of 1917, primarily from Western Europe and North America. These include *pedology* (alternatively, referred to as “pedagogical psychology” or “experimental pedagogy”), *psychotechnics*, *psychotherapy*, and *psychohygiene* (in North America known as *mental hygiene*).² On the other hand, a few original Soviet disciplinary “brands” were created such as the *reflexology* of V. M. Bekhterev (originally, Bekhterev’s “objective psychology” of the pre-revolutionary period that, at its creator’s insistence, radically departed from the original and quickly changed its “brand-name” after the Bolshevik revolution) (Bekhterev, 1925, 1933). Other examples are K. N. Kornilov’s *reactology* and *defectology*, understood as a complex scientific-practical agency towards overcoming children’s “defectiveness”: physical, mental and psychological, and social alike.

According to the Bolsheviks’ requirement of the *practicality* of science, it was practice that would become the criterion of truth and usefulness – quite in agreement with the postulates of *Marxism*, which, in fact, was the second of the Bolsheviks’ requirements of science. Indeed, the requirement of practicality could be interpreted as a direct challenge to philosophy’s ambition to provide a theoretical viewpoint, yet it was certainly an extension of Marx’s ideas on the role of philosophy in the radical and revolutionary transformation of the world as opposed to its traditional understanding as a purely theoretical and speculative enterprise. The role psychology was to play in this social transformation was very special and highly important. Psychology was to find the means for the normative remolding of the “old man” of the capitalist past and educating the “new man” of Communism. These methods would be subsequently implemented in large-scale social projects and would lead to the creation of the improved and advanced people of the future. These utopian and idealistic plans were also supported by most immediate and utterly practical goals of concrete social reality. The country was recovering after the Civil War (1918–22) and the actual tasks of the day were to modernize the national – predominantly agricultural – economy, overcome child homelessness and illiteracy, reanimate the system of schools and higher education, reform health care, and provide professional reorientation and training to thousands of new workers.³ Therefore, it was not abstract, theoretical interest, but the urgent demands of social practice that determined the rapid development of applied psychoneurological disciplines grounded in the actual concrete tasks of the establishment of a new society.

The agency of the Soviet psychologists in the 1920s, therefore, was not confined within the borders of psychology as an isolated discipline. Lavishly supported by the Bolshevik leadership, work was done on creating a pragmatic interdisciplinary synthesis of scientific-practical interventions and a higher-level theoretical paradigm that would encompass all human sciences and bring about a universal framework in which disciplines at different levels and from various spheres of application would work together as a complex, based on a shared methodological and philosophical foundation. The development of all these disciplines and social movements was rooted in a wide range of scientific societies and civil organizations. Hundreds of new research institutes were founded in the 1920s. In 1928 a few new scientific journals were launched such as *Psychotechnics* and *Psychophysiology of Labor* (in 1932 renamed *Soviet Psychotechnics*), *Psychology*, *Pedology*, and *Problems of Defectology*.

As a result of all these social transformations, a range of new scientific schools and research groups in human sciences emerged in the Soviet Union by the end of the 1920s. Soviet psychology triumphantly entered international psychological science at the IX International Congress of Psychology held at Yale University in early September, 1929, where Soviet scholars were represented by a record-breaking third largest non-American delegation (after those of Great Britain and Germany). This scientific event was followed by major international congresses held in the Soviet Union – the VII International Congress of Applied Psychology, or Psychotechnics, (Moscow, 1931) and the XV International Physiological Congress (Leningrad and Moscow, 1935) – that solidified the success of Soviet human and biomedical sciences. Characteristically, Carl Murchison's *Psychologies of 1930* for the first time contained a whole new section titled "Russian Psychologies," which included three chapters that featured Ivan Pavlov's theory of higher nervous activity (Pavlov, 1930),⁴ Vladimir Bekhterev's *reflexology* (Schniermann, 1930), and the "dialectical-materialist psychology" of Konstantin Kornilov (Kornilov, 1930). These were accompanied by a number of translated publications of Soviet scholars that came out in the West mostly in the second half of the 1920s and first half of 1930s.⁵

Subsequently, a number of Western scholars visited the Soviet Union in order to familiarize themselves with the state of the art in contemporary Soviet psychology. These trips were reflected in a series of Western publications that present a relatively mixed, but generally quite favorable image of the success of the Soviet project in the field of the human sciences, including psychology.⁶

Soviet psychology as a "Stalinist science" from the 1930s to our time

The end of the 1920s in the Soviet Union saw the start of major social, economic, and cultural transformations that the leader of the country, Joseph Stalin, characterized as the "Great Break" (*Velikii Perelom*). The literature on Stalin's Great Break and its impact on virtually all spheres of social life in the USSR is enormous,⁷ but in the context of this discussion we are primarily interested in its effect on science

and particularly on the psychological and allied sciences. For our current purposes it suffices to point out that as a consequence of the “Great Break” and the accompanying social processes a new model of science and, furthermore, the model of the interrelations between science, the state, and the ruling Communist Party was established in the Soviet Union by the end of the 1930s. The reader is thus directed to the classic book by Nikolai Krementsov that provides an excellent and seemingly exhaustive discussion of the topic that the author referred to as “Stalinist science” (Krementsov, 1997). The phrase does not appear unquestionable and is used here interchangeably with another phrase with essentially the same meaning: the “Stalinist model” of science. While Krementsov’s book will provide a rich source of thought-provoking input to the interested reader, several points need to be clarified and explicated here in order to shed some light on the nature of the tectonic shift of this period and those specific changes that Soviet science had to undergo in its transformation in agreement with the “Stalinist model.”

First: The rationale of the Great Break as it is related to scientific research and national science is perhaps best understood as the Party and state demand for the accountability of all subordinate structures of society, which primarily required establishing control over these structures and social institutes. Indeed, as far as the social and human sciences are concerned, the preceding decade of the 1920s is characterized by the state-sponsored but relatively free establishment and proliferation of numerous revolutionary and experimental projects in science and social practice. In contrast, the decade of the 1930s was characterized by the introduction of planning in virtually all spheres of social life, primarily the economy of the Soviet Union, now to develop according to a series of Five-Year Plans. Therefore, the whole rhythm of social life changed during this decade, and even scholars were now to create their annual plans of research and submit them for inspection to the supervisory agencies. Another consequence of the major transformation as it is directly related to the psychological and allied sciences was the beginning of the process of inter-disciplinary struggle for survival under the scrutiny of the organs of state and Party control. Indeed, as it turned out by the beginning of the 1930s, quite a few of the new scientific disciplines of the post-revolutionary era of the 1920s considerably overlapped in their topics, theories, and methods of research and were more often than not represented by pretty much the same set of spokesmen and activists. A characteristic example of such overlap would be the interplay between such disciplines as *psychology*, *pedology*, *psychotechnics*, and *defectology* that appeared to represent just different faces of the same entity. For fairly obvious reasons such inexplicable fragmentation could by no means satisfy the administrators who were appointed to supervise the progress of scientific research in the Soviet Union in the early 1930s.

Second: The decade of the 1930s and the overarching “Stalinist model” of science gave birth to a number of specific rituals that, according to a new social contract, were understood and followed by all parties involved as the new system of communications between science and its only grant-making agency in the Soviet Union – the state and its supreme guiding force, the Communist Party of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics. The rituals can be divided into closely

interrelated behavioral and rhetorical ones and included a number of techniques and performances such as celebrating a wide range of jubilees and reporting progress on achievements on these occasions, writing letters to the leaders of the state, public discussions, including public criticism and self-criticism, and many others. In the sphere of ritualistic discursive practices the most notable examples include the penetration of the political newspeak of the Bolshevik fashion in the oral and written discourse of Soviet science to the extent of the virtually total disappearance of the difference between the two, and the emergence of the standard of “nomadic quotes” and mandatory references that would typically be expected on the very first pages of publications as a token of loyalty and alignment with the goals of the sponsors of science and, at the same time, the political leadership of the state.

Third: As a result of all these transformations of the decade of the 1930s a new model of national science, the “Stalinist model,” is best described as the hybrid of state, Party, and science, according to which the borderline between the three entities in most instances was extremely blurred and hardly distinguishable. The main technology and the instrument of this merger was the custom of *nomenklatura* appointments described at considerable length in the classic book by Voslensky (1984) and succinctly discussed in its relation to Soviet science by Kremontsov:

The main instrument of party personnel policy in general was the system of *nomenklatura*. *Nomenklatura* was, literally, a list of posts that could not be occupied or vacated without permission from the appropriate party committee. All party committees, from the Central Committee to the smallest one in the countryside, established personnel departments, whose main function was to approve candidates for appointment to any post included in their own *nomenklatura*. Initially devised for the personnel of party organs and agencies, the system was expanded in the early 1930s into the scientific community. The *nomenklatura* system was strictly hierarchical – the higher the post, the higher the party committee controlling its personnel. The posts of president, vice-president, and scientific secretary of such central institutions as the USSR Academy of Sciences and VASKhNIL were in the *nomenklatura* of the Politburo. The posts of institute director and editor-in-chief of a journal were in the *nomenklatura* of the Central Committee Secretariat. The position of laboratory head belonged to the *nomenklatura* of the regional party committee. Even the post of librarian in a scientific institute was in the *nomenklatura* of the local party committee.

(Kremontsov, 1997, pp. 40–41)

Therefore, here the loop closes: The custom of *nomenklatura* was, on the one hand, the main and apparently the most efficient instrument of the top-down Party-state control over science, and, on the other hand, inevitably dictated the necessity and utmost importance of rituals for the bottom-up processes that allowed scholars to manipulate their bosses in the government and utilize their goals and aspirations – as distant from their personal, career, and research goals as they might have been – in

order to benefit from the ever-changing agenda of the increasingly authoritarian supervisory agencies in power.

As a result of numerous and somewhat chaotic processes in the turbulent 1930s, by the middle of the decade the understanding had developed in the leadership of the country that the multitude of “revolutionary” disciplines in the human sciences was fairly redundant and, therefore, had to be reduced in favor of a few – apparently the most conventional – disciplines and related social practices. It seems that among the most important criteria that played the decisive role in making the decision was the discipline’s representation and recognition at the international level and Soviet scholars’ participation in similar international societies, associations, publications, etc. of the kind that would bear exactly the same name as the one Soviet spokesmen for their discipline would advocate. It appears that on close inspection there was but one scientific discipline that would stand any possible criticism from this perspective, whereas the rest of the disciplinary newcomers of the post-revolutionary era had to go and to give way to more conventional projects, i.e. more traditional and well-established in international scholarly networks. Thus, as a result of natural selection and the disciplinary purge of the 1930s all those fashionable disciplinary projects of the 1920s such as *pedology*, *psychotechnics*, *defectology*, *reactology*, *reflexology*, and the like were to unconditionally merge with the traditional disciplines and social practices. The social practices that benefitted from this merger were primarily education (and the directly related “science of pedagogy”) and medicine, encompassing former defectologists, psychotherapists, psychohygienists, and some pedologists (i.e. typically those professionals who originally had a medical education or were inclined to get re-educated, like, for instance, both Vygotsky and Luria). As for the winner in the inter-disciplinary struggle for survival – the winner was ... psychology, perfectly forged in the late 1930s along with the “Stalinist model” in the making. Thus, after a brief interruption of most social activities caused by another of Stalin’s social projects of the 1930s – the Stalinist Great Terror of 1936–8 that considerably confused the system of the interrelationship within informal personal networks of Soviet scholars and their Party/state bosses and patrons, some of them outlawed and persecuted in purges – Soviet psychology re-emerged as one of the leading human sciences that was seemingly supposed to be the bridge that would provide the link between inevitably overly abstract and essentially speculative philosophy and the “real” empirical sciences and social practices related to humans and their activities in concrete social-historical contexts. As a result, it turns out that by the end of the 1930s the multitude and diversity of theories, disciplines, and approaches dramatically decreased and the dominant model of the 1920s that included four levels within the continuum “philosophy–general (psychological) theory–applied sciences–social practices” was reduced to two level hybrids, namely, the hybrid of “philosophy–general psychological theory” and, on the other hand, “applied psychologies–social practices,” which in effect meant total failure to bridge the gap between theory and practice and a return to the age-old problems of the late Imperial period of psychology’s development. Thus, in other words, theoretical psychology remained speculative and hardly usable in empirical research, whereas

TABLE 1.3 The structure of psychoneurological and human sciences in the USSR in the 1920s and 1930s

<i>1920s: four levels of human sciences</i>	<i>End of 1930s: two hybrid levels of psychological sciences</i>
1. Marxist philosophy	
2. General sciences	1. Marxist philosophy and general science
3. Applied sciences	2. Social practice and applied sciences
4. Social practices	

applied studies returned to the original pre-revolutionary state of being fully subordinated to practice and virtually fully isolated from any theoretical thinking whatsoever. For an illustration of this situation see Table 1.3.

In sum, the start of the great disciplinary cleansing was announced in 1936 with the publication of the Communist Party's notorious "pedological decree" that in effect banned or considerably limited the area of application of a number of revolutionary projects of the preceding decade. Thus, Soviet psychology as the main winner of the fight was forged in 1936. This was followed by a series of other important achievements that included a range of officially endorsed textbooks in psychology that came out in 1938–41, the establishment of the Institutes of Psychology in Soviet Georgia (under the auspices of the Academy of Sciences of GSSR, in 1941) and in Soviet Ukraine (in 1945), important and most prestigious national scientific awards granted to psychologists (e.g. the award to S. L. Rubinstein of the Stalin Prize in 1941), and first appointments of psychologists to the top of the social scientific hierarchy, the Academy of Sciences of the USSR (Rubinstein and Kravkov as Corresponding Members, in the 1940s). Finally, the last stroke was to follow: In 1946 psychology was introduced in public school curricula as a mandatory subject to be taught all over the Soviet Union. This event logically concludes the ten-year period that can be legitimately referred as the Golden Age of Soviet Psychology of 1936–46.

Yet, the last phase of the formation of the discipline of Soviet psychology according to the "Stalinist model" followed in the late 1940s/early 1950s with the evolution of this model as such. Following the notorious "Lysenko trials" (1948) and the subsequent "Pavlovization" of the humanities (from 1950) and in relation to other infamous political campaigns of late Stalinism such as the "doctors' trials," the xenophobic search for national roots and Russian priority in virtually all spheres of human activity or the anti-Semitic fight against "rootless cosmopolitanism," Soviet psychology eventually took its shape as a "Stalinist science," conceived as such in the late 1930s and solidified in the early 1950s. Incidentally, it was virtually at this very time that the two first Departments of Psychology were founded in Moscow and Leningrad (in 1943–4) that started preparing new cadres for the new discipline, and their exclusive monopoly in the professional reproduction of specialists in this field would be preserved for several decades to come. Thus, the first wave of Candidate

of Sciences dissertations was defended right during late Stalinism's outbreak of neo-imperial nationalism and xenophobia, anti-Semitic campaigns, and extreme isolationism. All these factors, it seems, were to play a crucial role in the subsequent fate of the entire discipline in the country. The reason for that is pretty clear: it was this generation – who entered university in the second half of the 1940s, graduated and then wrote and defended their scholarly dissertations by the mid-1950s – that fully assimilated the “Stalinist model”: they were brought up in it, and massively implemented it when they finally came to power in the scientific administration of psychology in the USSR as a result of demographic processes and the change of generations. Thus, it makes perfect sense to talk about two generations of Soviet psychologists and dramatic differences between the two. Let us first focus on the older generation of scholars and scientific administrators of psychology.

Despite numerous differences between all these people, at a certain high level of generalization a number of similarities between them can be discerned. These similar features, then, can be put together in order to make up a vague and pretty impersonal “cumulative portrait” of this generation. Thus, the representative of this group of scholars was typically born into a university-educated family within the intelligentsia and was educated in traditional *gimnazia* in pre-revolutionary time, and therefore had a pretty good knowledge of at least two foreign languages, French and German; this was followed by university education in one of the Russian universities in Moscow, St. Petersburg (renamed Petrograd during World War I), Kazan', or abroad, most typically in Germany. The group of the representatives of this generation, thus, was born, roughly, in the 1890s, brought up in the classical intellectual and cultural traditions of late Imperial Russia; they enthusiastically took part in the Bolshevik project of radical social transformation and successfully passed through cleansings and post-Revolutionary “social selection” of various sorts.

This generation of intellectuals remained for a while in the somewhat ambiguous position of Bolshevik sympathizers, and at the same time as representatives of the older – politically suspect and presumably disloyal – pre-Revolutionary intelligentsia of the “bourgeois” cultural tradition. The crucial turn took place in 1936 that inaugurated the birth of a distinctly Soviet intelligentsia:

In one of many drastic reversals of the Stalin period, a social category that had been relegated to the dustbin of history experienced an unexpected revival. In 1936, the dictator declared that a reformed and loyal “toiling intelligentsia” had emerged, a “stratum” (*prosloika*) with a rightful place in socialist society alongside the workers and collective farmers. While perhaps dubious in its Marxist credentials, Stalin's re-establishment of intelligentsia as a social category was both constitutive and reflective of the social system that took shape in the 1930s. By legitimizing the place of educated professionals under socialism in doctrinal terms, Stalin's “toiling intelligentsia” signaled a wider integration of educated elites in the Soviet order ... Just as importantly, the “toiling intelligentsia” provided the possibility of rehabilitation to the remaining representatives of the pre-revolutionary educated stratum, people who

had been considered class enemies or marginalized as “bourgeois specialists” in the preceding years. Of course, such assimilation came at a price: the Stalinist system made professional thinkers of all sorts more dependent on state power and agendas than ever before. Relentless demands from above for unquestioning service and “party-mindedness” accompanied state-employed intellectuals’ newfound prominence and (relative) social privilege. Indeed, the very construct of the “toiling intelligentsia” underscored intellectuals’ reliance on serving the state, as it defined membership in the group according to formal educational achievement and occupational criteria (the performance of “mental labor”), both of which the party-state monopolized.

(Tomly, 2014, pp. 4–5)

Subsequently, the small circle of the “chosen ones” of the “generation of the 1890s” occupied all the highest positions in the scientific administration of Soviet psychology in the 1940s, when psychology as a scientific discipline got access to the top of the scientific hierarchy: the Academy of Sciences of the USSR. It should be noted, though, that, according to the “Stalinist model” of science, virtually all administrative power and control over national psychology in the 1940s was in the hands of one person, Sergei Leonidovich Rubinstein (1889–1960), the first psychologist elected as a Corresponding Member of the Academy of Sciences, the first psychologist awarded the Stalin Prize, and who simultaneously occupied positions as Director of the Institute of Psychology in Moscow (in 1942–5), Head of the Department of Psychology at Moscow State University (1943–9), and Head of the Sector of Psychology and Deputy Director of the Institute of Philosophy under the auspices of the Academy of Sciences of the USSR (1945–9). The tumultuous social processes of late Stalinism undermined Rubinstein’s unquestionable authority and brought his power to an end: in 1949 Rubinstein, like many other Jews in the Soviet Union at that time, turned out to be a “rootless cosmopolitan” and was released from all his supervisory and administrative positions. And yet, the high concentration of power and influence within a narrow circle of individuals – highly characteristic of the “Stalinist model” – was preserved even after Rubinstein’s demise. Thus, for instance, the renowned Swiss psychologist Jean Piaget, who visited the Soviet Union in the mid-1950s, immediately after the visit published a report of the trip, where he reminisced about his meetings with the “Great Five” that comprised official top-rank Soviet scholars Rubinstein, Teplov, Smirnov, Leontiev, and Luria (Piaget, 1956), of whom, according to anecdotal evidence from another source, only Teplov and Smirnov had real power throughout the 1950s, at least (Shchedrovitskii, 2001). Piaget, who personally met these academicians – all these the representatives of the “generation of the 1890s” – recalled the nice and free exchanges they had had in his native French during his trip to Moscow and was apparently impressed by the fairly Western manners of his Soviet peers and their familiarity with recent trends in international psychological science. The sharper and more striking contrast is between these representatives of the “generation of the 1890s” and the new generation of their students and followers, the psychologists of the next generation

to come and reign. Despite the vulnerability of such a generalization, let us sketch another “group portrait”: that of the representative of the “new generation.”

The representative of the “new generation” of Soviet psychologists is a person who was born within the period of, roughly, the second half of the 1920s/first half of the 1930s. The childhood of this individual took place at the time of early Stalinism, and he received his high-school education during World War II, not unusually, in remote eastern areas of the Soviet Union, far from the front line, where families were relocated during the war. Unlike the “generation of the 1890s,” who were typically educated in classical, elitist, German-style gymnasiums of the late Imperial tradition, the representatives of the “new generation” spent their high-school years in a fairly “democratic” and “affirmative-action” Soviet educational system. Furthermore, the wartime period was characterized by deprivation and continuous disruption of the learning process caused by the lack of qualified – especially male – teachers, the relatively low status of school studies during the war, and particularly the poor quality of foreign-language instruction. Then, these individuals obtained their university education in the post-World War II period, when their undergraduate and graduate studies typically coincided with the social processes of late Stalinism, characterized by a distinctly neo-imperial, xenophobic, Russian nationalist, anti-Semitic, demonstratively patriotic, and, to large extent, isolationist rhetoric that in more or less apparent forms continued throughout the entire decade of the 1950s. The representative of the “new generation” of Soviet psychologists would typically receive a university education at one of the two existing departments of psychology (in Moscow or in Leningrad). The person normally graduated in 1950s, often joined the Communist Party of the Soviet Union at the end of the 1950s/early 1960s, defended Candidate and then Doctoral dissertations in the 1950s–1970s, and made a fairly successful scientific career. To a certain degree this description fits quite a few representatives of the “new generation,” some of whom were to replace their teachers and predecessors of the pre-revolutionary generation in the administrative leadership of their discipline. The new group of academic bosses eventually came to power and got control over virtually the entire discipline of psychology – if not in the whole multi-national country, then definitely in its largest part, the Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic (RSFSR). Quite in line with the requirements of the “Stalinist model” the circle of the new leaders is quite limited, and does not exceed a dozen names of varying importance.

It was this generation, whose formative years passed during the period of Stalinism of the 1930s–1950s, that gradually occupied all key positions of power and authority, their most triumphant achievement being, in 1971, the establishment of the Institute of Psychology at the Academy of Sciences of the Soviet Union under the leadership of its founder and director Boris Fedorovich Lomov (1927–89) and his associates. This “new generation” – that came to power in the 1960s–1970s and remained in control over the course of development of Soviet psychology until the early 2000s – was to ultimately accomplish the “archetype of Soviet psychology,” in other words to implement the “Stalinist model” of psychological science in a wide range of educational establishments, research institutions, and social practices

throughout the entire country – long after the mastermind of this model, the “Great Leader and Teacher” Joseph Stalin, had died.

Interestingly, Stephen Toulmin in his famous article of 1978 on the scientific legacy of Vygotsky and Luria, characteristically titled “The Mozart of psychology,” also mentions the “generation gap” of some twenty years between 1935 and 1955 and points out the profound negative effect this gap had on the development of psychology in the Soviet Union in general, and, specifically, on Vygotsky’s legacy in the Soviet Union. In particular, Toulmin argues that despite the fact that “half a dozen of his students survived the Second World War, and took up important positions after it”, still, because of this very “gap” that was filled with psychological studies of a reductionist kind:

In fact, some informed American observers consider that his ideas are likely to be developed and exploited more effectively in the US during the years ahead – by such people as John Flavell of Stanford and Ann Brown of the University of Illinois – than in the Soviet Union. By some intellectual version of Gresham’s Law, just as Western psychology is beginning to escape from its earlier positivism, Russian academic psychology is, ironically, beginning to look more like the American experimental psychology of the intervening forty years!

(Toulmin, 1978)

The gap between the two scholarly cultures and traditions in Soviet psychology – as it was realized in the scientific work of the two generations of the 1890s and the 1920s – is as conspicuous as it is detrimental. Furthermore, there is every reason to believe that many – virtually all – idiosyncratic characteristics of the “archetype of Soviet psychology” have been preserved in the group mentality and, thus, social behaviors of contemporary Russian psychologists, the self-proclaimed heirs of the “great,” “unique,” and “self-sufficient” Russian psychology.

Archetype of contemporary Russian psychology (1990s–2010s): a sketch for a portrait

We have got used to thinking about the so-called Soviet *shestidesiatniki* – despite the considerable vagueness and imprecision of this expression – as the representatives of the Soviet scientific-engineering and artistic-humanities intelligentsia socially active in the 1960s and onwards and charged with the ideas of social transformation, modernization, and progress. Recent studies in the culture and tradition of the Soviet Union of the twentieth century tend to interpret the ideology of this group within the Soviet intelligentsia of the 1960s as being rooted in the early Soviet, so to say, “pre-Stalinist” period of the 1920s that served them as the source for cultural self-identification as the spiritual heirs of the utopian romanticism of the post-revolutionary era. No doubt, there were many individuals among the Soviet psychologists of the “new generation” of the 1960s who would perfectly fit this

description. And yet, there is also no doubt that it was a group of the representatives of this very generation who implemented in social practice the conservative “Stalinist model” of science in the Soviet Union pretty much in the same fashion as it was designed and institutionalized during the period of late Stalinism. Different scientific disciplines within the somewhat abstract and overly general “Soviet science” apparently demonstrated different patterns and group behaviors of their agents, and therefore this “Stalinist model” was not necessarily implemented in all disciplines without exception. Still, the “Stalinist model” can be clearly seen in the institutional organization and social practices of psychology as a scientific discipline throughout its postwar history.

As we now know, both Imperial Russia’s pre-revolutionary psychology and Soviet psychology of the 1920s and 1930s were intrinsically connected with foreign scholarship and followed international academic standards (Yasnitsky, 2011a, 2012b, 2012c), which, furthermore, appears to have considerably contributed to its survival in the process of “natural selection” of experimental revolutionary disciplinary projects in the humans sciences – such as the exotic and, therefore, extinct “reflexology,” “reactology,” “defectology,” “psychotechnics,” etc. – during the era of “disciplinary cleansing” of the mid-1930s. At the same time, Soviet psychology and its ideological heir – the science of psychology in contemporary Russia – is conspicuously different from the cumulative image of “Western science.” What distinguishes the two is the whole set of idiosyncratic features that do not seem to be well understood in the West up to the present – even by the relatively numerous group of Western admirers of Soviet and Russian psychology. It is this set of distinctive features of Russian psychology in its social habitat that is discussed in this chapter and is referred to as “the archetype” of Soviet psychology. In order to better understand what exactly is meant by “archetype” here, let us summarize the major distinctive features of the “archetype of Russian psychology,” formerly “Soviet psychology,” that by the mid-1950s was consolidated as “Marxist,” “ideological,” “militant,” and “advanced” science (Bogdanchikov, 2006). These are the characteristics that appear to represent the values and attitudes, therefore, to motivate the behavior patterns of the majority of individual agents of Russian psychology, and, finally, to determine its form and contents throughout several decades of the history of this scientific discipline and related social practice.

(1) *Centralization and control*

The highest form of Party–state control over science and at the same time its supreme institutional embodiment was the Academy of Sciences of the USSR, originally founded by decree of the Russian tsar Peter I in 1724. In the course of its historical development the Academy underwent a series of transformations and was renamed a few times, but only as a result of the organizational reforms of the mid-1930s did the Academy get those enormous and unprecedented rights and power that characterize the highly centralized “Stalinist model” of scientific

organization and management and that this organization, renamed the Russian Academy of Science after the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, retained until its latest reform in 2013:

The main peculiarity of the Academy of Sciences of USSR that was established by the new *Ustav* [i.e. the Statute of the Academy of Sciences of the USSR] in 1935 was that the Academy ceased being autonomous from the state scientific establishment as it was founded and had existed for 200 years. Personified by its members – and the leadership of the Academy and the administrative bodies the Academy members would elect – the Academy turned into a full-fledged social institution, in fact, a *Narkomat* [i.e. the Ministry] of non-industrially significant science that would supervise the scientific and auxiliary establishments affiliated with the Academy, determine their research agendas and distribute between these establishments the budget that was granted from the state to the Academy as a whole. The Members of the Academy acquired the status of special high-rank state scholars with well above the average remuneration and professional privileges unprecedented in the history of world science ... Like other *Narkomats*, the Academy of Sciences was directly subordinated to the head of the government of the state. Only the highest governmental officials were entitled to interfere in planning research agendas of the Academy's research institutes and in internal regulations of the Academy (albeit only by means of changes in the Statutes of the Academy) ... A contemporary reader well-versed in political intrigues does understand that in 1935 a new social stratum comprising individuals highly loyal – if not in earnest, then according to the new social contract – to authority was created within the hierarchy of numerous *nomenklatura* strata of Soviet society. Between now and then virtually everything has changed. Late Soviet Union elites degenerated and provoked the collapse of the regime that promoted them, and, in turn, they disappeared with the collapse of the regime. And only the Full and Corresponding Members of the contemporary Russian Academy of Sciences (RAN) – along with the Members of two other “state-owned” Academies, those of Agricultural and the Medical Sciences – whose social roots essentially are in the *nomenklatura* system of the Soviet Union, position the existing order as the allegedly natural and necessary structural organization of any science at the national and federal level. In fact, though, they are just a forlorn relic of the era that has gone.

(Khromov, 2002)

Similarly, the system of state control over science has preserved the Higher Attestation Commission (VAK), established in 1932 (and in effect launched in 1934), the national government agency that oversees the awarding of advanced academic degrees, including those of Candidate and Doctor of Sciences. A high level of centralization of power in the administration of science is implemented not

only at the federal level, but also at the lower level – within each specific discipline or geographical locale. As a rule, quite in agreement with the “Stalinist model,” power is concentrated within the hands of one or a very limited number of individuals. Traditionally, administrative control over psychology in the Soviet Union was granted to the representatives of Moscow or Leningrad (after 1991 renamed St. Petersburg) universities or individuals closely related with them. This tradition has been largely preserved until now. Thus, for instance, the Dean of the Department of Psychology of Moscow State University concurrently occupies a number of the key administrative positions that allow him direct control over a considerable segment of academic and applied psychology in the administrative, research, publication, and supervisory domains of this discipline as a social institution.⁸

(2) *Cliquism and patronage*

The pervasiveness of cliques and patronage in contemporary Russian science, specifically psychology, is manifested in the intellectual and organizational separation of different cliques of scholars in conjunction with the authoritarianism of scientific administrators (who share several key appointments of different kinds) and the servility and personal loyalty of the subordinate personnel. The consequence of this is the more or less definite “clique self-identification” of psychologists and demarcation of the borderlines between “ours” and “others.” In his reminiscences of the early 1980s Georgii Shchedrovitskii rendered a very characteristic description of this phenomenon that he once heard from P. A. Shevarev, a psychologist of the old school of the “pre-revolutionary generation.” Shevarev was talking about one particular group of Soviet psychologists, but it seems this characteristic applies to the whole social system and intergroup dynamics in Soviet and contemporary Russian psychology in general: “I do not like the students of Vygotskii. They are like black market traders.”⁹ This is a group for whom there are no truths, what they know is only ‘ours’ or ‘not ours’, that is, somebody who does belong to the group or an alien.” Further, Shchedrovitskii commented in these words:

I should say, the old man was absolutely right, and I had many occasions to make sure that his judgment was correct, that is, that the group of Vygotsky’s students lives and has always lived first and foremost following the principle [of distinguishing] the “own” or the “alien,” and this is what determined their relationships. The problem of the contents, the truth, has always receded into the background. It did not cease altogether, but it has always been secondary. The preservation of friendly relationships within the group and their struggle against the others – this is what became their second nature. This is how they were brought up, and it has always been a determining element of their group culture. Furthermore, they never considered such factionalism as immoral ... I would not really dare to accuse these people now, and I do not want everything I am saying on this matter to be interpreted as personal negative

judgment – I am far from that. Furthermore, I do not even know if I can express and am entitled to a judgment on such issues. This is a very delicate matter. I only make a snapshot of this situation as a fact of the lifestyle and culture of the people that they assimilated in those, apparently very complex, perhaps life-threatening circumstances, in which they would turn out at some points. But I would like to use this example in order to demonstrate the difference between the people of the preceding generation, who were brought up in a totally different culture, on the basis of very different principles, and the people of the new generation, who were brought up already in the 1920s–1930s. Theirs is a different morality, different logic, for them political correctness, political interrelations, labeling “ours–the other” became dominant in principle and started determining their behavior. Perhaps we should keep it in mind that they have long been under pressure and that they had to live as a narrow group who defended themselves from offensives from all sides, and therefore, when they reached a few positions of power, they used this power in the spirit that they were brought up in. At this point, I only underline the difference between the cultures of the two generations that came one after the other – this is what must be known and must be understood. I am far from the position of accusation, but at the same time I think that such a situation – and this is what I discovered on the basis of my personal encounters with all these people, regular collaborative work with them, and conflicts that ensued as a result – made them in principle incapable of scientific work. One cannot be a scholar, a thinker, with such values, such culture. This is what is important, in my opinion.

(Shchedrovitskii, 2001, pp. 50–51)

An interesting manifestation of cliquism and its special variation is the characteristically Soviet nepotism in science. The relatively high social status of intellectuals in the Soviet Union was finally established as the cultural norm in the post-World War II period and, as a result, “along with improved standards of living came hereditary continuity. The Stalin-era professional strata – both the old holdovers and the many more newcomers – reproduced their social position by passing on educational achievement to their children, taking advantage of the end of forced social mobility” (Tromly, 2014, pp. 8–9). The notable outcome of such “hereditary continuity” is the phenomenon of distinctly Soviet “scientific dynasties” that in the case of psychology comprise the continuity of up to four subsequent generations of psychologists, the most remarkable example being the extended family of the descendants of Lev Vygotsky.

(3) Ritualism

The Soviet science of the “Stalinist model” is characterized by considerable ritualism that encompasses a wide range of scholars’ behaviors and practices and spreads

from the top to the very bottom of the social pyramid. Thus, for instance, administrative control and supervision over the agency of Russian scholars is up even to the present day performed by the administrative bodies that inherited the idiosyncratic Bolshevik newspeak phraseology and preserved it in their official titles such as “Presidium,” “Sovet,” “Bureau,” and “Sekretariat.” Quite often this phraseology is indicative of the preservation of institutions virtually in the same form as they were introduced during the Stalinist era. One might counter this observation with the entirely legitimate remark that bureaucratization of state control over science is characteristic not only of the “Stalinist model” and not only in the Soviet Union or in its legal and spiritual heir, the Russian Federation.

And yet, ritualism of the Soviet type – unlike that of industrially developed countries – is supported not only through the administrative apparatus or the phraseology used in naming these organizations, but also through the actual functioning of these supervisory and administrative bodies in concrete social contexts. Thus, the ritualism of scientific bureaucracy of the “Stalinist model” reveals itself in a wide range of “carnavalesque” phenomena and events such as various jubilees of prominent individuals, scientific groups, administrative units, and organizations that, according to age-old Soviet tradition, keep being celebrated every ten or even, not unusually, every five years in the form of a variety of celebratory events such as public meetings, round tables, banquets, jubilee conferences, etc., and are frequently inaugurated in special publications, for instance edited volumes, special journal issues, conference proceedings, etc. dedicated to these celebratory events. Frequently these and many other publications of the kind are accompanied with obligatory number of “group references” (ironically also referred to as “mass graves”) and “nomadic quotations,” mandatory from the standpoint of the social norms, scientific micropolitics, and diplomatic positioning of specific publications. It is likely that the practice and extent of this technique differs depending on the specific scientific discipline and the genre of academic writing, but, as it appears in informal and unsystematic observations of Russian scientific discourse, this practice is really widely spread among Russian psychologists.

Finally, ritualism of the Soviet kind is also implemented in the form of idiosyncratic discourse, which does not allow characterizing its functional style as scientific speech proper, but rather suggests that this is a hybrid between scientific style proper and a journalist-propagandist style. Numerous examples of such hybrid discourse include a number of linguistic and stylistic peculiarities such as (a) subjective evaluative statements; (b) emotionally marked phraseology; (c) binary synonymic and antonymic oppositions for denoting identical phenomena and processes depending on whether the context of discussion is critical or laudatory; (d) argumentation *ad hominem*; (e) differentiated attribution of historical figures in psychology, when certain persons are referred to by their first name and patronymic in an abbreviated form; furthermore, in specific instances the last name of those individuals may be dropped (compare the following examples: “S. Freud,” “A. A. Smirnov,” or “K. Lewin” as opposed to “Lev Semenovich [Vygotskii]” or, more rarely, “Aleksandr Romanovich [Luria],” etc.). All these stylistic and semantic peculiarities of Soviet

scientific discourse most likely originate in the discourse of Bolshevik bureaucracy of the 1920s, but in the most conspicuous forms they appear to have solidified in the Soviet “scientific newspeak” of late Stalinism during the early Cold War period (Gerovitch, 2002).

(4) *Gap between theory and practice*

The gap between theory and practice, characteristic of late Imperial Russian psychology, was not overcome in the 1920s, despite the considerable efforts of a few Soviet scholars, and was further aggravated during the 1930s – primarily because of considerable ideological and political influences on Soviet psychological science. The critique of this gap “from inside” is quite characteristic of the state of the art in postwar Soviet psychology; of particular value is an indication of the ideological nature of this gap:

Generally, in Leontiev’s conception – as well as in the speculations of many other psychologists – the issue of the analysis of distinctly psychological process of development of needs – that is, the process of their transition into qualitatively new forms – has remained beyond the scope of his discussion. He attempts to solve this problem in the abstract-theoretical plane, with the use of the arguments of *istmat* [i.e. “historical materialism”] in those instances when he has not enough concrete psychological data. And this can be easily explained given that there are only a few experimental studies in this field of knowledge in which he could have grounded his work.

(Bozhovich, 1972, p. 14)

The history of Soviet psychology has passed through a series of periods of dominant theoretical frameworks, mandatory for all national research in this field. These are the period of “Pavlovization” (i.e. aligning all psychological research with the teaching of Ivan Pavlov, Nobel Prize winner in medicine and physiology) in the 1950s/early 1960s, followed by the period of “activity approach” (1960s/early 1970s), and then “systemic approach” (mid-1970s/1980s), the last two periods primarily associated with the names of A. N. Leontiev and B. F. Lomov, respectively. All these periods were understood as variations of “Marxist psychology,” which, in turn, came to an end in the late 1980s and was finally decisively and demonstratively denounced, damned, condemned, and ridiculed only after the political collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 and the demise of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union. Interestingly enough, all these fairly radical twists and turns of the “mandatory theoretical line” had minimal (if any) bearing on the course of empirical research in psychological sciences in the Soviet Union. Indeed, the change of theoretical terminology and, therefore, the set of mandatory “nomadic quotes” on the first pages of publications had virtually no impact on the actual studies. Therefore, psychological theory in the Soviet Union of the postwar period is best understood

as mainly belonging to the rhetorical space and the context of social legitimization of empirical research rather than as the source of ideas and the springboard for further experimentation. More often than not this conclusion fully applies to the legacy of Vygotsky, whose writings in certain contexts are used as merely a source of highly superficial and uncritical – not rarely, self-contradictory – quotations and references, primarily for the purposes of social positioning and as a token of conformity to the academic standard of publication. Overall, the age-old gap between theory and practice – demonstrated by great numbers of atheoretical empirical and, in contrast, highly speculative theoretical publications in contemporary Russian psychology – has been preserved to the present.

(5) *Intellectual and linguistic isolationism*

Recent studies of the alleged “isolationism” of Soviet psychology have clearly demonstrated that the development of this scientific discipline during the 1920s and 1930s – despite brief xenophobic campaigns in society and science – was accompanied by intensive international exchanges and active cooperation between Soviet psychologists and their peers abroad (for a discussion of one of the most prominent cases in the history of transnational collaboration and cooperation see Chapter 9).¹⁰

In contrast, strong isolationist tendencies in national scientific policy drastically increased during the period of late Stalinism and the early Cold War (i.e. in the late 1940s and early 1950s). Although this period was relatively short, its impact on post-war intellectual isolationism was considerable. Indeed, in the mid-1950s an official Psychological Society of USSR was authorized at the highest level of the country’s political and state leadership and was formed and affiliated with the International Society of Psychological Sciences in 1957. By this time, Soviet psychologists – more precisely, mainly a narrow circle of loyal official representatives of the export version of “Soviet psychology” who comprised renowned scholars and high-ranking administrators of science and their associates – quite regularly traveled abroad to scientific and organizational events all over the world. Rank and file researchers, though, also had, albeit somewhat limited, access to international scholarship through a number of channels. Thus, for instance, the record-breaking attendance of roughly 4,000 domestic and international scholars from forty-three different countries – including those of the “capitalist West” and the Soviet “Eastern bloc” alike – was registered at the XVIII International Congress of Psychology that was triumphantly held in the midst of the Cold War in Moscow in 1966 (Rosenzweig, Holtzman, Sabourin, & Bélanger, 2000).

Nevertheless, as paradoxical as it might appear, it was during the post-World War II period that Soviet psychology increasingly turned into an isolationist, demonstratively “Soviet science” characterized by (a) the lack of reading knowledge in foreign languages in the majority of the agents of the new population of Soviet researchers, resulting in (b) their ignorance of the state of the art in contemporary scholarly research in the West (rare exceptions such as Alexander Luria and his collaborators

only prove the general rule), and (c) relatively small numbers of foreign studies cited in publications within Soviet Union and, conversely, of Soviet publications cited abroad. One of the most direct consequences of this situation was the fact that Soviet psychologists largely failed to acquire the skills of statistical analysis of experimental data and, more generally, did not catch up with the developing culture of quantitative research and, even broader, the standards of research presentation in the West.¹¹

This description mainly applies to the situation in contemporary psychology in Russia. Russian psychologists today, according to the new official priorities of national scientific policy of the Russian Federation, quite often have strong budgetary and career incentives to present their research abroad – specifically, to publish their studies in foreign languages in top-rank scholarly journals in the West – but in the vast majority of cases for some reason or another are incapable of independent preparation of their scholarly materials for publication in accordance with the standards of Western academic publishing.

Besides, the evidence of scientific intellectual isolationism is often demonstrated by the claims of “self-reliant,” “unique,” “exceptional” Russian psychology and by the search for the special “Russian way” in science. One of the most remarkable and radical – and astonishing – examples of the isolationism of the kind is the so-called “Christian” or even, more precisely, “Russian Orthodox psychology” that is actively developed, advocated for, and promoted by quite a number of contemporary psychologists and psychotherapists in the Russian Federation nowadays, including the leadership of the Psychology Department of Moscow State University, traditionally considered one of the oldest and most prestigious psychological schools in the country.

(6) *Cultism and hagiographies*

The principle of *nomenklatura* appointments not only was essential for the whole structure of Soviet society, but is also highly characteristic of the entire framework of Soviet psychology as a discipline and social institution. From the early 1990s, after the collapse of the Soviet Union and the elimination of the Communist Party’s administrative apparatus of control over professional appointments, it is hardly appropriate to refer to the *nomenklatura* proper, in its original sense. This change, however, brought about greater independence for scientific-administrative cliques, randomly freed from Party control from above. Thus, the void was largely filled with the *clique principle* of professional appointments.

These large-scale social and historical processes had a direct bearing on the historiography of Soviet and Russian psychology as a powerful mechanism that was used in rebuilding the new ideology to fill the lacuna of “loyalty to the Party.” Thus, the new ideology’s motto can be described as “loyalty to the tradition,” where by tradition is meant a primitive version of an “intellectual history of science,” fairly idealized, seemingly depoliticized, and clearly separated from its original

socio-historical context. According to the logic of administrators of science after the collapse of the Soviet Union, it is faithfulness to the tradition that serves as the criterion for a future employee's evaluation and as a guiding principle of professional selection. In practice, however, this results in even further separation between the cliques and in hiring of one's "own" graduates (i.e. selecting loyal "ours" and rejecting the suspicious "others" and the "aliens"), which further leads to the decrease of intellectual cross-pollination and competition between different intellectual traditions and, at the same time, to an increase of intellectual degeneration and corruption in the system of academic psychology in the country.

Therefore, the historiography of Soviet and Russian psychology in contemporary Russia serves an important social function of constructing an ideology that, in turn, is used as a foundation in the processes of policy-making, including reproduction of scientific elites, especially in the human and social sciences. In practice, over the past few decades we observe an increase of the hagiographic tradition in historiography, manifested in the proliferation of various cults of "Founding Fathers" and their "scientific schools," the traditions of "sacred names" of "Our Teachers" and their loyal "brothers-in-arms" and devoted students. Among the most important instruments and techniques for creating cultist hagiographies in the historiography of science – such as the historiography of Russian and Soviet psychology – and, therefore, the criteria for detecting such hagiographies in scientific discourse are:

- (a) heroic depiction of the historical past;
- (b) emotionality and ethical valuation of discussion, quite often involving propagandist and militarist phraseology;
- (c) binary polarization of historical characters and protagonists into "the forces of good" and "the forces of evil" and depiction of historical processes as the struggle between the two forces;
- (d) demonization of the "evil" and the victimization of the "good," who, in fact, quite in the tradition of medieval *Lives of the saints* (i.e. *hagiographies* proper) are presented as "martyrs" and "innocent victims" of persecutions.

Some examples of uncritical and propagandist constructing of the historical past are presented by the cults of G. I. Chelpanov, G. G. Shpet, the "cult of the Psychological Institute" (in Moscow) or the "cult of the Department of Psychology of Moscow State University." The latter is frequently supported by numerous publications – books, collected volumes, and journal articles – on the so-called "activity theory," most directly associated with the names of Aleksei N. Leontiev and his clique as the core group of Vygotsky's students and intellectual heirs. These and many other similar but less significant "cults of the scientists," regardless of how little related to each other they might appear, follow essentially the same structural model and use virtually identical rhetorical tools of an idiosyncratic victim-heroic narrative about a "Great Man" or a "Great Institution," depending on the propagandist and career purposes of their proponents and advocates.¹²

Revisionist Vygotskian narrative rewritten against the background of the history of “Stalinist science”

And yet, the most famous “cult” in the history of Soviet and Russian psychology that spread virtually all over the globe is arguably the “Vygotsky cult,” forcefully promoted in scholarly literature in contemporary Russia (and Eastern Europe) and abroad – primarily in North America and, perhaps less prominently, in Western Europe, Australia, and South America.¹³ Quite curiously, the cult emerged as a result of diverse, complex domestic and international activities across state borders and scientific disciplines. Still, the domestic context of the “Vygotsky cult” as it developed in its natural environment of the “Stalinist model” of science in the Soviet Union seems to have largely determined the many problems that are now faced by the revisionist movement in Vygotsky studies. Many of these are addressed in this book.

First, a cult requires a figure of a solitary Founding Father on the very top of the social and intellectual pyramid constituted by academic worshippers of the cult. Therefore, the tradition of a “Great Man” history is countered here by a holistic approach that takes into consideration the whole group of scholars behind a theory or an idea, albeit never leaving out of focus individual agents of history. Most important from this perspective are the collaborative projects of the Vygotsky–Luria circle (see Chapter 2), the extended team of German-American psychologists, the proponents of Gestalt psychology, and the overlap between these two major groups of scholars that are discussed here as a Soviet–German–American project of “cultural-historical Gestalt psychology” (see Chapters 6, 8, and 9).

Second, the cliquism, hagiography, and ritualism of the “Stalinist model” and its contemporary Russian and Western derivatives requires the reign of authority, mystery, and miracle. None of these might possibly impress the revisionists, whose chief method is critical, meticulous, and rigorous analysis of the most reliable empirical data. Particularly illustrative of this approach and of this kind of scholarship are textological and historical reconstructions of actual Vygotsky texts, published and unpublished, and analysis of their contemporary relevance and theoretical importance, such as in Chapters 4, 5, and 6.

Third, provincialism and isolationism is solidly based on keeping the borders of various sorts. The new scholarship presented here is quite different from the traditional in its focus on transnational and cross-disciplinary processes, which is generally characteristic of many new revisionist works, but is particularly explicit in comparative histories of the development of “Vygotskian tradition” in psychological and allied sciences in the USSR (Chapters 2, 3), and in the West (Chapter 7). These are followed by the histories of a truly transnational Soviet–German–American scientific project that developed in the interwar period in the Soviet Union, Western Europe, North America, and even, to smaller extent, the Near East and Central Asia (Chapters 8 and, particularly, 9).

Fourth, cultist traditions in science need foundational myths – histories of their origin, legends about heroes, and the veneration of victims and sacred objects. The critical scholarship represented by the Vygotskian revisionism tolerates neither the

“heroes” nor the “martyrs.” Thus, for instance, an attempt at “devictimization” and overcoming the “sacrificial cult of Vygotsky” is made in Chapter 3 of this book. Another, similar effort at “deheroization” is undertaken in Chapter 8, which scrutinizes a heroic story of Luria’s expedition to Central Asia that has always been among the foundational myths of the whole field of “Vygotskian” studies worldwide.

Fifth, this book is not merely about historical, textological, and theoretical research. In other words, the revisionist project not only generates critical studies that reveal histories or reevaluate commonly held ideas, but also provides ideas for future cutting-edge research in human sciences. By virtue of the combination of “critical” and “constructive” strands in Vygotskian revisionism the new scholarship bridges the gap between theory and practice, and sorts out the most valuable in the diverse and fairly inconsistent Vygotsky legacy, still potentially of interest in a contemporary context (Chapter 4), suggests some ideas to international brokers and academic translators (Yasnitsky, 2012d), and presents a conceptual and terminological framework for talking about the most important topics in the last period of Vygotsky’s scholarship: the topics of consciousness, sense, and meaning (see the Epilogue).

All this new scholarship seems to be instrumental in helping us overcome the old “Stalinist” and cultist model of science that is still dominant in Russian and Western “Vygotskiana” alike and in helping us move forward, to new heights, into the future. Or, on the contrary, the revisionism may be said to direct us back, to the past of the revolutionary pre-Stalinist Bolshevik project of radical social and cultural reconstruction. Both options are good and, regardless of the phraseology and metaphors that we might use, words as such change virtually nothing. After all, real action still remains the criterion of the truth, even in such a seemingly highly abstract and theoretical enterprise as scientific research.

2

UNITY IN DIVERSITY

The Vygotsky–Luria circle as an informal personal network of scholars

Anton Yasnitsky

During his lifetime Lev Vygotsky (1896–1934) failed to establish himself as a leader of an institutionalized scientific school in the human sciences associated with his name, unlike, for instance, his contemporaries and compatriots Ivan Pavlov (1849–1936) or Vladimir Bekhterev (1857–1927). Both Pavlov and Bekhterev not only founded scientific theories and rival research schools, but also set up institutionalized “factories” for massive production of scientific knowledge (Todes, 2002, 2014). However, Vygotsky was fairly well known, and for his contemporaries the name of Vygotsky was associated with his theory of human development that was at different times variously referred to as “instrumental,” or “cultural” psychology, or a “theory of cultural development,” or a “theory of cultural development of higher mental (psychical) functions” (Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991). This terminological diversity and fluidity reflects the constant search for the adequate descriptors for the original research program and theoretical innovation of integrative human developmental science introduced by Vygotsky and his associates in a wide range of fields and disciplines. This chapter explores the dense network of scholars associated with Vygotsky during his lifetime, the interpersonal and professional interrelationships of Vygotsky and his group, and the dynamics of group change in the interwar period (1924–41).

The “school of Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria” narrative

The first written contributions to the emergent historiography of Vygotsky’s psychology (that perhaps tell us more about their authors than the subject of their papers) appeared as early as in the mid-1930s, in obituaries and memorial speeches written or delivered by his closest collaborators soon after Vygotsky’s death (A. N. Leontiev, 1934; A. R. Luria, 1935a, 1935b). However, the core of the now widely

disseminated narrative about “the school of Vygotsky” was not formed until the period from mid-1970 to the early 1980s. This is when a pile of publications on the history of the “school” came out, including a series of memoirs, public presentations, and interviews with the protagonists of the history of Vygotskian psychology in the Soviet Union (A. N. Leontiev, 1986; A. N. Leontiev & Leontiev, 2005; A. N. Leontiev & Luria, 1976; A. R. Luria, 1979, 1982) as well as a number of publications by their followers and students (Davydov & Radzikhovskii, 1980, 1981, 1985; Radzikhovskii, 1979). Quite a few of these appeared around the time of the death of Alexander Luria (in 1977) and Aleksei N. Leontiev (in 1979) (Elkonin, 1983, 1984; Galperin, 1983, 1984; Zaporozhets & Elkonin, 1979), which might account for the laudatory and elevated rhetorical style of these publications, and the sometimes uncritical and rather heroic depiction of the protagonists. Two edited memorial volumes on the scientific legacy of the two scholars are especially notable as the two foundational and comprehensive collections of articles on the life and scientific legacy of Luria and Leontiev authored by their former colleagues and students (Khomskaya, Tsvetkova, & Zeigarnik, 1982; Zaporozhets, Zinchenko, Ovchinnikova, & Tikhomirov, 1983).

The stream of these and related publications formed the solid corpus of what we might refer to as the “canonical” account about the “school of Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria” that has several key narrative elements. The core of the narrative is the story about the 1924 meeting in Moscow of the three founding fathers, Lev Vygotsky, Alexander Luria, and Aleksei Leontiev, and the formation of the first alliance of the *troika* (“the three”). Then, a second alliance was formed by the five first-generation students of “the triumvirate,” named the *piaterka* (“the five” in Russian), which included Alexander Zaporozhets, Lidia Bozhovich, Roza Levina, Natalia Morozova, and Lia Slavina. According to this canonical narrative, the group of these eight individuals constituted the “school of Vygotsky.” Typically, this narrative does not provide us with any information about the later fate of the *piaterka*, but we are told that at the end of 1931 a group of Vygotsky’s followers that included a part of the *troika* (Luria and Leontiev) and a part of the *piaterka* (Zaporozhets and Bozhovich) left Moscow for Kharkov, then capital of Soviet Ukraine, to start their work in a new organizational unit, the Sector of Psychology at the Ukrainian Psychoneurological Academy (UPNA). In Kharkov, the Muscovites met with a group of local scholars, including Pietr Gal’perin, Pietr Zinchenko, Vladimir Asnin, Ksenia Khomenko, and Grigorii Lukov, who formed an alliance that later came to be known as the Kharkov group or the Kharkov school of psychology. According to this narrative, Luria headed the Psychology *Sektor* (Section) at UPNA, whereas a position as Head of the *Otdel* (Department) of Child and Genetic Psychology was offered to Leontiev. However, Luria reportedly soon returned to Moscow; and after his departure Leontiev became the Head of the Psychology Section and supervised virtually all administrative and research work from then on. A series of recent publications added the name of Mark Lebedinskii as one of those scholars invited from Moscow to Kharkov, as well as other minor details, but the structure of the narrative, the sequence, and the interpretation of the main events remain basically identical

across the vast majority of “traditional” publications on this topic (cf. Ivanova, 1995; A. A. Leontiev, 1983; A. A. Leontiev & Leontiev, 2013; A. A. Leontiev, Leontiev, & Sokolova, 2005; Sokolova, 2007, 2011).

The history of *troika da piaterka* (“the three and the five,” in Russian) and the interpretation of the history of Vygotskian psychology along the lines of A. N. Leontiev’s so-called “activity theory” is not the only interpretation of the history of the Vygotskian research project after Vygotsky’s death. A number of researchers questioned the validity of the construct “the school of Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria” from time to time, and doubted the legitimacy of the claims of the continuity of Vygotsky’s original framework in the research program of activity-oriented psychological studies. For instance, Luchkov and Pevzner (the latter, as it happened, another of the first generation of Vygotsky’s students) argued that “we have every reason to doubt the appropriateness of the phrase the *activity theory of Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria*, as well as the juxtaposition of these three names with respect to this theory. Furthermore, in the school of Leontiev, it has recently become usual to talk, generally, about *the school of Vygotsky–Luria–Leontiev* ... which is also illegitimate, in our opinion” (Luchkov & Pevzner, 1981).

However, the full-scale revision of the *troika da piaterka* version of the history of the Vygotsky school started around the end of the 1980s/early 1990s and seems to have coincided with the processes of *perestroika* in the Soviet Union. The traditional history of Vygotskian psychology evoked much criticism from authors who questioned Leontiev’s role as leader of the school of Vygotskian scholars and challenged the claim that Leontiev’s “activity theory” was a direct continuation of Vygotsky’s theory of cultural development. The critique of the “official” historiography can often be recognized by the authors’ insistence on the split between Vygotsky on the one hand and Leontiev and the Kharkov group that reportedly departed from Vygotsky’s research program on the other. Another characteristic feature of the “revisionist” historiography of Vygotskian psychology is the authors’ insistence on the rupture in Vygotsky’s theory development in the works of his students and followers – despite recognizing the continued influence of Vygotsky on his students (Kozulin, 1984, 1986, 1990; Orlov, 2003; Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991). Some scholars even discuss Leontiev’s and Luria’s personal betrayal of Vygotsky and “his case” that allegedly took place sometime around the end of 1933, approximately half a year before Vygotsky’s death (Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991; Vygodskaya & Lifanova, 1996). However, despite considerable criticism of the “school of Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria” narrative, scholars in favor of the traditionalist interpretation of the history of Vygotskian psychology are still fairly active and the *troika* discourse is quite notable in various publications to date.

The Vygotsky–Luria circle as informal personal network

Notably, the vast majority of these publications follow the tradition of “Great Men” histories, or, in other words, represent “hagiographic” historiography that is

characterized by distinctly celebratory (or, otherwise, accusatory and denunciatory) accounts of the history of ideas against the background of the personal life-stories of a few protagonists, typically, Vygotsky, Leontiev, or Luria. In contrast, the present account is inspired by the idea that, “remarkably, Vygotsky’s approach *de facto* embodies, in its real life history, the very theoretical principles central to it, such as the inseparability of knowledge and action, theory and practice, and the collaborative nature of cognition” (Stetsenko & Arieivitch, 2004, p. 58). This account of the Vygotsky–Luria circle contrasts with the traditional narrative of the school of Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria by investigating the “cultural-historical school as a collaborative, multi-generational, value-laden, and ideologically-driven investigative project that stretched far beyond the confines of science in its traditional mentalist guise” (Stetsenko, 2003, p. 96). Recent literature in Vygotsky studies increasingly stresses essentially the collective, dialogic, and collaborative nature of the “Vygotsky project” that was born in and existed through lively discussions with a number of people, who

formed the so-called Vygotsky Circle, which included several brilliant women, and they carried out research projects collectively ... [T]he ubiquitously collaborative nature of Vygotsky’s project in general must be emphasized, especially because it has often been underestimated or even ignored in previous accounts of his heritage.

(Stetsenko, 2004, pp. 502–503)

Thus, this account follows the lead of those researchers who underline the importance of informal personal networks for understanding the processes of science development. Mark B. Adams, who introduced the notion of informal networks in the discourse of the historiography of science, clarifies:

Here, I am not referring to anything arcane or technical – not to the ‘networks’ of the sociologist, dynamist, or social studies theoretician, much less the computer specialist – but to the looser, more evocative meaning the word has come to have in everyday language, one familiar to every kind of historian: personal networks. A personal network is a much looser, less coherent ‘structure’ than either an institution or a discipline. Developed out of extended family, old school ties, mutual experience, hobbies, private passions, and shared interests, such networks involve ramifying contacts that are multiple and complex – as are all free associations that underline civic society. They can also form ‘nodes’ or ‘ganglia’ where various networks interface and new connections are made – sometimes in the form of informal circles, private societies, clubs, salons, soirées, and the like, sometimes in more organized forms, ranging from things we might call ‘movements’ to interest groups, political organizations, and even ‘mafias’. And some of these, in turn, might eventually gain further structure as would-be disciplines or proto-institutions.

(M. B. Adams, 2001, p. 261)

The informal personal network of Vygotsky included a lot of individuals, many of whom are not necessarily related to his scientific enterprise. Tracking down the agency of a network of such individuals is obviously a very ambitious goal. Therefore, this chapter focuses on a smaller subset of the larger network: the people who either directly collaborated with Vygotsky or made a considerable impact on him through personal contacts, discussions, and, possibly, correspondence. This “node” of the network of thinkers and scholars is discussed here as the Vygotsky circle of those who – willingly or unwillingly – contributed to Vygotsky’s research program and whose impact on Vygotskian psychology can be discerned. Apparently, in many instances at the same time the reverse impact of Vygotsky on these individuals and their research agenda is even more notable. And still, even with its focus on a relatively smaller group of Vygotsky’s collaborators, this study is almost necessarily somewhat limited and fragmentary – much as the available data are limited and fragmentary. Therefore, this chapter presents a systematic – yet somewhat superficial – attempt at reconstructing the composition of the Vygotsky circle, the range of scholarly activities of its participants, and the dynamics of intergroup change within this group of scholars. Given Vygotsky’s closest association and collaboration with Alexander Luria (1902–77) that lasted throughout his entire career in Moscow in 1924–34, it seems even more appropriate to designate the hub of the larger “Vygotsky network” as the “Vygotsky–Luria circle,” and therefore both expressions will be used here interchangeably.

According to the traditional historiographical narrative, Vygotsky’s psychology was first developed by the members of Vygotsky’s *troika*. In contrast, it appears that we have no compelling evidence of the *troika*, the trio of Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria, during the last decade of Vygotsky’s lifetime (1924–34), and it is more appropriate to single out the duo of Luria and Vygotsky and their numerous personal and professional connections and interrelations. There are a number of reasons for selecting the duo of Luria–Vygotsky as the intellectual and organizational core of a team developing cultural-historical theory in the 1920s–30s, and if the number of publications alone is indicative, then from the sheer number of collaborative publications it is clear that Vygotsky and Luria were closely connected indeed. For instance, in the mid-1920s they wrote two introductions to the Russian translations of psychological books (Vygotskii & Luria, 1925, 1926); then, they participated in preparing educational materials and handbooks (Artemov, Bernstein, Vygotskii, Dobrynin, & Luria, 1927; Artemov, Vygotskii, Dobrynin, & Luria, 1927); co-authored a paper on egocentric speech that Luria presented at the IX International Congress of Psychology held at Yale University, which Vygotsky was unable to attend (Vygotsky & Luria, 1930), a book (Vygotskii & Luria, 1930), and a book chapter that was to appear in Murchison’s *Handbook of child psychology* in 1930 (Vygotsky & Luria, 1930/1994). Finally, their collaborative book was written at the end of the 1920s, but remained unpublished for several decades.¹ In contrast, the only paper that came out under the names of both Vygotsky and Leontiev was the introduction to the book on psychology of memory written by the latter under the supervision of the former (A. N. Leontiev, 1931). It is also interesting

how contemporaries – mostly outsiders and critics – perceived and attributed Vygotsky's group and theory. Thus, for instance, Talankin in his speech given in June of 1931 in Kharkov attacks the group of Vygotsky and Luria and calls for a Marxist critique of their psychological theory (Talankin, 1931, 2000). Around the same time, another critique of the “theory of cultural development” came from Feofanov, for whom it is clearly associated with just two individuals: Vygotsky and Luria (Feofanov, 1932, 2000). Somewhat later, in 1934, Razmyslov severely criticized Vygotsky's and Luria's cultural-historical theory of psychology (Razmyslov, 1934, 2000). Finally, in 1936 an author that identified (or rather *did not* identify) himself with the just two letters G. F. – which presumably stand for philosophy professor Filipp Georgiev (A. A. Leontiev et al., 2005) – also mentions the school of Vygotsky and Luria in the context of a critical discussion in the light of the Party decree of July, 1936 (F. G., 1936). Judging from their personal correspondence and the facts of their biographies the connections between Vygotsky and Luria remained very close until the very last days of Vygotsky's life. For instance, in the fall of 1931 Vygotsky and Luria resumed their studies in medicine: they both got accepted as students in the Medical Department in Kharkov, and were spending much time together preparing for their exams (E. A. Luria, 1994). At the same time they were involved in intensive research in clinical settings conducted in parallel in Kharkov and Moscow (Vygotskii, 2004; Vygotsky, 2007).

This circle of scholars as a unit of analysis comprises only those individuals who were related to both its leaders and excludes people occasionally involved in the episodic independent projects of the two protagonists. The data used in this study include mainly scientific publications of the interwar period and, to a somewhat smaller extent, archival data and materials of correspondence between the members of the Vygotsky circle and some second-hand sources, such as postwar research overviews and memoirs. The development of the Vygotsky circle – rather, Vygotsky–Luria circle – is traced here throughout the period 1924–41 and has been divided into several phases.

Phase one (1924–1927): prehistory of the Vygotsky–Luria circle

The first phase of Vygotsky's circle starts with Vygotsky's move from Gomel' to Moscow, and is characterized by his initial activities at the Institute of Psychology and in various defectological institutions. During this period he made his only foreign trip, in the summer of 1925, to a conference in London on the problems of the deaf (Van der Veer & Zavershneva, 2011). After his return from that European trip, in the fall of 1925, Vygotsky was hospitalized with tuberculosis and spent several months of 1925–6 in hospital. At the end of 1925, on the basis of his unpublished dissertation *The psychology of art* he was awarded a doctoral degree without defense, in absentia. Virtually all of 1926 Vygotsky spent in hospital or, subsequently, at home recovering from the disease in a state of temporary professional disability, officially recognized as an invalid. During this period Vygotsky was also writing his



FIGURE 2.1 The pre-history of the Vygotsky circle in 1924–1927

methodological work on the crisis in psychology, but never finished the oeuvre and abandoned it without even attempting its publication as such (Zavershneva, 2012b; Zavershneva & Osipov, 2012a, 2012b).

Aleksander Luria seems to have been instrumental in inviting Vygotsky to Moscow and very soon the new scientific alliance of Vygotsky and Luria was formed. The two closely collaborated and as early as the mid-1920s published several co-authored pieces. Apart from Luria, Vygotsky's major academic contacts and collaborators during this time were his Moscow colleagues and graduate students Leonid Zankov, Ivan Solov'ev, Leonid Sakharov, and Boris Varshava, and relatively short-term collaborators at the Moscow Institute of Psychology, most notably Nikolai Bernstein.

Not much is known yet about the professional interconnections between Bernstein and the Vygotsky–Luria project, but on the basis of an account in Bernstein's biography (Feigenberg, 2004), we may assume, at least, fairly strong personal ties between them (for a discussion of Bernstein's likely involvement with the “cultural-historical Gestalt psychology” project of Luria, Vygotsky, and their German-American peers see Chapter 9). These ties were later reinforced during World War II when a group of Vygotsky's associates launched a series of clinical studies in wartime hospitals on the rehabilitation of motor skills in the wounded and speech disorders of patients with brain lesions. This group included, among others, Solomon Gellerstein, which might also be a possible – yet unverified – indicator of his affinity to the Vygotsky–Luria group in the 1920–30s.

Another major area of Vygotsky's activity was defectological work, which was done chiefly in contact with Daniushevskii, his acquaintance from Gomel', who

occupied a high administrative position in the *Narkompros* of the RSFSR (later renamed the Ministry of Education of the RSFSR) and was most likely instrumental in helping Vygotsky get a middle-level governmental position as supervisor of the defectological sector within this administrative body in charge of the social and legal protection of children and adolescents (in Russian: *sotsial'no-pravovaia okhrana nesovershennoletnikh*, SPON).

In turn, Luria and Leontiev were continuing their investigation of affect by using Luria's combined motor method, a research project initiated by Luria in which Vygotsky did not seem to have been particularly interested or to have participated – at least, not during his first years in Moscow. Mark Lebedinskii, a medical doctor, was another important Luria collaborator, who implemented Luria's research method in clinical settings treating patients with nervous and psychiatric disorders. Another of Luria's associates was Roza Averbukh, a medical doctor from Kazan' and, like Luria, a former member of Kazan' Psychoanalytic Society, who left Kazan' for Moscow and there joined the Russian Psychoanalytic Society. It was during this period of the mid-1920s that Luria occupied the position of the secretary of this Society and regularly reported on the Society's activities in his numerous publications, in German, that came out in the West in the 1920s.

Among Vygotsky's main research interests in Moscow in 1924–7 was the investigation of dominant reactions in collaboration with his students Zankov, Solov'ev, Sakharov, and, episodically, Gagaeva (Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991, pp. 33, 128), and defectological work – primarily of an administrative and propagandist nature – with Daniushevskii, Zankov, and others. Also, during this period Vygotsky initiated his relatively well-known research on concept formation in collaboration with his student Leonid Sakharov (1900–28) (Sakharov, 1928, 1930, 1994). Sakharov's research was most likely completed by the end of 1927: according to van der Veer and Valsiner, on January 1, 1928 Sakharov presented his findings at the Pedological Congress in Moscow, and on May 10, 1928 he died under unknown circumstances, possibly committing suicide (Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991, p. 96). Another of Vygotsky's collaborators during his first years in Moscow was Boris Varshava (1900–27), whose premature and tragic death in July 1927 Vygotsky mourned in the introduction to their only collaborative publication, a *Psychological dictionary* that came out, after considerable delay, in 1931. In retrospect, Vygotsky's words about Varshava, written on the occasion of the publication of their collaborative work, seem to be quite characteristic of his own life and scientific legacy:

Varshava was just at the beginning of his path as a psychologist-researcher and a writer. He made only first steps on this road that was interrupted by his death. But these first steps left no doubt to anybody who knew him as to *what kind of* road was waiting for him. This road was one of creative scientific work and a struggle for the complete reconstruction of psychological science on a new methodological foundation, and his choice for this road was very early and decisive.

(Vygotskii, 1931a, p. 3)

We tend to measure the extent of the loss of those who worked along with us by the extent of what they achieved, accomplished, completed. And this is correct. But the opposite is correct too: to measure by what remains unrealized. This measure will be great if we apply it to the death of Boris Efimovich Varshava. What he could have achieved is incomparably more than what he has achieved. The measure of what he was destined to carry out and what is left unrealized is greater than the measure of his achievements. And this is the true meaning of the tragedy of his death.

(Vygotskii, 1931a, pp. 5–6)

The projects undertaken by many of Vygotsky's colleagues and collaborators in the years 1924–7 do not leave the impression of being interrelated pieces of a unified research program. Indeed, this period of Vygotsky's thought development is characterized by a search for a research methodology and a theoretical foundation. However, by the end of this period several disparate lines converged and became increasingly intertwined, leading to the emergence of new research alliances and new teams of collaborators.

Phase two (1927–1931): Vygotsky–Luria circle formation

The larger Vygotsky and Luria circle includes all their co-workers and like-minded individuals of that time, and their acquaintances; the exchange of ideas in a circle normally takes place through more or less informal communications and personal discussions (e.g. Vygotsky's and Luria's "internal conferences" and their extensive domestic and international correspondence). The *periphery of the circle*, however, is formed by the individuals who cannot fully qualify as students or collaborators of either Vygotsky or Luria, but whose work and ideas must have been very important for the development of Vygotsky's theory and whose influence on Vygotskian psychology – despite the lack of any formal records such as scholarly references to published works or co-authored papers – must have been pervasive and profound. In-depth analysis of the interrelations between the Vygotsky–Luria group and these peripheral members of the circle remains beyond the scope of this discussion. Yet, a digression is needed in order to illustrate the complexity and the multitude of the professional connections of this scientific alliance, if only to delimit the "inner circle" of Vygotsky and Luria. A number of individuals are of great importance for the complete reconstruction of Vygotsky's "peripheral circle" of his "invisible college." Among these are Soviet intellectuals and researchers Nikolai Bernstein, Solomon Gellerstein, Sergei Rubinstein, Dimitry Uznadze (alias: Usnadze) and German–American psychologists Kurt Koffka and Kurt Lewin to mention but a few (for the discussion of Lewin's influence and Soviet–German–American transnational communications and collaborative projects see Chapters 8 and 9). Let us consider just one example: Sergei Eisenstein.²

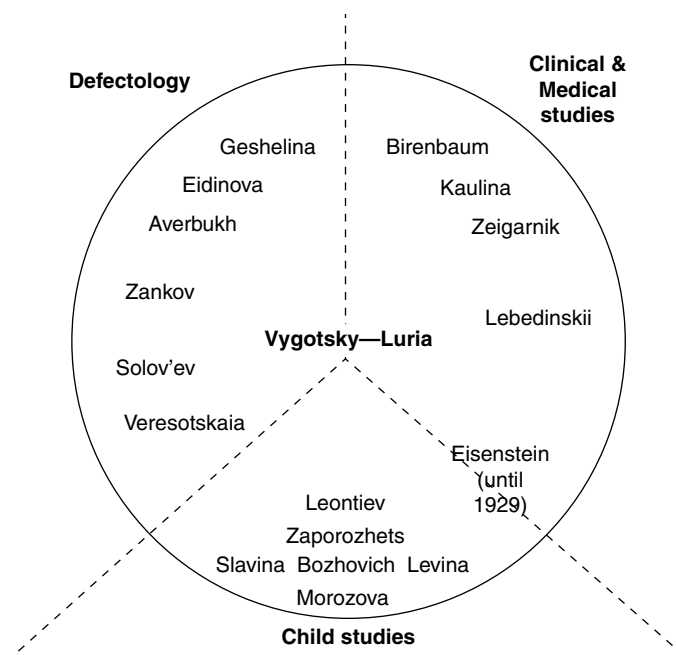


FIGURE 2.2 The Vygotsky–Luria circle in 1927–1931

Sergei Eisenstein (1898–1948), a revolutionary Soviet film director and film theorist, first met Luria sometime around the end of 1925/beginning of 1926, soon after the theatrical release of Eisenstein's *Bronenosets Potemkin* (*The battleship Potemkin*) in order to discuss psychological problems of the “theory and psychology of expressiveness” that were of great interest to him at that time. Luria most likely introduced Vygotsky and Eisenstein to each other, and the three eventually became close friends (E. A. Luria, 1994, p. 121). In the late 1920s, Eisenstein – along with Vygotsky and Luria – participated in psychological studies on human movement under hypnosis (in December, 1928) (E. A. Luria, 1994, p. 122) and the investigation of the phenomenal memory of the famous mnemonist Shereshevskii and in his notes of 1937 thus reflected on this case:

He [Shereshevskii] presents a unique example of a man who – along with the absolutely full and perfect development of a normal human being – preserved as well the entire set of early mechanisms of perception. Over the years, professors Vygotsky and Luria were doing a wide range of psychological observations and experiments with him. In turn, I managed to have a series of most interesting discussions with him about the problem that interested me: synaesthesia that was represented in him in utmost completeness (in 1928 and in 1933).

(Eisenstein, 2000, p. 385)

In the 1950s, Shereshevskii recalled the voices of Vygotsky and Eisenstein and described Vygotsky's "crumbly, yellow voice" and Eisenstein's voice as an "entire composition, a bouquet ... listening to him, it was as though a flame with fibers protruding from it was advancing right toward me" (record of November, 1951) (A. R. Luria, 1987, p. 24). The discovery of the only surviving manuscript of Vygotsky's doctoral dissertation *Psikhologiya iskusstva* (*The psychology of art*) in Eisenstein's personal archives attests to the fact that the contacts between these three individuals in the 1920s, before Eisenstein's trip to Europe and North America (August, 1929–May, 1932), were remarkably intense. In the early 1930s, after Eisenstein's return to the Soviet Union, another research project was conceived: the film director and theorist Sergei Eisenstein, the philologist academician Nikolai Marr, and the two psychologists Lev Vygotsky and Alexander Luria planned to systematically analyze the "problems of the nascent language of cinematography." However, the untimely death of Vygotsky (in June, 1934) and Marr (in December, 1934) put an end to this ongoing research (Eisenstein, 2002a, p. 136). Still, there is evidence that the group produced – or, at least, planned to produce – several scholarly papers that would present their findings to a Western audience. Thus, according to the announcements of 1932–3 in the section "Some Forthcoming Articles" of the journal *Character and Personality*, several papers by Russian authors were scheduled to come out, specifically the articles by Vygotsky (two papers titled "Comparative psychology of the child" and "Strong memory and the structure of personality"), Luria's "Self-analysis and social conduct," and Eisenstein's "The dynamics of facial expression (an experimental study in cinematography)." For unknown reasons, publication never took place, and we do not know the whereabouts of these manuscripts or even if they were ever submitted to the journal. The connections between the three of them seem to have been fairly strong, so even after Vygotsky's death and Luria's relatively short – intensive albeit intermittent – tenure in Kharkov's Ukrainian Psychoneurological Academy in 1931–4, personal and professional contacts between Eisenstein and Luria continued. The evidence for that can be found in Eisenstein's diaries, for instance, the entry of December 29, 1938 about the schizophrenic case of "Tioma" that Luria demonstrated to Eisenstein on December 26, 1938 (Eisenstein, 2004, p. 672) or his reference to the experiments with Luria in his diary entry of July 24, 1940 (Eisenstein, 2002b, p. 431) (for further discussion of the Eisenstein–Vygotsky–Luria intellectual interdependence see Bulgakowa, 2014).

And yet, despite the great importance of the peripheral interconnections with a wide range of intellectuals at home and worldwide, the work of the "inner circle" no doubt was even more important for the development of the original contribution of this group to theoretical and empirical psychology. From the end of the 1920s, for a number of organizational, social, political, professional, and – last but not the least – personal reasons, research in the "inner circle(s)" of Vygotsky and Luria was conducted by several relatively independent groups. The extent of independence and isolation of these groups varied.

This period was quite productive for Vygotsky, Luria, and their group's experimental research. Thus, Vygotsky continued the studies on concept formation that

had been interrupted by Leonid Sakharov's sudden death in May, 1928. Vygotsky's occasional collaborators Kotelova and Pashkovskaia undertook this research, and the study was completed by the end of 1929. As follows from the final footnote to the posthumous publication of Sakharov's paper that was read several months before his death at the Pedological Congress in Moscow, the study had been completed by the time of this publication, and a monograph was being prepared for the press (Sakharov, 1930, 1994). The monograph, though, was never published, and we do not know for sure if it was ever actually written.

Also during the late 1920s, Luria and Vygotsky initiated research in clinical settings, typically in collaboration with medical specialists (neurologists, psychiatrists, etc.), such as Mark Lebedinskii, Roza Averbukh, Lia Geshelina, or Marina Eidinova. This research was typically conducted under the auspices of the G. I. Rossolimo Clinic of Nervous Diseases of the First Moscow University and the Department of Clinical Psychology at the Academy of Communist Education (AKV) (Lebedinskii & Luria, 1929; A. R. Luria, 1929b, 1931a, 1932c). The alliance of Luria with Lebedinskii seems to have been instrumental in sustained clinical research in the Vygotsky circle from the end of the 1920s onwards. Also, it was during this period that Lebedinskii conducted major research on the development of "higher motor functions" in children that was published as a book in 1931 (Lebedinskii, 1931).

Another group of "Vygotskians" was formed during the period and included the five students of the Department of Pedology at the Second Moscow University (1925–30), later known as the *piaterka* ("the five") of Aleksander Zaporozhets, Lidia Bozhovich, Roza Levina, Natalia Morozova, and Lia Slavina. This group, along with the *troika* ("the three") of their teachers at the University – Vygotsky, Luria, and Leontiev – was involved in a series of experimental studies conducted under the aegis of either the Second Moscow University or the Psychological Laboratory at the Academy of Communist Education (AKV), such as: "The development of memory" (Leontiev), "Motor skills development in children" (Zaporozhets), "The role of sign-mediated [*znakovyi*] operations in the reaction of choice" (i.e. the development of complex choices in small children) (Morozova), "The planning role of speech" (R. Levina), and "The development of imitation in children" (Bozhovich and Slavina). At the same time, the whole group was collaboratively involved in studies using the "method of pictograms," when children of different ages were asked to invent pictures that would help them memorize a set of abstract words (A. R. Luria, 1979, pp. 46–51; Vygodskaya & Lifanova, 1996, p. 104). After their graduation in 1930, the members of the *piaterka* were appointed to mandatory jobs in different geographic locations across the Soviet Union (the so-called *raspredelenie*), and ceased to exist as a unity or a research team (see, e.g., the biography of one of the members of the group, Bozhovich, in Gutkina, 2008).

From Vygotsky's and Luria's overviews of the experimental studies done by their group by the beginning of the 1930s (Vygotski, 1930; Vygotskii, 1930b; Vygotsky & Luria, 1994), we also know about the studies on "active" (i.e. voluntary) remembering and attention (studies by Zankov, Solov'ev, and Veresotskaia), visual thinking

(Geshelina), the transition of external to internal speech (Leontiev, Shein), as well as clinical studies on patients with oligophrenia (Zankov, Leontiev, Bozhovich, and Slavina), aphasia (Luria, Slavina, Bozhovich, and Morozova), and hysteria (Eidinova and Zaporozhets). In his postwar publications, Luria also noted that a study on hysteria and the role of “hypoboulia” (i.e. unconscious) processes was initiated by Vygotsky in collaboration with Averbukh and Eidinova (A. R. Luria, 1960, pp. 434–435). Quite a few of these studies were never published and remain virtually unknown.

It was also during this period that a group of former students of Kurt Lewin, a German psychologist of the Gestalt school in Berlin, returned to the Soviet Union (in 1930–1) and joined the Vygotsky–Luria group. These included Gita Birenbaum, Nina Kaulina, and Bluma Zeigarnik, who started their work in clinical settings of the Institute of Higher Nervous Activity in Moscow and notably contributed to the convergence of Lev Vygotsky’s, Alexander Luria’s, and Kurt Lewin’s ideas (for further discussion see Chapters 8 and 9).

Phase three (1931–1934): Vygotsky–Luria circle and the beginning of specialization and separation (Moscow–Kharkov–Leningrad)

During the period 1931–4, several groups of “Vygotskians” were working in parallel in a number of institutions in three cities of the Soviet Union: Moscow, Kharkov, and Leningrad. However, the internal unity of this geographically and thematically extended research project was guaranteed by Vygotsky’s and Luria’s role as mediators between these groups and as coordinators of a whole range of studies of normal development, developmental pathology, and clinical research.

Until 1931, Vygotsky’s and Luria’s collaborators were working in a number of educational and research institutions in Moscow, but the end of the year was the turning point in the history of the groups, when a few of Vygotsky’s former colleagues left Moscow for **Kharkov** (the capital of Soviet Ukraine in 1919–34) to head research at the Psychology Sector of the newly formed Ukrainian Psychoneurological Academy (UPNA). This group of ‘Kharkovites’, formed by the local psychologists (e.g. Gal’perin, Zinchenko, Asnin, Rozenblum, and others) and the newcomers from Moscow (Luria, Leontiev, Lebedinskii, Bozhovich, Zaporozhets, and his wife Ginevskaia), is commonly referred to as the “Kharkov school of psychology” and is best known for their work on the foundations of what is often called Leontiev’s “activity theory” (Yasnitsky, 2008, 2009a; Yasnitsky & Ferrari, 2008a, 2008b).

Vygotsky also might have planned to move to Kharkov at some point and – along with Luria – even started his studies at the extramural department at the local Medical Institute, but his move to Kharkov never took place, and instead, in the fall of 1931, he accepted an invitation to lecture part-time in **Leningrad** at the Herzen State Pedagogical Institute. This is where a third research center was formed. From 1931 until his death, Vygotsky frequently commuted to Leningrad to lecture and supervise the research of the Leningrad group of his collaborators, which included

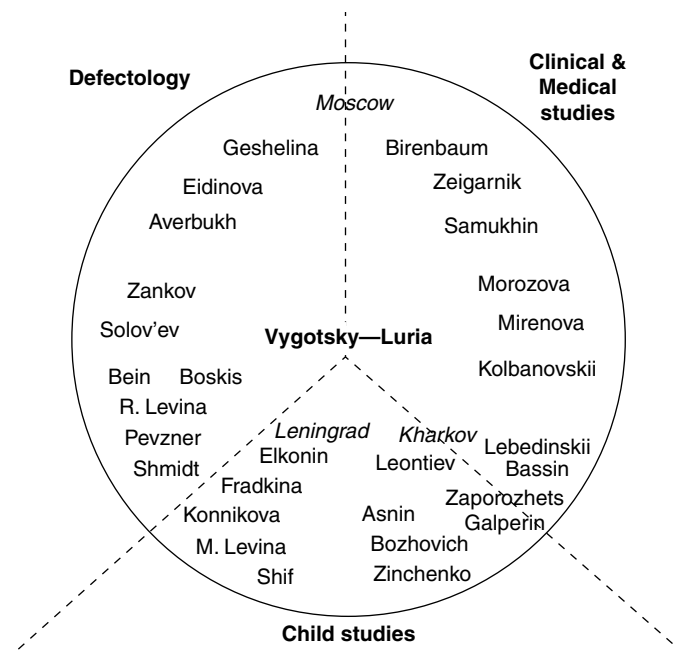


FIGURE 2.3 The Vygotsky–Luria circle in 1931–1934

Daniil El'konin, Mira Levina (not to be confused with Roza Levina, from Moscow), Zhozefina Shif, Tatiana Konnikova, Frida Fradkina, and several others.

In **Moscow**, Vygotskian studies continued in the field of defectology under the auspices of the Moscow Experimental Defectological Institute (EDI). This group included long-time Vygotsky collaborators Zankov and Solov'ev and their colleagues, such as medical doctors, educationalists, and defectologists Vera Schmidt, Maria Pevzner, Rakhil' Boskis, Roza Levina, Natalia Morozova, Esfir' Bein, Ksenia Veresotskaia, Marina Eidinova, Lia Geshelina, and Zhozefina Shif (the latter moved from Leningrad to Moscow in the early 1930s).

Another line of Vygotskian research in Moscow in the early 1930s was conducted by Kurt Lewin's former Berlin students Bluma Zeigarnik, Gita Birenbaum, and Nina Kaulina, who returned to the Soviet Union in 1930–1 and started collaborating with Vygotsky's group on psychological research in clinical settings (Birenbaum and Zeigarnik) and in the field of child studies (Kaulina: in VIEM, from the mid-1930s). In 1931–2 Birenbaum and Zeigarnik worked at the Clinical Department of the Institute for Research in Higher Nervous Activity (IVND), and later moved to the All-Union Institute of Experimental Medicine (VIEM) in 1933. Until Vygotsky's last days they worked in VIEM under his (and Luria's) supervision and, according to their publications, collaborated with a group of researchers at the local psychiatric clinic, mostly medical doctors – psychiatrists and neurologists – that included N. V. Samukhin, E. S. Kaganovskaia, and A. M. Dubinin.

The work of the Moscow group of clinical psychologists was paralleled by clinical research in Kharkov, at the Department of Clinical Psychology of the Ukrainian Psychoneurological Academy (UPNA) (Luria, Lebedinskii, Gal'perin, Zaporozhets, Bassin, Kozis, Margolis, and Voloshin).

During the last months of his life, in the spring of 1934, Vygotsky was hectically working to organize a psychological department – hypothetically, a department of clinical psychology – at VIEM (Vygodskaya & Lifanova, 1996, pp. 129, 318–319), most likely with the Psychological Sector of the UPNA in Kharkov as a model for this new organizational unit. According to Vygotsky's archival documents, he was going to form another research team and invite a number of individuals, including Solov'ev, Zankov, Veresotskaia, R. Levina, Slavina, and Shif (Vygodskaya & Lifanova, 1996, p. 129). Unfortunately, this project was never realized: in May, 1934, due to a throat hemorrhage that was caused by chronic tuberculosis, Vygotsky was prescribed bed rest until his hospitalization and death in June, 1934. This is the situation that Alexander Luria described in his speech at the L. S. Vygotsky memorial meeting in Moscow at the Dom Uchenykh (House of Scientists) on January 6, 1935:

This death was even more tragic given that Lev Semenovich died amongst everybody's devotion and love, for the first time in his life being on the verge of bringing all his plans to life and gathering the organized group of researchers he had been dreaming about all his life, and who could undertake the realization of everything that was hidden in this brain of a genius.

(A. R. Luria, 2003a, p. 275)

Phase four (1934–1936): the circles of Vygotskians and disintegration of the original research program

After Vygotsky's death, several groups – or, for that matter, several circles – of researchers evolved. The two major circles were formed by Vygotsky's former associates at the Experimental Defectological Institute (renamed Scientific-Practical Institute for Special Schools and Children's Houses of the *Narkompros* of the RSFSR in the mid-1930s) and scholars of the so-called Kharkov group (Kharkov school) that remained virtually unchanged from the preceding period.

In 1934 both Luria (in March) and Leontiev (at the end of the year) returned to Moscow from Kharkov. Well before he officially quit as the Head of Department of Psychology in Kharkov, Luria was hired by the Medico-Biological Institute (in March, 1935 renamed Medico-Genetic Institute), where he took charge of the Psychological Department and, following the earlier work of Lebedinskii and other researchers affiliated with the institute, such as Anna Mirenova, Viktor Kolbanovskii, and Faina Yudovich (Lebedinskii, 1932; Mirenova, 1932, 1934; Mirenova & Kolbanovskii, 1934; Mirenva [*sic*], 1935), headed this team of researchers and launched a series of experimental studies with twins. Some of these studies were published in the 1930s (A. R. Luria, 1936; A. R. Luria & Mirenova, 1936a, 1936b;

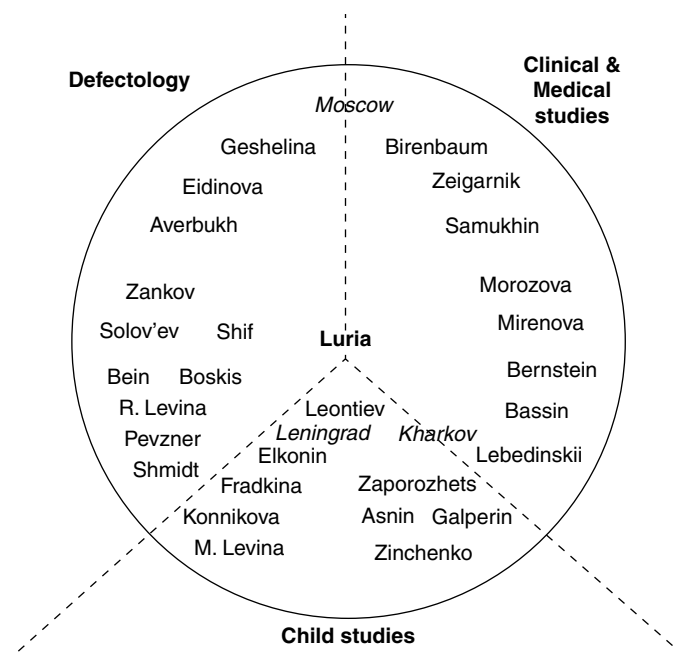


FIGURE 2.4 The circles of Vygotskians in 1934–1936

A. R. Luria, Mirenova, & Morozova, 1936), yet others came out only several decades later (A. R. Luria, 1948, 1962, 2002; A. R. Luria & Yudovich, 1956, 1959). This research on the interrelation between genetic and cultural factors in development of twins made visible impact on Vygotsky's thought in the last year of his life as evidenced by his increasing involvement with the problems of the role of inheritance and environment in the child's development in his 1933–4 “pedological” lectures and public presentations, published posthumously (Vygotskii, 1934b, 1935b, 1996, 2001).

From October, 1934, Luria was also serving as the Head of the Department of Clinical Psychology at VIEM. It is not quite clear yet if Luria was officially employed at the Defectological Institute, but, by his own account, he collaborated with researchers from this institute, many of whom had been the old-time members of the Vygotsky–Luria circle. Thus, Luria's “inner circle” and research team of that time included Birenbaum, Zeigarnik (Clinical Psychology Department of the All-Union Institute of Experimental Medicine), Mirenova, Morozova, and Yudovich (Department of Psychology of the Medico-Genetic Institute), as well as R. Levina, Boskis, and S. Ya. Rabinovich (all from the Defectological Institute) (Luria, 1937).

Leontiev also left Kharkov and in October, 1934, like Luria, was hired by VIEM, where he headed the Laboratory of Genetic (i.e. Developmental) Psychology. Around this time, Leontiev also became a Professor at the Higher Communist Institute of Enlightenment (in Russian: *Vysshii Kommunisticheskii Institut Prosvescheniia*,

VKIP). Formally, he also remained employed by the Ukrainian Psychoneurological Academy in Kharkov (until December, 1936) and the Kharkov State Pedagogical Institute (until December 1, 1937), and occasionally traveled to Kharkov to supervise the work of his colleagues (Leontiev, Leontiev, & Sokolova, 2005, pp. 59, 63). The work of the group of Kharkov scholars was discussed at length in recent publications on the development of Vygotskian psychology in the “Kharkov school” (Yasnitsky & Ferrari, 2008a, 2008b). During this period the Leningrad group of developmental psychologists from the Herzen State Pedagogical Institute, led by El’konin, established first personal and professional contacts with the Kharkov group and became increasingly close to the Kharkov developmentalists. An interesting research project, very highly reminiscent of Kurt Lewin’s “topological psychology,” was conducted in Gorky Central Park of Culture and Leisure in Moscow in 1935 under the supervision of Leontiev and his colleague from the Kharkov Institute of Labor A. I. Rozenblium. Another former student of Vygotsky’s – Lidia Bozhovich – also participated (A. N. Leontiev & Rozenblium, 1999). This was the only distinctly “topological” study conducted by the associates of Vygotsky. Such an “anomaly” does not strike as inexplicably mysterious given that among the participants of the study was Nina Kaulina, a former Berlin student of the founder of “topological psychology,” Kurt Lewin (Lewin, 1936) (for discussion see Chapter 9). Both Bozhovich and Kaulina were Leontiev’s subordinates in the Department of Genetic Psychology at VIEM that he headed at that time.

This period may well be referred to as the brief “Golden Age” of Vygotskian psychology in the interwar period (Yasnitsky, 2012e). Thus, after a dramatic decline in the number of Vygotsky’s publications in 1932–3 (e.g. just two publications in 1933: a scholarly paper on thinking in schizophrenia and a two-page-long introduction to a book), a pile of Vygotsky’s books came out posthumously in 1934–6, including his *Thinking and speech* (1934), *Foundations of paedology* (two editions: Moscow: Second Moscow State University, 1934 and Leningrad: Herzen State Pedagogical Institute, 1935), *Mental development of children in the process of learning* (1935), *The mentally retarded child* (1935, co-edited by Vygotsky and Daniushevskii), and *Diagnostics of [human] development and paedological clinical treatment of abnormal childhood development* (1936).

All these book publications became possible due to the concerted effort of Vygotsky’s students and collaborators, the former members of the Vygotsky–Luria circle. Thus, for instance, *Thinking and speech* was prepared for posthumous publication by Kolbanovskii, Zankov, and Shif (Kolbanovskii, 1934, p. v). According to Aleksei N. Leontiev’s recently published memoirs of the early 1970s, the participation of Kolbanovskii in this publication project was not incidental: Kolbanovskii, who was never in any formal way associated with Vygotsky, still, reportedly, considered himself as Vygotsky’s associate and follower (A. N. Leontiev & Yaroshevskii, 2013). Indeed, the first postwar publication with Vygotsky’s name in the very title was the paper by Kolbanovskii, who was the first in the decade of the 1950s to openly and most energetically advocate Vygotsky and his methodological standpoint (Kolbanovskii, 1956). This fact not only corroborates the testimony of

Leontiev in his reminiscences of the early 1970s, but also suggests that Kolbanovskii might well have been instrumental in the organization of the first postwar publication of Vygotsky's works, the volume of 1956 (for a discussion of the complexities and the history of domestic publication and non-publication of Vygotsky's works see Chapters 3 and 4).

Another posthumous volume was published in 1935, also by Zankov and Shif, in collaboration with El'konin (Vygotskii, 1935d). The latter book presents a remarkable collection of Vygotsky's works of the 1930s on the problems of the interrelation between learning and development. It was in this book that perhaps the best known of Vygotsky's theoretical innovations, the "zone of proximal development," was discussed at considerable length. Some of these texts that came out in English translation four decades later (Vygotsky, 1978) were instrumental in the launch of the "Vygotsky boom" among North American educators and psychologists (Cole, 2004). Also in 1935, a volume of collected defectological papers by Vygotsky, Zankov, and Solov'ev-Elpidinskii came out in Moscow under the supervision of the director of the Defectological Institute, Daniushevskii (Vygotskii & Daniushevskii, 1935). A handbook on the foundations of pedology was published in Leningrad under the editorship of Mira Levina of the Herzen Leningrad Pedagogical Institute (Vygotskii, 1935b), and yet another pedological booklet was prepared for publication in 1935 and published the following year in Moscow by Roza Levina of the Experimental Defectological Institute (Vygotskii, 1936).

Finally, during this period Vygotsky's students conducted research on normal and retarded child development and the degradation of mental functions (for an overview see Yasnitsky, 2008; Yasnitsky & Ferrari, 2008a). Several works in the fields of defectology and clinical psychology were published with explicit acknowledgement of Vygotsky's supervision or collaboration (Birenbaum, 1934; Birenbaum & Zeigarnik, 1935; Kaganovskaia & Zeigarnik, 1935; Samukhin, Birenbaum, & Vygotskii, 1934; Zeigarnik, 1934; Zeigarnik & Birenbaum, 1935), and several books by former Vygotsky students came out with a dedication to the memory of their late teacher (Levina, 1936; Shif, 1935; Zankov, 1935).

Phase five (1936–1941): the beginning of the "Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria school"

The notorious decree of the Communist Party on "pedological perversions" officially banned studies in pedology in July, 1936. In addition, in the summer of 1936 a campaign against Western (i.e. bourgeois) influences in Soviet science and a patriotic struggle with "kowtowing to the West" was launched. This campaign specifically targeted Soviet scholars who published their work abroad (the so-called "Luzin affair"). Finally, the summer of 1936 is notorious as the beginning of major political trials that initiated the "Great Terror" (alternatively: the "Great Purge") in the Soviet Union. All these processes contributed to social unrest and led to the

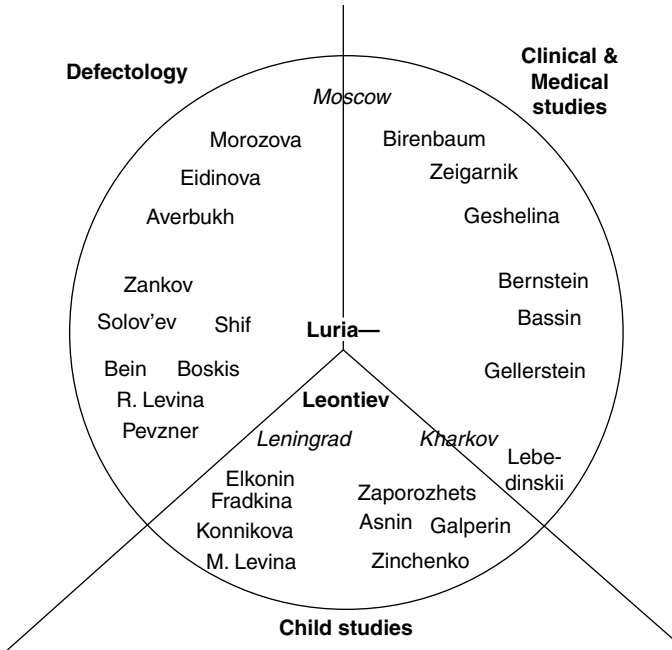


FIGURE 2.5 The circles of Vygotskians in 1936–1941

period of instability in the established system of interrelations between scholars and their Bolshevik patrons in power.

Thus, by the end of 1936, Luria – a professor of psychology with a record of international publications – resigned from all his academic and research positions in order to “disappear” in the relative quietness of an internship at the N. N. Burdenko Clinic of Neurosurgery in Moscow that he qualified for as a recent Medical Department graduate (graduated in 1937), in isolation from social pressure. This internship (1937–9) probably helped him survive the years of the Great Terror. Then, in 1939, he joined the Institute of Experimental Medicine in Moscow where he – yet again – headed the Laboratory of Experimental Psychology (E. A. Luria, 1994, p. 89). Indeed, the two years 1936–7 of Stalin’s Great Terror can be best described as a period of the utmost instability, anxiety, and disorientation. The second half of the 1930s, though, is typically notoriously misunderstood and its significance is underplayed by historians of Soviet psychology. Yet, this period seems to be particularly important for the development of the entire course of Soviet psychology. Let us see why this is so. The careers of two protagonists, Aleksei Leontiev and Alexander Luria, are particularly interesting in this respect and deserve a closer analysis.

On the basis of fairly fragmentary evidence available to date we know that both Leontiev and Luria were very active and had made quite impressive careers by their mid-thirties when the disastrous July 4, 1936 decree prohibiting pedology was issued. A series of discussions of the decree ensued. Criticism of Vygotsky and his

associates, one of the leaders of pedology at the time, concluded with a notorious booklet signed with the name of Eva Rudneva, and titled *Pedological perversions of Vygotsky* (Rudneva, 1937). This publication, which came out in January of 1937, virtually replicated the title of the Communist Party decree and constituted the major offensive against Vygotsky and his followers. There is circumstantial evidence to the effect that both Leontiev and Luria were likely to have been forced to quit their jobs around 1936–7. We can also assume that Luria had to temporarily flee from Moscow in order to find a relative refuge in the Caucasus area. From the publication of Luria's correspondence with Max Wertheimer we know, for example, that his letter to Wertheimer of September, 1936 was sent with a return address in Teberda (Caucasus region) (King & Wertheimer, 2005). Likewise, it was in Tbilisi, Soviet Georgia, under uncertain circumstances, that Luria defended his doctoral dissertation, allegedly, in 1937. Perhaps, resigning from their professorships and fleeing from the capital were not the only social strategies for physical and professional survival used by Luria and Leontiev. Thus, we know about a paper by Leontiev on "The teaching about environment in pedological works of L.S. Vygotsky (a critical investigation)" that was most likely the basis for an oral presentation that he made some time during the turbulent years of 1936–7 (A. N. Leontiev, 1998, 2005). Such a presentation was likely to have taken place in 1937 when, after a considerable break, Leontiev returned to the Institute of Psychology. This paper was originally located in the archives of the Institute and was not published until the late 1990s, when it was accidentally discovered by the well-known Russian scholar Irina Ravich-Shcherbo. Employed as a strategy of survival, Leontiev's public critique of Vygotsky might have served the purpose of distancing himself from Vygotsky and his affiliation with pedology. Another strategy that both Leontiev and Luria must have applied was to establish personal connections with decision-makers and key individuals in power at that time; in the absence of any official or archival documents, we can only speculate about such possible connections. For example, Alexander Luria's father, Roman Al'bertovich Luria, was one of the most successful medical professionals of the time, and the personal doctor to quite a few of the elite inhabitants of the Moscow Kremlin, including the Prosecutor General of the USSR Andrei Vyshinskii (E. A. Luria, 1994). Another of Alexander Luria's possible connections with the Communist Party leadership was Lev Sheinin, an aide to Vyshinskii in the late 1930s, with whom Luria collaborated in the mid-1920s during his studies on the traces of affective reactions in suspected criminals. This research resulted in the publication of Luria's first major English book *The nature of human conflicts* (A. R. Luria, 1930c, 1932c). It is still unclear who exactly helped Luria and Leontiev establish personal connections with key figures in power, but it is fairly apparent that both scholars were successful in building such connections with powerful patrons of the time.

Thus, it is not coincidental that it was in 1939 that both Luria and Leontiev were appointed to supervisory positions in research and educational institutions in Moscow and Leningrad. A contemporary historian of Soviet science, culture, and society, Nikolai Kremmentsov, points out that

by 1939, Soviet scientists understood perfectly well the principles of operation of the Stalinist science system and had learned to use that system to their own advantage. They knew that the real power was concentrated in the highest party bodies – the Central Committee and its Secretariat – and they petitioned party bosses in numerous letters. For their part, the party bosses read scientists' petitions and relayed them with their own remarks and notes to the lower level of the party hierarchy “for consideration” or “for implementation,” and sometimes “for archiving”. These second-hand echelon bureaucrats prepared concrete decisions and sent them back to the top for approval. The behaviour of both the top officials and their subordinates was shaped by their own interests and agendas, and thus by considerations external to the scientific questions raised in the petition.

(Krementsov, 1997, p. 80)

It is clear that from the end of the 1930s onwards only those individuals who thoroughly understood the real meaning of Soviet science policy and the internal mechanics of decision-making in the country could make scientific careers in the Soviet Union.

In 1940 Leontiev defended his dissertation on the “Genesis of the psyche,” largely based on empirical research on the origin of sensation conducted in Kharkov and Moscow in the mid-1930s under his supervision. Along with S. L. Rubinstein and B. M. Teplov, an opponent at Leontiev's doctoral dissertation defense was Leon Orbeli, a great Pavlovian scholar and one of the most influential figures in Soviet scientific hierarchy before World War II. By 1940 Orbeli, considered Pavlov's scientific heir after his death in 1936, was a Member of the Academy of Sciences of the USSR (from 1935), the Head of the Institute of Physiology of the Academy of Sciences of the USSR (from 1936), and Director of the I. P. Pavlov Institute of Evolutionary Physiology and Pathology of Higher Nervous Activity (from 1939). Furthermore, in 1942 Orbeli was appointed Vice-President of the Soviet Academy of Sciences and in 1943 Head of the Military Medical Academy in Leningrad. It seems that connections with Orbeli as well as with a number of other prominent scholars (and, most likely, Soviet officials) of the highest rank in the hierarchy of the Soviet scientific establishment was one of the key factors that facilitated Leontiev's future success as one of the leaders of Marxist Soviet psychology. Furthermore, as a token of recognition of their trustworthiness and loyalty, both Luria and Leontiev were invited to contribute to the most prestigious *Bol'shaia Sovetskaia Entsiklopediia* (Great Soviet Encyclopaedia), particularly, to co-author such important articles as *Psikhologiia* (Psychology) and *Rech'* (Speech) (A. N. Leontiev & Luria, 1941; A. R. Luria & Leontiev, 1940). In addition, they contributed an independent article each: both Luria's *Psikhoanaliz* (Psychoanalysis) (A. R. Luria, 1940) and Leontiev's *Psikhika* (Psyche) (A. N. Leontiev, 1940) came out in 1940. These publications of Luria and Leontiev in this multi-volume edition – perhaps the most prestigious edition of the time – marked the inclusion of their authors in the Soviet scientific *nomenklatura* of the highest rank. Hence, not surprisingly, during the war Luria and

Leontiev were appointed the heads of military hospitals in the Ural region. Fairly soon thereafter, both joined the Communist Party of the Soviet Union (Luria in 1943, Leontiev in 1948), a move that should most likely be interpreted as a precondition of future social success and major career advancement.

From the end of the 1930s, therefore, the alliance of Luria and Leontiev formed the new organizational center of Vygotskian psychology. Also, this is the origin of the “school of Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria” and the “Kharkov school of psychology.” The latter term was probably first introduced in 1938, but would not get actively used in historiographical and psychological discourse until the late 1970s (Yasnitsky, 2009a). As the new center, Luria and Leontiev served as mediators between different groups of scholars who continued the Vygotskian line of research in the country. For instance, the remains of the Leningrad group and the Kharkov group received considerable support from Leontiev around the mid-1930s when they established personal and professional ties between the two groups in Kharkov and in Leningrad (for instance, Leontiev served as an official supervisor of the dissertation of El’konin, from Leningrad, at his defense in 1935). The ties between the Leningrad and Kharkov groups especially strengthened after 1939 when Leontiev – like Vygotsky in 1931 – started commuting between Moscow and Leningrad, where he spent ten days of each month lecturing and heading the Department of Psychology at the Leningrad Krupskaja Pedagogical Institute (A. A. Leontiev et al., 2005, p. 74). Thus, during this period Leontiev’s brokerage between different groups of scholars was somewhat limited to Soviet scholars, who mostly worked in the field of child studies. In turn, Luria was instrumental in establishing international and cross-disciplinary communications between clinical and defectological researchers that, in turn, considerably contributed to his own studies on the brain and the then-nascent discipline of neuropsychology (see, e.g., A. R. Luria, 1937).

Relatively little is known about the research of the former members of the Vygotsky–Luria circle after 1936. There was no a single specialized psychological journal in the country at that time: the journals *Psikhologiya* (Psychology) and *Pedologiya* (Pedology) were closed down in 1932, *Sovetskaia Psikhotehnika* (Soviet Psychotechnics) in 1934. In 1936, *Nevropatologiya, Psikhiaetriia i Psikhogigiena* (Neuropathology, psychiatry, and mental hygiene) was renamed and shortened to just *Nevropatologiya i Psikhiaetriia* (Neuropathology and psychiatry), which clearly left out “psikhogigiena” (i.e. mental hygiene). Still, this Moscow journal, along with the journal *Sovetskaia Psikhonevrologiya* (Soviet psychoneurology) that was published in Kharkov, was accepting studies by clinical psychologists and defectologists, and several studies by former Vygotskians such as Zeigarnik, Lebedinskii, Boskis, Levina, and their associates were published there (Boskis & Levina, 1936, 2006; Dubinin & Zeigarnik, 1940; Lebedinskii, 1936, 1938, 1940). Another major outlet for psychologists during that period was the journal *Sovetskaia Pedagogika* (Soviet pedagogy, founded in 1937) that published several papers by defectologists, developmentalists, and educational psychologists formerly associated with Vygotsky (Boskis & Levina, 1938; Bozhovich, 1937, 1940; A. N. Leontiev, 1937; Levina, 1940; Slavina, 1939). In addition, Soviet scholars’ publications abroad in foreign languages were getting

increasingly rare during the second half of 1930s, but still – quite contrary to popular opinion – were not impossible for researchers in the Soviet Union (Yasnitsky, 2011c). For a few examples of such foreign publications by Soviet psychologists in the late 1930s see the works of the participants of the Vygotsky–Luria circle that came out in 1936–7 in three languages – German, English, and French – in Austria, the United States, and France, respectively (Lebedinsky, 1936a, 1936b; A. R. Luria, 1936, 1937).

Quite a few studies came out in various *Scientific notes* of institutes such as the Herzen State Pedagogical Institute in Leningrad and the Kharkov State Pedagogical Institute. Finally, several books written by the former members of the Vygotsky–Luria group were published in a range of subfields of psychological research. These include clinical psychology (Lebedinskii, 1941), but are mainly concerned with defectology (Boskis, 1939; Daniushevskii & Zankov, 1941; Korsunskaiia & Morozova, 1939; Pevzner, 1941; Zankov, 1939; Zankov & Daniushevskii, 1940; Zankov & Solov'ev, 1940).

All these studies present an interesting yet unexplored development of what we might refer to as the “Vygotsky–Luria–Lewin project” of the mid-1930s. However, one should certainly keep in mind that in many instances due to self-censorship – whether legitimate and necessary or not quite – the authors afforded only indirect, camouflaged references to Vygotsky or, for that matter, Kurt Lewin after 1936, which certainly complicates the task of historical and theoretical reconstruction (for a discussion of censorship issues in relation to Vygotsky's and, for that matter, Lewin's and, more broadly, Gestaltist scholarship see Chapters 3 and 9, respectively).

3

DECONSTRUCTING VYGOTSKY'S VICTIMIZATION NARRATIVE

A re-examination of the “Stalinist suppression” of Vygotskian theory

Jennifer Fraser and Anton Yasnitsky

Although many facets of Lev Vygotsky's (1896–1934) life have attracted considerable attention from historians of science, perhaps the most commonly acknowledged feature of his personal narrative was that he was actively chastised by the Stalinist government, with his work being placed under an enforced publication ban that would persist for a period of almost twenty years after his death. References to this infamous ban pervade contemporary accounts of Vygotsky – almost all of them emphasizing that in the years from 1936 to 1956, it was forbidden to either discuss or disseminate any of Vygotsky's works within the Soviet Union. According to these narratives, it was only after Stalin's death in 1953 that Vygotsky's ideas were able to resurface in Russia, as a network of his collaborators and associates began to circulate his central tenets during the late 1950s, which is allegedly due to the first post-Stalinist era publication of Vygotsky's works in 1956.

In the most general sense, the entire corpus of literature that to a varying extent focuses on Lev Vygotsky and his scientific legacy can be referred to as “Vygotsky studies.” Hardly an independent field of knowledge, these “Vygotsky studies” are informed by and feed back to several somewhat more canonical scholarly traditions such as psychology and education, the history of the Soviet Union and Russia, and the history of human sciences. There are notable differences between all these disciplinary subfields, and we are fully aware of the dangers of oversimplification, yet for simplicity's sake these will be further referred to as “psychology” and “history,” and their agents will be described as “psychologists” and “historians” respectively. Thus, it might be instructive to sketch an outline of the early history of the “Vygotsky ban” narrative as it is presented in various publications on Vygotsky in the West and in the East. The history of the reception and the social construction of the life story of Vygotsky and his legacy has not been written yet, and such endeavor is definitely beyond the scope of this chapter. Yet, we believe that some tentative generalizations

are possible even at this early stage and that this study contributes to understanding the “Vygotsky myth” as it circulates in the contemporary international context.

Deconstructing the narrative of the “Vygotsky ban”

Presumably the first reference to the “Vygotsky ban” can be found as early as in the first major post-World War II English-language publication of Vygotsky's work. This is Jerome S. Bruner's Introduction to Vygotsky's book *Thinking and speech*, which came out under the title *Thought and language* in 1962 (Vygotsky, 1962). Twenty years later, in his autobiography, Bruner described the circumstances of his participation in this publication project: “Then in 1961, after his official ‘rehabilitation’ in Russia and a great deal of backing and filing diplomatically to obtain rights, his *Thought and language* was translated into English by my colleague Eugenia Hanfmann. She asked me to write a preface” (Bruner, 1983, p. 139). Then this Introduction, signed by its author in July 1961 in Cambridge, Massachusetts – among other fairly curious statements of interest to a historian of science – presents the following paragraph:

For an English-speaking audience it avails little to trace the ideological course of Vygotsky's work through the groundswells and storms of psychology in the Soviet Union. It was inevitable that his work should disturb the doctrinaire guardians of “proper Marxian interpretation,” particularly during the period of the “battle for consciousness.” As two of Vygotsky's most gifted collaborators, Luria and Leontiev, put it in 1958, introducing the German translation of his work in the *Zeitschrift für Psychologie*,¹ “The first and most important task of that time [the late 1920's and 1930's when the ‘battle for consciousness’ raged]² consisted of freeing oneself, on the one hand, from vulgar behaviorism, and, on the other hand, from the subjective approach to mental phenomena as exclusively inner subjective conditions which can only be investigated introspectively.” It is no surprise then that Vygotsky's *Thought and Language* should have been suppressed in 1936, two years after its appearance, not to reappear again until 1956.

(Bruner, 1962, pp. v–vi)

Jerome Bruner (born in 1915), not a historian but a stellar human sciences researcher and a classic of American and British psychology, clearly did not have first-hand knowledge of Vygotsky or, apparently lacking reading knowledge of Russian, of his original Russian legacy and clearly owed to somebody else the information that he reproduced in his Introduction. Indeed, on another occasion, in a chapter of a book of 1985 that was based on a special “Vygotskian” conference held in Chicago in 1980,³ Bruner provided an account of his first encounter with the name and ideas of Vygotsky. It was in Montreal in 1954, when the first post-World War II Soviet delegation took part in the International Congress of Psychology. As

we know, the delegation included the Soviet scholars B. M. Teplov, A. N. Leontiev, A. V. Zaporozhets, G. S. Kostiuk, E. N. Sokolov, and E. A. Asratyan. Out of the six members of the delegation, it was Sokolov and Asratyan who were (psycho)physiologists, and only the latter – the founding director of the Institute of Higher Nervous Activity in Moscow – can be described as a “true Pavlovian.” Bruner comments on the fairly unusual (by the standards of Western academia) impression made by the Russian presentations he attended in Montreal in 1954:

Their presented papers characteristically started with a genuflection to Pavlov, followed quickly by some rather interesting studies of attention or problem solving or whatever that had little to do with the Pavlov I read. They seemed to represent some other interest whose nature I could not quite discern. And then there was a classically Russian reception toward the end of the week, replete with vodka and a barrel of caviar. It was at that reception (and an informal party at Wilder Penfield’s) that I first encountered talk of Vygotsky ... Vygotsky’s work, I learned that evening, was widely circulated, though it was officially banned.

(Bruner, 1985, p. 22)

This encounter with the idiosyncratic “quasi-Pavlovian” Soviet psychology apparently triggered Bruner’s interest in Soviet research and continued contacts between Bruner and some Russian scholars, most notably, Alexander Luria – Vygotsky’s closest associate and the most ardent advocate of Vygotsky’s scholarship in the West – who was highly instrumental in securing Vygotsky’s first English-language book publication. Thus, according to Bruner’s reminiscences, Luria’s impact on him was quite notable, at least as far as the image of Vygotsky and his scholarly legacy is concerned:

Vygotsky’s book finally appeared in English in 1962. I was asked to write an introduction to it. By then I had learned enough about Vygotsky from accounts of his work by Alexander Romanovich Luria, with whom I had become close friends, so that I welcomed this added goad to close study. And I read the book not only with meticulous care, but with growing astonishment. For Vygotsky was plainly a genius. Yet it was an elusive form of genius, his.

(Bruner, 1985, p. 23)

The narrative of ban (and “rehabilitation”) yet resurfaces in Bruner’s autobiography of 1983: “Vygotsky published little, and virtually nothing that appeared in English before 1960; indeed, until the late 1950s, most of what he wrote in Russian was suppressed and had been banned after the 1936 purge” (Bruner, 1985, p. 137). Thus, by the beginning of the so-called “Vygotsky boom” in the mid-1980s the idea of a “ban,” or “suppression,” of Vygotsky in 1936–56 and his subsequent “rehabilitation” seems to have been as much common knowledge about Vygotsky as it was part and parcel of the narrative of “Vygotsky the (elusive) genius.” This

complex construct of “elusive genius as victim” triggered two – often intertwined, yet distinct – lines within “Vygotsky studies,” especially those produced by authors that we refer to as “psychologists” (i.e. psychologists and educationists as opposed to “historians”; on the latter see below).

The first line can be referred to by the title of the famous book by René van der Veer and Jaan Valsiner *Understanding Vygotsky* (1991). Indeed, the “elusiveness” of Vygotsky’s genius generated quite a number of publications attempting to understand what exactly constitutes the ingenuity of Vygotsky and what his original and distinctly “Vygotskian” contribution to psychological science is. Such publications, the earliest of which appeared in the 1930s, are numerous and keep appearing (see, e.g., Yasnitsky, van der Veer, & Ferrari, 2014).

The second line is represented by the numerous references to the “Vygotsky ban” that reappear in virtually any writing that deals with the life of Vygotsky from the 1980s onwards. One example of the reference to the ban and speculations about its causes can be found in *Vygotsky and the social formation of mind*. This is the book by James Wertsch that was partially based on the author’s conversations with Vygotsky’s daughter, Gita Vygodskaya (1925–2010), in October, 1981 (Wertsch, 1985, p. 13) and appears to be one of the first English-language books that mentions Vygotsky’s name in the very title:

A few of Vygotsky’s writings were published shortly after his death, but for political reasons a twenty-year period ensued when his work was for all practical purposes banned in the USSR. This resulted partly from the 1936 decree of the Central Committee of the Communist Party against pedology, a discipline roughly equivalent to educational psychology, especially as it concerns psychometrics ... Other factors in the demise of Vygotsky’s official position were the conflict between some of his claims and those found in Stalin’s 1950 essay on linguistics, and the rise in the late 1940s of a form of dogmatic Pavlovianism that is now referred to in the USSR as “vulgar materialism”.

(Wertsch, 1985, p. 14)

Vygotsky, a cult figure to a number of psychologists and educationalists, remained of relatively little interest to scholars outside these areas of studies and social practice. In contrast with psychologists, historians – including historians of the human sciences – until quite recently have largely by-passed “Vygotsky studies;” therefore, we have a fairly limited number of historical publications that would focus on Vygotsky and his associates. Then, the historiography of the human sciences is distinct from the writings of psychologists in yet another respect. Unlike psychologists, who produced a corpus of fairly elevated and laudatory literature, the publications of historians are notably more reserved and even, on some occasions, demonstrate quite critical – if not ironic – attitudes to the topic of their discussion. For an example of this kind of discourse see the paper by David Joravsky, a noted American historian of the Soviet Union, whose paper of 1987, characteristically titled “L. S. Vygotskii: the muffled deity of Soviet psychology,” predated his treatment of this

topic in his monumental book on Russian psychology (Joravsky, 1987, 1989). Thus, describing the impact of Vygotsky on Russian psychological scholarship, Joravsky made the astute and fairly scorching observation that:

He laid out a most ambitious program of unification [of fragmented psychologies of the day], with an “historico-cultural” approach as the central feature. Though tuberculosis cut him off at a very early age, Vygotskii left prolific disciples, most notably A.R. Luria (1902–1977) and A.N. Leont’ev (1903–1979), who founded the Vygotskii school of cognitive psychology, focused on brain damage and child development. There is a great irony in that history: Preaching a comprehensive science, Vygotskii started one more school. Much of his work was actually concealed by his avowed disciples or by the censorship, or by some combination of timid disciples and fearsome censors. His major books were withheld from publication, for 40 years in one case, 55 in another. When they finally appeared, his admirers had become thoroughly specialized adepts in one or two parts of his comprehensive project, conditioned to ignore the rest. There are peculiarly Soviet features in this ironic history, but there are also striking analogies to the fate of Wundt or James among Western psychologists, who also profess reverence for founding fathers and ignore their central ideas.

(Joravsky, 1987, pp. 190–191)

And yet, despite his scholarly erudition, critical attitude, and somewhat provocative stance, Joravsky interprets the life story of Vygotsky in the context of the alleged struggle between the “true Marxists” (such as Vygotsky) and “dogmatic Stalinists” and ultimately yet again reiterates the victimization narrative as the history of the “muffled deity of Soviet psychology.” Fairly similar sentiments and interpretations can be found in the work of another historian of Soviet science and the doyen of this field of knowledge, Loran Graham (see the thematic chapter on Vygotsky in Graham, 1987). In sum, as we see, regardless of their assessment of the scientific legacy and theoretical impact of the work of Vygotsky and his intellectual heirs in Soviet Russia, Western scholars have always tended to uniformly subscribe to the “Vygotsky ban” narrative that, to the extent we can judge on the basis of anecdotal evidence, seems to have been imported from the USSR from the mid-1950s onwards through a series of informal personal exchanges and interactions between Western and Soviet agents, such as Vygotsky’s closest friend and collaborator Alexander Luria, Vygotsky’s daughter Gita Vygodskaya, and the like. The “Vygotsky ban” construct appears yet again in van der Veer and Valsiner’s classic *Understanding Vygotsky* (1991), which remains the best and one of the most influential works in the genre of “intellectual biography” of Vygotsky to date. It seems that only a forthcoming book in this genre will significantly reassess the age-old account of Vygotsky’s life and scholarly legacy (Yasnitsky & van der Veer, 2015). Interestingly enough, the traditional narrative of Vygotsky’s life as it was presented and socially positioned in the Soviet Union followed a different scenario, quite distinct from the Western one.

It was Bruner, who – as early as 1954 in Montreal – observed the striking and unsettling “doublespeak idiosyncrasy” of Soviet academic discourse. Indeed, the “genuflection” to Ivan Pavlov (1849–1936) – the physiologist and for a long time the only Noble Prize winner and citizen of the USSR that the Soviet establishment and propaganda could be proud of[†] – was quite notable in a great many publications and official public presentations by Soviet psychologists. On the other hand, the demonstrative idolization of Pavlov was at the same time paralleled by the dramatically different kind of discourse of informal meetings and peer chats. Interestingly, Bruner’s reminiscences of his first encounter with Soviet academic “doublespeak” are remarkably mirrored in the memoirs of Francophone psychologists Jean Piaget (1896–1980) and René Zazzo (1910–95), who shared very similar recollections of Soviet “doublespeak” at it was manifested in the events immediately preceding, during, or following the International Congress of Psychology in Montreal in 1954 (Piaget, 1956; Zazzo, 1982, 1989). Thus, it is important and, for all practical purposes, sufficient to distinguish between the “written tradition” of the discourse of official Soviet science and its “oral tradition” of informal personal networks. The two traditions generated notably distinct “Vygotsky narratives” in the Soviet Union.

The official narrative of the “Vygotsky Studies” in the USSR was typically presented in the context of the discussion of the struggle for a truly Marxist psychology and emphasized the continuity of the tradition from Vygotsky to his “best students,” “loyal disciples and followers,” or, in somewhat militant Soviet newspeak, his “brethren in arms.” An integral part of this discourse was the construct of the *troika* (the three) of Founding Fathers that included Vygotsky and his associates A. N. Leontiev and A. R. Luria. This construct was subsequently transformed into the narrative tradition of the “school of Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria” that allegedly founded the so-called psychological “activity theory,” its Western incarnation being the so-called “cultural-historical activity theory,” also known by its abbreviation “CHAT”; for a deconstruction of this narrative and critique of its theoretical claims see the recent literature (e.g. R. Miller, 2011; Toomela, 2000, 2008; Yasnitsky, 2012i; see also Chapter 2, above). Naturally, no reference to any “ban on Vygotsky” can be found in the Soviet “written tradition” that typically presents this scholar as a “genius,” “true Marxist,” and the Founding Father of a distinctly and characteristically “Soviet psychology.”

Quite in contrast to official writings (and related public presentations), the underground “oral tradition” depicted Vygotsky as the victim of an oppressive regime, whose publications were banned for two decades in the period 1936–56. This is the somewhat dissident image that was quite popular within the “inner circle” of knowledgeable insiders in the USSR and which, on the other hand, was actively exported outside the Soviet Union by the Soviet brokers between Russian and Western academic communities, such as Alexander Luria. The sharp contrast between the two traditions was maintained until the launch of the official campaign of *glasnost*’ (“publicity”) in 1986, but the difference between “official” and “oral” narratives may be said to eventually cease to exist only after the collapse of the Soviet Union

and the abolition of state censorship in 1991. It was only in the 1990s that the first Russian books came out that could qualify as more or less scholarly biographies of Vygotsky, albeit none written by a professional historian (A. A. Leontiev, 1990; Vygotskaya & Lifanova, 1996; Yaroshevskii, 1993). For obvious reasons, all these publications present fairly clear statements on Vygotsky's genius, victimhood, and the ban imposed on his publications by the oppressive – yet anonymous – Stalinist regime. The notion of the “Vygotsky ban” remains the dominant and unquestionable construct within Russian psychological discourse from the 1990s until now.

Why the narrative of the “Vygotsky ban” is problematic

Although this ban has been both widely acknowledged and frequently cited by historians of psychology, the exact nature of this “Vygotsky censure” by the Party is far less clear-cut. Although the suppression of Vygotsky's works has been referenced by a variety of scholars, few individuals have been able to provide an effective delineation of the factors underlying the Communist Party's decision to openly denounce Vygotskian theory. Even the most committed scholars of Vygotskian science fail to provide readers with a detailed account of this “official ban,” collapsing this interesting instance of “Stalinist” oppression to a one-line-long anecdote. These authors also fall short in illuminating the reasons behind the ban, often falling victim to the age-old (and largely inaccurate) Cold War era historiographical heuristic of Soviet science that insinuates indiscriminate Stalinist hostility towards scientific research. Capitalizing on the explanatory power of totalitarian catchphrases, these writers tend to perpetuate ambiguous secondary accounts of the “Vygotsky ban” – often speculating that “ideological disparities,” or “political differences,” between Vygotsky and the Communist Party probably played a role in the censorship of his works, despite the corpus of recent research that points out the many problems with applying the “state-suppression” model to Soviet science.⁵ Those authors who resist the temptation to rely on the explanatory power of “totalitarianism” in order to explain away the ban often fall back on a variety of other well-known, but grossly over-simplified, historical truisms, often hypothesizing that the “Vygotsky censure” might have somehow stemmed from Soviet anti-Semitism, or Vygotsky's alleged “cosmopolitan”⁶ sympathies. Although political differences, an ideological departure, religious discrimination, or frequent communication with foreign psychologists may certainly have contributed to his censure, a rote listing of these broad factors can, at best, only ever provide a partial account of any active political effort made to suppress Vygotskian theory. In light of the abstruse nature of pre-existing explanations, many aspects of this purported ban remain largely enigmatic, with the reasons underlying this twenty-year censure being even more so.

In order to shed light upon this historical mystery, this study takes a closer look at the “Vygotsky ban.” To avoid making the same mistakes as many Vygotsky

biographers, and providing overly simplified versions of the censure, this chapter draws largely upon original Russian sources as well as English-language translations of a plethora of documentary evidence, including political pronouncements, professional publications, posthumous records, and archival studies carried out by Russian-language researchers at the Vygotsky archive. Further, a critical attitude towards all pre-existing historical depictions of the ban has been adopted to ensure that this study does not perpetuate vague, "broken telephone" accounts of this instance of "Stalinist suppression." Concentrating specifically on the period of 1934 – the year of Vygotsky's death – through 1936 – the year of the notorious decree of the Central Committee of the Communist Party that banned *pedology* (alias "paedology") as scholarly discipline, mass movement, and related social practice, therefore, and the purported beginning of the "Vygotsky ban" – to 1956 – the year when the first post-World War II Vygotsky volume was published in the Soviet Union (Vygotskii, 1956), which signifies the beginning of the post-Stalin psychological publication "thaw," this chapter endeavors to set the record straight about this frequently cited period of Soviet censorship by providing interested readers with the information that has long been left out of traditional narratives.

Since this twenty-year period of Stalinist censure has been widely cited, but rarely described in sufficient depth by Vygotsky scholars, this study begins by describing the organs of Soviet control over information in an attempt to describe what exactly is meant when the term "ban" is employed by historians of science. By illuminating the institutions affiliated with the censorship process, the mechanisms through which written works were censored by the state, and the types of individuals that were subjected to this very public – yet not necessarily publicly advertised – form of blacklisting, the next section operationalizes the term "ban" and discusses exactly how an author's writings could be "actively suppressed by the state" in Russia during the mid-twentieth century. After explicating the methods by which Soviet writers and scientists could be banned during the Stalinist era (and, in fact, all subsequent political eras until the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991), the chapter then undertakes a critical examination of the documentary evidence that is usually cited by contemporary biographers as proof of the Stalinist "ban" placed on Vygotskian theory. Focusing especially on those sources that have traditionally been either ignored, mischaracterized, or misunderstood by contemporary historians of science, this section will consider official Soviet regulations, trends in Vygotsky's personal publication rate, and references to Vygotsky's work in Soviet psychological treatises. By focusing on the logistics of *how* Vygotsky was allegedly banned, and also, perhaps more importantly, *why* this twenty-year-long period of censure was initiated in the first place, this study endeavors to correct a historical narrative that has been so frequently mischaracterized by historians of science, and augment the growing body of revisionist literature that serves to deconstruct the mythologized persona of Lev Vygotsky and his even more mythologized scientific legacy.

Operationalizing “official” bans: the mechanics of Soviet censorship

Although this chapter was inspired by the inability of contemporary historians to provide a satisfactory answer to the question of why Vygotsky’s works endured a twenty-year-long period of suppression within the Soviet Union, preliminary research into this issue suggested that this was not the only question that has been left unanswered within existing historical narratives of the Vygotsky ban. Not only have historians failed to provide readers with detailed, well-researched reasons for the ban’s implementation, but there is also a startling absence of any sort of information on what exactly an “official ban” was, or the mechanisms underlying this protracted period of state-supported censorship. Before we can provide a comprehensive account of *why* Vygotsky was banned, it is imperative that we define *what* exactly an “official ban” was, the logistics behind Soviet censorship, and the primary causalities of this form of state-supported criticism.

According to historian of Russian and Soviet literature and the leading scholar in the history of Russian censorship Arlen Blyum (2000, 2003), by the late 1920s the system of Soviet censorship took the form of a many-tiered control mechanism, ranging from direct dictatorial intervention to an author’s own self-censorship, whereby an author molds his text to avoid the moral, aesthetic, and other – primarily political – objections his or her text might encounter throughout the course of the publication process. Although the monitoring of literary and scientific works was in many ways a multi-level system, the main body of Soviet censorship was the Main Administration for Literary and Publishing Affairs – commonly known as Glavlit (Ermolaev, 1997). Attached to the *Narkompros*, the People’s Commissariat of Enlightenment, and later to the GPU (or security police, later renamed NKVD, then MGB, and later, infamously, the KGB), Glavlit carried out preliminary inspection of nearly all manuscripts, as well as photographs, drawings, and maps, to ensure that all written materials conformed to the *Perechen’* – a top-secret series of circular letters issued by the Central Committee that listed the kind of information that should not be published in the open press because of its political or economic significance to the state (Ermolaev, 1997). Although Soviet censorship appears to be a top-down, unidirectional flow of power from the Politburo censors to the censored, with the Main Administration for Literary and Publishing Affairs operating as a mediator, the Glavlit actually functioned relatively autonomously (Plamper, 2001). Rather than receiving explicit instructions from the Central Committee, Glavlit functionaries often had to reinterpret publicly issued Party statements and ascertain whether these proclamations had any implications for the publishing process (Blyum, 2003; Rogers, 1973).

In order to ensure that new written materials were congruent with the *Perechen’*, one of the main functions of the Glavlit was pre-publication censorship, whereby functionaries would, “[filter] ten times water that was already distilled,” subjecting the text, “not only to the excision of ‘inconvenient parts’,⁷ but also to substantial changes and, not infrequently, to censors’ additions” (Blyum, 2003). In addition, the

Glavlit was also responsible for ensuring that all existing literary works were supportive of contemporary Party policies. This type of post-circulation censorship could take several forms; however, the two most common actions taken against reactionary literary products already in distribution were removal and revision, whereby undesirable parts of products could be eliminated (for instance by the blacking out of names), or entire books could be taken from library and bookstore shelves and stored in a restricted-access special collection known as the *spetskhran* (Choldin, 1991; Plamper, 2001; Rogers, 1973). Contemporary accounts of the “Vygotsky ban” do not specify the type of censorship endured by Vygotsky’s works over the course of this twenty-year ban. However, if Vygotsky had been subjected to a form of blacklisting, one would expect that he, like other officially censored individuals, would have been subjected to both pre- and post-circulation censorship: his existing works would have been removed from library shelves, and his future writings would have been denied publication.

Although censorship was commonplace within the Soviet Union, with almost every author experiencing some form of either pre- or post-circulation censorship during the 1920s and onwards, explicit Party bans on individuals were far less routine. Even authors whose works showcase a variety of Glavlit insertions, deletions, or blacked-out portions or were frequently denied publication by the censors were rarely banned from publishing further, and usually faced few long-term consequences for their moral, political, or ideological literary errors. After scouring histories of Soviet censorship, publication prohibitions aimed towards specific individuals seem to be restricted to “enemies of the people” or those individuals who had been arrested, legally condemned, and executed in the public purges endemic within the Soviet Union during the 1930s (Ermolaev, 1997). Whereas the majority of pre- and post-circulation censorship efforts had few long-term consequences for authors, personal publication bans were usually the end-result of highly condemnatory statements issued by Stalin or, less often, by the highest state officials. While these statements were usually a political rally commentary or a letter to official Party mass media rather than publicly issued Party decrees, they likely would have been interpreted by the Glavlit as an “official” publication ban. Such an example can be observed in the case of Trotsky, “the prophet outcast,” exiled from the Soviet Union in 1929, whose pre-existing works were placed under a publication ban in the wake of a 1932 article authored by Stalin, dubbing Trotskyism “the vanguard of counter-revolutionary bourgeoisie fighting against Communism, against Soviet power, and against the building of socialism in the USSR” (Ermolaev, 1997, p. 67).

In light of this information, the authors of this chapter embarked upon a search to find any sort of Party-authored document that was overtly critical of either Vygotsky’s personality or his psychological theories. Upon further research it appears that no scholar, either professional or amateur, has been able to unearth any sort of documentation authored by Stalin, or by any other leading members of the Central Committee, that explicitly mentions the name of Vygotsky, thus suggesting that Vygotsky’s work was not formally banned within the Soviet Union. Further, Vygotsky’s personal narrative makes the likelihood of an explicit ban on his work

even more suspect. Given that the 1930s was a decade characterized by the Great Terror, it might seem surprising that Vygotsky lived out his last few years peacefully, dying of natural causes in 1934, while so many of his contemporary scientists were publicly arrested, imprisoned, and in many cases executed. As René van der Veer aptly notes, “[i]n a period when people were charged and sentenced to ‘ten years without the right of correspondence’⁸ ... on grounds of having planned to dig a tunnel from Moscow to Great Britain ... the fact is that Vygotsky was [never] arrested” (Van der Veer, 2000a, p. 5). Furthermore, one needs to remember that after his death Vygotsky’s body was buried, and has always remained, in its final resting place – Novodevich’e Cemetery – one of the most prestigious national cemeteries within the USSR, second only to the necropolis of Kremlin Wall, which seems to indicate Vygotsky’s fairly high status within the Soviet scientific hierarchy (Yasnitsky, 2012e).

Given the lack of documentary evidence suggesting that Vygotsky was formally criticized, or personally persecuted, by Stalin, or any high-ranking members of the Central Committee, it appears as though an “official” Stalinist censure of Vygotsky’s works simply never existed.

Vygotsky’s declining publication rate: multiple meanings?

While it appears as though the contemporary historians of science may have been wrong about the formal nature of the ban against Vygotsky’s theories, quantitative data cited by Vygotskian biographers seems to suggest that there may still have been some type of concerted effort on the part of Glavlit functionaries to actively suppress his work. Many scholars have lent support to the Vygotsky–victimization narrative by noting a dramatic drop in Vygotsky’s publication rate after his death, whereby from 1936 to 1956, none of Vygotsky’s works were published within the Soviet Union. This decline is seen as strong corroborating evidence for a sustained period of Soviet suppression, as one would expect that an author’s publication rate would wane in the midst of a targeted censorship program aimed towards their work. Although the cause–effect relationship between Stalinist censure and publication decline makes logical sense, a critical examination of the data must be undertaken before this hypothesis is accepted by historians and permanently attached to Vygotsky’s personal narrative.

Although Vygotsky’s publication rate does experience a marked decline from the period of 1934 to 1956, this overarching trend is by no means linear, as fewer of his published works were released to the public in both the mid-1920s and early 1930s. One such example is his doctoral dissertation (Vygotskii, 1965; Vygotsky, 1971). Confusing the alleged temporality of the “ban,” Vygotsky’s 1925 doctoral thesis *Psychology of art*, although contracted for publishing in November, 1925 (Vygodskaya & Lifanova, 1996), was most likely barred from circulation until 1965 – when it was eventually published in the Soviet Union by the famous Russian–American linguist and semiotician Vyacheslav Vs. Ivanov – as a result of his tendency to reference

several 'subversive' Soviet public figures and political leaders in his work (Van der Veer, 2000a). Most important among these individuals was Leon Trotsky, the Marxist revolutionary and Soviet politician, who had fallen from grace within the Soviet Union's political leadership during the mid-1920s. An enthusiastic follower of Trotsky, Vygotsky repeatedly and approvingly incorporated many quotations from his works into his professional writing, including his published book *Educational psychology* (1925) and unfinished manuscript *The (historical) significance of the crisis in psychology* (Zavershneva, 2012b; Zavershneva & Osipov, 2012a, 2012b).⁹ Although Soviet editors usually censored Vygotsky's political missteps during the posthumous publication process by either removing the punctuation surrounding borrowed quotations, or by deleting citations referring to these ostracized figures, censors would sometimes withhold publication of certain works that portrayed unpopular individuals in a particularly positive light (Van der Veer & Yasnitsky, 2011). This was most likely the case for Vygotsky's *Psychology of art*, as he ends his thesis with this lengthy extract from Leon Trotsky's prophetic and utopian *Literature and revolution*:

[Man] will try to master first the semiconscious and then the subconscious processes in his own organism, such as breathing, the circulation of the blood, digestion, reproduction, and, within necessary limits, he will try to subordinate them to the control of reason and will. Even purely physiologic life will become subject to collective experiments. The human species, the coagulated *Homo sapiens*, will once more enter into a state of radical transformation, and, in his own hands, will become an object of the most complicated methods of artificial selection and psycho-physical training. This is entirely in accord with evolution ... Man will make it his purpose to master his own feelings, to raise his instincts of consciousness, to make them transparent, to extend the wires of his will into hidden recesses, and thereby to raise himself to a new plane, to create a higher social biologic type, or, if you please, a superman.

(Vygotskii, 2008, p. 207)

Not only did *Psychology of art* experience pre-circulation censorship in the 1920s, but it also underwent "editorial censorship" during the 1960s for political correctness. All references to L. D. Trotsky, N. I. Bukharin and other "enemies of the people" that had been discovered in Vygotsky's original manuscript were removed by the editor of this edition of 1965 (second, expanded edition of 1968), only to be fully restored in a 2008 Russian edition of the text (compare: Vygotskii, 1965, 1968, 2008; Vygotsky, 1971). Quite characteristically, all those censored were Russian authors, whereas the list of foreign references remained intact. Apparently the 1928 edited volume *Social sciences* enjoyed a somewhat similar fate, as a variety of the book's contributors (including Vygotsky) made references to political "outcasts," including a characteristically Trotskyian passage found within Vygotsky's textual contribution (Vygotskii, 1928; Vygotsky, 2012). Thus, unlike Vygotsky's *Psychology of art*, which remained unpublished during his lifetime, this volume was released to the public, but was subsequently censored by the authorities and relocated to the

spetskhran. Despite the fact that these two works were initially withheld from public audiences, this publication prohibition had little effect on either Vygotsky's personal life, or his professional career, as Vygotsky was able to subsequently secure a variety of academic positions, and went on to have most of his writings published in spite of his reverence for highly provocative figures within the Soviet Union (Kotik-Friedgut & Friedgut, 2008; Yasnitsky, 2012e).

Another complication that arises when trying to ascribe Vygotsky's publication fluctuations to a demarcated period of censorship (1936–56) is the marked decrease in Vygotsky's publication rate observed within the early 1930s, specifically between 1931 and 1933 (Figure A1 in Appendix B). With the exception of several textbooks and curriculum materials, neither of his major works written in this period,¹⁰ or before, was released to the public, and even the publication of his most famous book, *Thinking and speech*, experienced an indeterminate delay. This period also saw a proliferation of criticisms aimed towards Vygotsky, with individuals such as Talankin (1931, 2000), Abel'skaia and Neopikhonova (1932, 2000), Feofanov (1932, 2000), and Razmyslov (1934, 2000) critiquing his mechanism, his “menshevizing idealism”, and ultimately condemning his theories for eclecticism and uncritical borrowing from the West, and thus harboring ‘bourgeois’ sympathies. This period of publication rate decline and popular hostility can perhaps be partially attributed to a series of Uzbekistan experiments overseen by both Vygotsky and Luria during the early 1930s, as some contemporary scholars criticized this psychological project as colonialist and (even worse) racist, and stated that both its methodology and research results opposed Marxist theory (Razmyslov, 1934, 2000). Yet, the story of Luria's expedition to Central Asia is much more complicated than that (for an in-depth discussion of this topic see Chapter 8).

While these external critiques might certainly have played a role in dissuading Vygotsky from submitting some of his more recent studies for publication, alternative revisionist accounts of Vygotsky's life also suggest that self-criticism might have impacted his waning publication rate during the early 1930s. These scholars suggest that during the period 1929–31, Vygotsky's career was affected by a profound theoretical and personal crisis that emerged in the wake – or rather during and, furthermore, as a result – of the Cultural Revolution and the rapid social and economic developments that corresponded with the First Five-Year Plan (cf. Chapter 8). In this period Vygotsky was intensely critical of his work, as evidenced in his rare official publications, private correspondence, and personal records, often resulting in his failure to prepare some of his more recent manuscripts for publication, including an untitled draft manuscript that starts with the words: “The history of the development of higher psychological functions,” etc. While this document was published by Vygotsky's colleagues in 1960 under the title borrowed from the very first line of the text (Vygotskii, 1960a), it appears as though Vygotsky never intended its public release, as it does not appear in Vygotsky's authorial bibliography of his published works, or within his self-made list of unpublished manuscripts (for further discussion of Vygotsky's published and most important works see Chapter 4).

Therefore, while it may be true that fewer of Vygotsky's writings were released during the second half of the twentieth century, fluctuations in his publication rate are by no means solely attributable to Communist Party hostility as a variety of mitigating factors all served to affect the amount of work published by Vygotsky within a given year. In fact, evidence shows that one of the biggest censors of Vygotsky's work might have been Vygotsky himself, for it is after his death in 1934 that we observe an explosion in the number of his published works. This 1934–6 surge in Vygotsky's posthumous publication rate (see Figure A1 in Appendix B), sometimes referred to as the "Golden Age of Vygotskian Psychology," has been attributed to the efforts of a number of his colleagues and associates, who enthusiastically endeavored to make Vygotsky's unpublished theories available to the wider public (Yasnitsky, 2012e).

While it is hoped that the aforementioned arguments have revealed the non-linear nature of Vygotsky's publication rate, and have problematized pre-existing interpretations of the "Vygotsky ban's" temporality, the fact remains that historians of science are fundamentally correct when they state that fewer of Vygotsky's works were published after the mid-1930s, specifically after 1936. Although this drop has been previously conceptualized as an active period of Soviet suppression, it is important to remember that this drop might be related to Vygotsky's early death in 1934. Since Vygotsky was no longer alive to actively and publicly promote his own research, it only makes sense that fewer of his works – if any – would be published after his death. Further, it should be noted that fluctuations in Vygotsky's publication rate seem to mirror the publication trends occurring within pedology, his chosen field of study (see Figure A2 in Appendix B).

Pedology as a possible culprit: the 1936 decree

Although the discipline of pedology emerged as a primarily Western phenomenon, characterized by the work of individuals like G. Stanley Hall, Ernst Meumann, Wilhelm Preyer, James Mark Baldwin, and many others, interest in this growing child-study movement soon spread to Russia in the late Imperial period (Byford, 2008). Anchored primarily within the fields of psychology and education, this pioneering group of Russian pedologists, like their European and North American counterparts, drew upon the disciplines of psychology, sociology, and pediatric medicine to define a new approach to the study of the character and development of children (Ewing, 2001; Petrovsky, 1990). Following the October Revolution, pedagogical activity assumed a new dimension, as the newly established political climate within the Soviet Union fostered child-study research efforts and advocated for the reformulation of educational systems upon materialistic, empirical, and scientific foundations (Hoffmann, 2011). Disciplinary endorsement from at least three People's Commissariats¹¹ (including the People's Commissariat for Enlightenment, Health, and Railways) resulted in the proliferation of pedagogical institutions that were established for the purpose of training enthusiastic teachers and advanced

pedagogues in the science of child development (Byford, 2008; Petrovsky, 1990). Seeking to fulfill the claim that their discipline had both scientific legitimacy and social significance, many new graduates saw educational institutions as a site for both empirical research and practical experiments (Ewing, 2001). Charged with the task of improving Soviet schools, many of these pedologists began to administer sets of mental and personality tests within the classroom in order to measure the learning potential of children and expedite annual enrollment decisions. Under these facilitative social circumstances, a variety of leading Soviet psychologists, educators, psychiatrists, and medical doctors led by Konstantin Kornilov, Mikhail Basov, Aron Zalkind, Pavel Blonskii, and a few other spokesmen for the emerging scientific discipline and social practice began to undertake research into child problems, and as a result were subsumed into the administrative and organizational sphere of pedagogical leadership (Petrovsky, 1990). Vygotsky was also recognized as a leading pedologist in the USSR, as he participated actively in the field during the 1920s and 1930s, delivering a series of pedology lectures at the Second Moscow State University and Leningrad State Pedagogical Institute, and publishing a variety of pedagogical textbooks including *Pedology of the school age* (1928), *Pedology of the adolescent* (1929, 1930, 1931), and *Lectures on pedology* (1934, 1935) (Yasnitsky, 2011b, 2011d; for discussion of Vygotsky's publications also see Chapter 4).

The discipline of pedology did not always enjoy such a fruitful existence though, as a variety of pedagogical theories and practices came under attack in the 1930s, as many teachers and educational policy makers thought that pedology was of "little benefit to the [educational] system."¹² These complaints eventually culminated in the 1936 resolution of the CPSU Central Committee, "On Pedological Distortions in the System of People's Commissariats of Enlightenment," which called for the elimination of pedology as a scholarly discipline, mass movement, and social practice.¹³ Although there are several different hypotheses explaining this denunciation of pedology, the 1936 decree was mainly a methodological critique of pedagogical practice, as many party members were growing increasingly concerned that unqualified pedologists were abusing and misinterpreting psychometric test results and over-ascribing mental deficiencies to Soviet children – a fear that is far from unjustified when one notes that in Leningrad, from 1935 to 1936, approximately 14 percent of 7- to 13-year-old pupils were asked to stay behind to repeat their school grades. Stalin appears to have been especially disillusioned with the pedagogical practice of mental testing upon his reception of a pedagogical assessment suggesting that his son was mentally deficient (Minkova, 2012). Pedology was also critiqued for its incompatibility with Marxist doctrine and the emerging 'New Man' theory of psychology, as Soviet leaders rejected any suggestion that heredity or environment presented limits that could not be overcome with the proper combination of enthusiasm and dedication (Bauer, 1952; Ewing, 2001). Although the 1936 decree was effective in banning mental testing as a method of research and psychological assessment, and in virtually eradicating pedology as a scholarly discipline, with the decree immediately resulting in the closure of all pedagogical centers in the Soviet Union, this pronouncement did not mark the end of the child-study movement in

Russia. The years following 1936 saw many well-known pedagogists change over to pedagogical practices – a growing field that shared many of the same features as its now-blacklisted predecessor. Thus, to the unbiased contemporary observer, all the 1936 Party decree seems to have done is facilitate a change in labels (for a pioneering introduction to the comparative disciplinary history of Soviet psychology of the first half of the twentieth century see Yasnitsky, 2015).

Although the 1936 decree never openly gave an order for the active suppression of pre-existing literature on pedagogy, the public nature of this political pronouncement and the political clout of the administrative body that issued it inspired Glavlit officials to take pre-emptive measures, preventing the publication of recently written pedagogical works, and indiscriminately sanctioning all pre-existing materials that touched on pedagogical topics.¹⁴ This ban had clear implications for Vygotsky's pedagogical writings, as more than 120 pedagogical textbooks were blacklisted at once, "among the authors being such prominent educators and psychologists as Blonsky and Vygotsky" (Rogers, 1973, p. 26).¹⁵ Thus, in the context of the 1936 Party decree, the censure of Vygotsky's works appears to be less of an "official" attack, or informal suppression, and more of an inadvertent result of the increasingly anti-pedagogical Soviet political *Zeitgeist*. Nevertheless, even an indirect and impersonal ban is a ban, and while we can critique contemporary Vygotsky scholars for their lack of primary-source research and for their gross over-simplifying of this particular historical instance, it appears as though we cannot fault them for arguing that from 1936 onwards Vygotsky's works did experience a demarcated period of active suppression.

Vygotsky's posthumous legacy and the many meanings of the ban

Or can we? Although common sense tells us that an explicit Party ban on Vygotsky's works, however accidental or inadvertent, would result in a marked decline in both his public image and publication rate, a closer examination of contemporary data suggests that the Communist Party ban on pedagogy had little impact on Vygotsky's posthumous legacy even during the years immediately following the 1936 decree.

Rather than being actively chastised or strategically ignored in the years following the 1936 ban on pedagogy, the late 1930s saw Vygotsky venerated within the Soviet Union, as his name was neither avoided nor omitted from a variety of important public forums. With the exception of two particularly harsh and, presumably, politically motivated critiques of Vygotskian theory that were released in the late 1930s, including A. V. Kozyrev and P. A. Turko's "Professor L. S. Vygotsky's 'pedagogical school'" (1936, 2000) and E. I. Rudneva's infamous *Pedagogical perversions of Vygotsky* (1937, 2000), Vygotsky – as a psychologist – faced very few long-term consequences for his non-pedagogical work, as his name and theories were referenced (and celebrated) at various times within influential texts during the period 1936–55. Perhaps the two most striking examples of this phenomenon are (a) over thirty references to Vygotsky found within S. L. Rubinstein's

1940 edition of *Foundations of general psychology*, and (b) his presence within the highly prestigious (and rigorously censored) *Great Soviet encyclopedia* of 1940 (Luria & Leontiev, 1940, p. 525). His presence in both of these works is startling as Rubinstein's book (1940) – presumably a highly censored publication that was approved and officially prescribed by the *Narkompros* of the RSFSR as the handbook for pedagogical colleges – was subsequently the recipient of the prestigious Stalin Prize for 1941 (awarded in 1942),¹⁶ which appears to have notably contributed to Rubinstein's appointment to a range of the highest administrative positions in Soviet psychological establishments (in 1942) and his election to the Academy of Sciences of the USSR (in September 1943), as the first ever psychologist in Russia awarded the title of Corresponding Member of the Academy. At the same time, the *Great Soviet encyclopedia*, a multi-volume series created with the purpose of “furthering the aims of [both] ... party and the state,” celebrated Vygotsky's work for, “[laying] the foundation in Soviet psychology for experimental investigation of the development of such most complex psychical [mental] processes as the processes of concepts formation in children, development of oral and written speech” and created a basis “for [the] experimental investigation of higher psychical [mental] functions after brain lesions and brain development defects” (Luria & Leontiev, 1940, p. 525).

Vygotsky's memory continued to be venerated well into the late 1940s and early 1950s, with his name appearing a dozen times within A. R. Luria's ground-breaking volume *Traumatic aphasia*¹⁷ (1947). Vygotsky's work also continued to be showcased in the second, postwar edition of S. L. Rubinstein's prize-winning *Foundations of general psychology* (1946). A characteristic example of Soviet scholarly discourse on Vygotsky and his legacy can be found in B. G. Anan'ev's Russian article “The progressive traditions of Russian psychology” (1945), and a follow-up English article by the same author titled “Achievements of Soviet psychologists” that came out in the *Journal of General Psychology* (1948). In this publication, Anan'ev – another major official in the hierarchy of Soviet science and the leader of the so-called “Leningrad psychological school” – refers to Vygotsky's work as a series of “splendid investigations” and notes Vygotsky's contributions to the contemporary understanding of the general laws associated with the human thought process (Ananiev, 1948, p. 261).

Another remarkable publication during this period is B. M. Teplov's public lecture “Soviet psychological science” (1947), which was publicly released as a brochure in truly astonishing numbers, with 100,000 copies printed.¹⁸ Although Teplov did criticize Vygotsky for a variety of pedagogical mistakes and theoretical digressions, the lecture was ultimately favorable to Vygotsky – glorifying him as one of the leading and most prominent Soviet psychologists. Thus, on a number of occasions, Teplov referred to the “splendid experimental research initiated by Vygotsky” (1947, p. 14) and “the great many very valuable works that he created as a first-rank Soviet psychologist” (1947, p. 18); and praised him and his associates for “several works of great significance on the problems of memory and thinking,” for creating “original methods of experimental investigation of [higher psychological] processes in children” (1947, p. 22), and for the “discovery of the most interesting facts and

particular regularities in this field" that were presented in a few monographs that "belong to the number of best works of Soviet psychological science" (1947, p. 16).

However, a relatively brief period of the post-World War II "thaw" was followed by a period of social and political unrest roughly between 1948 and 1954 caused by a number of particularly alarming and terrifying domestic processes in the Soviet Union of the early Cold War (such as the state-sponsored campaigns of xenophobia and anti-Semitism, renewed political show trials and massive executions, the enforced administrative control in science, etc.) and the change in the political leadership after the death of Stalin in 1953.¹⁹ This period of 1948 to 1954 demonstrates a notable decline of scientific publications in psychology, as is clear from a number of available scholarly bibliographies of the official leaders of the psychological sciences in the USSR, such as Rubinstein, Luria, Leontiev, and Teplov. However, as early as the end of 1954, the first specialized postwar psychological journal, *Voprosy Psikhologii*, was officially launched and a new series of psychological publications followed.²⁰ The name of Vygotsky figures again prominently in a few publications and oral presentations of 1955, such as Luria's published paper "The role of the word in the formation of temporary connections in normal and abnormal development" or the talk "Speech and organization of behavior" that he delivered at the scientific session to mark the 200th anniversary of Moscow State University, May 9–13, 1955 (Luria, 1955a, 1955b).

Then, according to the traditional "suppression" narrative, it was only in 1956 that the mythical "Vygotsky ban" was finally lifted. In 1956, the newly established journal *Voprosy Psikhologii* published a landmark paper by the journal's Deputy Editor V. N. Kolbanovskii, former Director (1932–7) of the Institute of Psychology in Moscow, the editor of the first Russian edition of *Thinking and speech* (1934), and, according to A. N. Leontiev's recently published "oral history" reminiscences of the early 1970s, an enthusiastic supporter of Vygotsky's ideas (A. N. Leontiev & Yaroshevskii, 2013, p. 10). Kolbanovskii's important paper, "On psychological views of L. S. Vygotsky" (1956), was the first postwar thematic journal publication on Vygotsky and his scientific legacy that had Vygotsky's name in its title. Eventually the first major postwar publication of Vygotsky's work took place: his *Selected psychological investigations* was publicly released in Moscow during 1956, followed by yet another volume in 1960 (Vygotskii, 1956, 1960b) – in retrospect, yet again severely problematizing the notion that Vygotsky's works experienced any sort of active suppression within the twenty years from 1936 to 1956. This conclusion necessitates a reframing of our original research question, as the issue at hand is not so much a question of *why* Vygotsky was suppressed, but *if* he was "banned" at all. While the answer appears to be "yes" – as a recently discovered 1961 edition of the top-secret government document *Perechen'* reveals that a couple of works of Vygotsky's, including yet another of his "Trotskyist" works of the mid-1920s, the *Pedagogical psychology* of 1925, were in fact "blacklisted" (even after and, for that matter, regardless of the postwar publication of two of his works!)²¹ – this study suggests that there is still much to be learned about what it meant to be "banned" within the Soviet Union. Despite the fact that some of Vygotsky's works do seem to have

been on a list of “officially” banned works, the personal, professional, and posthumous consequences of the alleged “Stalinist suppression” may not have been nearly as dramatic as contemporary historians of science have portrayed them. Consider the following example.

Between the publication of *Development of psychical functions* in 1960 (Vygotskii, 1960b) and the release of the first volume of Vygotsky’s *Collected works* in 1982 (Vygotskii, 1982) only one of his major theoretical books came out in the Soviet Union. Vygotsky’s *Psychology of art*, published in 1965 by Iskusstvo [The Art] publishers, was prepared for publication, edited, and extensively annotated by a non-psychologist – Soviet linguist and semiotician Vyach. Vs. Ivanov (Vygotskii, 1965).²² The editor of the book had the reputation in Soviet academic circles of a brilliant young scholar, yet a dissident, who in 1958 had been fired from Moscow State University for his public support for Boris Pasternak’s Nobel Prize winning novel *Doktor Zhivago*, banned in the Soviet Union, friendship with its author, and intense scientific and personal contacts with Russian-American linguist Roman Jakobson. Given the rarity and scarcity of Soviet-period publication of Vygotsky, one might assume that publishing the works of this author was virtually impossible, especially for a scholar of relatively lower administrative rank and somewhat suspicious political standing. However, it was only three years later, in 1968, that the second, expanded edition of this volume – including Vygotsky’s “Psychology of art,” a long scholarly essay on Shakespeare’s *Hamlet* of 1916 (the author’s first-known major written work), and a sixty-page editor’s commentary (Ivanov, 1968) – came out, from the same publishing house and yet again under the editorship of Ivanov (Vygotskii, 1968). Apart from an eight-page Preface to the book signed in the name of A. N. Leontiev no trace of a psychologist’s involvement can be detected in this publication.

In order to yet further problematize the notion of suppression as it applies to Vygotsky and his scientific legacy, one might wonder why the six-volume collection of Vygotsky’s works did not come out in the Soviet Union immediately after it was endorsed for publication by the State authorities in 1966 and when the preparation of this publication started in the late 1960s.²³ Although a number of the highest administrative positions in science were occupied by Vygotsky’s former associates and, from a theoretical standpoint, Soviet psychology appears to have been dominated by A. N. Leontiev’s so-called “activity theory,” the collected works of Vygotsky did not come out until after the death of a number of official “followers of Vygotsky” who were in powerful positions, such as A. R. Luria (in 1977), A. N. Leontiev (1979), and A. V. Zaporozhets (in 1981).²⁴

Indeed, fairly interesting and thought-provoking testimonies can be found in “oral tradition” accounts by noted Russian intellectuals and scholars Georgii Shchedrovitskii (1929–94) and Vladimir Zinchenko (1931–2014) – the contemporaries and direct participants of those events of the 1950s–1980s – whose reminiscences were published in the early 2000s (Shchedrovitskii, 2001; V. P. Zinchenko, 2003).²⁵ According to Shchedrovitskii, the publication of the first post-World War II volume of Vygotsky’s works took place in 1956 as a result of the effort of Vygotsky’s

family (including his widow and two daughters) rather than his former students and associates, who reportedly even hindered this publication. Shchedrovitskii, who was at that time employed by the specialist publishing house under the auspices of the Academy of Pedagogical Science of the RSFSR, unambiguously stated: "Soon, to my great surprise, I realized that not only the enemies of Vygotsky, but primarily his closest disciples were doing their best to ensure that his work would not come out." Thus, for instance, Shchedrovitskii reminisced about Luria's and Leontiev's resistance to his initiative to publish the works of Vygotsky in the late 1950s and, presumably, 1960s. One episode is particularly telling.

The publication of Vygotsky's volume of 1956 triggered the proposal for a follow-up volume of Vygotsky's works, and yet again neither of the two – Leontiev and Luria – did anything to interfere in the ritualistic critical "public discussion" of Vygotsky's legacy orchestrated at the Institute of Psychology in Moscow that, according to Shchedrovitskii, was apparently designed in order to officially denounce Vygotsky and dismiss this proposed publication project altogether. It was only due to the active public intervention of some other individuals, including Shchedrovitskii, Zaporozhets, and several others, that this anti-Vygotsky campaign of the late 1950s was diverted at the very launch and the second volume of Vygotsky's works subsequently did come out in 1960.

Similarly, Zinchenko stated that Leontiev consciously and continuously delayed the publication of the multi-volume collection of Vygotsky's works in the 1970s: On the one hand, Leontiev insisted that the first volume necessarily required an introductory chapter that he – allegedly, the closest associate and the major intellectual heir – would author. On the other hand, Leontiev kept deliberately finding numerous excuses for not writing this chapter. As amazing as this story might appear, Zinchenko claimed that the opening Introduction that eventually came out under the name of Leontiev in the first volume of the six-volume *Collected works* of Vygotsky in 1982 was in fact penned in the late 1970s by Leonid Radzikhovskii, a promising young psychologist and historian of psychology at that time and a well-known Russian journalist today. According to Zinchenko, only this "trick" made it possible to launch the publication of the six-volume series. And even that would not happen until after Leontiev's death.

From a certain perspective, this publication phenomenon may also be seen as a suppression of Vygotskian theory – perhaps even more dramatic and harmful to psychological science than the alleged, mythological suppression of the Stalinist period.

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PART II

Texts and legacy

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4

VYGOTSKY THE PUBLISHED

Who wrote Vygotsky and what Vygotsky actually wrote

René van der Veer and Anton Yasnitsky

Eighty years have passed since Lev Vygotsky's death but, as unbelievable as it might appear, we still neither know the exact number of his published works nor do we have a rigorous study that provides the chronology of their composition and assesses the relative scholarly value of these publications. No doubt, we do have a few bibliographies of Vygotsky's works (Lifanova (Shakhlevich), 1984; Lifanova, 1996; Shakhlevich, 1974; Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991; Vygodskaya & Lifanova, 1996), but all of them seem fairly deficient and flawed in some or another respect. For instance, Lifanova's bibliography (1996) – perhaps the most complete of all – is problematic due to the unclear principle of chronological attribution of texts. Thus, Lifanova indiscriminately combines published works and unpublished materials; therefore, her chronology mixes up date of publication (for published works), presumed date of composition (for manuscripts), and date of oral presentation (for shorthand reports of public presentations or course lectures). Also, her bibliography is not complete and contains a number of mistakes in indicating source, title, pages, etc. Thus, on the one hand, the bibliography seems to underestimate the number of Vygotsky's writings. On the other hand, in some instances, Lifanova mentions the subheadings of the main bibliographic entry as separate publications, which creates the effect of artificial extension or padding. Other, relatively minor, criticisms could be added to this, in our opinion, best available bibliography of Vygotsky's works but these will be left out of consideration here. It must also be acknowledged that Lifanova faced a difficult task given that critical studies of Vygotsky's scientific productivity were not yet available at the time of the composition of her bibliography. A recent study that identified Vygotsky's main works and the chronology of composition (Yasnitsky, 2011b) was only the first effort of its kind and was limited with respect to the historical period reviewed: in search of Vygotsky's most advanced ideas, the study focused on the books and longer manuscripts of the later period of his life and, therefore, left out his work of the so-called "instrumental

period” of the mid-1920s. This study, as important as it is, remains largely inaccessible to the English reader: the paper was written in Russian and only a considerably shorter version is available in English (Yasnitsky, 2011d).

Quite recently, we also witnessed a surge of studies that made considerable progress in the philological study of Vygotsky’s works. For example, these include the analyses of *The (historical) meaning of the crisis in psychology* (composed and then abandoned by its author around 1926–7) (Zavershneva, 2009, 2012b; Zavershneva & Osipov, 2010, 2012a, 2012b), *Tool and sign (in the child’s development)* (first version of the work created around 1930) (Kellogg, 2011a, 2011b; Kellogg & Yasnitsky, 2011; Yasnitsky, 2011b), and *Thinking and speech* (1934) (Mecacci & Yasnitsky, 2011). Furthermore, several studies and reminiscences that focused on the history of these publications revealed fairly amazing episodes of actual falsification of Vygotsky’s original texts. Sometimes, several manuscripts were merged and published as one piece (e.g. *The history of the development of higher mental functions*) (Yasnitsky, 2011b). On other occasions, the text was translated back from the English translation of the original Russian manuscript (e.g. *Tool and sign*) without mentioning this; a case of what has been called “benign forgery” (Cole, 2012; Goldberg, 2005, 2012; Van der Veer, 2012; Yasnitsky, 2011d, 2012f). Such studies throw light on one of the problems that will occupy us in this chapter: how many publications did Vygotsky actually write (himself)?

In this context it is relevant to briefly mention the negative effects of the publication of Vygotsky’s so-called *Collected works* (*Sobranie Sochinenij*) in the Soviet Union of the 1980s. Three of the four texts mentioned here – with the exception of *Thinking and speech* (Vygotskii, 1934a) – were first published in the form we know now in that six-volume collection released by Pedagogika Publishers in Moscow. Although the publication of these volumes was a major event for Vygotskian scholarship, unfortunately, the texts were heavily edited and censored by the editorial team (for numerous examples of censorship and editorial interventions, see Mecacci & Yasnitsky, 2011; Zavershneva & Osipov, 2012a, 2012b) and uncritically presented as Vygotsky’s most important theoretical works. To make things worse, these very texts – and, for that matter, the most laudatory assessments of these texts – were subsequently disseminated internationally. Both the highly questionable and unreliable English six-volume collection *The collected works of L. S. Vygotsky* by Plenum Press and the Spanish five-volume edition *Obras escogidas* by Visor and the Spanish Ministry of Education, not to mention other, minor, international editions, were translated from the censored Soviet *Collected works* edition of 1982–4.

Under these circumstances we are left with the uneasy feeling that we have been robbed of the historic Vygotsky and we wonder who the “real Vygotsky” actually was and what belongs to his scientific heritage. The international Vygotskian legacy, the problems of the philological study of Vygotsky’s texts, and the issue of translations is a separate topic that receives an in-depth discussion in Chapter 7 of this book. In this chapter, we attempt to reconstruct the holistic image of Vygotsky’s work in psychology and allied sciences in the last decade of his life, in 1924–34. There are at least three major questions that need to be answered:

First, who wrote Vygotsky? That is, given that we now know that not all texts published under Vygotsky's name were actually written by him or, at least, not in that form, we may ask what was added, construed, and misrepresented – and, for that matter, by whom – to pass as Vygotsky's foundational contribution to international psychology.

Second, what did Vygotsky actually write? That is, we need to form a clear picture of the number of his academic publications and the number of manuscripts that can be reliably attributed to him.

Third, which of these writings constitute the theoretical core of his thinking? That is, we must ask what Vygotsky himself and what present-day scholars regard as his main contribution to psychological science.

Strange as it may seem for a figure considered by many as a classic of contemporary psychology, we still do not have clear – unambiguous, and grounded in solid data and rigorous research – answers to these questions. In order to address them we can look at:

- (a) Works by Vygotsky that were completed and, primarily, published during his lifetime. This will require checking various bibliographies and consulting lists compiled by Vygotsky himself in the context of job applications, and so on.
- (b) Vygotsky's references to his own works as evidenced in his publications, correspondence, and archival documents. This may give us an idea about works that were planned and not realized, or begun and not finished, etc.
- (c) Published works and manuscripts that remain marginal to the main body of his work. Writings that were ignored by later editors or not published during his lifetime (i.e. non-publication due to both censorship and self-censorship) may give us a clue about the socio-political context of Vygotsky's writings and the way it canalized his productivity.

Together, these sources will allow us to determine how many academic publications and manuscripts can be reliably attributed to Vygotsky the psychologist. On the basis of that first quantitative approximation we can proceed to more qualitative considerations as to the relative theoretical value of various publications and manuscripts, etc. Such an approximation is, of course, primarily based on Russian publications and would not be possible on the basis of the English-language publication record, which is far more limited. It is interesting to briefly mention this record before we continue with our argument.

English-language publication record

Disregarding translated articles we can briefly summarize the English-language publications of Vygotsky's work as follows. Early translations went virtually unnoticed

and Vygotsky became known to a larger public only with the first publication by the MIT Press of *Thought and language* (Vygotsky, 1962). This book still remains Vygotsky's best-known work. The second of Vygotsky's books to see the light in the Anglo-Saxon world was *The psychology of art* (Vygotsky, 1971), a book that because of its subject matter is far less popular among general psychologists. These early translations were followed by a book that subsequently would become immensely popular, namely *Mind in society* (Vygotsky, 1978). *Mind in society* and other books paved the way for the retranslation, after almost twenty-five years, of *Thought and language* (Vygotsky, 1986). Yet another translation of *Thought and language* appeared one year later under the title *Thinking and speech* as the first volume of the Plenum edition mentioned above (Rieber & Carton, 1987). The second volume came out in 1993 (Rieber & Carton, 1993), and the next four volumes of the Plenum edition appeared after even more delay in the late 1990s (Rieber, 1997, 1998, 1999; Rieber & Wollock, 1997). In between, we saw the appearance of two translations (under different titles) of *Ape, primitive, and child* (A. R. Luria & Vygotsky, 1992; Vygotsky & Luria, 1993), a volume of translated articles and chapters (Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1994) and *Educational psychology* (Vygotsky, 1997a).

Together, these books present a fairly good (although not accurate, as we will see) picture of the work of Vygotsky the psychologist, but it would be an illusion to think that they are in any way exhaustive. That is, although on the basis of the existing translations into English one can form a reasonable idea of what Vygotsky's main ideas were, there remain still large gaps in the translation record, as will become clear in the remainder of this chapter.

Vygotsky's published psychological works of 1924–1936: general overview

In order to construct a general image of the published Vygotsky, we used Lifanova's bibliography as a starting point and critically revised it. In addition, we independently did literature research as well as utilizing the findings of earlier publications and added recently discovered and republished rare publications. Included in our definitive list are both publications in Russian and foreign publications. The latter were in all cases (abbreviated) translations of the former. We decided to cover the period from 1924 (the year of Vygotsky's first psychological publications) to 1936, that is, two years after his death. After 1936 no republications of Vygotsky's writings appeared in the Soviet Union for two decades. As a result, we arrived at a revised bibliography of Vygotsky's publications. To improve the readability of the long bibliographical list we divided it into several, somewhat artificial, categories (see Appendix A and Appendix B). Several issues deserve a preliminary and somewhat superficial comment.

First, in our analysis of these numbers we must certainly consider the fact that data collection, interpretation of findings, preparation of manuscripts, and, finally, publication of the study are all different stages in the process of scientific production.

Therefore, publication records represent a delayed image of actual scientific activity and, incidentally, may also present views the author no longer holds. Several of Vygotsky's writings were published with a delay of two or more years, as he himself noticed (Vygotskii & Leontiev, 1932, p. 2). Then, we must also take into account that the designated categories are somewhat arbitrary. We have followed the rule that entries in books are chapters and entries in journals are articles. Some of Vygotsky's chapters in books, however, are very short (less than five pages) and some of his journal publications were no more than the printed account of some remarks made at a conference. To speak of chapters and articles in these cases is, therefore, somewhat misleading, but perfect classification systems are difficult to find (see below). A final problem for a bibliography such as the one we constructed is, of course, that one can never be entirely sure that it is complete, although we can be reasonably sure that Vygotsky published something in the range of 115 to 120 psychological writings.

With these caveats in mind, we can clearly see that Vygotsky's prime time was in the years 1927–30, preceded and followed by periods of a fairly moderate publication rate. Particularly notable is the sharp decline of Vygotsky's publications in 1931–3 (for the discussion of possible reasons for this decline see Chapters 1 and 3). Also remarkable is a brief period of increase in the number of publications – more than half of these being books and book chapters – beginning in the year of Vygotsky's death, which presents a fairly unusual and somewhat counterintuitive trend.

Second, the publications as given here in a sense result in an overestimation of Vygotsky's productivity, as they include several writings published after his death and sometimes without his authorization. For example, several books (Vygotskii, 1934b, 1935b, 1935d) were compiled by students – fully or partially – on the basis of lecture notes. It is ironic that Vygotsky's arguably most famous notion, the notion of the zone of proximal development, which he, incidentally, consistently attributed to others, was published in one of these books. And, of course, some of Vygotsky's books were no more than textbooks or readers. These were important in themselves, of course, but add little to our picture of Vygotsky the theorist. And, finally, some texts were published several times. We know, for instance, that Vygotsky sometimes presented an idea first at his institute, then at a conference, then published the idea in an article, which then, finally, was republished in a book. In the publication record such a course of events might yield a score in the categories proceedings, articles, and chapters. Such self-citation (nowadays strangely called self-plagiarism) was not infrequent in Vygotsky's hectic professional career. Nevertheless, even when we discount the double and triple publications, Vygotsky's 'productivity' can be considered as being quantitatively adequate. Even in our times of 'publish or perish' his yearly average would have been entirely acceptable.

Third, it is interesting to ask to what extent Vygotsky's present reputation – in the Soviet Union and in the West – is based on writings published in his lifetime or shortly thereafter, such as *Thinking and speech* (1934), which Vygotsky did not see in print, and *Mental development in the process of education* (1935), published one year after his death. After all, several of his texts circulated in the Soviet Union in the

fairly narrow circles of scholars, mainly in Moscow, as typewritten copies of unpublished works (*samizdat*). We are referring primarily to *The psychology of art* (1925–6), *The crisis in psychology* (1926–7), and several similar works. These works were published with a delay of forty or more years and substantially determined the modern reputation of Vygotsky. Now popular ideas, such as the zone of proximal development or the dynamic localization of function in the brain, earned their popularity quite recently and were not generally known in the Soviet Union of the 1930s. So, Vygotsky's reputation is at least partially based on manuscripts not published during his life. On the other hand, several of Vygotsky's publications that do form part of his publication record have always been ignored by self-declared Vygotskians. A case in point is *Imagination and creativity in childhood* (Vygotskii, 1930d), a booklet of eighty pages written for the general public (see below). In sum, Vygotsky's reputation is based on a selection of his writings, and the principles on which this selection is based are rarely discussed in the scientific literature.

Of course, some selection is inevitable given the multitude and the diversity of over a hundred published sources. Clearly, not all of these are equally important for us now or, for that matter, were equally important for their author. This brings us back to the question of the “real Vygotsky.” What can be considered to be his core writings? In order to answer this question we need to apply the method of critical elimination.

A superficial look at the data might suggest the principle for such elimination: the genre of scholarly writing. Indeed, as we can see, almost half of Vygotsky's publications were general-audience newspaper and journal articles, non-specialized encyclopedia entries, book reviews, editorial introductions, conference abstracts and proceedings that might seem of no theoretical value whatsoever. However, in order to sort out those materials that can potentially be of interest to the contemporary scholarly community of psychologists and practitioners (as opposed to experts in, say, Russian and East European studies or historians of science) we need to take into account that what we know about scholarly genres does not necessarily apply in Vygotsky's case. Thus, for instance, several of his editorial introductions and book reviews contained in-depth analyses of the author's work and a critical assessment that betrayed Vygotsky's theoretical views at the time of writing. The introductions to the Russian translations of books by Wolfgang Köhler, Jean Piaget, and Kurt Koffka form an illustrative example (Vygotskii, 1930a, 1932b, 1934c). So, it would be unwise to use such a formal criterion to exclude writings as being theoretically useless. On the other hand, genres of scientific writing that would seem to be very relevant need not be so. A significant segment of Vygotsky's journal articles, for example, would hardly be considered as “research papers” by the standards of our time: indeed, as a social activist and middle-level governmental employee, Vygotsky would write programmatic, administrative, review or polemical articles, which was not infrequent in the academic press in the Soviet Union of the 1920s–30s, but is quite unusual for us now. These articles typically did not present any empirical studies and hardly touched upon in-depth theoretical issues, but addressed matters of scientific policy or philosophical foundations of Marxist scholarship or reported

the progress of scholarly activity in a specific locale or organization. For obvious reasons, such publications are mainly of historical interest. More or less the same holds for the genre of books. Vygotsky published an impressive number of books and book chapters during a relatively short period but not all of them were theoretically relevant. In fact, a notable number of these book publications were written for non-academic audiences (e.g. general readers lacking basic undergraduate education or minimally trained professionals with traditional agrarian or working-class backgrounds). Such texts often presented compilations and overviews of contemporary Western (mostly European) studies in the humanities and social sciences and were never meant to circulate in the academic context as original scholarly contributions.

Thus, the attempt to determine Vygotsky's core writings on the basis of formal criteria is bound to fail. The issue is decidedly more complicated than that. Even Vygotsky's most famous book, *Thinking and speech* (1934), can be used to illustrate this state of affairs.

The case of *Thinking and speech* (1934)

This book is traditionally positioned and widely discussed as the summit of Vygotsky's theorizing, his claim to fame and the "swan song" of the untimely deceased scholar, who passed away in his late thirties. Indeed, according to different sources, the last additions to the book were made during the last months of the author's life, and the final release of the volume took place roughly half a year after his death. The question is, though, whether all this allows us to characterize *Thinking and speech* as the main contribution of the author to psychological theory. The answer is: hardly so. There are a number of reasons why we feel justified to make this claim.

First, as we can see, this book was partially based on articles and chapters that Vygotsky published earlier and, therefore, roughly half of the book might qualify as a compilation rather than as a monograph (see Table 4.1). Furthermore, the diversity of the genres that contributed to the composition of the book yet again reminds us about the danger of relying on formal criteria in the assessment of scholarly production.

Second, this example also illustrates the danger of oversimplification of chronology (see our discussion of Lifanova's bibliography above). Indeed, the formal release of the book in 1934 does not qualify it as the source that was created in 1934 or even within a reasonably short time before that. As we see, the earliest text incorporated in *Thinking and speech* was written sometime in 1928, which creates a serious challenge for our assessment of the intellectual integrity of the whole book, given Vygotsky's criticism of his ideas of the 1920s, which he expressed in the 1930s on a number of occasions.

Finally, as far as this specific book is concerned and, specifically, with respect to the claim that it represents the peak of Vygotsky's thinking: despite the fact that it was the last book in his lifetime oeuvre, it definitely did not represent his ultimate views and insights. For, as we know, it was already in 1932 that Vygotsky

TABLE 4.1 The structural composition of Vygotsky's *Thinking and speech* (1934)

<i>Text</i>	<i>Pages</i>	<i>Date of writing</i>	<i>Original source</i>	<i>Genre of first publication</i>
Preface	1–3	Not later than spring 1934	–	–
Chapter 1	4–15	Not later than spring 1934	–	–
Chapter 2	16–66	1930	(Vygotskii, 1932b)	Book editor's introduction
Chapter 3	67–75	Not later than early 1929	(Vygotskii, 1929c)	Book review
Chapter 4	76–102	1928	(Vygotskii, 1929a)	Theoretical review/article
Chapter 5	103–162	Not later than fall 1930	(Vygotskii, 1931d)	Undergraduate handbook
Chapter 6	163–176	February 1934	(Vygotskii, 1935a)	Book introduction
	177–255	Not later than spring 1934	–	–
Chapter 7	256–259	February 1934	(Vygotskii, 1935a)	Book introduction
	260–318	Not later than spring 1934	–	–

conceived the whole book project, planned the study of his graduate student Zhozefina Shif discussed in the penultimate chapter, publicly presented the overview of the volume, and even reported it as “in press.” Which means that the topics that were clearly of utmost interest to Vygotsky during the last two years of his life (i.e. in 1932–4) – such as the wide range of clinical and neuropsychological issues or his growing fascination with German-American psychologist Kurt Lewin's scholarship (see Chapters 2 and 9) – are hardly presented in this volume at any length.

In sum, none of the formal criteria of scientific production assessment, such as its release data, the genre of scholarly writing, or even reputation and international fame can serve as a sufficiently solid foundation in our analysis. Overreliance on each of these taken alone potentially leads us to a flawed analysis and inadequate conclusions. Instead, a complex approach grounded on a combination of various factors and criteria is needed. And even this does not free us from mistakes. Therefore, expert opinion and professional interpretation of the various data is crucial. Needless to mention, this does not guarantee success in our assessment of the intellectual legacy, either. Yet, it is the best we can do.

Vygotsky's self-assessment

In this situation, before we ultimately give our own opinion and interpretation of the data, it might be not a bad idea to consult Vygotsky himself and find out his

opinion about his scientific works. However, this seems hardly possible considering the fact that the author has not been with us for the last eighty years. And yet, hope never dies and we still can get a glimpse of the author's self-assessment of his contribution to science. Interviewing the author is not an option under the circumstances, but we certainly can consult his published works in order to check what he considered valuable and to which of his published works he most often referred.

Unfortunately, this method is hardly helpful in the present situation. The reason is that, as we can see in Figure A1 (Appendix B), the decline of the author's publications in the most interesting period of the early 1930s considerably limits the actual material we could use as data. Even the publications that we have refer back to studies that the author did not necessarily consider as his most important, valuable, or representative of his theory in its most advanced form. Keeping in mind this general limitation of using data of the kind, we need a better source of information than the author's self- and cross-references.

Luckily, we do have some useful material. First, as we know, the Soviet Union was a highly bureaucratic state that created tons of all kinds of documents, most of which are still faithfully kept in the state and institutional archives of the Russian Federation. A normal job-selection procedure in the Soviet Union included filling out a questionnaire or writing an essay according to a given plan providing the future employer with personal information of various kinds. Of relevance to our current quest is the fact that in academia quite a few of such forms and essays required informing a future boss about one's publications, if any. It is clear that the applicant, were he or she a scientific worker like Vygotsky, would completely realize that the whole procedure did not exactly qualify as an "objective self-assessment of the personal contribution to international scholarship," and that he or she would mention the published works that would present him best under these specific circumstances and in this particular moment of time – i.e. given the current, ever rapidly changing (particularly in the 1930s), political situation in the Soviet Union. Nevertheless, we consider such data to have considerable value, if used critically, *cum grano salis*.

Unfortunately, the "archival revolution" in Vygotskian scholarship is still in its infancy. That is, we do have several of the relevant documents, but much more remains unexplored: highly interesting material is currently preserved in archives and somebody just needs to go there to collect the data. In any case, as of now we have copies of three documents that present Vygotsky's self-created auto-bibliographies, all created at different moments and on different occasions during the 1930s. First, there is the handwritten document, dated March 13, 1931, that Vygotsky produced upon the request of the administration of the State Institute of Child and Adolescent Health Protection (*Gosudarstvennyi Institut Okhrany Zdorov'ia Detei i Podrostkov imeni 10-letia Oktiabr'skoi Revoliutsii*) in Moscow, as a part of his application for the job of Vice-Director of the Institute (in charge of scientific research).¹ Second, we used the bibliography of Vygotsky's works that was published in English in a volume of 1932 under the editorship of American scholar and scientific entrepreneur Carl Murchison (Murchison, 1932). We have every reason to

believe that no one other than Vygotsky authored this bibliography and that it was finished not later than early 1931. Third, there is another handwritten document that was created on January 14, 1933 – i.e. a year and a half before his death on June 11, 1934 – under doubtful conditions and for an unknown recipient. This document, entitled “Nauchno-pedagogicheskaia biografiia,” was published in 1996 by Vygotsky’s daughter in the Russian journal *Voprosy Psikhologii* (Vygotskaya, 1996) and is currently available online.² The bibliographies in these three documents vary in terms of their length and the selected publications. Thus, the first bibliography is the shortest (five items only) and includes just books published in the Soviet Union. In contrast, the second and the third are notably longer and include books, unpublished manuscripts, and scholarly papers, both published in Russian in the USSR and published abroad in foreign languages.

Vygotsky’s autobiographic official documents and publications

In our analysis of these materials we followed two rules of thumb. First, the more frequently a publication is mentioned by the author in these three documents, the more important to him it should be considered. Therefore, in our selection we eliminated those publications that Vygotsky mentioned only once in any of these documents. And, on the other hand, those that he mentioned in all three were considered as unquestionably important for the author. Second, the later documents were given some preference in our assessment. Thus, in our opinion, the third document (signed on January 14, 1934) has more weight as a source of information about the most advanced stages of Vygotsky’s work, although, unfortunately, it still does not cover the period of the last year and a half of his creative work. All these considerations and limitations should be kept in mind.

As a result, four items that occur in all three documents occupy the top of the list of Vygotsky’s publications. These are:

- (1) *Pedagogical psychology* (1926)
- (2) *Pedology of the school age* (1928)
- (3) *Pedology of the adolescent* (1930, 1931)
- (4) *Studies in the history of behavior* (1930).

These four titles were published in 1926–31, but, as our earlier study demonstrates (Yasnitsky, 2011b), written not later than the end of 1930. As to the third item on this list, *Pedology of the adolescent*, it is worth mentioning that in different documents Vygotsky indicates different years of publication: 1930 (in document three) and 1931 (in documents one and two). Given that this item came out as a three-volume series in 1929, 1930, and 1931, it is somewhat difficult to identify which of these Vygotsky meant to identify on his list. We even do not discount the possibility that Vygotsky made a mistake in indicating the year of publication or meant to indicate the whole three-volume series. However, as we know, entities should not be multiplied without necessity, therefore, in our analysis we stick to the data as it is and

assume that Vygotsky would range the volumes of this edition according to their importance: volumes two (1930) and three (1931) as relatively more valuable scholarly contributions and volume 1 (1929) as relatively less significant.

Then, we created the auxiliary list of publications that occur in two of the three documents and include not only books but also a few scientific papers:

- (1) *The psychology of art* (book manuscript, 1925–6)
- (2) Consciousness as a problem for the psychology of behavior (chapter, 1925)
- (3) Principles of social education of deaf and dumb children in Russia (conference paper, 1925, in English)
- (4) The problem of dominant reactions (chapter, 1926)
- (5) The problem of the cultural development of the child (article, 1929, in English)
- (6) *Imagination and creativity in childhood* (book, 1930).

This list, yet again, comprises pieces that were created mostly in the 1920s and not later than early 1930. Interestingly, it contains one unpublished manuscript, *The psychology of art*, which was contracted for publication as early as in 1926 (a photocopy of the contract was published in Vygotskaya & Lifanova, 1996), but was eventually denied publication during Vygotsky's lifetime – under circumstances which remain unclear, but, as we tend to believe, for censorship reasons (for discussion of censorship issues see Chapter 3). Also notable is the inclusion of two foreign-language publications: a journal article of 1929 and a conference paper of 1925, both in English.

A last remark on these three documents is in place. It is interesting to note that the third list contains a number of items that could have been mentioned in one of the earlier bibliographies (such as in document two), but in fact were not. On the other hand, quite a number of those publications that occur in the second bibliography are not mentioned in the later bibliography of January 14, 1933. In our cautious interpretation, this may be evidence of Vygotsky's reassessment of his scientific work that started somewhere mid-1929 and continued throughout the whole period of the early 1930s until his death in June, 1934. Thus, we would not be surprised to eventually come across a very different version of “the best of Vygotsky” in one of the author's documents created around 1933–4, when and if such an archival document is discovered.

Vygotsky's private documents and correspondence

In addition to these autobiographies and auto-bibliographies, another important source of information is Vygotsky's private correspondence. This is particularly rich with first-hand information about Vygotsky's opinions, preferences, thoughts and doubts; information that can hardly be found in official publications or formal presentations. Fortunately, the correspondence and personal notes have been published not just in Russian (Vygotskii, 2004), but are also available to the interested reader in English and German translation (Rückriem, 2009; Vygotsky, 2007).³ These

materials we have also checked for indications of Vygotsky's self-assessment of his scientific legacy and scholarly publications.

Characteristically, Vygotsky's correspondence and private documents contain little in terms of positive assessment of his published work. However, there is a wealth of critical assessment and also several self-critical remarks and statements that provide insight into how Vygotsky would range his work in terms of its importance and contribution to international scholarship. Besides, a number of other, indirect and seemingly tangential, remarks and statements also provide us with essential information.

A good example is Vygotsky's correspondence about a book jointly planned and written with Luria. In a letter to Luria dated July 26, 1927, he wrote:

I was called to GIZ to sign a contract concerning the 'ape' ... It looks like the date will be December 1. What remained was to sign the contract at the finance department, which I will do immediately. Once that is done, they will give me the money – 175 roubles. I feel boundless joy about this commission. It is an opportunity to present the outlines of psychology in light of the concepts of culture and the superman.

(Vygotskii, 2004, p. 11)

In this fragment Vygotsky refers to a book that was eventually published under the title *Studies on the psychology of behavior: Ape, primitive, child*. Vygotsky seems to indicate the deadline for manuscript submission: December 1, presumably 1927. The book, however, was considerably delayed and did not come out until 1930. By that time, Vygotsky's enthusiasm about this project had considerably decreased. Thus, in a letter to Leontiev of July 23, 1929, he wrote:

I am correcting the 2nd part of the 'ape'. Goodness, the 1st part is written wholly in the spirit of the Freudians (not even according to Freud, but according to Vera Schmidt (her materials), Melanie Klein, and other second-rate stars). And then the impenetrable Piaget, who is absolutized beyond all measures; and over and above all that, tools and signs are mixed together, etc. etc. This is not Aleksandr Romanovich's personal fault, but that of the entire "era" of our thought. We must ruthlessly put an end to that. What is not yet clear from our view, how it should be transformed so as to become an organic component of our theory – all that should not be allowed to be part of the system. Let us wait then ... And, therefore, we should structure the same external organizational regime so that the errors of the 'monkey' become impossible.

(Vygotskii, 2004, p. 18)

The same letter gives us an idea of what Vygotsky thought about some of his own work, but does not provide specific references to any particular commitments

and obligations: “For the moment I am at the dacha. I am busy with profitable [khlebyne] and therefore useless tasks until August 1” (Vygotskii, 2004, p. 19).

In 1930 a collected volume of papers with the overviews of contemporary strands in Western psychology was published. Vygotsky authored two chapters for the volume, one on Gestalt theory that he referred to as “Structural psychology” (*Strukturnaia psikhologiya*, in Russian) and the other about the then popular theory of eidetic perception developed by the German psychologist Erich Rudolf Jaensch (1883–1940), who, as a matter of fact, would later join the National Socialist German Workers’ Party (NSDAP, the Nazi Party). Vygotsky seems to have been in correspondence with Jaensch, as follows from one of his letters. Vygotsky’s assessment of these two chapters of 1930 seems to be generally applicable to much of the work that he did at that time. Consider a fragment of his letter of December 27, 1930, to Vladimir Vagner:

The book (anthology) by Fingert et al. has come out; I have not yet received and read it, but have heard bad opinions about it: It had been planned as a large, broad anthology, comprising all directions and branches of modern psychology in a popular presentation. I wrote two essays – extremely basic and popular.

(*Rückriem*, 2009, p. 250)

Vygotsky’s critical attitude to some of his publications was not incidental and was partly rooted in the deep crisis in his theoretical thinking that he experienced after 1929. In a certain sense, we can describe it as a Copernican revolution and major shift in his theorizing during which he realized that the most foundational concepts and terms that he had been using until 1929 were no longer satisfactory and valid. One of the foundational notions that underwent radical transformation during that period was that of “psychological function.” We know of at least one context in which Vygotsky announced a dramatic change in the entire conceptual framework and, thus, the research goals of his team. In a talk that he gave to his colleagues on October 9, 1930, Vygotsky stated:

In the process of development, and in the historical development in particular, it is not so much the functions that change (these we mistakenly studied before). Their structure and the system of their development remain the same. What is changed and modified are rather the relationships, the links between the functions. New constellations emerge which were unknown in the preceding stage.

(*Vygotsky*, 1997b, p. 92)

This theoretical crisis continued in 1931 and no apparent solution was found to the numerous problems that Vygotsky was fruitlessly struggling with. Thus, in a letter to Luria, dated June 12, 1931, Vygotsky wrote:

I am still beset with thousands of petty chores. The fruitlessness of what I do greatly distresses me. My scientific thinking is going off into the realm of fantasy, and I cannot think things through in a realistic way to the end. Nothing is going right: I am doing the wrong things, writing the wrong things, saying the wrong things. A fundamental reorganization is called for – and this time I am going to carry it out.

(Vygotsky, 2007, p. 36)

This dissatisfaction with the state of the art of his work continued and is evident even by the end of 1932. This is how Vygotsky described this situation in the personal notes that he prepared for his presentation of December, 1932, a year and a half before his death:

1. The necessity of a new stage of inquiry does not stem from the fact that a new thought has occurred to me or a new idea has caught my interest, but from the necessity of developing the research itself – new facts prod me into searching for new and more intricate explanations. The narrowness, bias, and schematism of the old mindset led us to a wrong assessment of the essential principles, which we mistook for the secondary ones: interfunctional connections. We focused attention on the sign (on the tool) to the detriment of the operation with it, representing it as something simple, which goes through three phases: magical – external – internal. But the knot is external and the teenager's diary is external. Hence we have a sea of poorly explained facts and a desire to delve more deeply into the facts, i.e., to evaluate them theoretically in a different way. 2. The higher and lower functions are not constructed in two tiers: their number and names do not match. But our previous understanding was not right either [, according to which] a higher function is the mastery of the lower ([e.g.] voluntary attention is the subordination to it of involuntary attention) because this means exactly – in two tiers.

(Vygotsky's record titled "Symposium, December 4, 1932,"
see Zavershneva, 2010b, pp. 41–42; see also Chapter 5 and,
specifically, Chapter 6)

Yet, the situation was not as desperate as it might seem. Indeed, the early 1930s – despite Vygotsky's considerable dissatisfaction with the theory – opened up promising new avenues for empirical research and, quite possibly, new theoretical insights and groundbreaking discoveries.

As we have seen, in his bibliography of January 13, 1933, Vygotsky included his paper on schizophrenia that came out in English in the United States in 1932. This paper was published through the mediation and translation of the local scholar and medical doctor of Russian descent Jacob Kasanin, who by his admission had visited the Soviet Union in 1930, where he met Vygotsky and had first-hand acquaintance with his work (on Kasanin and his role in the dissemination of Vygotsky's ideas in the West see also Chapter 7). On several occasions Vygotsky refers to his

correspondence with Kasanin about his paper. Thus, in his letter of June 1, 1931, he wrote to Luria: "I received a letter from Kasanin that my article is on the way" (Vygotskii, 2004, p. 24). Indeed, the original paper that Vygotsky refers to in this letter was apparently penned sometime in 1931 in order to eventually come out in Russian in 1932 (Vygotskii, 1932a). This paper was imported by Kasanin into the United States and was published there two years after its publication in Russian (Vygotsky, 1934).

In the same letter we come across a reference to Vygotsky's book: "I was terribly happy about your words on my book. I know it is bad, but considering your pessimism ('We haven't done anything') I am glad that you see the path with its broader perspectives" (Vygotskii, 2004, p. 25). There is not much clarity about exactly which book Vygotsky is referring to in this letter, but given that we know of only one book that Vygotsky published in 1931, it might be a reference to volume 3 of his *Pedology of the adolescent*. Perhaps this negative self-assessment is related to the over-delayed *Psychological dictionary* (1931), co-authored with his associate Boris Varshava (1900–27) and probably completed in the late 1920s. Alternatively, what Vygotsky meant by a "book" was perhaps yet another unpublished manuscript that we now know as one of his "lost works" (see the discussion of Vygotsky's "lost work" below).

Yet, the topic of schizophrenia appeared to be of increasing interest to Vygotsky and again and again it emerged in his personal correspondence. Thus, a year later, on June 26, 1932, Vygotsky wrote to Luria: "I finished a lecture on schizophrenia and would like to speak to you about several things in this context" (Vygotskii, 2004, p. 35). Then, less than a month later, Vygotsky yet again returned to this disquieting and exciting topic of interest. On July 13, 1932, he wrote to Luria: "I have written a lecture on schizophrenia; I will tell you more about it in a few days" (Vygotskii, 2004, p. 36). And, indeed, this lecture and paper, finished in the summer of 1932, was subsequently published in 1933 under the same title as his preceding "schizophrenia paper," which was very confusing. This persistent reference to the same mental disease indicates the whole new world of exciting research that Vygotsky switched to in 1932–4: research on pathology in clinical settings.

In one of Vygotsky's letters of 1933 we came across a most curious discussion of an anticipated publication that, unfortunately, was never to materialize. Thus, in his letter of November 21, 1933, Vygotsky wrote to Luria:

Finally, about the series: If it actually and periodically is to be published (at all costs from issue to issue), we must take it into our own hands with full responsibility. I have already: (1) the classification of aphasia, (2) Birenbaum and Vygotsky: aphasia and dementia, (3) Birenbaum and Zeigarnik: agnosia, (4) Vygotsky: written speech in brain lesions, (5) Vygotsky: grammatical dysfunction, etc. etc. *ohne Zahl*, as our patient answers when asked about the number of fingers she has on one hand. By the middle of December I will have prepared my first article and we will prepare three or four others in advance. A general title for all papers, as in *Gestalttheorie*, Lewin, etc., is a must ...

The title for the series (options):

1. psychological [~~crossed out~~] Investigation of the higher psychological functions in development and disintegration;
2. investigations in clinical psychology;
3. experimental and psychological [~~the last word crossed out~~] clinical investigations in psychopathology;
4. investigation of thinking and speech in pathological dysfunctions;
5. psychological investigation of nervous and mental diseases;
6. psychological clinic of nervous and mental diseases.

(Vygotskii, 2004, p. xx)

The whole projected series of publications clearly indicates very intensive research conducted by Vygotsky along with his Moscow (Birenbaum and Zeigarnik) and Kharkov (Luria, Lebedinskii, and their associates at the Department of Clinical Psychology) teams in 1932–4. Not much of this work has been published to date and what was published appears of considerable interest not only to Vygotsky and his collaborators at that time, but also to contemporary scholars who are generally unfamiliar with this work (Birenbaum, 1934; Birenbaum & Zeigarnik, 1935; Kaganovskaia & Zeigarnik, 1935; Samukhin, 1934, 1935; Samukhin, Birenbaum, & Vygotskii, 1934; Zeigarnik, 1934; Zeigarnik & Birenbaum, 1935).

Finally, the summative assessment of Vygotsky's general contribution to psychology and specifically the theory of consciousness that he was most intensely engaged with during the last two years of his life can be found in one of the personal notes discovered among his archival documents. This is how Zavershneva presents this quotation in her English publication of 2010:

The series “Manuscript Progress” includes an entry that apparently can be regarded as the last one he made before leaving for the hospital. The entry “Conference (Zaks)” [Konferentsiia (Zaks)] begins with someone else's words: Vygotsky quotes some science functionary who asks why he needs a big auditorium, what he is going to talk about; then come fragmentary notes from a symposium (a discussion of the clinical cases of Kogan and Zaks), and then the text changes direction, as it no longer runs lengthwise down the page but instead runs across it. It is a very personal entry that indeed runs at right angles to the entire text, above it. It reflects the mood with which Vygotsky said goodbye to what had constituted the purpose of his life:

NB! Pro domo suo

This is the final thing I have done in psychology – and I will like Moses die at the summit, having glimpsed the promised land but without setting foot on it. Farewell, dear creations. The rest is silence.

(Zavershneva, 2010b, p. 58; see also Chapter 5)

In order to shed light on this – fairly pessimistic and somewhat cryptic – self-assessment of Vygotsky’s contribution to psychology we suggest comparing it with the statements that Vygotsky made in the first and the last chapters of his last, posthumously published, book *Thinking and speech*, where he equally pessimistically asserted:

We perfectly well understand the inevitable imperfection of that first step in the new direction that we tried to make in this work. But we see its justification in the fact that it, in our firm belief, moves us ahead in the investigation of thinking and speech in comparison with that state of this problem that had formed in psychology when we began our work. It uncovers the problem of thinking and speech as the key problem of all psychology of man and directly leads the researcher to a new psychological theory of consciousness. However, we touch upon this problem only in the few concluding words of our work and interrupt the investigation at its very threshold.⁴

(Vygotskii, 1934a, p. 3, in our translation from Russian)

This statement is mirrored in and further clarified by the concluding words on the last page of the book, where Vygotsky clearly stated:

In conclusion of our investigation, we cannot but dwell in a few words upon those perspectives that unfold beyond its threshold. Our investigation leads us closely to the threshold of another, even vaster, even deeper, even more grandiose problem than the problem of thinking – the problem of consciousness.⁵

(Vygotskii, 1934a, p. 318, in our translation from Russian; for a discussion of Vygotsky’s theory of consciousness see Zavershneva, 2014)

The similarity and parallels between these fragments and their imagery are as striking as they are obvious: Written in the same period, they provide us with Vygotsky’s perception of his work as unfinished, abandoned at the “threshold” of the ultimate goal of his life. Thus, the history of Vygotsky’s (and his collaborators’) theory of consciousness is the re-enactment of the old biblical plot, when the hero, who brought his people from slavery to the Promised Land, has to die without ever setting foot on the new terrain. And although the settings and guiding metaphors in these two stories – the one of Vygotsky (and his research team) and the other of Moses (and “his people”) – are quite different, in both cases the mission was not entirely accomplished and the hero tragically dies.

“The lost works”

In order to identify the “best of the best” of Vygotsky, that is, to assess the relative importance of Vygotsky’s works we made the decision to “interview the author” and analyzed his self-bibliographies, correspondence, and personal notes

for evidence of Vygotsky's self-evaluation. We believe this method of research is productive, although not universally applicable. Of course, someone might argue that the author did not necessarily mention all the works that he considered most important or valuable. The reason for this might be Vygotsky's fear of criticism and censorship that might eventually become a threat to his career or even lead to political persecutions and criminal charges. Indeed, this was not an unlikely scenario in Stalinist Russia, although, at the same time, we believe that the horrors of the so-called "repressed science" (*repressirovannaiia nauka*) have been grossly overestimated by Western scholars of the Cold War era and their intellectual heirs in the Soviet Union from the late 1980s and until now (see discussion of these issues in Chapters 1 and 3). In any case, we are certainly aware of the phenomenon of "self-censorship" in Soviet culture and science and need to analyze our findings from this perspective, too.

We have carried out an additional investigation of the sources that we will call here "the lost work" of Vygotsky. The reference is to those bibliographic items that were either censored at some point in the history of Soviet censorship or were mentioned in a source but never saw the light of day. Here we have something that may well be interpreted as a layer of "unknown," "hidden," "prohibited," or "banned" works – works that are yet potentially utterly important for contemporary scholarship. A list of the "lost works" of Vygotsky can be found in Appendix A. On the basis of our analysis of this material we came to a few conclusions.

First, the list contains an incredible number of bibliographic entries that are referred to in some source but were never published – at least not under the given titles. Furthermore, this category includes a wealth of items that were reported as "in press" (in several instances, in non-existent publishing houses), but no trace of either subsequent publications or archival manuscripts were found (for discussion of Vygotsky's archival materials see Chapters 5 and 6). This leads us to the tentative conclusion that these manuscripts either never existed or were lost or even "secretly borrowed" from the archive by Vygotsky's anonymous admirers. Another option is that some manuscripts did exist at some point but were renamed – quite possibly, several times; for a historical precedent see the discussion of alternative titles of Vygotsky's manuscript "(Historical) Meaning of the crisis in psychology" in (Zavershneva & Osipov, 2012b). Possibly, some of these manuscripts were reworked and included in some other – unpublished or eventually published – works. For example, we have certain reasons to believe that the text that was published under the title *The history of the development of higher psychological functions* in the Soviet edition of 1983 was constructed by the Soviet editors in the early 1980s on the basis of two unrelated manuscripts of Vygotsky. In fact, this title never occurred in a single one of Vygotsky's texts or documents and a manuscript of that name is conspicuously absent in Vygotsky's archive. Most likely the text was compiled from the manuscripts *The investigation of higher psychological functions* (1930) and *(Outlines of the) history of the cultural development of the normal and abnormal child* (1928–9), which were mechanically merged and published under one, artificially created title (Vygotskii, 1983).

Second, in several instances Vygotsky did not finish his work on certain manuscripts and abandoned them. These texts are clearly distinct from those that he did finish and intended to publish. Perhaps the most notable feature of Vygotsky's unfinished (and most often abandoned) works is the absence of full references in the body of the text and the lack of a bibliography after the text. These are the case in his (*The historical) meaning of the psychological crisis* (1926–7) or his variously titled manuscript on Spinoza and the psychology of the emotions of 1932–3. This is also characteristic of the last chapter of Vygotsky's *Thinking and speech* in the original edition of 1934, which was notably “rectified” in the “corrected” versions of the text of the later editions. These unfinished manuscripts stand in sharp contrast to the published works of Vygotsky or, for that matter, his contemporaries and even to those unpublished works that Vygotsky did finish and prepared for publication. An example of the latter case is the book manuscript *Psychology of art*, which was, as we saw before, contracted for publication but never published during Vygotsky's lifetime. The argumentation in this manuscript – as we know it from Soviet publications of the 1960s that came out under the editorship of a non-psychologist, the philologist Vyacheslav Vs. Ivanov – was most meticulously supported with numerous references and concluded with a list of over 160 quoted sources (Vygotskii, 1965, 1968, 2008).

We know that in several instances there was nothing fatal or tragic in Vygotsky abandoning his unfinished writings: thus, for instance, it was recently demonstrated that virtually the entire set of key ideas of Vygotsky's unfinished manuscript on the crisis in psychology was eventually published during the author's lifetime. The ideas appeared in scholarly articles that were more consistent, coherent, and unambiguous than in the unfinished manuscript (Zavershneva, 2012b). There were also instances – not unusual for Vygotsky – when already published segments of works were later republished by their author (see our discussion of the case of Vygotsky's *Thinking and speech*, above).

Third, one might argue that the absence of Vygotsky's references to his unpublished works was due to (self-)censorship and that they still are of considerable value regardless of whether Vygotsky referred to them or not. Having examined our data, we would disagree with such an interpretation. The example of *The psychology of art* – Vygotsky's doctoral dissertation manuscript that in all likelihood was banned from publication for political reasons (such as references to “politically incorrect” figures like Leon Trotsky) – is quite telling. The title does occur on Vygotsky's own list of his most important works. In contrast, a number of other “lost work” titles did not deserve Vygotsky's praise as important – yet unpublished – works. Perhaps these works do not deserve our praise, either.

Conclusion: Vygotsky's foundational works

The time has now come to connect the loose threads and put all the pieces of the puzzle together. In order to single out Vygotsky's main works we used the materials of his authorial bibliographies and focused on books that occurred no less than

twice in the three documents that we studied. That criterion resulted in the following list, ordered chronologically:

- (1) *The psychology of art*; unpublished manuscript, 1925–6
- (2) *Pedagogical psychology*; textbook, 1926
- (3) *The pedology of school age*; textbook, 1928
- (4) *Imagination and creativity in children: A psychological essay*; popular booklet, 1930
- (5) *Studies on the history of behavior: Ape, primitive, child*; book, 1930 (in collaboration with Luria)
- (6) *Pedology of the adolescent*; textbook in three volumes, 1929, 1930, and 1931.

These publications, according to Vygotsky, constituted the core of his published works and appear to represent the main tenets of his theory. Yet, we would like to comment on this list, as important as it is.

First, it is interesting to note that none of these works was included in the Russian and English six-volume collection of Vygotsky's works, with the exception of part of the third volume of the *Pedology of the adolescent*. This seems to reveal a quite remarkable discrepancy between the author's representation of his scientific legacy and the image of the "Vygotskian legacy" as it was constructed after World War II by his "intellectual heirs": the publishers, editors, and censors of his works – typically, the very same people at the same time.

Second, as we know, not all Vygotsky's publications were of equal scholarly value. Thus, by Vygotsky's own admission, several of them were written just to earn some money ("*khlebnye zakazy*"). These were written in the popular science genre and often based on secondary – most typically, Western – sources rather than original research. This is the case for items four and, partially (i.e. the first half of the book), five on the list.

Third, another series of Vygotsky's publications was written for teaching purposes and addressed the lowest academic level, the undergraduate audience (see also above). Therefore, these books also hardly qualify as solid theoretical treatises. This is true of items of two, three, and six.

Finally, the list comprises works that were written not later than the end of 1930, and, therefore, might illustrate Vygotsky's ideas of his "instrumental" – mechanistic and fairly reductionist – thinking of the 1920s but not the major shift that his thinking underwent in the tumultuous 1930s.

For all these reasons, we need to augment the above list with other works: the publications that came out after 1931 and, where possible, the studies that Vygotsky and the members of the "Vygotsky circle" conducted during Vygotsky's "holistic period" of the 1930s. This task is quite challenging, given the dramatic decrease in publications of this period, Vygotsky's self-criticism, and the apparently unfinished nature of his project of the theory of consciousness (see discussion in Zavershneva, 2014). Therefore, the best we have is a series of posthumous publications of 1934–6 – apparently, not authorized by their author for publication, but still, in our estimate, not so profoundly and shamelessly edited (and distorted) as the Soviet publications

of the 1950s–80s. The materials are somewhat fragmented and further research will be needed to reconstruct the overall image of Vygotsky’s “holistic period.” This reconstruction will chiefly be done on the basis of several books that came out after Vygotsky’s death under the editorship of his associates V. N. Kolbanovskii, Zh. I. Shif, L. V. Zankov, D. B. El’konin, M. A. Levina, and I. I. Daniushevskii. These titles include:

- (1) *Thinking and speech*; book, 1934
- (2) *Foundations of pedology*; textbook, 1934/5
- (3) *Mental development of children in the process of learning and instruction*; book, 1935
- (4) *The mentally retarded child*; book, 1935.

Vygotsky mentioned none of these publications as being among his best published works (the only exception is *Thinking and speech*, which occurs in his auto-bibliography of January 1933), and for quite obvious reasons: they were posthumous editions prepared and submitted for publication after the author’s death on June 11, 1934. For one reason or another they can be criticized for lack of scholarly integrity or as not being sufficiently “scientific”: thus, the list includes a publication based on shorthand notes of Vygotsky’s undergraduate lectures (item 2) or edited collections of works written on different occasions at different periods of Vygotsky’s life (items (3) and (4), and, as we have already demonstrated, item (1) – *Thinking and speech* – also fit this description). And still, these are the publications that give us an idea about how and in what direction Vygotsky’s thought developed during the last years of his life. Yet again, with the exception of the first item, none of these sources was included in the six-volume Russian or English edition of Vygotsky’s *Collected works* or fully republished during the Cold War/Soviet period.

Finally, the list of Vygotsky’s books of the 1930s needs to be augmented with various smaller publications by the members of Vygotsky’s circle who worked on the problems of speech impairment and other dysfunctions caused by trauma, neurological and infectious diseases, brain lesions, and psychiatric disorders. An important direction of their theoretical work was the deliberate synthesis of certain of Vygotsky’s ideas on mental development with the ideas of Gestalt psychologists, perhaps most notably those of Kurt Lewin and his associates. For references to specific publications and the overview of these scientific interdependencies and transnational developments see Chapters 2 and 9.

All this creates a fairly new, not so familiar image of Vygotsky and his scientific legacy. Readers – particularly those readers who have always considered themselves as experts in “Vygotskian psychology” – might feel uneasy and startled by the *terra incognita* and the new pathways that it suggests. If so, we would consider our mission accomplished. In fact, this is what the “revisionist revolution” in Vygotsky studies is all about.

5

VYGOTSKY THE UNPUBLISHED

An overview of the personal archive (1912–1934)

Ekaterina Zavershneva

The main reasons to study Vygotsky's personal archive

In this chapter we will present the results of our study of Vygotsky's personal papers in the family archive. It has been argued repeatedly that Vygotsky's personal archive should be studied scientifically (e.g. Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991, p. 9). The main reason is that this source has never been subjected to systematic historical scrutiny. Even during the preparation of the Russian edition of Vygotsky's *Collected works* in six volumes in the early 1980s, no systematic ordering of the archive took place, no inventory of the documents was made, and the manuscripts published in these volumes were not studied in any detail. Another reason to begin our study of the archive in 2006 was the unreliability of the text of the *Collected works*, which until now remains the basis for republication of his works in Russian and other languages. It is well known that the policy of active editorial interference in the original text led to a large number of unjustified factual and semantic changes (and even replacements), which continue to be reprinted in new editions. The level of historical analysis of Vygotsky's works also leaves something to be desired: for example, the dates of writing of manuscripts, such as *The (historical) meaning of the psychological crisis*, *Defect and compensation*, and *The problem of consciousness*, are given incorrectly. Also, the text itself of the writings in the *Collected works* and in other Soviet writings is almost never subjected to critical analysis. A positive exception is Ivanov's edition of *The psychology of art* (see Vygotskii, 1968). Apart from that, the investigation of the personal archive should involve the historically most interesting part: the notebooks, scientific diaries, and scattered notes, which until the early 2000s remained practically untouched. As it turned out, it was precisely the study of Vygotsky's personal notes that formed the missing link that allowed us to view the creation of a great number of works,

such as *Thinking and speech*, *A theory of the emotions*, and *Pedology of the adolescent* in a new light. It proved possible to establish the date of writing of manuscripts more exactly and to uncover several of Vygotsky's plans for future books and investigations that never materialized.

When we began the ordering of the archival materials we had two major goals: (1) to search for hitherto unknown writings, and (2) to reconstruct the original form of previously published texts. It seemed obvious that the archive would reveal many new facts about Vygotsky's life, but even the preliminary results far surpassed our expectations. We were able to find unknown manuscripts (several of them from the Gomel period of his life), we could complete the bibliography of his works, and we managed to bring order to the personal notes: from the early years (1912–16) to the notes written in the final months of his life (1933–4). More than two dozen previously unknown shorthand versions of lectures were found. These included the lectures *The problem of perception* (April 25, 1934) and *The main problems of the preschool age* (May 7, 1934), which Vygotsky gave one and a half months before his death and which were not mentioned in existing bibliographies. There is also a rare but excellently preserved copy of an issue of *Veresk*, the journal that the young Vygotsky edited in Gomel. At present Vygotsky's very first text, dedicated to the book of Ecclesiastes, and entitled *The tragicomedy of strivings* (1912), is ready for publication. We also found drafts of an analysis of Shakespeare's *Hamlet*, theater and book reviews from the Gomel period, the manuscripts of the talks at the Second All-Russian Congress of Psychoneurology and the 2nd SPON¹ Congress in 1924 – with these talks the young researcher from Gomel entered psychological science (Vygotskii, 2013; Zavershneva, 2013), and much more. In addition, we reconstructed the authentic text of *The (historical) meaning of the psychological crisis*, from which the references to 'inconvenient' authors (e.g. Trotsky, Bukharin, and Radek) had been removed (Zavershneva & Osipov, 2012a, 2012b). Finally, we reconstructed the idea of the monograph *Foundations of defectology* and deciphered and systematized practically all of Vygotsky's notes. The present chapter succinctly presents the results of the investigations carried out in this part of the personal archive.

The unequivocal scientific value of the archival notes is not just that they reveal ideas and plans that were not realized, but they also help us to follow the process of Vygotsky's thinking. Most interesting are not so much his chains of reasoning but the leaps of thought, the sudden flashes of insight, the ruptures in the argumentation. More than elsewhere, in these notes one feels Vygotsky's direct presence as a colorful and open person and at the same time a deeply tragic figure, who realized that the time allotted to him was short and the task immense; a task that he planned to solve if not alone, then with a small group of kindred spirits. This task was the creation of a general psychological theory in which all preceding approaches would be "superseded" (to use a Hegelian term Vygotsky often used), which, in its turn, would allow us to overcome the crisis in psychology.

General characteristics of the personal notes

Outside appearance and degree of preservation

It must be noted that the archive has survived to date thanks to the Vygotsky family and, notably, Vygotsky's wife Roza Noevna and his eldest daughter Gita L'vovna. The personal notes are generally very well preserved, although somewhat less well than the bigger manuscripts. This is because they were not meant to be read by other persons and were jotted down on whatever was at hand, such as pieces of paper, cards, the backs of forms, off-prints, and even newspaper pages. All documents are small – the result of Vygotsky's predilection for miniature notebooks and the acute shortage of paper in those times. As a rule, Vygotsky has written on both sides of the paper – mostly in no particular order, so that the order of the notes must be reconstructed when preparing texts for publication – in his small but clear handwriting, which changed markedly toward the end of his life. In the years 1933 and 1934, Vygotsky frequently resorted to abbreviations, the text lost most of its vowels, and sometimes a phrase or quotation was indicated with just the first letters of the words. In the notes from 1934, Vygotsky's handwriting becomes unsteady and the paper shows tiny brown specks, which presumably reflect the fact that the author had just a few months to live and died of a hemorrhage caused by chronic tuberculosis of the lungs.

Unsorted, the notes filled approximately five to six voluminous boxes, filled to the brim with small leaflets. The notes were scattered over the boxes and painstaking work was required to reconstruct the complete texts from the separate fragments. Several documents contain sketches that are hard to read, because they are partially erased or faded by sunlight (part of the notes were kept outside the archive under inappropriate conditions). However, there was little that could not be reconstructed, not counting the cases when we did not manage to find the missing pages in the notes. Several records remain unstudied, however, because reading them requires the use of ultraviolet light or handwriting expertise.

Special characteristics of the work with Vygotsky's notes

The same circumstances that made Vygotsky's work difficult now substantially help the investigator of the archive. Had these fragments been typed on simple white paper, it would have been extremely difficult to assemble the complete texts, let alone to establish their date of writing. However, each piece of paper in the archive has its own profile, its own individuality. A first sorting of the documents according to the type of paper immediately revealed several basic groups of documents, within which it was easier to find one's way. Subsequently, within each group, subgroups could be distinguished on the basis of both their content and formal characteristics, to wit:

- (1) the type and format of the paper;
- (2) the handwriting characteristics (slope, roundness, extent of abbreviation, etc.);

- (3) the numbering of the pages or statements (the position on the page, brackets, dots, number type, etc.), type of ink or pencil;
- (4) persistent quotations, expressions characteristic of a specific period, repetitive aphorisms or sayings, frequently used foreign terms;
- (5) mention of names of collaborators, colleagues, students; references to events known from the literature about Vygotsky; polemics with the major scientific opponents of a specific period;
- (6) the theme of the notes and their link with the central themes of the given period as reflected in Vygotsky's published and unpublished texts; references to his own writings;
- (7) the link of the major themes of the notes to material both within a given group and with other groups.

Both the formal characteristics and the content characteristics (with the exception of point (3), of course) were not just used to assemble the texts, but also to establish their date of writing, because Vygotsky rarely put a date on such notes. Within one group, texts from which the date of writing was firmly established formed a reference point for the work with the other texts; comparison of similar text fragments yielded approximate dates. Material with printed dates (for example, library cards, invitations, bills) provided a lower time boundary, just like quotations from works with a known date of writing or publication.

The theoretical foundation for the work with the documents was a detailed periodization of Vygotsky's scientific life that we created. It describes the hard core of his scientific research program (the main principles) and the related ideas (auxiliary hypotheses, research methods, etc.), the problematic propositions, the vulnerable spots in his conception, a list of anomalies (i.e. facts which require another explanation) caused by progressive shifts in the scientific research program, and also an indication of Vygotsky's main opponents with whom he had oral or written discussions that were very important for the development of his thinking. These key moments were used as chronological markers, but in a number of cases it turned out that the generally accepted view on the appearance of some theme in Vygotsky's work, based on his published writings, itself needed correction. In particular, the archival documents showed that the cultural-historical theory in the proper sense of the word originated in mid-1926 (notebook from Zakhar'ino hospital) and that the so-called "principle of the semantic structure of consciousness" was introduced no later than mid-1932.

The most important archival documents: series of notes, exercise books and notebooks, separate notes, letters

The notes cover the greater part of Vygotsky's life, but the various periods are represented unevenly: most materials belong to the years 1931–4. The year 1932 is particularly well represented – both quantitatively and qualitatively. This was the year of a turning point, a huge step forward from the system principle, formulated toward the end of 1930 in the talk *On psychological systems* (Vygotsky, 1997b), to the

hypothesis of the semantic structure of consciousness. Also well represented are the final two years of Vygotsky's life, when he worked with incredible energy and was full of plans for the future.

As said before, the division into groups was carried out on the basis of a series of criteria. It primarily served the practical function of systematizing the archive and also allowed us to preserve the chronological order in the exposition of a theme. A separate investigation should be dedicated to the links between the groups, the historical continuity, and the dynamics in the treatment of certain key problems that return in all periods of Vygotsky's work. However, these tasks go beyond the boundaries of this chapter and we will limit ourselves to the preliminary description of the notes and the most important documents that substantially complete or change our ideas about Vygotsky's biography.

The titles of the notes cited below are based on their first lines; the shorthand abbreviations (leaving out letters in words) have been deciphered, the spelling and punctuation of the original have been changed in accordance with contemporary norms. Editorial insertions are given in square brackets; illegible words are given in angle brackets, and a provisional interpretation is provided. No emphasis in the quotations has been added.

Notes from the years 1912–1930

Exercise books and notebooks

Exercise books 1–3 revealed little-known aspects of Vygotsky's work from the years 1912–15.

1. *The tragicomedy of strivings*. This is an exercise book, labeled 1912, that contains the draft of a talk dedicated to the interpretation of the book of Ecclesiastes. Presumably, it is the detailed plan for a talk that the gymnasium student Lev Vygotsky planned to give during one of the sessions of the circle for the study of Hebrew history and the philosophy of history (for a description of that circle, see Feigenberg, 2000, pp. 7–11). Vygotsky set himself the task to present a philosophical and psychological analysis of Ecclesiastes as an “eternal symbol” of the history that repeats itself in the spiritual quest of each person, a sort of existential Odyssey. He distinguished three periods in the life of Ecclesiastes, pointed out their connection, and wrote that the main tragedy of human life is felt as the impossibility of achieving the plenitude of being. However, each of us is forced to live under the circumstances of a fragmented, polar world, with its irreconcilable contradictions: “we ask, and know in advance that we will not get it; we knock the door of knowledge that is forever closed, knowing in advance that it will not be opened; we seek, knowing in advance that we shall never find,”² writes the 16-year-old author. And, nevertheless, the book of Ecclesiastes, a complete mystery, shows that an answer can be found: despite the fact that “no one has as yet unraveled life” we may bring ourselves to accept it if we do not search for the temporary but for the eternal, with its inaccessible plenitude

and integrity, which is projected on the surface of the world as a struggle between contrasts.

The text was written in the old spelling and among the cited authors we find Belinsky, Dostoevsky, Steinthal, and others. The tone and content (the tragedy of existence in a disrupted world, the longing for the absolute) resonate with the *Tragedy of Hamlet*.

2. Exercise books with sketches (drafts) for a large text, in which the historical fate of the Jewish people is discussed and the possibility of the creation of the state of Israel. Vygotsky criticized the ideas of radical anti-Semite and pro-Jewish political movements (in particular, nationalism, autonomism, and so on). The document is dated 1915 and written in the old spelling. No less than half of the text consists of elaborate quotations from the works of philosophers, politicians, journalists, and writers who in their works touched on the Jewish question (e.g. Judah Halevi, Chaim Bialik, Nikolai Berdiaev, Semen Dubnov, and Daniil Pasmanik). Most of the text is rather abstract. However, the end of the fifth exercise book contains a quite striking fragment about the tragedy of the Jewish people during World War I, which was at its height when Vygotsky wrote these passages, as if he apprehended the future Holocaust. The Jewish people bear the stamp of a tragic fate and at the same time of divine providence, he remarked. On the last page of the fifth exercise book, Vygotsky glued a clipping from the newspaper *Russkoe Slovo*:

Finally, I shall present a small episode from this war, which in light of the great events is lifted to the height of a general symbol:

Brother against brother.

In one of the last battles near the river San a Jewish soldier killed an Austrian rifleman with a blow of his bayonet and was himself wounded on the spot. When he was brought to the field hospital he refused to leave the wagon. He asked the nurses and the doctor not to touch him and refused to answer questions. The rabbi was called and the dying man told him: "When I hit the enemy in the chest with my bayonet, he fell and cried: 'Shma Yisrael!' ('Hear, O Israel!') – the words that the Jews pronounce when they die or are in terrible danger. I then decided that, although I fought as my duty and military conscience demanded, I could no longer live" (*Russ. Sl.*).

In this symbol-fact all sides of Jewish history emerge as if in a focal point, are refracted, and glow in light of the great events. Two Jews ("whoever says 'Shma Yisrael' is a Jew", says the Talmud, and from the desperation of the one and the pain of the other it is clear that both are Jews; here Jewry lives in this pain) act in this insoluble tragedy as blind tools of dark forces – one is killed, the other driven crazy – and from the grave and from insanity (from outside the usual) they shout the meaning of this tragic senselessness.

Later this episode found its way into one of Vygotsky's articles for the journal *Novyi Put'*, under the title "Thoughts and Moods: Some Lines about Hanukkah"

(Vygotskii, 1916), and several of its ideas were included in a series of articles about the Jewish question and the fate of Jewry in Russia (Zavershneva, 2012a).

3. An undated exercise book belonging to a larger study of Dostoevsky begins on page 33 and has no conclusion (the missing pages of the manuscript were not found). The paper is the same as that of the *Tragicomedy of strivings* and the spelling is old (thus, the notes may date from the years 1914–15). Its major theme is Dostoevsky's attitude to the Jewish question and the way Jews are depicted in his novels. Vygotsky rejected the common opinion that Dostoevsky shared the 'everyday anti-Semitism' of his time, pointed out that Dostoevsky penetrated deeply into the essence of the issue, and argued that his view can only be regarded as national extremism after a first and superficial study. Vygotsky analyzed the scene of Svidrigailov's suicide in *Crime and punishment* and wrote:

After Svidrigailov's nightmare, why exactly was it a Jew who proved to be the 'official witness' of his suicide? Was it accidentally? Or a continuation of the nightmare? ... There is a hidden, inexplicable, symbolic meaning in this scene, whose reality borders on the fantastic ... a stroke of genius of incredible force gives the whole scene its strange appearance and fills it with symbolic meaning.

In any case this stroke is unforgettable: the real, and at the same time fantastic, nightmarish, delirious scene, flooded with a strange, enigmatic twilight, gets lost in a thick milky fog, and a strange, unlikely (and at the same time real) "small person, muffled in a grey military coat and wearing a copper Achilles helmet" merges with this fog and becomes inseparable from it, and the sorrow of the dying night merges with the "age-old peevish sorrow" on his face, and we hear, and hear, and hear this sorrowful, anxious, frightened ... "This is not the right place!" and his mournful Jewish pupils become wider and wider ...

Vygotsky showed that Dostoevsky took all the typical everyday viewpoints about the Jewish personality and appearance to create a symbolic character, who lacks all accidental features and who has some mystic, marked relationship with fate and death. Unfortunately, the manuscript contains only fragments from the second part and it is almost impossible to guess its conclusions. We may assume that the text is a preliminary version of a little-known article, called *The Jews and the Jewish question in Dostoevsky's writings*, which was first published in the Israeli newspaper *Vesti* in 1997, and subsequently in a volume with several of Vygotsky's early writings (Feigenberg, 2000). According to Bela Kotik-Friedgut (personal communication), the manuscript of this article is in the archive of Semen Dobkin, one of Vygotsky's friends in Gomel.

4. A notebook dated summer 1925. This tiny gilt-edged booklet contains Vygotsky's diary of a trip abroad. It is about Vygotsky's visit to a London congress dedicated to the problems of deaf-mute children, the only foreign trip he ever made. A large part of the notebook contains notes of a personal character. Judging by the notes in this notebook, the foreign trip became one of the major events in Vygotsky's life:

In a foreign country, in the fresh air (an airplane) at sea – you feel a strong aloofness of everything. A reconsideration of your whole life, a soul-searching. Suddenly you look at your whole life from aside, as in the minute of death ... In my destiny, this is the sign of enormous future ordeals. Am I afraid? Of course, I am afraid, I feel terror, but I keep it in check ... My journey is astounding and its purport is much more important and larger than just its work aspect.

However, the personal was tightly interwoven with the non-personal; Vygotsky made a quite striking statement in his notebook in which he connected his fate with that of the new Russia:

In essence, Russia is the first country in the world. The Revolution is our supreme cause. Just 1 person in this room knows the secrets of the genuine education of d-m [deaf-mutes, EZ] – and that person is me. Not because I am more educated than the others, but because I was sent by Russia and I speak on behalf of the Revolution.

These words spoken to himself, in a notebook for private use that miraculously survived, confirm that his attitude toward the events in his country was not for show (let alone that he was following instructions), but formed part of a deeply felt personal conviction.

The notebook also contains information about the sights that Vygotsky saw in England as well as addresses and telephone numbers of colleagues from various European countries, excerpts from library catalogues, impressions from visits to the British Museum, and so on.

This notebook was the most difficult to work with; its pages were greasy, the pencil faded and some fragments probably cannot be reconstructed. Nevertheless, on the basis of the pages that could be read (some 80 percent of the notebook) and a cross-validation with the congress events, Vygotsky's stay in London could be almost exactly reconstructed (Van der Veer & Zavershneva, 2011).

5. The notebook from Zakhar'ino hospital from the first half of 1926. It is a voluminous text with valuable notes that throw light on one of the periods in Vygotsky's life that is most hard to analyze: the origin of the cultural-historical theory in the strict sense of the term. As far as we know, the notebook contains the earliest formulation of the theory of sign mediation. It also has notes concerning the problem of consciousness and the psychophysical problem, additions to *The psychology of art*, the first draft of the manuscript *The (historical) meaning of the psychological crisis*, a plan for the unwritten monograph *Zoön politikon*, in which Vygotsky planned to give a sketch of a theory of consciousness based on the idea of the social origin of consciousness, and propositions about the leading role of speech in the genesis of consciousness.

The notebook begins with a note that adds to *The psychology of art* and the *Tragedy of Hamlet* (the analysis of several fables, new propositions and citations) and discusses Alfred Adler's idea of supercompensation:

This is a central set of ideas, which I share in the psychology of art, but it does not come from Freud or from *the formalists*. In essence, it is a dialectical principle of a philosophical, epistemic nature.³

However, the principal themes of the notebook are the relationship between thought and word (in which Aleksandr Potebnia's influence is notable⁴), word meaning (a theme that Vygotsky developed further only in the 1930s!), consciousness as an interiorized system of social relationships (Marx is frequently quoted), consciousness as an internal dialogue (Vygotsky refers to Lev Shcherba⁵ and, remarkably, not to Mikhail Bakhtin⁶). We shall give one fragment of the notebook, in which Vygotsky writes about the leading role of speech in the development of consciousness and plans a series of papers (or chapters of a book) about thinking and speech:

2. The difference between the vocal and the speech reaction is not in their symbolic nature, which they share: the conditional vocal and speech stimuli are both symbolic, the unconditional are both nonsymbolic. The difference is not about the relationship between things. The word is not a relationship between the sound and the object to which it refers. It is a relationship between the speaker and the listener, a relationship between people, directed toward the object; it is an interpsychic reaction, which establishes the unity of two organisms in one direction toward the object. Linguistics makes the word into a fetish; the psychologist reveals that behind the apparent relationships between things are relationships between people (cf. Marx's commodity fetishism). It signifies the unity of the reaction of 2 persons or 2 reactions, not of two stimuli.

3. Consciousness = speech in oneself ... deliberate speech is always a dialogue (Shcherba). Consciousness is a dialogue with oneself. The fact that the child first listens and understands and only later acquires verbal consciousness already shows that 1. Consciousness originates in experience, 2. Speaking with himself = acting consciously, the child places himself in the position of the other, relates to himself as to the other, imitates the other who speaks to him, replaces the other in the relationship to himself ...

5. The meaning of word [*sic*; in English in the original, EZ] is not the object which it replaces but a dialogue (the function of listening is speaking in oneself); the relationship between people is speech; between objects it is a symbol; between each of the speakers and the word (the thing) it is empathy. Each article must end with the statement of a problem for the next one. Epigraphs to the whole book: form and appearance according to Marx, I – Zoön politikon,⁷ II – Freud word and consciousness, III – Lipps – empathy makes organisms social. The title of the whole book is *Zoön politikon: The key to the psychology of man*.

At the end of the notebook we find statements that were developed further in *The (historical) meaning of the psychological crisis*, in particular about the indirect

method on which scientific psychology must rely. The handwriting is at times inconsistent, illegible; notes of a personal nature testify to the fact that Vygotsky had not yet recovered from a severe attack of tuberculosis. The breakthrough toward a new theory literally took place on the verge of death and the end of the notebook coincides with the discharge from the hospital:

In the half year spent in this home, where death was as everyday and common as the morning breakfast and the doctor's round, I absorbed so many impressions of death that I am inclined to death just like a tired person is inclined to sleep.

Before departure

May 18, 1926

However, fatigue and torpidity gave way to new enthusiasm. Very many themes are addressed in the notebook and the formulation of the new conception became increasingly clear:

Thus, the differences of the word: it is an artificially created stimulus (cf. technique), it is a tool of behavior; it presupposes two subjects and one object. Verbal behavior differs from nonverbal behavior just like labor differs from the adaptation of animals.

In this citation we find both the psychological question of the specific characteristics of man and the future scheme of the instrumental act, which was later precisely described in the talk *The instrumental method* (Vygotsky, 1997c). It is factual proof that Vygotsky formulated the basis of his cultural-historical approach already mid-1926. It was only in December 1927/January 1928 that this theory became public in his talk *The development of the difficult child and its study*, presented at the 1st All-Union Pedology Congress. Of course, we can find the pre-requisites of this approach in all of Vygotsky's early writings but only in 1926 were they combined and thereby became a hard core of the conception, i.e. a series of postulates, upon which the whole scientific research program rests that subsequently became refined and formulated anew. The system principle was added in 1930 and the principle of the semantic structure of consciousness in 1932. We suggest the following as a criterion for the birth of the cultural-historical conception in the strict sense of the term: the synthesis of two ideas that until 1926 were not clearly connected (i.e. the principle of sign mediation, which in the continuation was dramatically changed and receded to the background of the conception, and the idea of the cultural development of the mind). In the past, it was assumed that 1927 was the critical, transitional year: Vygotsky's correspondence with his colleagues gave rise to the idea that the experimental investigations with the new method of the double stimulation were carried out in the summer of 1927 but did not reach the press. Now we know that the theoretical basis for these investigations was formulated one year earlier.

The notebook has been published in the internet journal *Gefter*,⁸ a detailed analysis can be found in Zavershneva (2012b).

Various notes

1. A series of notes about the Jewish question on the pages of an exercise book. It primarily contains excerpts from other authors (Merezhkovsky, Smirnova-Rosset, Dostoevsky), lists of Hebraisms in Russian, plans for various articles (“The Problem of the New Jewry,” “The Jewish Socialist Movement,” and so on). Dates from approximately 1914–17, old spelling.

2. Several poems written by Vygotsky in various years (1915, 1921). Written in the form of syllabic quatrains, stylistically close to the poetry of Symbolism.

3. A series of notes about *The psychology of art* (no date) on narrow strips of paper. Preparatory texts for chapters on the proverb, the saying, and the riddle, lists of Russian proverbs (presumably not later than 1925).

4. A short note, called *N.B. Will (The central idea)*, written on the upper part of stationery from the Osborne Hotel (2, Gordon Place, London, WC1). It is difficult to give an exact date for the fragment. As mentioned, Vygotsky was in London in 1925, but this does not mean that the note is from that year as he was in the habit of collecting pieces of paper (with or without text) and writing on them later on. Several of the terms in this note (dominant, subdominant) we meet in his writings of 1924–5, whereas the idea of the social organization of brain centers was elaborated only in the last years of his life. Nevertheless, we cannot exclude 1925 as the date of writing, despite the fact that an exact formulation of the idea of the “transfer inward of social relationships” appears only in 1926 (all in all, we hypothesize that the note was written around 1927–8). The note shows that Vygotsky began thinking about the theme of volition much earlier than is evident from his publications. The abbreviated aphorism *natura parendo vincitur* (the translation of the complete text is “nature to be commanded must be obeyed”) belongs to Francis Bacon and was frequently used in the notes from 1928; for example, in the notes 3.04.1928 and *NB! Lightnings of Spinozian thought* (Vygotsky, 2010). This is the first part of the note.

NB.

The will (the central idea) must not be derived from the mutual subordination and regulation of centers (cortex, subcortex) and processes (dominant, subdominant), but from social relationships that are transferred inward and embodied in the activity of the centers when they make use of natural, organic subordination (superseded category, executive mechanism, *parendo vincitur*). What are these relationships?

Commands of subordination.

Cf. Blondel: the mechanisms of will and maximal obedience coincide.

[In the left margin with pencil; EZ] Nietzsche: the affect of commanding.

5. A similar theme is dealt with in another document, called *The instrumental method and will*, presumably written in 1928–9. Here we see the typical formulations characteristic of this period and similar to the statements in his talk *The instrumental method*, which was characterized by a rather rigid and partly mechanistic interpretation of cultural development, discarded by Vygotsky after 1930. The instrumental act here functions as Archimedes' fulcrum to move the world.

NB! 1. Why is the I.M. [Instrumental Method; EZ] important for education, for the abnormal child, etc.?

In the instrumental function of sign use we find the root of all culture (= higher intellectual development). Whoever is incapable of the instrumental function, is incapable of arithmetic, language, writing, mnemotechnics, etc., etc. Let us call this X, this function, 'will', i.e. intellect that has reached such [a level of] development that it is turned to itself.

Cf. Spinoza. Int. et vol. iden.⁹

This note is primarily valuable because it contains an explicit definition of will that is based on processes of thought, moreover, thought that for the first time can consider itself (reflect). It is clear that other processes as well – attention, in particular, but even practical action – will have a volitional and intellectual nature. Volition and thinking are placed at the center of the psychological system, which also rests upon the almighty sign operation. Another archival note (*On giftedness*, presumably 1929–30) reflects Vygotsky's youthful optimism in aphoristic form: "Everything can be replaced – Binet: this guarantees unlimited development." But within two or three years his interpretation of the process of development changed considerably. We can only master what we have, Vygotsky wrote in *Thinking and speech* (Vygotsky, 1934, p. 227). Obviously, the mind is not infinitely malleable by outside forces, the sign operation builds on a foundation that is somehow prepared, and, having rooted, proceeds differently depending on that foundation. As is well known, when around 1933–4 Vygotsky created his conception of the cooperation of nature and culture, heredity and environment, he introduced the notion of the zone of proximal development, which provides a measure of what can be potentially reached with the help of the instrumental act.

6. A note about the name of his own conception is particularly interesting, because until now we have had no idea whatsoever about Vygotsky's preferences for a name. In a document that may have been written in 1930 we read:

NB! The name, the designation we lack. It must not be a signboard (intuitivism). Not instrumental, not cultural, not significative, not constructive, etc. Not just to avoid confusion with other theories, but also because of inner vagueness: for example, the idea of the analogy with the instrument = just the wood, more essential is the dissimilarity. Culture: but where does culture itself come from (it is not primordial, but this is hidden). Thus:

1. as a designation of the method
method of double stimulation;
 2. for the theory as a whole
 - (a) psychology of the higher functions, i.e.
 - (b) historical psychology or
 - (c) the historical theory of the higher psychological functions.
- Because the central concept for us is the concept of the
higher function;
it contains the theory
- (a) about its development, (b) about its psychological nature, (c) about its method of investigation.

Having discussed the name, Vygotsky opted for variant 2c but we should not forget that here he was characterizing his approach in the version of the late 1920s, i.e. before the radical changes. Already by the fall of 1930, the concept of “higher psychological function” ceased to be a guiding instrument, a leading concept, although it remained part of the conceptual framework.

Letters

The letters from Bykhovskii, Shklovskii, Ehrenburg, Ivanovskii, Kornilov and Luria found in the archive also belong to the period 1912–29. The most interesting documents are two letters by Kornilov, at that moment a well-known scholar and director of the Institute of Experimental Psychology, to Assistant Professor Vygotsky, whom he had hired some time before. Kornilov openly expressed his delight with *The psychology of art*, which Vygotsky had submitted as his doctoral thesis. One of the letters Vygotsky received at Zakhar'ino hospital in April, 1926. We will present some fragments from the other letter, dated October 12, 1925:

If I had not read your dissertation (and I only just finished it), I would address you with the usual “Most respected”, but now my whole being longs to call you “Dear Lev Semenovich” and this is why ...

Your application of the principle of monophasic energy expenditure in the domain of emotions is exceptionally good, I had not thought about such an interpretation of the application of the principle.¹⁰ But what especially surprised me is that you and I simultaneously raised the question of the explosive reactions. While you arrived at these explosive reactions from purely theoretical considerations about art, I myself, as you know, arrived at this question purely experimentally, as a direct continuation of the investigation of reactions of a more complex order ...

It was this coincidence of results, using completely different methods, that surprised me so much: it is the best proof of the ideological affinity between us. And for the first time I clearly realized that if we were to succeed in working together for a few more years, we would no doubt form an ideologically

exceptionally close-knit collective. And somehow I thought that no one other than you, with your creative mind, might organically grow into this collective, while at the same time preserving all of your rich individuality. This is why it is so extremely painful to me to realize that you are temporarily absent from our ranks, due to your disease. Let us hope that it will be temporary and that you will soon recover. I regret it very much that we cannot organize a public defense of your dissertation to have the opportunity to tell the others about its exceptional value. But I think that only now, when your disease has exacerbated, will we get all formalities through the board and the other echelons. When you have regained your strength, we will, independent of all formalities, organize a public discussion of your work. We'll catch up with what needs to be done, and until that time will give you the possibility to use all your rights connected with your work, which is your unconditional right.

I studied your work for a week, learning from you how to deal with the aesthetic reaction, how to treat it from our position. You did a tremendous job and I am extremely glad that I have such a strong comrade to work with, and this joy gave me the right to call you "dear", which, I hope, you will not mind.

My deepest and sincerest regards,

K. Kornilov

P.S. No answer whatsoever is required; you must avoid all strain. We will talk later.

It should be mentioned that we have another document specifying the conditions of the written defense of *The psychology of art* as a doctoral thesis. The rest is self-evident.

Notes from 1930 to 1934

Before we proceed to a description of the documents, we will give a brief sketch of the last part of Vygotsky's scientific life, because all notes cited below are intimately connected and in the notes we can trace leading ideas that have the principle of the semantic structure of consciousness as their basis.

The system principle, advanced toward the end of 1930 (Vygotsky, 1997b), and also the inner logic of the development of the idea of sign mediation, led to the appearance of the new theory of consciousness as a dynamic semantic system in 1932. All previous achievements were reconsidered in light of this new view. Vygotsky submitted himself and his co-workers to sharp criticism, increased the number of 'internal conferences' for his closest colleagues, intensified the polemic with Leontiev, created separate research groups, and at the same time the new principle turned out to be incredibly fertile. Vygotsky began working in several important areas at the same time (psychopathology and clinical psychology, child, developmental, and educational psychology, the problem of thinking and speech, the theory of emotions, neuropsychology); even at the internal conferences he did not

manage to share all his new insights, and several of his ideas did not appear in print but remained in the private notes (“Previously I had nothing to say. And now more than I can,” from the note *The present state of the psychological theory of emotion*). These shifts are also reflected in the archival documents. From the notes quoted below, series 1 (*Green ink*) contains documents of a transitional period, when, in particular, the principle of the systemic structure of consciousness was elaborated. Series 2 (*Spinoza*) is dedicated to one of the unsolved key problems of Vygotsky’s conception – the theory of the higher emotions. Series 3 and 4 (*Library cards*, *The French article*) form one whole and date from 1932. They contain propositions for the further development of the cultural-historical approach and show the rapid progress toward a new theory of consciousness (cf. Zavershneva, 2014).

In 1932 the ultimate goal, already formulated in the 1920s – the creation of a general psychological theory – came within reach. Vygotsky sketched plans for a book dedicated to the problem of consciousness, which he did not manage to write (Vygotskii, 2007). From 1931 to 1932 he found a first-class opponent in Kurt Lewin, perhaps Vygotsky’s most serious opponent of all, a person of equal strength, striving for the same goal, and because of that more like an ally than an opponent. First from a distance, but then also at a personal level, they developed a relationship of open discussion and even friendship, which is also apparent from Lewin’s short visit to the USSR (the polemic with Lewin is reflected in the series 5–9; see below). Among the opponents of the second rank were Jean Piaget and William Stern (by 1932 Vygotsky had already found the major arguments against their theories), the psychophysicists Kurt Goldstein and Henry Head, and others. Sigmund Freud was also a strong figure in this circle of opponents, but he rarely left the shadows, rarely left the inner dialogue for open polemics. For that reason the remarks about him in the personal notes are even more valuable (cf. *The conference on research themes* and the notebook *Anomalous development*). Among the factual ‘anomalies’ that allowed the theory to progress were first of all Vygotsky’s own studies of thinking, Walter Cannon’s experiments, studies in the field of clinical psychology, in particular the ‘enigma’ of schizophrenia, which according to Vygotsky, constituted a loss of the person’s semantic network, the Shereshevskii phenomenon – in his personal notes Vygotsky pointed out that this phenomenon was scientifically most important (cf. A. R. Luria, 1968), and so on. The theoretical shift was caused by the movement in two directions – the study of the development and loss of conceptual thinking (Vygotsky developed the principle of the unity of the laws of development and disintegration of the mind).

Emotions, in particular, formed a problematic field for the new theory; almost simultaneously with *Thinking and speech*, his *A theory of the emotions* was being written (1931–3) (Vygotsky, 1999), which, however, remained unfinished. Vygotsky was looking for the unit of the synthesis of intellect and affect and it finally appeared in his last works on developmental psychology: the emotional experience (Russian: *perezhivanie*; German: *Erlebnis*) was introduced as the unit of the internal and the external, the person and their environment. We see that Vygotsky gradually completed the “upper floors” of his theory, approaching comprehension

of the concept of personality, which was also present in his early work. But he was also busy with strengthening the foundation – the central theme of the last period of his life was elaborated along the lines of the idea of the systemic localization of the higher psychological functions. Discarding the subdivision into lower and higher psychological functions (see below) and trying to create a unified theory of mind, Vygotsky suspected this split, this unsurmounted dualism, also in his own new conception. The psychophysical problem got a central place in his notes. He kept proposing new solutions, but his early death – or, perhaps, the irredeemable internal problems of his theory – prevented him from realizing his ambitions.

Series of documents

1. *Green ink*. The series dates from approximately 1929–30 and the notes are in green ink. Most of them are theoretical: Vygotsky reflects on genuine concepts, polemicizes with Hegel and Henri Bergson; actively quotes not just Marx but also Lenin, basically their arguments against Plato, Hegel, and other authors considered idealist. We also come across authors seldom mentioned in Vygotsky's writings, such as Ernst Cassirer, Boris Stolpner, and Nikolai Marr.¹¹ The quoted fragments from Lenin ("analysis in practical action") also appear in *Pedology of the adolescent* (Vygotskii, 1931d). The notes in this series are very similar to the spirit of that book, which Vygotsky considered to be an important step in his scientific development. The basic theme of his observations is that freedom of thought rests upon genuine concepts. We should not forget that among the major anomalies requiring explanation – which would also allow the appearance of a new view on the nature of mind – were the experimental results about the development of word meanings found with the Vygotsky–Sakharov method in the late 1920s. Memory and attention could easily be described in terms of the instrumental act but thinking was a different matter. The reflections about what is behind the sign operation in this domain subsequently led to the idea of word meaning. In the *Green ink* series we see the genesis of new ideas in elaborate reflections, in still very unclear moves, repetitions, and doubts, and yet toward the end of 1934 from these doubts arose the seventh chapter of *Thinking and speech* with its law of the "equivalence of concepts" (Vygotskii, 1934a, pp. 242–243). It should be mentioned that this theme remained present in Vygotsky's private notes until the very last months of his life; the most important note of the series, *Everything is historical, the modern theory of concepts as well*, is also dedicated to it. We present two excerpts from this text, both dealing with philosophical aspects of thinking and directly leading to the formulation of the law of equivalence of concepts; the first one touches upon the freedom of thought, the second is about the problem of the general and the unique in the word.

Thus: the central idea: In the simplest generalization, in the most elementary general idea is a certain piece of fantasy = freedom. In the concept is freedom. The rational analogue of the idealist theory of concepts (they are not things but ideas) is the theory about the freedom from the thing in the concept (=

in the idea of the thing). This is the genuine (and great!) meaning of Plato and all idealism ... Lenin contra Hegel (?) and I contra Bergson: why cannot the separate be named? ... If the word might be subsumed under one concept, Hegel would be right, but the possibility to say: the round card table that stands there etc., i.e. to include the object in an overlapping network of concepts, of which it forms the center, allows us to call the word unique.

Another important note in the series, *On the problem of systemic investigation*, was probably written in 1930. It is interesting because it reveals the polemic with Leontiev about the issue of practical intellect and the relationship between thinking and speech. In the document Vygotsky discussed the outline of the experimental study of the analogues of complexive thinking¹² in practical actions; the outline is accompanied by a drawing of the experimental device (a disk with weights, suspended at various distances from the center). We may surmise that this outline illustrated a study by Bozhovich,¹³ which she began in 1929 and which lasted for some three years;¹⁴ apparently, the documents from different archives – Bozhovich's and Vygotsky's – refer to the same events.

A further note, dedicated to giftedness and cultural age, and mentioned above, also demands our attention. It is joined by a separate text about youth as a cultural phenomenon. In this note appears the still indistinct term “the zone of proximal possibilities,” which obviously anticipated the idea of the zone of proximal development that appeared two to three years later.

2. *Spinoza*. This series is dedicated to the (unwritten) second part of the fundamental work *A theory of the emotions* (1931–3). The notes were primarily written with a simple pencil on small pieces of paper and also on narrow strips of paper of approximately 3 cm. They are hard to read because of the many abbreviations and, in fact, resemble inner speech. The texts contain many deletions, illegible parts; some parts are lost. On the whole it can be said that Vygotsky had a rough idea of the theory of the higher emotions, i.e. a vague image of the desired result, but didn't know yet how to achieve it.

The central theme of the series is the theory of the higher emotions, which could only be developed after the solution of the psychophysical problem, according to Vygotsky. He assumed that Spinoza's *Ethics* contained a number of postulates that could be helpful but needed rethinking:

Spinoza's greatest idea, which liberates all of psychology, is not the idea of the absolute power of the soul over the body (Spinoza rejects it) but that of its relative power (which Spinoza accepts), i.e. the relationship between soul and body (life and intellect) is not absolute and immutable but changeable, relative. *Inde*¹⁵ – this is not the postulate but the problem (i.e. Spinoza made the problem the postulate, and the postulate the problem). *Inde* – the real possibility of psychology (a special form of movement–development) of the change of the contribution of the soul to the life of the body, of intellect / of life.

This is real, this is accessible, this moves.

Everything in Spinoza's theory struggles with mechanical causality, with immutability (there is no development), with incoherency, with parallelism and demands to transcend its limits.

This is ... the strength and the weakness of Spinoza: strength because he created what leads to this; weakness because it is not yet there.

(from the note Spinoza's greatest idea)

In the document *The end of the preface* a note was discovered that reveals Vygotsky's personal assessment of *A theory of the emotions*, plus reflections about to whom this book should be dedicated:

The book of all my life,

Is badly written, but its thoughts are mine –

What is of the evil of the day will become obsolete

(I am writing it not at the heights of my spirit, but overwhelmed by the evil of the day.¹⁶ Something will remain for the future.

The seed are my children and students, those to whom I would dedicate it if I would value its prospects higher. But the past, in whose power I am, is stronger. That is why <labor>).

Maybe dedicate it to Roza? Alive?

[The next clause outlined; EZ] The greatness of what is mortal and perishable.

The idea of dedicating *A theory of the emotions* to Roza Vygotskaya replaced the idea of a dedication to his father Semen L'vovich Vygotskii, who had died in October 1931 (another note of the *Spinoza* series contains the dedication 'SLV').

Vygotsky was of the opinion that Spinoza managed to formulate the idea of man from the 'peak' viewpoint. He planned to finish *A theory of the emotions* using this idea: "This idea can be leading for the psychology of man as a science. It is a real idea, because it corresponds with the object, because it shows – using Shakespeare's words – man in the fullest sense of the word.¹⁷ Thereby it shows the psychology of man its true object. *Ecce homo*¹⁸" (Vygotsky's note *L.S.V. A theory of the emotions*).

The series also contains reflections about *The ethics*, marginalia to it, and schematic sketches for the second part of *A theory of the emotions* (cf. Vygotsky, 2010).

3. *Library cards*. This is the truly "golden" series of the family archive; it contains extremely important documents that reveal the inner dynamics of the transition toward a new viewpoint on the nature of consciousness. The notes are made on the backs of library cards (typographically set in 1931); several of them are dated by Vygotsky. The series contains notes made during internal conferences, notes about colleagues (including Leontiev), reflections about the psychophysical problem, about the expedition to Central Asia, about the nature of schizophrenia and

other pathological phenomena (aphasia, in particular), a polemic with Goldstein and Head, and statements about child development, but its core is the idea of the semantic structure of consciousness and the relation between thought and word.

The note *Symposium, December 4, 1932* begins with a radical revision of the previous achievements:

1. The need for a new stage in the investigation does not arise because a new idea came up, because a new idea became interesting, but because the development of the investigations required it – new facts lead us to the search for new, more complex explanations ... We focused our attention on the sign (tool) to the detriment of the development of the operation with the sign, presenting it as something simple that goes through 3 stages: magical, external, internal. But the knot is external and the diary of the adolescent is external. Thus we have lots of inadequately explained facts and want to dive deeper into the facts, i.e. to theoretically re-interpret them.

2. The higher and lower functions are not built in 2 floors: their number and names do not coincide. But neither our previous understanding: the higher function is the mastery of the lower one (voluntary attention is the subordination of involuntary attention), for this also means 2 floors.

Vygotsky pointed out that his main goal was the search for a method that allows the study of the dynamics of consciousness and he called this method “semic analysis.”¹⁹ The colleagues wondered whether in so doing he would not replace the study of the whole mind by the study of just one part of it – the verbalized part. Vygotsky countered: “A.N. [Leontiev, EZ] is wrong: The verbal and nonverbal experiment do not coincide with the studies of speech and action and the concepts of pure speech. This is the problem, but the first thing is: the research method. *Ergo*, the place of A.N.’s own work is also wrong.” This was the beginning of a difference of opinion between him and Leontiev and Vygotsky’s further notes abound with the word “contra” in those places where he discusses Leontiev’s propositions. They did not agree in their theoretical assessment of the processes involved in the transition from speech to thought: Leontiev suggested the metaphor of “spectral analysis,” Vygotsky rejected it. Speech, he said, participates as actively in this transition as thought itself; we should not present it as a picture, a cast, a sort of death-mask made of the living process of thinking. The role of speech is not just to fixate the thought or what remained of it after the translation of the thought into a tangible form; the word is not just the main carrier of the thought, its canvas, but also the carrier of consciousness as a whole. Leontiev insisted on the investigation of the practical action as the central theme, but Vygotsky did not agree: the dynamics of the action derive from the dynamics of meaning and in itself, separate from the ‘peak’ dimension of meanings, cannot be analyzed. The polemic between them became increasingly pungent, as is evident in Vygotsky’s notebook of October 1932 (cf. Vygotskii, 2007), and also in the excerpts from other documents (for further discussion see, in particular, Chapter 6). We will not analyze this polemic in any detail

but it remains a fact that Leontiev from the early 1930s distanced himself from the study of consciousness as proposed by Vygotsky, although he continued participating in the work of the Vygotsky–Luria extended group, carried out experiments, and participated in the discussions during their symposia.

Another part of the document *Symposium, December 4, 1932*, contains Vygotsky's answer to an objection raised by Bozhovich. To a considerable degree it was also an answer to Leontiev ("speech is not a discovery"). The fragment is remarkable: not only is the question of the relationship between thinking and speech raised in a manner that we do not even encounter in the monograph of the same name (when does thinking become thinking in the proper sense of the word?), but also provided is a new formulation of the psychophysical problem (cf. Zavershneva, 2010c):

Lidia Il'inichna.

1. From without–inward: but the question is the method: how can we in a mediated way study the inner hidden processes. [The next two statements are vertically marked on the left with the remark: "this is wrong"; EZ] Thinking reveals itself in speech and action. Why is it that action and speech are essential, where is the criterion of essential disclosures?

[The statement is outlined; EZ] This is totally wrong: this is why we differ from all older psychology – speech is not a discovery.²⁰

2. Is thinking a cloud?²¹ Or does it become thinking, when pours out into speech. Thinking <gn.> is its [own] action? How does the inner psychological relate to behavior – the psychophysical problem. This is also the problem of thinking and speech

[Statement outlined; EZ] This is terribly important:
speech / thinking as psycho / physical problem.²²

Other notes in the series also emphasize the special role of speech in the development of consciousness and are directly linked with the talk *The problem of consciousness* (Vygotsky, 1997d):

Speech and consciousness: first we thought: speech and thinking, then: through intellectualization – speech to memory, attention, perception. I.e., we spread speech all over consciousness. More important: to infer it from the change it causes in consciousness. The first word is a change of consciousness long before the change of thinking; *prise de conscience*,²³ cf. the problem of the first questions (*in aphasia, schizophrenia and other pathological changes*).

In other documents from 1932 Vygotsky pointed out that the child's first orientation is semantic, the first questions are about the sense and not about the meaning of the surrounding world (*Consciousness without the word, The first questions: Origin of the object world, etc.*).

Vygotsky described the complex dynamics of meanings and their inner contradictions, and provided an interesting philosophical treatment of the relationship

between thought and word; one sees a hidden dialogue with Potebnia, whose book *Thought and language* exerted a considerable influence on the young Vygotsky:

Two paradoxes of thinking:

1. Why thinking ≠ associative reproduction
2. Why thinking ≠ logical figures Barbara[.] Celares.²⁴

Because it proceeds in the struggle against tendencies with semantic fields and in the consciousness of these fields (cf. inner speech – creates the fields – external speech proceeds through these fields).

The new viewpoint suggested by Vygotsky also led to progress in the domain of psychopathology (and neuropsychology, which at the time did not exist as a separate branch of psychology). Leontiev remembered that a talk about consciousness that Vygotsky gave at an internal conference toward the end of 1932 provided the general picture of the future theory: “all psychology was reduced to word meaning.”²⁵ Apart from that, Leontiev said, “aphasia, schizophrenia, statements about localization (neuropsychology), etc. also crept in” (A. N. Leontiev & Leontiev, 2005, p. 374).²⁶ And indeed, Vygotsky not only became a student for the third time, studying medicine in the Kharkov Medical Institute but, according to his notebooks, he also actively worked in the clinic until the last month of his life. His paper about schizophrenia was published in 1932 (Vygotskii, 1932a)²⁷ and no less than a dozen notes are dedicated to this theme. We will give an excerpt from the note *Toward the problem of sch* [schizophrenia; EZ]: “what we observe in the disease is the life of a consciousness torn from its vital roots: i.e. the shipwreck of consciousness, of its heights, as if it struck a submarine cliff in the depths.”

4. *The article in French.* The notes were made on the back of a French paper on child psychology. The series contains another plan for a book about the problem of consciousness, a protocol of the discussion during a symposium (with the participation of Leontiev, Zaporozhets,²⁸ Luria, and Bozhovich), observations of his youngest daughter Asya, and a separate document with remarks for Leontiev. The book plan belongs among the more complete ones; apart from its basic claims (about the principles and methods of the new theory), it contains the titles of chapters about the freedom of man, about the dynamic of meanings (a separate chapter is dedicated to an analysis of Velimir Khlebnikov’s poetry²⁹), about the psychophysical problem, and about the unconscious. Inserted is a separate note testifying of the fact that Vygotsky was constantly thinking of his discussion with Leontiev: “How can comrade Leontiev be fertilized – by the light of the problem of consciousness?” In the note *NB! A.N.*, on the left part of p. 17 there is a bracketed section with six exclamation marks: “The way to study meaning is the central question of our investigation. The plan³⁰ looks backward, does not make a decisive step forward to the new stage of work – to semic analysis. What does the meaning of action mean?”

Linked to these two series are the documents *Comments to A.R. Luria’s talk*, *Toward the question of the historical current in psychology*, and notebooks dated 1932.

5. *Geographical maps*. The notes on the back of leaflets with a picture of the earth's hemispheres date from 1932/3. They include comments on the propositions by Leontiev and Luria, on Lewin's theory, and also descriptions of clinical cases (*The trip to the headquarters*, *The lost mail*), which Vygotsky personally observed. He often returned to the analysis of these cases in other notes.

6. *Publishing house ONTI*. Notes on the backside of a publisher's form, part of the notes dated 1933. It is with this series that the debate begins with Lewin about the role of thinking in personality development and about the unity of two types of dynamics: the fleeting dynamics of the semantic field and the more rigid dynamics of action. Among the published works about this theme was *The problem of mental retardation* (Vygotskii, 1935c), which contains a number of formulations that are verbatim repetitions of the notes.

The document *K. Lewin. 3.05.33* consists of two parts: the first is a criticism, the second, entitled, *Lewin. Lectures*, contains an exposition of several claims of Lewinian psychology. We assume that the second part is a summary of the lectures that Lewin gave during his two-week stay in Moscow in the spring of 1933 (see Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991, pp. 287–288, and Chapter 9). In his note Vygotsky remarked that the child's ability to 'leave the field' is underestimated, an ability which Lewin considered to be the distinguishing characteristic of man. This is what Vygotsky wrote:

1. Why do concepts liberate action?
2 problems: (1) the relation of thinking to the real plane
 (2) shifts in the plane of thinking ...
 Thinking allows us to overcome the forces.
2. Why does thinking acquire ever more meaning over the years?
Concepts are genuine relations. (numbers) are relations of systems.
Most important in thinking is freedom: *ich kann was ich will*.³¹ From there it is transferred to the action.
 But freedom is born in the thought.
 Thinking provides the way out of the vector field.

The series also contains preparatory notes for the last chapters of *Thinking and speech* (the functions of speech, their differentiation in ontogeny, the dynamic of the transition from thought to word, the nature of inner speech, etc.) and descriptions of clinical cases.

7. *Aerial photo* and *Histology*. The notes are on the back of sheets of paper with, respectively, a picture of the earth's surface and a picture of the cell structure, of equal size; apparently the series date from the same period (roughly 1933–4). The documents of this series are dedicated to the continuing discussion with Lewin and to psychopathological and neuropsychological matters (aphasia, agnosia, the post-encephalitic syndrome, schizophrenia, mental fatigue); various notes contain an analysis of Pörtl's views and a criticism of the Jackson–Ribot law. The series is joined by the shorthand protocol of a conference on Wolpert's agnosia (simultag-nosia); the main presentation was by Luria, the shorthand report begins at p. 18,

preserved is just Vygotsky's talk, in which he discusses the key tenets of the theory of the systemic localization of the higher functions. In the document *About complete aphasia*, we find a remark about the problem of the concept of color (exactly which abstract features can create it? What is the similarity between color perception and the perception of words, what is hidden behind the obvious difference between the two processes?) and color agnosia. Vygotsky phrases the question as a neuropsychological one:

Are alexia and color agnosia analogous to object agnosia? The difference is tremendous: perception of an object + perception of a symbol (<the printed> word) + perception of a quality, which is most difficult to generalize (color) are different things. Why does alexia go hand in glove with color agnosia? Whoever solves this psychologically, unravels one of the hardest mysteries.

The color concept is one of the brain-twisters that arises when one thinks about the law of the equivalence of concepts, which elucidates the central note of the series *About the extent of commonality of concepts*.³² Vygotsky polished this law for a number of years, criticizing his own investigations of the development of word meaning. He now believed his introduction of the idea of a network of concepts was 'artificial' and tried to comprehend its application to the system of the real, living language:

For a long time we (vainly) searched for a (reliable) symptom to qualify the structure of generalization in real word meanings (syncretic wholes, complexes, etc.) and thereby for a bridge from the experiment to real concepts: apparently, it can be found in the extent of commonality, because this (the relationship of commonality) is the most fundamental and essential feature of every meaning (to be a meaning = to stand in certain relationships of commonality with other meanings, i.e. to have a specific extent of commonality), which can be the most reliable criterion for the structure of generalization of real concepts: the relationship between *Ober-* and *Unterbegriff*.³³

See also the fragment from a document called *Lewin's fourth dimension*:

We must study the little known properties of the complex, the pre-concepts, etc. In each of these domains of thought there is another relation to the object and another act to grasp the object in thought, i.e. 2 fundamental features, characterizing the concept. *Inde* the nature of these concepts and all their properties are different.

8. *The psychology of art*. The notes on the cards with the title *The psychology of art*, which were printed to be glued on folders with the text of the dissertation, belong to 1933–4 (it was not exceptional for Vygotsky to use material that was ten years old; sometimes the notes were written on the back of sheets with texts in the

spelling used before the reform of 1918). It is a short series, but one of its documents (NB! *About Zaks and Kogan. Intellect and dynamics*) is unique, because it contains not just a critique of Lewin's theory and an analysis of complex cases (the patients Kogan and Zaks; no first names were given³⁴), but also the outlines of a dynamic theory of consciousness. We will present fragments in which one can detect statements close to activity theory, a reinterpretation of Lewin's theory, an aphoristic formulation of the criterion for the unity of intellect and affect, and a sharp criticism of his own approach:

1. Consciousness determines life (form), but itself it originates in life and forms an aspect of it: *ergo* life determines life through consciousness. As soon as we separated thinking from life (from the dynamics) – and regarded it as a psychic concept and not a psychological one, we closed the door to any clarification and explanation of its major property: to determine the form of life and behavior, to act, to exert influence ...

3. The degree of development of concepts is the degree of transformation of the dynamics (the affect) of the real action into the dynamics of thinking ...

6. The mistake of our analysis of Z. and K. is that the analysis is carried out in 2 planes: the external field and the semantic field – there is no unity, but parallelism and correspondence.

We must have a unified plan: because the dynamics is of the *flüssig* type,³⁵ to the extent it is in the action, the action involves thinking. The freedom of dynamics in the real field and the action is an exact measure of the participation of thinking in behavior.

7. The criterion of the unity of intellect and affect is the principal fundamental relation to the situation – in the sense of connectedness and freedom: this is the genuine unit of affect-intellect. The degree of distancing of generalization from the object determines the degree of transformation of the affect of a thing into the affect of concept.

Later these claims were elaborated in the paper *The problem of mental retardation*, published posthumously (Vygotskii, 1935c).

The series also contains excerpts from Friedrich Engels and Edward Sapir (1921), a polemic with Leontiev, reflections about the motivation of thought, etc.

9. *Manuscript progress*. This series of notes, made in the last months of Vygotsky's life, shows how productive he was despite his rapidly deteriorating health. The notes were written on library cards: the handwriting had greatly changed (uneven, large), and vowels were only retained when absolutely essential for understanding: all this gives the impression of urgency. Vygotsky evidently felt his death was near (cf. his last note below). It is a voluminous series: among its themes are a unified viewpoint on the dynamic of consciousness, the problem of the relation between affect, intellect, and will, the periodization of child development, the social situation of development, the relation of teaching and development, the problem of aphasia and agnosia, etc. Several conferences (in November and December, 1933) were

dedicated to the theme of child play and toys; as usual, a number of notes are about the observation of patients and experimental studies in the field of neuropsychology.

The polemic with Lewin grew into a genuine dialogue; Vygotsky was convinced that dynamic analysis might become a valuable instrument in the work of the psychologist, including clinical work (entry: *Sehr wichtig*.³⁶ *The unity of intellect and affect*) (cf. Vygotskii, 1935c):

The unity of affect and intellect (is correct) – we must find the unit [of analysis].³⁷

But the fluid dynamics apparently does not exist at all outside thinking (this is what their unity is about); *ergo* to the extent that it is found in the dynamics of the field it was introduced there by thinking. Not like this: there is a dynamics of 2 sorts (fluid, free, and *stark*³⁸ connected) independent of the intellect (the elements: hydrogen) and there are two sorts of activities (thinking and real activity) independent of the dynamics ... But like that: 2 unities of dynamic activity exist: thinking and real activity. Both have their dynamic aspect, i.e. a dynamic system *sui generis*,³⁹ of a certain type and sort. Outside activity the 2 types of activity do not exist *in abstracto*. This is fundamental and important ... To say that thinking is disturbed is to say that dynamic processes of a certain type are completely disturbed everywhere. The role of thinking in reality exactly resides in the introduction of new dynamic possibilities in activity.

From other documents we should mention the text *The significance of the interaction with the ideal form in child development*:

(c) the moving forces of development ... are the fundamental contradictions in child development between the ideal and the genetic (developing) forms; d) in embryonic development the result (the ideal form) is preformed; in evolution it does not exist at all, it is in the end; in child development there is a genuine cooperation with it; e) which means that the ideal form cooperates with the genetic one: that the latter relates to the first as part to whole, as cell to tissue: cf. the child's one-word utterance forms part of a dialogue with the ideal speech of the mother, i.e. it is practically part of a whole with grammatization and other characteristics, with which the child's speech clashes. Thus: grammar in child speech is not introduced from outside in the 3rd year, but grammar pulls the child's first words upward from the very beginning.

The notebooks

The notebook *Anomalous development* begins with propositions about *The collective as a factor in the development of the anomalous child* – an article with the same name, in two parts, was published in 1931 (Vygotskii, 1931b, 1931c) – their content is much

broadly than the final variant published in the article. A large part of the notebook is dedicated to the problem of affect, both normal development of the affective sphere of personality and its development in pathology. The notebook ends with the notes of an internal conference in which Vera Schmidt⁴⁰ took part (the psychoanalytic approach to emotions, its criticism, “the grain of truth” in Freud’s theory, the observation of ‘psychoanalytic’ cases in Vygotsky’s practice, their assessment from the viewpoint of his own theory) and the defectologists Dmitrii Azbukin, Antonia Basova, and Pavel Pochapin⁴¹ (the difficult child in the child collective). In addition, there are propositions for talks about the fundamentals of clinical psychology and about the state of the theory of emotions in international psychology. A number of these claims were subsequently elaborated in *A theory of the emotions* (Vygotsky, 1999) and in *Lectures on psychology* (Vygotsky, 1998). Finally, Cannon’s experiments were analyzed, as were the James–Lange theory and the ideas of Pavlov, Freud, Bleuler, and Kretschmer.

We will provide a quotation from a conference dedicated to the problem of emotions and their study; Vygotsky argued against his critic Zakharii Chuchmarev:⁴²

Galvanometrics

1. To prove that this registers the emotional state: in the curves.
The study of emotions *post mortem*:⁴³ first we kill them, then we study them.
2. Language was not created for emotions. That is why the expression and study of emotions is difficult. Does it have to be so?? And naming the emotion changes the emotion (*prise de conscience*) not just in the sense of a “lie” (Tyutchev),⁴⁴ but also in the sense of changing its course: i.e. behind this difficulty is the real phenomenon of change

emotion – word!

The notes in the second part of the notebook reflect a transitional moment between the ‘instrumental psychology’, focused on the sign operation, and the new theory that aspired to the investigation of meaning and the semantic dynamics of consciousness. The hypothesis of the semantic structure of consciousness is not yet clearly described; about some of its aspects (which would take definite form mid-1932) Vygotsky writes hesitatingly. In the note below the term ‘sense’ appears for the first time:

Questions about concepts.

1. Understanding is more than the word.
Exclude all other aspects (expressive aspects).
2. The change of meanings in language and the development of language in the child – no psychological laws – weight of this argument.

3. The concept – what is it? The logical concept of science also in life.
4. Meaning = sense? Is it enough: meaning = concept?
5. Various types of meaning: do the roads toward a clear concept coincide? ...
6. Conclusions? Do the childish forms disappear in adults or ingredients.

Notebook (October, 1932) is replete with very important documents: the plan for a book about consciousness, the psychophysical problem, a polemic with Leontiev, propositions for a talk by Solov'ev (the talk about the results of experiments with the modified Karsten method⁴⁵ is described in a separate document of the series *Library cards*). It was published with comments and historical notes in the journal *Novoe Literaturnoe Obozrenie* (Vygotskii, 2007; Zavershneva, 2010c; see also Chapter 6).

Notebook (summer, 1932) contains excerpts from Romain Rolland, Werner Sombart, Oswald Spengler, Eugen Bleuler, and observations of his daughter Asya (egocentric speech, child volition, memory, attention, the affective sphere, the one-year crisis). The document is valuable because it allows us to move the date of the new period even further back – to July 1932. The following fragment is from August 17:

The question: what is that? is of a semasiological nature, it is a question about sense (*eo ipso*⁴⁶ also about the word, but not the name, but about the logos) – its function is – thinking + awareness (*prise de conscience*). Hence: play with words: illusion games, their beginning (the solution of child play is in its semasiological nature) + lie + autism + future time. In particular: the worry about what will be while Asya is not here (about the immutability of the situation).

Conferences about research themes, October 27–29, 1933. An exercise book with propositions for talks and Vygotsky's comments to them. We will give the themes of the presentations as indicated by Vygotsky.

1. *V. F. Schmidt. The problem of the development of the psychoneurotic child*. Contains twenty-eight propositions with a detailed analysis of Freudian claims and also her own clinical researches in the traditional psychoanalytic domain. Here is one of the concluding propositions:

Perspectives: to preserve Freud's fundamental claim (psychoneuroses are the result of unsuccessful repression, the conflict between Ego and Id, the higher and lower layers of mind in the new system: Freud considers consciousness in light of the theory of the unconscious; we consider the unconscious in light of the theory about consciousness. The new theory of child psychoneurosis. [We should] neither discover America anew, nor consider it undiscovered.

He who wants to build a scientific psychology, must follow another road: Freud did not provide a theory of consciousness; we cannot just

complete Freud with a theory of consciousness; we must reorganize his facts and theories in a new framework.

2. R. A. Averbukh.⁴⁷ *Environment-emotional experience-character*. Emotional experience is considered as the unit of the personal and environmental aspects in the development of character; eight propositions.

3. Ek. Mikh. *The analysis of psychomotorics*. The name of the speaker could not be established; six propositions. Here is an excerpt from the text:

1. Recording, architectonics, meaning. Inner speech and motorics ... The unit of psychomotorics: meaningful movement, but not meaning + motor mechanism ... Visible and invisible meaning of movement: visible – the movement toward the goal (mechanically necessary) – and this meaning, without which movement is incomprehensible; but we never make only exact and necessary movements; therefore, movement always has a hidden, inner meaning of the movement, which always expresses the relation of the person to the goal, inner obstacle, struggle, hesitation, added goal, a hidden tendency or motive, ardor, weakness, exaggeration of the goal, to reach the goal to show off, etc. We do more or less than is required by the situation and in this more or less resides the key toward the hidden meaning. The interpretation of motorics.

4. M. S. Pevzner.⁴⁸ *Child development after encephalitis*. Twelve propositions about the structure of consciousness in a post-encephalitic child and about methods to train these children to become fit persons.

Among the notebooks are exercise books with clinical observations that Vygotsky carried out until the end of his life (the last note in the exercise book *The Don clinic*, written on May 4, 1934, during the examination of the patient Misha Kotikov, contains an analysis of the disease history; at the end of the note there is a remark: “show after the 20th”), summaries of other authors, an exercise book with detailed notes of his conversation with Roman Arrago,⁴⁹ a person with unusual numeric skills, who toured the music halls of Europe, South America, and Japan (the conversation took place in April, 1934), etc.

Scattered notes

From the notes that do not form a series – to date we have found more than 200 of them – we shall present three documents.

1. *Consciousness without word* contains propositions – along poetic lines and similar to the ideas artistically expressed in Osip Mandelstam’s poem “Swallow”, which is quoted in the last chapter of Vygotsky’s *Thinking and speech* – about the area where the word is not yet present, but the thought or its vague core already exists. The idea of the dynamic of meanings is present, but without clear outlines, the systemic

principle dominates (apparently, the note dates from the beginning of 1932). The text deserves to be published separately. We shall cite several central fragments. About the role of the word in the dynamics of consciousness, Vygotsky wrote:

3. The word plays a central role in consciousness but not in its various functions. Cf. attention is a central function of consciousness; its *Nichtexistenz*⁵⁰ follows from the *Nichtexistenz* of consciousness itself; cf. the role of the word in attention. Syncretism and disintegration are fundamental functions of consciousness: Köhler. If the psychosis of schizophrenia did not exist, we should call this function schizothymous. Amnesia is a disease of consciousness ...

13. The complaints about the inadequacy of the word – but how are they stated in the word: O, if the soul could express itself without the word.⁵¹ A thought once uttered is a lie:⁵² but this thought is uttered, i.e. false (cf. the sophism about the Cretan, who lies).⁵³ Where is truth: the word does not introduce an idyll in consciousness, but drama, even (insoluble) tragedy. In general, life of consciousness is unlike life of the organism – (this is why consciousness stands outside organic life), is not an idyll, not Spinoza's peace, but tragedy: *amor fati*.⁵⁴

There is also criticism of his own views (the assessment of Sakharov's experiments confirms our conjecture that they had the status of a decisive anomaly in the transition toward the new viewpoint):

7. Like with Sakharov: we unwittingly, spontaneously got what is in *Adolescent*.⁵⁵ He died [Sakharov; EZ] without suspecting it. We should not proceed that way, but the problem of meaning and system was forced upon us by this study ...

17. Our shortcoming is not a shortage of facts but the inadequacy of the theory: this is the main difficulty in the analysis of our crisis, not the divergence from the facts. This contra A.N. Thus: salvation is not in the facts, but in theory. We introduced the system viewpoint too late. Cf. the pictogram, memory in A.N., Morozova's experiments. Now I have a deeper understanding.

About poetry:

25. Poetry = words without relation to an object, i.e., compositions of pure meanings (Jakobson, Khlebnikov). It is a remarkable fact that we can think one and the same thing through different meanings. This fog, this ice, this surface means: she, my beloved.⁵⁶

2. *Propositions for A. R. Luria's talk* consists of the protocol of a symposium with Leontiev, Bozhovich, Morozova, Levina, and others. Propositions 13 to 61 (end of the protocol) have been found. The text is remarkable because it may have been the first symposium where Vygotsky advanced his new idea that we need to study the

inner structure of the sign operation – its meaning. Various formulations literally coincided with the text of the last chapter of *Thinking and speech* (“the thought is not expressed in the word, but completed in the word” and so on), other formulations retain their novelty until this day and introduce essential modifications in the interiorization hypothesis: “55. Inner speech does not come after external speech. Inner mediation is present in speech from the very beginning, which is the undifferentiated unity of external / internal speech.” Questions from colleagues demonstrated the difficulties Vygotsky met with during the rethinking of the research program in 1932; Vygotsky moved forward too rapidly and he still had to prove there was a deep connection between the old and the new view and not a gap:

[On the left part of the page with two exclamation marks; EZ]

38. A.N.: change in meanings, because meaning is not constant? ... This is not the essence of the change of meaning. But this exists as well. Movement of meanings = their change.

[On the left of the page with a thick vertical line and an exclamation mark; EZ]

In particular, the change of meanings and movement of the senses is the experimental method to study systems and their internal structure and dynamics. The change of meanings is a deeper, more essential, more internal analysis of the sign operation ... It is a new way to experiment with the sign operation ...

42. A.N. Not true that meaning comes from ideology, it leads to the system. The sign supports the system thanks to the fact that the sign has meaning. The sign supports the system because it has meaning. ...

45. A.N. The word moves from meaning to meaning (no!) or meaning around the word? Yes ... consciousness creates meaning with the help of the word. Is the word just a carrier or word-centeredness? It all depends on what you mean by ‘word’ (phoneme or the unity of phoneme and meaning).

“The semasiological method,” which is also discussed at this conference, was essentially a new version of the indirect method, which Vygotsky already propagated in *The (historical) meaning of the psychological crisis*:

60. The problem of the inner mediation by meanings. What is meaning? A hypothetical concept about the inner formation, whose exact psychological nature is unknown but whose reality is beyond doubt, whose location is unknown (cf. the computation of undiscovered planets),⁵⁷ but whose effect we can and must study, without it the life of consciousness is impossible, like the life of an organism is impossible without vitamins or hormones.

3. *The result of many years of work.* A note of extraordinary importance contains the propositions for a talk in which Vygotsky presented the idea of his book *Thinking and speech* for a higher echelon. From the list of contents it is clear that

originally the plan for the book was broader; it also contained a chapter on the freedom of will (in *Thinking and speech* this theme is discussed in terms of the ideas of the voluntary and deliberate nature of the higher functions). Vygotsky recorded the course of the meeting, where he was the main speaker, but which also saw talks by Kolbanovskii, Shemiakin, and Vedenov.⁵⁸ Vygotsky's propositions were subjected to sharp criticism. The main accusations were idealism, anti-Marxism, methodological dilettantism, a lack of dialectics, etc. In particular, Vygotsky was rebuked for the fact that he did not have "phylogenetic material," such as the work on the material collected during Luria's expeditions to Central Asia (cf. Chapter 8). Vygotsky made a sad comment next to the objection about the material: "Where would I get it?" Vygotsky was also reminded of his duty to take care of his "fellow citizens" and to study the "laws of the socialist construction." Individuality and personality were narrow, limited topics, one of his opponents remarked, and his verdict was: "creeping empiricism + mechanicism."

The note sheds light on the previously unknown circumstances under which Vygotsky's famous work came into being. It shows, in particular, that the book was already ready for press in 1932. The location and time of the meeting were not indicated. Vygodskaya and Lifanova (1996, p. 136) have published the propositions for *Thinking and speech* from the Scientific Archive of the APN SSSR. These were the propositions for a talk by Vygotsky at the Institute of Scientific Education on April 2, 1932. There is every reason to suspect that the two events were identical, although we need further evidence, in particular about the participants in the April meeting.

The notes about the discussion of two more of Vygotsky's talks – on the nature of schizophrenia and the psychology of emotions – have a similar content: the opponents characterized Vygotsky's viewpoint as anti-Marxist and ideologically harmful (the mildest formulation was: "The talk just outlined approaches but did not suggest concrete solutions. Theoretical and not connected to the Red Army. Dissatisfaction of the military workers"). Tired by the irrelevant questions, Vygotsky noted: "My last opponent is a paranoiac." One of the archive's notes, addressed to the director of the Pedagogical Institute, shows, however, how hard it was for him to remain cheerful and alert:

To the director of the Herzen Pedagogical Institute in Leningrad

From a copy of the resolution by the committee that purges the Psychological Institute in Moscow, I learned that all my theoretical views, which I use in all my work, are qualified in that decision as "idealist and bourgeois theory" (p. 1) and as an "anti-Marxist conception" (p. 11). Because the decision of the purging committee was made without any substantial preliminary discussion of my theory and is exclusively based on declarations by collaborators of the Psychological Institute made during that purge, I assume that the accusations leveled against my theory are based on misunderstandings and do not correspond with reality. I have always considered my work to lie within the system of the Soviet sciences and not outside it. I subjectively felt that with my work I concretely participated in the construction of a Marxist

psychology and until now I continue to think that my work also objectively had some positive meaning in the struggle against idealist and bourgeois theories [the text stops here].

We thus have Vygotsky's personal testimony of the complex ideological situation in the scientific institutes during the period of Cultural Revolution in the USSR. Zeigarnik's words quoted by Yaroshevskii form external evidence of a similar episode: "I remember he [Vygotsky; EZ] ran back and forth in the room, like a wounded animal, and said: 'I cannot live if the Party thinks I am not a Marxist'" (Yaroshevskii, 1993, p. 16).

Letters

We will cite just one letter from June 8, 1934, which was brought to the dying Vygotsky in the Sebyanny Bor sanatorium. Its author was Vygotsky's collaborator Vera Schmidt, wife of Otto Schmidt, the investigator and navigator:

Dear Lev Semyonovich!

Better than any words these flowers convey our best wishes to you. Otto Yul'evich asked me to wish you a speedy recovery and would like to challenge you to a match, because you are now colleagues in disease.

I very much wanted to see you already in Moscow, but I was afraid to bother you. In the autumn, when you and O.Yu. have recovered, we will celebrate together this doubly festive day. Until that time I wish you all the best (whatever that may be for you). We now do not live in the real world but in a fairy-tale, amidst enthusiastic people, flowers, greetings, and so on.⁵⁹ Tomorrow we will bring O.Yu. to the dacha to recover in peace. Unfortunately, our plan to travel to the mountains with you did not materialize. The doctors allow neither you nor him to go there. But never mind! The air of the suburban pinewoods is no worse than the mountain aroma. Please, do recover, dear Lev Semyonovich, to the delight of all of us. I firmly shake your hand and send you my most friendly greetings.

V. Schmidt.

Vygotsky's last note

It is known that Vygotsky took *Hamlet*, the work he read all his life, with him to hospital. Vygotsky always identified with its protagonist and his last words were those of Hamlet: "I am ready." In the series *Manuscript progress* is a note that was presumably his last, written before he left for the hospital. The note *The conference (Zaks)* begins by quoting of the words of another person who wonders why Vygotsky needed a big room and about what he would speak. Then there is a fragmentary

note about a symposium (a discussion of the clinical cases of Kogan and Zaks), and then the direction of the text changes, it no longer follows the lines but runs across the page. It is a very personal note that reflects Vygotsky's mood at the moment he said farewell to what had been the meaning of his life:

NB! *Pro domo suo [sic]*⁶⁰

This is the last thing I did in psychology – and I will die on the summit, just like Moses who saw the promised land but did not enter it. Forgive me, dear creations.

The rest is silence.⁶¹

These words seem doubly bitter to us, because we know that it would be a long silence. Fifty years would pass between these words being written and the first publication of Vygotsky's *Collected works* – years of censorship, devastating reviews, and books taken from open access in libraries.⁶² However, we cannot but note that apart from sorrow there was something more, which alleviated his despair. It was the happiness to be chosen, to stand on the summit, to know that you did everything you could or almost everything.

6

“THE WAY TO FREEDOM”

Vygotsky in 1932

Ekaterina Zavershneva

In 2006 we began the first systematic study of a segment of the Vygotsky/Vygotsky archive that had until then remained unexplored: the scientific diaries and notebooks. Although fragmentary and scrappy, these documents are of enormous value and not just for the history of psychology. As is known, Vygotsky's work remained unfinished, did not lose its heuristic potential, and is open to further elaboration. Far from all of Vygotsky's projects were realized and no more than drafts or private notes remained of them; this is why the publication of archival materials may partially clarify the outlines of the general psychological theory that Vygotsky attempted to create.

One notebook, dated October 1932, stands out because it is one of the clearest and most accessible documents in the archive; it is exactly dated and distinguishes itself from the other texts, whose character reminds us of inner speech that can barely keep pace with the sudden flashes of insight. All the fundamental problems that haunted Vygotsky's thinking in the final years of his life are concentrated in this notebook. The document was published in Russian in 2007 (Vygotskii, 2007).

The text consists of three parts: (1) the plan for the unwritten book *On the question of the study of consciousness*; (2) notes about the psychophysical problem; and (3) propositions for talks by Vygotsky's co-workers Ivan Solov'ev and Aleksei Leontiev, presumably written during an internal conference for close collaborators. In general we may say that the text marks the turn towards a new psychological theory – the theory of consciousness as a dynamic semantic system – and also shows the emerging discrepancy between the views of Vygotsky and Leontiev. In the autumn of 1932 Vygotsky still hoped to continue the collaboration with Leontiev and tried to convince him with his ideas (which is confirmed by other notes made that same year); he criticized and encouraged his colleagues (who could hardly keep pace with his high speed of development), began a serious revision of his own theory, and also tackled the psychophysical problem.¹ Vygotsky was working feverishly,

he was full of plans, and he had less than two years to live. However, these very two years can be considered the most productive period of Vygotsky's entire life, a period that is connected with the discovery of new perspectives for his approach.

Thus, in the notebook dated October 1932 we find the problem of consciousness, the psychophysical – also known as the mind-body – problem, and the polemics with Leontiev and the German-American psychologist Kurt Lewin. Let us analyze each topic in more detail.

The plan for the unwritten book *On the question of the study of consciousness*

The plan for the book about the problem of consciousness is one of four similar plans so far discovered in the archive. The analysis of all four plans shows that Vygotsky's famous work *Thinking and speech* formed no more than the prolegomena to this unwritten book, because it dealt with just one – albeit the most important one from Vygotsky's viewpoint – interfunctional link in the system of consciousness. In the preface to this work, Vygotsky wrote that the problem of thinking and speech is the key problem of all human psychology and directly leads to a new *theory of consciousness*. However, just a few concluding paragraphs of *Thinking and speech* are dedicated to the problem of the theory of consciousness and the study breaks off “at its very beginning” (Vygotskii, 1934a, p. 3).

That goal – the creation of a general psychological theory of consciousness – can be traced to the early works of 1924–6 (Veresov, 1999; Zavershneva, 2013, 2014), but only now, in 1932, were the leading principles, and the facts confirming them, found. In 1930 Vygotsky introduced the principle of the *systemic structure of consciousness* into his theory (Vygotsky, 1997b), then towards the end of 1932 gradually *the principle of the systemic structure* (Vygotsky, 1997d) matured and the analysis of interfunctional connections lost its leading role to the semic analysis of consciousness. The accent is shifted from the problem of meaning to the problem of sense, and – in the last year of Vygotsky's life – to the problem of “emotional experience” (Russian word *perezhivanie*, copied from the term *Erlebnis*, then widely popular in German psychology) as the unit of analysis of consciousness and personality. The plan in the notebook is still rather schematic, whereas in later notes we see more details, connected with, in particular, the role of speech in the genesis of consciousness as a unified whole. It is remarkable that below the title of the earliest draft of the plan Vygotsky wrote the names of himself, Leontiev, and Luria. Apparently, the original idea was to include them as co-authors and Vygotsky later changed his mind.

In each of the variants of the plan the facts that confirmed Vygotsky's new theory were discussed. They were all connected with the idea of a leading role for the *semantic plane* in the dynamics of consciousness. Four major facts are mentioned in all variants: Asya, Shereshevskii, schizophrenia, and Khlebnikov (the normal adult is also mentioned as a comparison). They were examples of developing or disintegrating psychological systems.

The example “Asya”² (normal development) dealt with children’s first questions which, according to Vygotsky, were questions about sense, not meaning: “Cf. Pavlov’s ‘what is it?’ reflex and Asya’s first ‘what’s that?’ questions. It is a semantic orientation, in consciousness” (*Wordless consciousness*, Vygotsky archive). Here the movement in the semantic field is primary; it prepares all actions with the real object, and the impressions of or guesses about the sense of the event or thing become connected with a word.

Shereshevskii (“Sh”) was one of Luria’s patients, famous for his phenomenal memory and the protagonist of his book *The mind of a mnemonist* (A. R. Luria, 1968). Vygotsky highly valued this example of anomalous development: “Shereshevskii must be polished as a diamond; a bright precious one that will cut through the structure of our problems and solve them like a diamond will cut glass” (*Wordless consciousness*, Vygotsky archive). The example of Shereshevskii might show how a psychological system is built that is centered on memory; what kind of problems it causes the subject. Shereshevskii “in order to understand must see (he sees me when we are talking on the telephone),” he must memorize. His thinking was tied to visual images and did not reach that freedom of movement in the plane of pure abstraction that is characteristic of the mature thinking of an adult. His world in many ways resembled that of a preschool child; he represented “consciousness based on memory. He knows but doesn’t know he knows. Cf. the child who solved a problem but doesn’t know how” (ibid.).

In schizophrenia speech splits off from the other psychological functions, which regress to an ontogenetically prior stage. Mature consciousness gives way to more primitive syntheses that we can also witness in onto- and phylogenesis. The coherence, cognizance, and awareness that speech introduces into consciousness is lost; emotions that are separated from the word regress to a “primordial state.” The patient first develops infantile and primitive affects and subsequently the emotional sphere is completely destroyed (one of the major symptoms of schizophrenia is the growing indifference to what once was the meaning of one’s life: one’s job, relatives, etc.). The patient’s inner world becomes dim, disjointed, and incomprehensible; the verbal fabric of consciousness is disrupted and the inner dialogue with oneself and internalized interlocutors stops. The schizophrenic loses the capacity to verbally interact with himself, according to Vygotsky in his talk “On psychological systems” (Vygotsky, 1997b). Thus, schizophrenia is a perfect example of the loss of the semantic structure of consciousness.

The example of Khlebnikov (who also appears in *Thinking and speech*) was about supernormal or exceptional development, i.e. how poetry and creative language could create new perspectives and freedom:

Because thought does not coincide with meanings, because the path from thought to word goes through meaning, and speech is allegory,³ – for this very reason: (1) the complaints about the imperfection of speech, the inexpressibility of thought – but the flight of a poor heart ends only with impotent weariness;⁴ (2) to overcome these complaints – the attempt to fuse words

by creating new paths from the thought to the word, via new word meanings (Khlebnikov himself compared this work with paving the way from one valley to another,⁵ he talked about a (more) direct path from Moscow to Kiev not via New York, called himself the railwayman of language – “there is language, the fabric of the unities of mind, the fabric of concepts”); 3) to overcome these complaints – play on the crookedness of these paths and the expression of the inexpressible (Pasternak and others).⁶

(*Propositions to A. R. Luria's talk, Vygotsky archive*)

Of special interest is the postscript to the book plan: “Fate becomes a conscious part of personality. Spinoza’s power of reason and freedom of slavery is not yet the highest. It is the *amor fati*: cf. the experiments by Dembo – Koffka.⁷ ‘For me this knowledge is enough’.” This remark connected the first and second part of the text and partially clarified Vygotsky’s attitude towards Spinoza’s ideas. Around the same period, in his unfinished manuscript *A theory of the emotions* (Vygotsky, 1999), Vygotsky presented a wide-ranging critical analysis of contemporary psychology and returned to the theme of crisis, whose roots he now saw in the Cartesian dualism that was explicitly or implicitly present in all psychological theories. Vygotsky planned to build the positive part of his theory upon Spinoza’s ideas, where he hoped to find the monistic point of view so much needed by psychology. The second part of *A theory of the emotions*, however, remained unwritten. The fragmentary remarks on Spinoza, and the marginalia to his texts found in the archive, throw some light on his plan but the quotation given above shows that Spinoza’s theory was not the ultimate truth for Vygotsky.

Apparently, Vygotsky wanted to go beyond Spinoza to develop a ‘higher’ understanding of the problem of affect and will that was not purely philosophical but psychological. For Spinoza, Vygotsky wrote, volition is an affect and freedom consists in the mastery of one’s passions which, paradoxically enough, is only possible by obeying them (Vygotsky, in commenting Spinoza, frequently quoted Francis Bacon’s aphorism *natura parendo vincitur*). Another thing is that we are able to choose what we will obey, e.g. the noble passion, the *amor dei intellectualis*.⁸ However, how is reason able to choose, to strive for something, to make the person purposeful? Can this freedom be explained by some psychological mechanisms, or is it absolutely incomprehensible? Where does the person’s freedom come from? Spinoza’s answer – from God – Vygotsky could not accept, if only because it ends the discussion prematurely. A philosopher may, perhaps, find such a logical conclusion acceptable; not so the psychologist.

Below are several propositions from archival documents dedicated to Spinoza (cf. Vygotsky, 2010):

Freedom: affect in the concept.

A grandiose image of the development of the person: the path to freedom. To revitalize Spinozian thought in Marxist psychology ...

The central problem of all psychology is freedom.

(NB! *Lightnings of Spinozian thought*)

The will is a concept that has become an affect; a strong-willed man is a person, who derives his deeds and way of life from the Ego affect.

(NB! *On will*)

Vygotsky's path towards the 'peak' explanation of affect and will went through Marxism. But Vygotsky's Marxism was not formal. He made serious attempts to work with the Marxist tenets, to *investigate* what had to be taken for granted. He wanted to show how volition develops, how one becomes a mature person. The Marxist idea of freedom as the appreciation of necessity was in harmony with Spinoza's ideas (which is hardly surprising as the roots of Marxism lie in the new European philosophy), but Vygotsky could not fully agree with Spinoza. We should not say that we obey something that is 'naturally' present in us. Vygotsky wrote that thought and word, by shedding light on the affect, interfere with it and change it. The dark natural feeling is first torn from its primordial unity with the other feelings and then forms new relationships with them through the medium of words. A new system of feelings develops; a system that would be impossible in nature. In *Thinking and speech* Vygotsky provided two criteria for the mature mind: conscious realization and deliberateness characterize each component of consciousness. Emotions do not form an exception: transformed by thought and word, they are liberated from their natural substrate (Vygotsky, 1987), and, as a result, the 'higher emotions' are flexible and finely differentiated. The dynamics of specifically human emotions are no longer determined by a bodily state, 'from below', but by meanings, 'from above'. The tendency that Vygotsky found in the development of emotions is similar to that found in thinking: we are liberated from natural circumstances and leave them for the domain of the 'invisible', the domain of meanings. From his point of view, man does not obey affects, even if they are very noble, but himself creates his affects, personality, and destiny. According to Vygotsky, the ultimate goal of the development of the affect was a voluntary emotion.

It must be said that this viewpoint is somewhat problematic. Its Marxist base is evident and it reveals the attitude of expanding one's possibilities and liberating oneself from natural lack of freedom with the help of the voluntary act. On the other hand, we find the idea, nontypical for Marxists, of the transforming role of the word, which Vygotsky borrowed from the Humboldtian tradition of linguistics and, in particular, from Aleksandr Potebnia (Bertau, 2014).

The link between the Nietzschean project of the superman and Vygotsky's ideas is undisputable. In Vygotsky's work we trace the new European ideal of the superman-creator, who reforms nature, including his own. Furthermore, in Vygotsky's later works we see the outlines of a new image of man, whose specific distinguishing characteristic is that he *speaks* and *thinks*.

According to Vygotsky one of the major questions of psychology was that of the specific distinguishing characteristics of man. Behind his psychological studies the philosophical problem of the nature of man always loomed large.

To an extent his work can be viewed as an attempt to overcome metaphysics, because he strove to conceptualize the gap between the bodily and spiritual planes of human existence. The general orientation of Vygotsky's later works and his interest in the writings of Khlebnikov and Osip Mandelstam suggest that the idea of the person as a creative being, as a poet, who "gives names to the things," was dear to him.

In contrast to his work from the 'instrumental period' of the 1920s, with its zeal for social 'reforging' and the creation of a 'new man', Vygotsky's work from the 1930s was focused on the study of the subject's inner world. After all, what is created in the process of growth and development of the person is his inner world. Neither did Vygotsky in his later works on developmental psychology deny spontaneous development and the spontaneous activity of a child confronted with external conditions. Vygotsky discussed the critical periods in child development, when the susceptibility to certain environmental factors increases and these factors may radically change the course of development. The spontaneous activity is formed and guided from outside. Can we model or guide something that is not there? The transition 'inwards' of interpersonal relationships is no mechanistic process and even less a 'reflection' (in the sense of Lenin's so-called theory of reflection); it is connected with an act of personal choice (cf. Vygotsky, 1997b). The conviction that man is free was always at the background of the mature Vygotsky's thinking. For him the mechanisms of social mediation were not important in themselves; rather they contained the essence of man: they served as the ladder towards the new 'peak' psychology.

We can see how Vygotsky understood this concept when we have a look at the abstract of a talk from late 1932, published as *The problem of consciousness* in the third volume of the *Collected works*. First of all, Vygotsky contrasted his 'peak psychology' with 'depth psychology' (i.e. *Tiefenpsychologie*) and the whole psychoanalytic current (Vygotsky, 1997d, p. 137). According to Vygotsky, the unconscious "shines with reflected light," i.e. in the unconscious we do not find the essence of man. Our real motives are to be found in the superconscious rather than in the unconscious. Thus, peak psychology involves a vision of man from the fullness of his being, the summits of his existence. It is a vision that to some extent makes Vygotsky's thinking from the 1930s similar to that of the later humanistic psychology.

The words about the birth of the 'new man' in the process of his 'social re-forging' – the favorite theme of the young Vygotsky – probably reflected a longing for a full, holistic, and non-fragmented existence and an understanding of the historical importance of the time in which he was destined to live. The emergence of scientific psychology meant that people began to study what is most complex and important: man himself. It meant that the hour had come for the 'decisive battle' for the future; a struggle whose outcome depended upon the possibility of transforming the essence of man. Below we quote the final lines of his work on the psychological crisis, which mixes Marxism, Nietzsche, and themes such as freedom and necessity in complex ways:

In the new society our science will be in the center of life. “The leap from the realm of necessity into the realm of freedom”⁹ will inevitably give rise to the question of the mastering of our being, of subordinating it to ourselves. In this sense Pavlov was right when he called our science the last science about man. It will indeed be the last science in the historical period of mankind or in the prehistory of mankind. The new society will create a new man ... in the future society psychology will indeed be a science about superman. Marxism and the history of science wouldn’t be complete without this perspective. But this science about superman will nevertheless still be psychology; now it’s in our hands to create it. There is no need that this psychology will resemble the present one as little as – in Spinoza’s words – the Dog, the heavenly constellation, resembles the dog, the barking animal.

(quoted from the manuscript, whose text differs from that in the Collected works; see Zavershneva & Osipov 2012a, 2012b for a list of differences)

One might accuse Vygotsky of mixing up ideology and science but we should not forget that Vygotsky echoed the *Zeitgeist*. It was believed that a new time and future had come. This belief was not so much Marxist, but rather a belief of the concrete era to which Marxism belonged. Also, when the young Vygotsky echoed or copied the revolutionary Nietzschean slogans of the Bolshevik leader Lev Trotsky, he was not so much echoing or copying Trotsky but the spirit of the time that Trotsky represented: for a discussion of the Nietzschean current in Russian culture and, particularly, during the revolutionary period, see the works of Bernice Glatzer Rosenthal (1986, 1994, 2002). It should also be taken into account that in the 1930s Vygotsky wrote less about the new society and more about man as such. The analogy between the mind and a technical device disappeared and was replaced by statements about the meaningful word as the microcosm of human consciousness, as its living cell (Vygotskii, 1934a, p. 318).

Vygotsky’s ideas had yet another feature; it was less obvious than Marxism and Nietzschean thought but no less interesting: psychological matters were discussed in a manner that was more characteristic of philosophy than of psychology. The core of his conception, its main problem (which was not studied directly but represented the philosophical background against which his research proceeded), we can reconstruct as follows: What is the relation of the word to man’s ‘primary’ nature? Does the word only reorganize the natural processes, changing nothing but their order and combination, or does it really transform them in a radical way? What is the nature of the word itself? – if it is a mediator between nature and culture (or, in another variant, between body and spirit), then what is it? – a part of culture, a part of nature, or neither?

The word intervenes in perception and affect, Vygotsky wrote, it shapes destiny. Did these connections, these passions, not exist before the word had elucidated them, or were they there all the time, but we didn’t know about them, and

now we do? In different periods Vygotsky replied differently to these two alternatives: (1) the word changes just the order and connections of ideas, perceptions, and affects, (2) the word transforms them completely. Vygotsky did not choose one of these alternatives, but investigated and compared them.

It is remarkable that Vygotsky, who favored monism in explaining the mind, never resorted to, on the one hand, ‘matter’ (or ‘brain function’), or pure meanings, on the other. Later commentators have drawn the conclusion that Vygotsky pictured the mind as something purely artificial, something above or even outside nature. But Vygotsky himself wrote, for example, that:

We should not conceive of artificial (instrumental) acts as supernatural or meta-natural acts constructed in accordance with some new, special laws. Artificial acts are natural as well. They can, without remainder, to the very end, be decomposed and reduced to natural ones ... What is artificial is the combination (construction) and direction, the substitution and utilization of these natural processes.

(Vygotsky, 1997c, p. 86)

However, on this very same page Vygotsky made a strange remark: “This method does not negate a single natural-scientific method for the study of behavior and nowhere intersects with them” (Vygotsky, 1997c, p. 86). So, what do we have? Special laws, a special method? Or the simple combination of natural functions about which reflexologists and behaviorists already talked before Vygotsky? The radical nature of the propositions advanced during the second half of the 1920s, when the mind was compared to a machine or technical device, was replaced by more cautious utterances in the later works: “We can only become conscious of what we have. We can only master an already existing function” (Vygotskii, 1934a, p. 227). When the focus of Vygotsky’s research program was shifted from the sign-word to the sign-meaning, the questions about the reformation of nature and about the proper method became again acute: “By its appearance speech fundamentally changes consciousness” (Vygotsky, 1997d, p. 137).

Indeed, the postulate about the two planes in the development of the higher psychological functions contained an inner conflict. Because of this postulate, Vygotsky often had to defend himself against critics and at some point he finally recognized the fallacy of the idea. In the note *Symposium, December 4, 1932* he wrote:

The higher and lower functions are not built in 2 floors: their number and names do not coincide. But neither our previous understanding: the higher function is the mastery of the lower one (voluntary attention is the subordination of involuntary attention), for this also means 2 floors.

Vygotsky suspected that this conception of lower and higher functions, which was once considered his main discovery (an assessment that can still be found in textbooks), retained the older Cartesian dualism.

Remarks about the psychophysical problem

The psychophysical problem arose when it seemed Vygotsky had already got rid of it. In one of his last talks, about the localization of higher psychological functions (Vygotskii, 1934d), he repeatedly criticized Pavlov because Pavlov identified thinking with a function of the frontal lobes, and he challenged the researchers who adhered to the idea of strict localization of psychological functions. Instead, he proposed the system principle, which says that functions do not have a fixed composition and change structure depending on the concrete task. The organization of nervous processes and interfunctional links is changed with the help of extracerebral mechanisms; this reorganization comes about particularly in the social environment, in the interaction with other people with the help of sign systems. In his virtual polemic with the neurologists Goldstein and Head, Vygotsky claimed:

We: in naturalistic terms, in the brain and its functions there are no (and cannot be) structures that correspond with speech, they develop from above, from the psychological structures (2 brains that interact via the historical-cultural environment). The word is the source of new brain structures and not all operations with the word are present in the brain's morphological structure.

(Aphasia, schizophrenia, and other pathological changes, Vygotsky archive)

With the idea of sociocultural mediation Vygotsky reconsidered the psychophysical problem; he suggested replacing the old body-soul dilemma with another problem: "This is terribly important: speech/thinking as a psycho/physical problem" (*Symposium, December 4, 1932; Vygotsky archive*). The question again rested upon the problem of the word and its nature. This theme was so complex that Vygotsky more than once ended his notes with the same quotation from Aleksandr Pushkin's *The covetous knight*: "for me this knowledge is enough," i.e. it was enough that the problem had been formulated (Vygotsky, 1997d, p. 138).

Indeed, the psychophysical problem, which from the viewpoint of ordinary knowledge would seem to be extremely speculative and even curious, had a fatal influence on the development of scientific psychology. From its origin it was divided into two branches. The first branch we may call explanatory psychology (Wilhelm Dilthey's term), nomothetic psychology (Wilhelm Windelband's term), or natural-scientific psychology and subscribed to the principle of complete determinism. The mind was viewed primarily as a function of the nervous substrate and the problem was to find the link between mental phenomena and neural processes. The main task was to find universal laws for the development and structure of the mind and the major research tool was the experiment. The second branch, descriptive or idiographic psychology, followed in the footsteps of hermeneutics and did not acknowledge the experiment. The focus was on the person as a free, unique, and unitary being. In Vygotsky's time, the Soviet psychological literature presented this opposition as the opposition between materialistic and idealistic approaches to

the study of mind. That was, of course, a gross simplification, because the opposition between ‘general’ and ‘unique’ evolved long before Soviet philosophers hit upon the idea to divide the entire world into these two camps.

It is characteristic that the founder of psychology, Wilhelm Wundt, created not just one psychology, but two: physiological psychology and *Völkerpsychologie*. These two psychologies nowhere overlapped and represented totally different sciences. Within “physiological psychology” evolved the theory of individual consciousness as a structure composed of elementary sensations and feelings connected by association. With the help of a metronome Wundt measured the volume of consciousness; later the tachistoscope appeared, which allowed the study of ‘pure’ (i.e. not distorted by speech) consciousness by the brief presentation of images. *Völkerpsychologie* was dedicated to the description of supra-individual processes such as languages, myths, and customs. Wundt admitted that he was not satisfied with the division, but the generations after him all repeated him one way or the other. The history of psychology shows that revolutionary shifts in psychology were always connected with the appearance of two rival theories, one representing the ‘explanatory’ and the other the ‘descriptive’ side of the old dichotomy. Thus, at the beginning of the twentieth century psychoanalysis and behaviorism appeared almost simultaneously and remained for a long time the most powerful currents in psychology. Then, in the 1950s and 1960s, cognitive psychology and humanistic psychology appeared and immediately declared themselves to be opponents.

Vygotsky, however, always strove for a unified view of the mind; he wanted a theory that would finally combine and synthesize the two branches of psychology. A large part of his unfinished works *The (historical) meaning of the psychological crisis* and *A theory of the emotions* is dedicated to the analysis of contemporary theories. Step by step Vygotsky showed that what seemed unified theories were actually mixtures of heterogeneous components. As long as body and soul were considered as two independent streams, the hypothesis of parallelism worked, although not without problems, but not so in a psychology where the body–soul unity is an empirical reality. Until this day we have no satisfactory account of this unity, which is no less than disastrous. To support this view Vygotsky quoted the founder of Gestalt psychology, the great Max Wertheimer:

Only persons belonging to our recent European culture can separate the psychological and the physical as we do. A person is dancing. Do we really have, on the one hand, the sum of muscular movements and, on the other hand, joy and inspiration?

(Vygotsky, 1993b, p. 311)¹⁰

In the period between 1910 and the 1930s, when Vygotsky wrote his work, there was much interest in philosophical and methodological matters among psychologists. Many understood the untenability of the theory of parallelism but alternatives were not yet available. Psychologists and philosophers proposed various solutions for the psychophysical problem but on further inspection they turned out to be

no more than new variants of parallelism. Vygotsky believed that hypotheses about interaction could not solve the problem – after all, one then first tears the unitary process (“the unitary psychophysical act”) apart and subsequently tries to establish a link between the parts. Vygotsky’s notebook showed that he saw the hidden parallels in the solutions proposed.

Propositions for the talks by Vygotsky’s collaborators

The last section of Vygotsky’s notes contains the propositions for two talks by Solov’ev and Leontiev. It is no coincidence that they are found together. Here we have two approaches to the same problem: the relationship between the dynamics of action and the dynamics of meaning. Solov’ev had modified Anitra Karsten’s (1928, 1976) method and conducted a study whose results he generalized in a book chapter, “About psychological saturation” (Solov’ev-Elpidinskii, 1935).¹¹ He managed to establish the link between the dynamics of saturation in normal children with that of mentally retarded subjects. It turned out that adults confronted with a meaningless task regress to the level of a seven-year-old child and become field-dependent. Further experiments showed that the semantically underdeveloped processes of the mentally retarded children are reflected in rigid action dynamics, that the children get stuck in concrete details, are dependent on field conditions, on the material, and so on. A discussion of this and other experiments based on investigations by members of Kurt Lewin’s research collective, such as those by Karsten and Gita Birenbaum (1930), can be found in Vygotsky’s article “The problem of mental retardation” (Vygotskii, 1935c), published in the same volume as Solov’ev’s work.

Lewin was among the most outstanding intellectuals influencing Vygotsky: Lewin was the first to develop a way to study affect and volition; also, just like Vygotsky, he favored a monistic methodology based on a principle of strict causality. The new type of experiment proposed by Lewin had no precedent in psychology nor in science at large. Lewin’s studies were some sort of theatrical experiment, where the roles of subject and experimenter fundamentally changed and the idea of objective method received a new interpretation. These experiments went beyond the confines of laboratory study and had immediate practical repercussions. It was the discussions with Lewin that inspired Vygotsky’s thinking in the final years of his life. This is evident from Vygotsky’s published writings but also from a large number of notes from 1933 to 1934 found in the archive (See Chapter 9 for discussion of the personal contacts between Vygotsky and Lewin).

As early as the beginning of the 1930s Vygotsky had underlined the fact that emotions are the core of personality and that the chapter about emotions must become the most important one in the psychology of man. Nevertheless, in the majority of his writings the emotions play the ‘honorable’ role of a subjugated process (the development of emotions is conceived as the intellectualization of innate affect, as mastering it), and only in Vygotsky’s later works does one see the outlines of a new integral unit (“emotional experience”; *perezhivanie* in Russian), where

affect and intellect are no opposites, but form a complex dynamic synthesis. The cultural-historical theory of emotions that might have grown from these beginnings has not been developed as yet.

Returning to the polemic between Lewin and Vygotsky, we may remark that Karsten's experiment (and the study of Tamara Dembo) dealt not just with the problem of motivation but also with the problem of will, and it had to be explained why far from all subjects regressed in a meaningless situation. Lewin wrote that the ability to stand above the field, to leave the field by creating perspectives for future actions, even when these cannot be realized immediately, is a sign of maturity (he called this the capacity for volitional behavior). Vygotsky was looking for his own explanation of this volitional behavior; he criticized Lewin for his extreme preference for the emotional-volitional domain to the detriment of the study of thinking. For Vygotsky, it was precisely thinking that formed the primary lever that allows the person to overcome the forces of the external field and preserve their independence. Vygotsky also argued that the dynamics of saturation cannot be exhaustively explained unless we deal directly with the domain of meaning and turn to the semic analysis of consciousness. Subjects continue with a boring task mainly because they can reappraise the experimental situation and not because of an energy impulse from other domains of their inner field. As a result of this reappraisal, both the reorganization of the external and internal domains of the field and voluntary behavior become possible. In other words, affect can only be understood in connection with intellect; the dynamics of the situation can only be understood from the dynamics of meaning. It is important to reach the highest level of analysis; the level of the whole that determines its parts. Who should know this better than Lewin, the founder of a theory derived from Gestalt psychology?

Vygotsky claimed that at the basis of the mature person are tertiary links between psychological functions (the primary links are the unmediated innate ones; the secondary links are the mediated interfunctional ones; and the tertiary links are reformed secondary ones, deliberately constructed by the person to reach a specific vital goal). Hence, conceptual thinking, which makes it possible to understand oneself, to cast a conceptual net over one's dimly felt inner world, is of primary importance to the person. It is the meaningful word, added to the primary affect, that connects it with other conditions and the world; which elucidates it, makes it transparent and visible and, therefore, manageable and conscious. Vygotsky understood that his conception verged on intellectualism and he followed Lewin's studies with interest – they represented as it were the complement to his own research. It was only in his last writings on developmental psychology and partly in *Thinking and speech* that Vygotsky managed to soften this intellectualism. He searched for other forms of cognizance and awareness, not exclusively tied to the function of thinking but based on a complex Gestalt of all psychological functions. However, he did not manage to complete the revision of his theory.

Vygotsky used similar and quite sharp arguments against Leontiev: in his view Leontiev underestimated the higher processes and showed a low level of

theoretical generalization. In the note one senses that Vygotsky's former enthusiasm about the perspectives of their collaboration gave way to bewilderment. Leontiev studied the transitions between the cognizing and the practical intellect from the viewpoint of what later would become his activity theory. From Vygotsky's viewpoint, however, these transitions had to be studied as part of the larger – and methodologically primary – problem of consciousness: the dynamics of the action (such as the phenomenon of saturation) he wished to study solely within the framework of his “peak psychology,” i.e. in the context of the general dynamics of consciousness. As soon as we understand the dynamics of meanings, we will understand all the rest as effects that follow from a cause and vice versa: separating the action from the dimension of meanings, we lose the meaning of the action, its goal-directed nature, etc.

In his criticism Vygotsky said that Leontiev lacked discipline, lost the focus of the research, and ignored the systemic principle. To him, the step aside made by Leontiev was not just a deviation from the main goal – i.e. the creation of a theory of consciousness – but also a step backwards towards the functional analysis prevalent in Vygotsky's writings from 1928 to 1930, when each function that formed part of consciousness was investigated separately. However, now the time had come “to gather stones together”: to combine all results, to synthesize and rethink them in order to find a leading, ‘peak’ level of analysis that would permit the explanation of all components of consciousness, including the dynamics of action, with new laws characteristic of consciousness as a whole. Leontiev, apparently, was in no hurry to adapt his studies to the new plan.

The arguments against Leontiev remained within the boundaries of a normal scientific debate, although it is evident that Vygotsky was losing his patience: “Each of us made his *own* independent contribution, starting from the common assumptions. But where is *he* heading?” (*Notebook. October, 1932*). It seems that Vygotsky did not suspect that behind Leontiev's decision to dissociate himself from their research project may also have been a wide range of reasons. Leontiev subsequently developed his “activity theory” and made a career in the complex period from 1930 to 1950, becoming the leader of the activity-theory movement and the founder of the faculty of psychology at Moscow State University. Without discussing the differences of opinion between Vygotsky and Leontiev any further, we would like to point out one further circumstance that indicates that their disagreements were genuine: if we discount the edition of part of Vygotsky's (1956, 1960) works during the thaw period, psychologists in the Soviet Union had quite limited exposure to Vygotsky's writings until the 1980s, that is, exactly during the period in which Leontiev occupied leading positions in Soviet science (cf. discussion at the end of Chapter 3).

However that may be, at the present moment psychology knows an “activity theory” but no general psychological theory of consciousness nor a functioning theory of emotions. Of course, many things have changed since Vygotsky's death eighty years ago and his ideas can and should acquire a new significance, a new meaning.

Just as Vygotsky tried to problematize the psychology of his time, to find its weak spots and growing points, we must try to find them in Vygotsky's theory. In this sense a polemic with Vygotsky may be no less valuable than literally following his texts. Hopefully, the publication of new historical-biographical studies dedicated to Vygotsky's conception and of archival materials will help to resurrect the project for a general psychology that Vygotsky failed to realize.

PART III

Holism and transnationalism

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7

TRANSLATING VYGOTSKY

Some problems of transnational Vygotskian science

René van der Veer and Anton Yasnitsky

International interest in what are commonly believed to be the ideas of the Russian psychologist Lev Vygotsky is enormous. The number of publications about this historical figure and his scientific legacy is growing almost exponentially. Vygotsky's international fame and his status of celebrity are widely acknowledged by scholars and educationists all over the globe, although, it seems, the reasons for the glorification of Vygotsky in different regions of the world are different. Also different are the histories of the import and inculcation of Vygotsky into different regional scholarly communities. Thus, the posthumous fame of Vygotsky in the Soviet Union and Russia is chiefly due to the administrative success of the clan of his former students and associates who were raised to power and got control over a considerable segment of Soviet psychology in the 1960s/1970s. As an instrument for the consolidation of the clan and the ideology of their informal personal network, the canonic narrative of the archetypical 'Vygotsky school' was introduced and developed in numerous propagandist writings in this tradition. This canonic narrative included several foundational structural components, such as the dogma of the *troika* of Vygotsky, Leontiev, and Luria, and the *piaterka* (the five) of their devoted students and followers. According to the legend, all these – in the military newspeak of Soviet academia – 'brethren in arms' would later constitute the 'Vygotsky–Leontiev–Luria school'. Somewhat paradoxically, the rise to administrative power of the 'Vygotsky students' clan' was accompanied by a virtual absence of Vygotsky's publications in the Soviet Union. This can be considered as the factual 'ban on Vygotsky' in the Soviet Union in the 1960s–1970s (for an in-depth critical discussion of the 'archetype of Soviet psychology', the canonic narrative, and the history of the alleged ban on Vygotsky in the 1930s–1950s, see Chapters 1, 2, and 3 of this book, respectively). Although related to the developments in the Soviet Union, the international history of the 'exported Vygotsky' is quite different from the

domestic one, and is fairly specific to the particular locale, academic culture, and linguistic tradition. It is hardly possible to understand the issues of translation outside the larger context of the cultural assimilation of ideas circulating between countries, regions, and local academic and professional communities. The transnational history of Vygotskian science has not yet been written. And yet, such a history would be very helpful in our present discussion of “some problems of transnational Vygotskian science,” and, specifically, the issue of the translations of Vygotsky’s works. Therefore, we first provide a relatively brief and superficial sketch of such a future history, to be written some day. Then, we proceed to the discussion of the issues of translation, including the actual and anticipated potential errors, and suggest some practical guidelines for future translators.

A transnational history of Vygotsky in context

A transnational history of science and the practice of the “import” of ideas should be guided by the sort of questions that Pierre Bourdieu posed in his essay “The social conditions of the international circulation of ideas”:

A large number of translations can only be understood if they are placed in the complex network of international exchanges between holders of dominant academic posts, the exchanges of invitations, honorary doctorates, etc. The question that must then be asked is how it comes about that a certain writer or editor becomes the importer of a certain thought. Why is writer X published by publisher Y? For it is obvious that there will always be some sort of profit involved. Heretical imports are often the work of marginals in the field, bringing a message, a position of force from a different field, which they use to try and shore up their own position. Foreign writers are often subject to such instrumental use, and forced to serve purposes which they would perhaps refuse or reject in their country of origin. One can often use a foreign thinker to attack domestic thinkers in this way.

(Bourdieu, 1999, p. 223)

The ‘export of Vygotsky’ to North America and, by extension, the Anglo-Saxon world started as early as in the late 1920s and continued throughout the 1930s, although the impact of these early efforts was absolutely minimal. The interest in Vygotsky’s works in the English-speaking world during that period was close to non-existent. There were, however, two notable exceptions, both directly related to the activities and relative success of Vygotsky’s associates in the West. First, the book by Vygotsky’s associate, co-author, and collaborator Alexander Luria, *The nature of human conflicts*, which came out in 1932 in the United States and made quite a stir there (A. R. Luria, 1932c). In that book, Luria did acknowledge the impact of Vygotsky’s ideas, albeit rather inconspicuously. However, contemporaries were more inclined to see this volume as a major contribution to the development of the studies of Carl Jung, Max Wertheimer, or even Kurt Lewin (Leeper, 1943). Second,

the applied work done by Jacob Kasanin and his associate Eugenia Hanfmann in the field of psychiatry and mental testing, using the revised experimental technique developed by Vygotsky and his late collaborator Sakharov, was a quite notable contribution to the dissemination of Vygotsky's ideas in the West – at least some of these ideas. The effort of Kasanin and Hanfmann deserves a separate mention, for they not only replicated the Sakharov–Vygotsky studies on North American soil (Hanfmann & Kasanin, 1937, 1942; Kasanin & Hanfmann, 1938), but also were instrumental in the actual import of his texts: their first translation came out in English in 1934 (Vygotsky, 1934). All these efforts did not go entirely unnoticed at that time, and were acknowledged by a number of scholars, including such names as Kurt Goldstein, Harry Stack Sullivan, Norman Cameron, John D. Benjamin, S. J. Beck, E. von Domarus, and Andras Angyal (Kasanin, 1944). Kasanin was also instrumental in the first foreign publication of Vygotsky's text that would subsequently evolve into the first English-language publication of Vygotsky's *Thinking and speech* in 1962. The book's final chapter was published in English as a scholarly paper in 1939, in the journal *Psychiatry*, edited by the journal's founder Harry Stack Sullivan. Eugenia Hanfmann, Kasanin's collaborator in his clinical research, helped him also with these translations of the 1930s and later, in the 1950s, became one of the two translators of the complete book, published under the somewhat erroneous and misleading title *Thought and language* (Vygotsky, 1962). The translation, made in collaboration with Gertrude Vakar, was fairly idiosyncratic. The second edition of this book came out very soon afterwards, in 1965, by the same publishing house, the MIT Press.

In the 1930s and 1940s, however, Vygotsky had not yet become a major figure of international psychology, and fame reached him only through a number of later, postwar, publications that reveal the agency of a huge transnational informal personal network of scholars, translators, publishers, policy-makers, and the like. This informal personal network emerged after the relatively brief period, roughly from 1948 to 1955, of lack of contact between the two superpowers, the Soviet Union and the United States, during the initial phase of the Cold War. This brief period was characterized by, on the one hand, a dramatic separation of the two superpowers and intense competition in international affairs and, on the other hand, fairly symmetrical and parallel processes of witch-hunts and politically motivated persecutions in domestic affairs in both the USSR and the USA. Yet, everything was to gradually change, and the Soviet Union started reopening pretty soon after the death of Stalin in 1953. The first renewed contacts between Soviet psychologists and their Western peers took place in 1954 on the occasion of the 14th International Congress of Psychology in Montreal. Soviet scholars first re-established their connections with francophone, mainly French, psychologists, known for their explicit Marxist and leftist leanings. Soon thereafter, they renewed their connections with Anglo-Saxon – North American and British – psychologists as well. In these contacts, Vygotsky and his legacy became one of the main 'import-export' commodities of scientific exchange and interaction. In the history of these exchanges two highly illustrative episodes are of interest.

The French connection

The following reconstruction of the first episode, in three acts, is based on the reminiscences of francophone psychologists, who reflected on their exchanges with their Soviet peers in 1954–5. The first act of the ‘French connection’ plot took place in Paris in the spring of 1954. The first two psychologists who made a trip from the Soviet Union to France in the postwar period were Anatolii Smirnov and Natal’ia Menchinskaia (respectively, director and deputy director of the Institute of Psychology of the Academy of Pedagogical Sciences), who attended a conference on child psychology (*Journées de psychologie de l’enfant*) held in Paris on April 21–26, 1954. René Zazzo (1910–95), who was one of the organizers of the event, recalled that just two months later French psychologists realized that this surprise visit from behind the Iron Curtain was not just coincidental, because another larger delegation of Soviet scholars (Leontiev, Teplov, Zaporozhets, Kostiuik, Sokolov, and Asratyan) arrived in Paris in order to greet Henri Wallon (1879–1962) – a highly influential psychologist and political activist, member of the French Communist Party and director of the Institute of Psychology in Paris – on their way to the 14th International Congress of Psychology in Montreal. According to Zazzo’s reminiscences, it was in June, 1954 that Aleksei Leontiev invited Wallon to the luxurious hotel Lutetia (where the members of the Soviet delegation stayed during their visit to Paris) and asked Zazzo for help. According to Zazzo, Leontiev was concerned about the ‘rehabilitation’ of Lev Vygotsky, a brilliant and “the most prestigious” (*le plus prestigieux*) Soviet psychologist of the 1930s, who was compromised by his association with the officially banned discipline of pedology. Leontiev was seeking Zazzo’s assistance in publishing a volume of collected articles from the late Vygotsky that he and Luria had selected. Such anticipated publication was expected to make a strong impression on domestic Soviet authorities and speed up the publication of the book at home in the USSR.¹ Zazzo’s efforts in France remained unsuccessful but Luria was able to arrange a deal with publishers in the United States, and, reportedly, the manuscript was sent to North America in 1955. Finally, yet another year later, in 1956, the same collection of Vygotsky’s texts came out in Russian in the Soviet Union before and regardless of the international publication of Vygotsky’s works in translation.²

The second act of the story took place in Montreal on June 7–12, 1954, where a Soviet delegation of six arrived, four of whom presented at the thematic symposium *Recent advances in conditioning*, chaired by Donald G. Marquis (Michigan) and with Paul Fraisse (Sorbonne), Gregory Razran (Queen’s, Brooklyn), and E. L. Kelly (Michigan)³ as discussants. The four presentations all seemed grounded in Pavlov’s teaching on higher nervous activity and abounded with Pavlovian terminology. Another paper, *Development of voluntary movements* by A. V. Zaporozhets, was presented at the symposium on *Motor skills*. Finally, the presentation by Kostiuik on the development of thinking in children (*Du développement de l’intelligence chez l’enfant*) was published in Moscow by the Academy of Pedagogical Sciences of the RSFSR in a collection of conference papers presented by Soviet scholars. Yet, for unknown

reasons, the presentation by Kostiuk was not listed among the abstracts of the papers presented at the conference.

The third act of the Soviet-French exchange of 1954–5 was performed back in the USSR by Soviet scholars and a group of their francophone peers who were invited to visit the Soviet Union. The group included Henri Piéron (1881–1964), Paul Fraisse (1911–96), René Zazzo, and Jean Piaget (who was the president of the International Union of Scientific Psychology at the time). In April/May 1955, three of them (Piéron could not participate because of ill health) made a trip to the Soviet Union (mostly to Moscow, but they also visited Leningrad for a couple of days). Immediately after the trip Piaget published a paper, entitled “Some impressions of a visit to Soviet psychologists” (Piaget, 1956). In his fairly favorable overview of the trip and the psychological research conducted in the USSR, Piaget made several interesting remarks. For example, he noted that, contrary to the superficial impression that one might get from the published sources, psychology seemed to be a thriving discipline in the Soviet Union: physiologists were numerous indeed, but there were also large numbers of local psychologists employed by a wide range of institutions, such as universities, institutes dependent on the Academy of Sciences, the Psychological Institute of the Academy of Pedagogical Sciences, and the Institute of Defectology. He also noted that it appeared that the psychologists he met during the trip were surprisingly well read in contemporary scholarly literature: they “read everything that appears abroad, particularly in French and English.” In the end Piaget, who was most impressed by the experimental research, the variety of opinions, and the enthusiasm of his Soviet peers, had just one criticism:

If I may be permitted a critical reflection, the only one that occurred to me in the course of my visit or in analysing certain studies like those of Kostiouk [*sic*] on the psychology of number in children – I am under the impression that certain writers quote non-Russian sources less than they read them.

(Piaget, 1956, p. 344)

In this article Piaget also mentioned a meeting that their delegation had with the ‘great five’ (Leontiev, Teplov, Rubinstein, Luria, and Smirnov) and a ‘frank discussion’ about a number of questions on their minds, especially with regard to the “real implications of reflexological explanations in psychology.” In his characterization of this discussion, he added: “we found not only a full comprehension of our questions, but in addition a critical position more highly nuanced than we would have thought from some publications on the subject of these essential problems” (Piaget, 1956, p. 343).

Piaget also reported that they “learned *inter alia* that the publications of Ivanov-Smolenski [a zealous Pavlovian] by no means carry authority in Moscow, as is supposed outside the country” (Piaget, 1956, p. 343). In his memoirs of the 1980s, Zazzo sheds light on this somewhat cryptic reference to the ‘frank discussion’. He recalled the last meeting of the francophone guests with their Moscow hosts on May 2, 1955, in informal settings, and quoted their opinions on

the state of the art in Soviet psychology. In a somewhat provocative and utterly revealing paper that Zazzo published in 1956 in *La Raison*, the organ of the French Communist Party, some of these statements of Soviet psychologists were rendered verbatim, for instance: “For twenty years Ivanov-Smolenski has done nothing but verbal work, but no [research on] physiology of verbal [behavior]” (Leontiev); “I hate someone to explain the complex phenomena (of mental life) by the scheme of conditioned reflexes” (Teplov); “Within the immense domain of psychology Pavlov studied just a little bit” (Luria); “Pedagogy can not develop unless on the basis of paedology” (Smirnov)” (Zazzo, 1989).⁴ This paper had been written at the request of Leontiev, who asked Zazzo to help French comrades better understand the complexities of the Soviet situation in psychology and Pavlovian physiology, and to correct certain of their attitudes toward this issue (Zazzo, 1982).⁵ The paper caused quite a stir in Moscow, and, at Leontiev’s request, another paper signed by ‘the great five’ of Soviet psychology was published in the same edition. This paper was supposed to correct the ‘mistakes’ and ‘misinterpretations’ that might have occurred in translation of their conversation into French. The irony of this excuse was obvious to the participants of the discussion: everyone but Smirnov spoke French, and Zazzo was meticulously taking notes. In any case, regardless of the later ‘corrections’ and ‘clarifications’, the message of the first publication must have reached its intended francophone audience abroad.

Anglo-Saxon ties: a Cold War story

The second episode also took place in April, 1955. It appears that the group of francophone scholars was not the only delegation to make a trip to the USSR in the spring of 1955 in order to meet Soviet psychologists. An unidentified “small party of teachers and educationists” that included Brian Simon, a Communist sympathizer and a lecturer in Education at the University of Leicester, and, possibly, his wife Joan Simon, visited the Soviet Union at the invitation of the Academy of Pedagogical Sciences of the RSFSR. According to Simon, this group of British educationists arrived in the Soviet Union with the purpose of familiarizing themselves with the achievements of the Soviets in the field of polytechnical education and in preparation for the raising of the school leaving age to 17. However, as it turned out during the trip, in order for them to understand the ideas of Soviet educators and researchers the group of Westerners required some knowledge of developments in psychology. As a result, the members of the delegation had a series of most productive discussions with Soviet scholars, quite a few of whom are already familiar to us, including Smirnov, Menchinskaja, Leontiev, and Luria in Moscow, and Ananiev in Leningrad. The discussions proved so informative and revealing that the idea was born to prepare a volume of collected works of contemporary Soviet psychologists. This volume, comprising some twenty translated papers authored by Soviet psychologists, came out in 1957 under Simon’s editorship (B. Simon, 1957). This was

the first major postwar presentation of the achievements of Soviet psychology in the West: it was the first, but it would definitely not be the last.

The trip of anglophone teachers and educationists to Moscow in April 1955 resulted in a volume, *Psychology in the Soviet Union*. But this was not the only outcome of the trip. According to the papers of Brian Simon in the Institute of Education at the University of London, Simon extensively corresponded with Luria from the mid-1950s and made several other trips to the Soviet Union. As a result, Luria's 1930s studies of twins, published as a book in Russian in 1956, came out in 1959 under the editorship of Joan Simon (translated by J. Simon and O. Kovasc) from London's Staples Press (A. R. Luria & Yudovich, 1956, 1959). Apparently, Luria also traveled to the West in the 1950s,⁶ and some of these trips were organized and facilitated by his British colleagues, possibly the Simons. Thus, three lectures given by Luria at University College London in London in October, 1957 came out as a book, *The role of speech in the regulation of normal and abnormal behaviour* in Great Britain and in the United States in 1961 (A. R. Luria, 1961).⁷ Luria's foreign trips and his foreign contacts were by no means limited to the United Kingdom. In 1960, during his trip to the United States, Luria met the luminary of American science and the co-founder of cognitive studies, Jerome Bruner, who later recalled: "Luria and I became fast friends almost immediately. We were compatible temperamentally and very much in agreement about psychological matters" (Bruner, 1983, p. 145). It appears that this meeting was to become one of the major events in the history of the global spread of Vygotsky's ideas.

Following his British and North American exchanges, roughly a dozen of Luria's books were published in the UK and the USA during the 1960s, which is a strong indicator of Luria's rapidly growing reputation as a scholar of international acclaim.⁸ In turn, Brian and Joan Simon visited the Soviet Union in September, 1961. As a result of their cooperation with the scholars at the Institute of Psychology of the Academy of Pedagogical Sciences – once again, Menchinskaia (the Head of the Department of Educational Psychology and Deputy Director of the Institute) and Smirnov (Director of the Institute) were mentioned – another comprehensive volume of collected contributions by Soviet psychologists, entitled *Education and psychology in the USSR*, was published in London by Routledge and Kegan Paul in 1963 (B. Simon & Simon, 1963).

Another British 'broker' between the anglophone readership and Soviet psychologists was Neil O'Connor (Medical Research Council psychologist at the Institute of Psychiatry, the Maudsley Hospital in London), who had been involved in the Simons' international projects from the 1950s onwards. O'Connor edited another collection of contributions by Soviet authors, entitled *Recent Soviet psychology*, which was published in the United States by Liveright in 1961 (O'Connor, 1961). This book identified three main trends in contemporary Soviet psychology, namely: (a) physiological psychology based on Pavlov's work, (b) the growth of concept formation and of speech based on Vygotsky's and Luria's studies, and (c) the studies on 'set theory' done mostly by the scholars of the Georgian school of Uznadze. Five years later, in 1966, the same three general trends in Soviet psychology were discussed in

a volume issued by Pergamon Press. The book, *Present-day Russian psychology. A symposium by seven authors*, was also edited by O'Connor and included contributions of scholars from the UK, USA, and Israel (J. A. Gray; B. H. Kirman; P. M. A. Rabbitt; R. Lynn; D. I. Slobin; L. Rahmani; J. Brožek). The editor proudly boasted that the book was unique in that it was the first comprehensive survey of Russian psychological literature written by bilingual psychologists (O'Connor, 1966).

American scholars, from the beginning of the 1960s, were increasingly interested in the promise of Soviet psychology, and invested considerable time, funds, and effort into the exploration of this scientific *terra incognita*. Perhaps one of the first American scholars to make a trip to the Soviet Union after the war was the renowned linguist and literary scholar of Russian origin Roman Jakobson (1896–1982), who attended the meeting of the International Association of Slavists in Moscow in the spring of 1956, and later frequently participated in various scientific conventions held in the Soviet Union in the 1950s–1970s.⁹ A number of American psychologists visited the Soviet Union in the summer of 1960. Once again, the trip resulted in the publication of a book. It was edited by Raymond A. Bauer, who had already authored *The new man in Soviet psychology* (Bauer, 1952), which was written a year before Stalin's death and was largely outdated as of the beginning of the 1960s. The new book, *Some views on Soviet psychology*, included contributions by another group of anglophone scholars that consisted of Alexander Mintz, Walter R. Reitman, Urie Bronfenbrenner and Otto Klineberg, Tema S. David, Yvonne Brackbill, Edwin A. Fleishman, Neal E. Miller, Carl Pfeiffmann, Harold Scholsberg, and Gardner and Lois Murphy (Bauer, 1962). At the beginning of the 1960s, quite a few more American psychologists made trips to the Soviet Union, either in large groups and delegations or individually and independently, like Daniel E. Berlyne, who made his trip to the USSR in 1961, or, for instance, Michael Cole, whose visit to the Soviet Union for postgraduate studies with Luria in Moscow in 1962 started a series of continuous and productive exchanges between these two scholars and, subsequently, Cole's immense involvement with the dissemination of Soviet psychology in North America. Also in 1962, Jerome Bruner paid a visit to Luria in Moscow, and they together even recorded a "discussion program" on national radio (Bruner, 1983, p. 185).

Many of those who traveled to the Soviet Union or otherwise established contacts with Soviet psychologists constituted a network of American brokers between the East and the West. The members of this network were involved in translations of works by Russian authors and published Soviet research overviews (most notably, publications by Gregory Razran, who had been considered as an expert on Russia from the mid-1930s, Alexander Mintz, Jozef Brožek, Daniel E. Berlyne, and Ivan London). A number of reviews of books by Soviet psychologists came out on the initiative of Josef Brožek, who served as the editor of East European section of the journal *Contemporary Psychology*. A major breakthrough in bringing Soviet psychological research to the West was the launch of a journal of translations named *Soviet Psychology and Psychiatry* in 1962, under the editorship of Dan Slobin (founding editor of the journal from 1962 to 1969; the journal split into *Soviet Neurology &*

Psychiatry and Soviet Psychology in 1966; the latter was renamed *Journal of Russian and East European Psychology* in 1992). As a result of these numerous efforts to disseminate Soviet psychology, it had already been fairly well presented in the West by August, 1963, when, at the meeting of the International Union of Psychological Science (IUPsyS) Executive Committee during the 17th International Congress of Psychology in Washington, DC, Moscow was nominated as the next psychological congress venue for 1966.

In Moscow, from August 4 to 11, 1966, the 18th International Congress of Psychology was held at the invitation of the Soviet government. The Congress turned out a triumph for international psychology in two main respects. On the one hand, this Congress appeared to be the most representative congress in the history of the International Union of Psychological Science, which had organized such scientific forums ever since the end of World War II. The record attendance of 3,897 scientists from 43 countries and, in addition, approximately 1,000 accompanying persons was to be surpassed only by the Psychological Congress in Leipzig in 1980 (Rosenzweig et al., 2000). Thus, the Moscow Congress indicated a major success for the International Union of Scientific Psychology, the organization that was created just fifteen years before with the goal and ambition to coordinate psychological research globally. On the other hand, the organization of the triumphal Moscow Congress coincided with the establishment of the first two – rival and extremely competitive – Departments of Psychology in the Soviet Union founded under the aegis of the State Universities in Moscow (Department Dean – A. N. Leontiev) and Leningrad (Department Dean – B. F. Lomov), both opened in the fall of 1966. The organizational success of the two – the International Union of Psychological Science and Soviet psychology as a scientific discipline in the Soviet Union – was truly remarkable and instrumental in expanding the Union's activities over Eastern Europe and the countries of the Soviet bloc and, on the other hand, the further global dissemination of Soviet achievements in psychology. Vygotsky and his alleged legacy were a quite essential component of this process – which is true at least on the rhetorical level and as far as the members of the Leontiev clan's diplomacy, politics, and struggle for power are concerned.

The transnational Vygotskian network in action

The enormous global network of many actors from all walks of life and different theoretical outlooks included a considerable number of individuals who particularly favored the Vygotskian strand in Soviet psychology and did their best to promote it outside the Soviet Union. Vygotskian ideas infiltrated into non-Russian science in many subtle ways: through informal personal exchanges, official collaborative projects, Soviet research overviews, and original studies conducted chiefly by North American and Western European scholars who made use of the notions and ideas that they borrowed from their Russian peers. Still, translations of Vygotsky's works constituted the most direct, although, as it eventually turned out, not always the

most reliable, mode of transmission of his ideas abroad. Vygotsky's works spread among speakers of German, Dutch, French, Italian, Portuguese, Spanish, Danish, Greek, Japanese, Farsi, and many other languages in many different ways. However, the next part of this chapter is limited to the discussion of English translations only.¹⁰

The first major translation of Vygotsky's work after World War II came out only in the early 1960s, but a great deal of preparatory work preceded this notable event. We may speculate as to whether it was during Roman Jakobson's Moscow trip in 1956 or, more probably, during his trip to Moscow of 1958, or perhaps Luria's trip to the United States of 1960, that the work towards an American publication of Vygotsky's *Thinking and speech* began.¹¹

In 1961, a breakthrough took place: the first post-World War II English-language publication of Vygotsky in the West came out in the United States in the volume *Psycholinguistics: A book of readings*, edited by Sol Saporta. This was a republication of the last chapter of Vygotsky's *Thinking and speech* that, under the title *Thought and speech*, had previously been published in 1939 in the journal *Psychiatry*, in an English translation by Jacob Kasanin, Eugenia Hanfmann, and Helen Kogan, and constituted one of the chapters in this reader (Vygotsky, 1961).

As mentioned before, in 1962, eventually and after "a great deal of backing and filing diplomatically to obtain rights" the whole volume was published.¹² A truly international and interdisciplinary team of scholars was involved in this project. They included Soviet neuro- and cultural psychologist Aleksander Luria, the American linguist of Russian origin Roman Jakobson, American psychologist Jerome Bruner, American psychologist of Russian origin Eugenia Hanfmann, American-British poet and translator Gertrude Vakar, and Swiss psychologist Jean Piaget. This diverse team was instrumental in bringing to life the first ever English-language book by Vygotsky: the posthumous collection of Vygotsky's writings entitled *Thinking and speech*, published under the title *Thought and language*, with an Introduction authored by Bruner (Vygotsky, 1962). The book also contained a separate leaflet with a rejoinder to Vygotsky's critique of Piaget's works of 1923–4, entitled *Comments on Vygotsky's critical remarks*, that Piaget wrote for this occasion (Piaget, 1962).¹³ Although a major breakthrough in the history of Vygotsky in the West, this book, however, was not free from serious problems and disadvantages as far as its authenticity and reliability were concerned: in total, due to considerable editorial interventions, the book was 168 pages long, which was roughly half of the 324-page length of the Russian original. Three years later, a paperback version of the book followed. The publication of this book launched an avalanche of other publications of Vygotsky's works, prepared on different occasions and in various editions by a number of the members of the invisible Vygotskian informal network of scholars.

In 1963, in the United Kingdom, Brian and Joan Simon published an edited volume of the works of Soviet psychologists: *Educational psychology in the U.S.S.R.*, translated by Joan Simon. The first chapter of the book was Vygotsky's programmatic paper "Learning and mental development at school age" (Vygotsky, 1963). This chapter presented Vygotsky's views on the interrelations between learning and development, and a lengthy exposition of his idea of the 'zone of potential

development' – the phrasing that had been approved by Luria (J. Simon, 1987) – that from other publications is better known as the 'zone of proximal development'.

In 1965, British journal *Neuropsychologia* (Pergamon Press, Oxford, UK) published two articles with the following editorial introduction signed by "The Editors":

We are publishing in this issue the summary of a paper by the late Professor LEO S. VYGOTSKY, the outstanding Soviet psychologist and one of the founders of contemporary neuropsychology. The paper in full was prepared for the 1st Conference of Psycho-Neurological Sciences held in Kharkov (USSR) in the late summer of 1934. Professor L. S. VYGOTSKY died on June 11, 1934 and his premature death prevented him from presenting this paper. The present summary which he prepared was his last paper and was published only posthumously. Although it was published in Russian more than 30 years ago and some contraversions mentioned in this paper are no longer of urgent importance, the basic ideas of this paper are still of great interest, and will have considerable influence on the further development of neuropsychology.

(Editors, 1965)

Apparently it was Luria, a member of the Board of Editors of the journal, who initiated this publication of Vygotsky's paper of 1934, "Psychology and the localization of functions" (Vygotsky, 1965), along with his own paper with the self-explanatory title "L. S. Vygotsky and the problem of localization of functions" (A. R. Luria, 1965). According to Luria, the investigation of the development of higher psychological functions, their changes in conditions of injury, and their disintegration under brain damage, which Vygotsky started in the 1920s, laid the basis of a new discipline – neuropsychology. Vygotsky's last, posthumously published work presented the fullest program of investigation of the functional organization of the human brain – the organ of human consciousness.

In 1966, the Soviet publishing house Progress Publishers released two volumes with the works of Soviet psychologists translated into English and French. The volumes were not identical and included different sets of papers by different authors. For the benefit of an English-speaking audience interested in the work of Vygotsky, the English volume *Psychological research in the USSR* opened with Vygotsky's text "Development of the higher mental functions" in the translation of D. Myshne (Vygotsky, 1966). Still, the volumes came out in the USSR, and it is unclear how they could have reached the targeted wide international audiences had they not been distributed among the participants in the XVIII International Congress of Psychology held in Moscow same year, in 1966.

In 1967, the journal *Soviet Psychology* under the editorship of Dan Slobin republished the whole Vygotskian memorial issue of the Russian journal *Voprosy Psikhologii* that had come out in the Soviet Union a year before and included papers by members of the Leontiev clan – A. V. Zaporozhetz, P. Ya. Gal'perin, D. B. El'konin, V. V. Davydov, and A. R. Luria. All but Davydov (Gal'perin's and El'konin's student and

co-worker) were Vygotsky's former collaborators and associates.¹⁴ It was in *Soviet Psychology* that Vygotsky's paper "Play and its role in the mental development of the child" first appeared in English (Vygotsky, 1967). The issue contained a preface authored by Jerome Bruner, who argued that Vygotsky's *Thought and language*, which had been published in an "excellent translation" in 1962, had earned him the "admiration of a discriminating group of American readers, but neither created a 'boom', nor produced passionate disciples." However, in his view the importance of Vygotsky for North American scholars was enormous:

Vygotsky's work, completed in the 1930s and extended to our day by his admiring and distinguished students, corresponds to a comparable period in America when more "cognitive psychologists" were struggling against the orthodoxy of mechanistic American behaviorism. Each sought to redress the balance that had tilted psychology toward a simple model of learning based on the conditional reflex – a model given its principal legitimacy by the work of a Russian, Pavlov. Just as cognitive theorists in America sought to free the organism from "push-pull" determination of stimulus-response connections ... so Vygotsky sought to break away from the stimulus-substitution model of conditioning by noting that stimuli took their significance from the linguistic matrix in which they were imbedded.

Finally, after a brief discussion Bruner concluded that Vygotsky became a "seminal ancestor to contemporary cognitive psychology." Therefore, "he is, as such, an important link between Soviet psychology and contemporary American psychology – a link at the cognitive pole, just as Pavlov was at the stimulus-response conditioning pole" (Bruner, 1967, p. 5).

In 1971, the MIT Press published an English translation by Scripta Technica, Inc. of Vygotsky's *The psychology of art* (Vygotsky, 1971) that had been first published in Russian under the editorship of Vyacheslav Vs. Ivanov shortly before, in 1965 and a second, revised edition in 1968. Based on a typescript from 1925, which, according to the editor of the book, "Vygotsky himself prepared for publication" (Ivanov, 1968, p. 503), it was a small miracle that this book was published in English.

In 1974, another translation of Vygotsky's work came out in English, but this publication was titled *Vygotsky's view about the age periodization of child development* and appeared under the names of the two translators, Mary Ann and Bryce F. Zender. The latter later served as the editor and translator of the book *Computers and education in the Soviet Union* (B. F. Zender, 1975) and both disguised Vygotsky's paper that had come out in the leading Russian psychological journal *Voprosy Psikhologii* just two years before and "smuggled" it into the journal *Human Development* as their own paper on age periodization in Vygotsky's theory (M. A. Zender & Zender, 1974).¹⁵

In 1976, Jerome Bruner and his associates republished Vygotsky's paper "Play and its role in the mental development of the child" in their thematic reader on play whose title bore a close resemblance to Vygotsky's paper title, and directly hinted at

the problems covered in Vygotsky's original presentation of 1933 – *Play: Its role in development and evolution* (Vygotsky, 1976).

In the late 1970s, three other Vygotsky works were published in *Soviet Psychology* under the editorship of Michael Cole (journal editor 1969–2002): “The development of higher psychological functions” (1977), “The development of higher forms of attention in childhood” (1979), and “Consciousness as a problem in the psychology of behavior” (1979).¹⁶ In addition, at the same time, two volumes were published by M. E. Sharpe, Inc.: *Soviet developmental psychology: An anthology*, edited by Michael Cole (1977), and *The concept of activity in Soviet psychology* (editions of 1979 and 1981), edited by James V. Wertsch, a Ph.D. graduate (in 1975) from the University of Chicago. Wertsch spent a year as a postdoctoral fellow in Moscow, where he studied linguistics and neuropsychology (Wertsch, 1981a). The former volume contained a collection of papers on various topics in developmental psychology published in the journal *Soviet Psychology* over the fifteen years of its existence, including a slightly edited text of the 1967 publication of Vygotsky's “Play and its role in the mental development of the child,” which became the third publication of this paper over roughly a decade (Vygotsky, 1977). The volume *The concept of activity in Soviet psychology*, in contrast, presented a set of articles previously unpublished in English, particularly, three newly translated works by Vygotsky: “The instrumental method in psychology,” “The genesis of higher mental functions,” and “The development of higher forms of attention in childhood,” all three translated on the basis of the texts that came out in the Soviet volumes of 1956 and 1960. The whole volume was preceded by a preface written by Cole and an introductory chapter, “The concept of activity in Soviet psychology,” authored by Wertsch. Quite characteristically, the whole set of papers was selected and presented in order to demonstrate the existence of so-called ‘activity theory’, a phrase that actually never occurred in Vygotsky's original writings. Thus, Vygotsky's three works, as well as his overall scholarship, were recast from the perspective of ‘activity theory’, which was presented here as the most direct and only development of Vygotsky's scholarship. In his introductory chapter Wertsch clarified that

the volume focuses on what is probably the most important concept in Soviet psychology – the concept of activity [deyatel'nost']. It attempts to elucidate the crucial features of one theoretical framework that has been built around this concept by illustrating how each of these features is used in one or more contributions selected for translation.

(Wertsch, 1981b, p. 6)

And yet, as in the mid-1960s when Jerome Bruner regretted that notwithstanding the recent publication of Vygotsky's *Thought and speech* a ‘Vygotsky boom’ was not apparent, the 1970s did not bring about the large-scale change so much desired by the “discriminating group” of American admirers of Vygotsky's work. A dramatic change in the popularity of Vygotsky only took place by the end of the

1970s. Two events were instrumental in this truly paradigmatic shift that, ultimately, led to the ‘boom’ or, in other words, the cult of Vygotsky in the West.

The first event was the publication of yet another volume of Vygotsky’s works. Generally, the beginning of the work on this publication dates back to the year of 1962–3 when Michael Cole pursued his postdoctoral research in Moscow with Luria, who asked his American postdoc student to help him with the English-language publication of the manuscripts of two of Vygotsky’s works. Cole enlisted the help of his colleagues Vera John-Steiner and Sylvia Scribner, who were to help him with the translation of Vygotsky’s and some of Luria’s works, including the latter’s autobiography that eventually came out as a book chapter and as an independent book in 1974 and 1979, respectively. As to Vygotsky’s texts, the work on these did not start until the 1970s. This is how Cole described this project in his recently published memoirs:

I received the Vygotsky manuscripts from Luria in early 1970s. But even with the expert help of able colleagues and a good translation to work from, I could not convince the publisher, with whom Luria had made arrangements, that the manuscripts were worth publishing. All of the problems that I had experienced earlier remained in place. The work seemed dated, the polemics either opaque or outdated, and the overall product was certain to produce fiscal disaster, not to say personal embarrassment. Faced with this seemingly insurmountable barrier and with help from Luria, whom I visited every year or two and with whom I corresponded regularly, we were able to produce a reasonable selection of readings from the two manuscripts he had given me. To these we added several essays of an applied nature so that readers could see how the abstract theoretical argument played out in practice. The result, entitled *Mind in society*, was published in 1978. I heaved a great sigh of relief: I had finally discharged my obligation to Luria and the publisher, thanks in good measure to the hard work of my colleagues.

(Cole, 2004, pp. x–xi)

In the Introduction, the editors provided some details about the nature of their work on the book. According to the editors’ written statement, Luria provided them with rough translations of two of Vygotsky’s works, the previously unpublished “Tool and symbol in children’s development” and “The history of the development of higher psychological functions” that came out in a Russian volume of Vygotsky’s selected works in 1960. Then, the editors confessed that they “have constructed the first four chapters of this volume from ‘Tool and Symbol’”; then chapter 5 “was taken from section 3” of the other manuscript that they received from Luria; chapters 6 and 8 were borrowed from Vygotsky’s posthumously published essays of different periods;¹⁷ and, finally, chapter 7 was based on a lecture on play of 1933 that first came out in the Soviet Union in the memorial Vygotskian issue of the Russian journal *Voprosy Psikhologii*, which, in fact, became the fourth publication of this paper in English and made it the most frequently republished text of Vygotsky’s to date.

Further, the editors – Michael Cole, Vera John-Steiner, Sylvia Scribner, and Ellen Souberman – in their Introduction to the book confessed that while preparing the materials for publication they took “significant liberties” with respect to Vygotsky’s original text:

At several places we have inserted material from additional sources in order to more fully explicate the meaning of the text. ... In a few cases passages have been taken from the work of Vygotsky’s students or collaborators which provide concrete examples of experimental procedures or results which the original text describes with extreme brevity. ... The reader will encounter here not a literal translation of Vygotsky but rather our edited translation of Vygotsky, from which we have omitted material that seemed redundant and to which we have added material that seemed to make the points clearer. ... Because proper references were rarely given [in Vygotsky’s original manuscripts], we have supplied our best guess as to the exact sources to which Vygotsky referred. ... We realize that in tampering with the original we may have distorted history; however, we hope that by stating our procedures and by adhering as closely as possible to the principles and content of the work, we have not distorted Vygotsky’s meaning.

(Cole, John-Steiner, Scribner, & Souberman, 1978, p. x)

Thus, as an outcome of all this editorial work the book *Mind in society* came out under Vygotsky’s name (Vygotsky, 1978) and, according to Cole’s memoirs of 2004, at the time of its publication it did not promise much of commercial success or reputational gains.

The second inaugural event that largely contributed to the advent of the long-awaited ‘Vygotsky boom’ was yet another publication. This was a review of three books – *Mind in society: The development of higher psychological processes* (Harvard University Press, 1978), Vygotsky’s *The psychology of art* (MIT Press, 1971), and *Soviet developmental psychology: An anthology* (M. E. Sharpe, 1979) – by the well-known British philosopher Stephen Toulmin for the prestigious *New York Review of Books*, a magazine written by and for intellectuals (Toulmin, 1978). It is not altogether surprising that Toulmin dedicated his review to two books that bore the name of Vygotsky on their covers and another book that included a chapter by Vygotsky. In earlier reviews for this magazine, published in 1968 and 1971, Toulmin had already mentioned Lev Vygotsky and, for that matter, his closest associate and collaborator, Alexander Luria (Toulmin, 1968, 1971). In a footnote to his article of 1978, Toulmin specifically mentioned that he originally encountered Vygotsky’s and Luria’s work through neurologist and neuropsychologist Norman Geschwind, a Harvard scholar like two other Western admirers of Vygotsky, namely Roman Jakobson and Jerome Bruner.¹⁸

But it was in this review of 1978 that Toulmin gave a fairly thorough, lengthy, and most laudatory exposition of Vygotsky’s and Luria’s ideas and scientific legacy. By his own admission, “the central figure of this story is Lev Semyonovich Vygotsky,”

who received from Toulmin the most honorable title of the “Mozart of psychology.” The other protagonist of this story was Luria, a “Beethoven to Vygotsky’s Mozart” and “his most distinguished co-worker ... whose extraordinary range of interests and abilities made him possibly the finest all-round psychologist of the century.” Yet, according to Toulmin, “the wide-ranging intellectual possibilities pursued by Luria, in his own less theoretical ways, from literature across the board to neurophysiology by way of linguistics and educational innovation, had all been initially suggested in discussions with Vygotsky and his associates during the years around 1930.”

The exposition of Vygotsky’s and Luria’s ideas gave Toulmin an opportunity to reflect on the state of the art in American psychology and, more broadly, American behavioral sciences. In his review, Toulmin took the position of an external observer and, from this position, he overviewed contemporary psychology in its North American variation:

If we take the view from Moscow, American psychology appears excessively fragmented, as well as being divided along outdated ideological lines. A vast amount of busy research has gone on in the US during the last fifty years, in dozens of different branches of psychology, neurology, linguistics, and educational innovation. But no common theoretical picture has been developed capable of integrating all their results. The different branches have, thus, also been separate branches. Given the positivist conceptions about “scientific method” dominant in American psychology, the behavioral sciences have proliferated into dozens of highly specialized, and largely noninteracting, subdisciplines: so behavioral scientists have organized their research on the principle that the more narrowly and sharply defined a question can be, the more “scientific” it is.

[Continued in Toulmin’s footnote 11:] Positivism has also impoverished the practice of experimentation in American psychology. In physics and biology, many striking experiments aim simply at checking out the qualitative effects or relationships suggested by some novel theoretical analysis. Behavioral scientists in the United States rarely allow themselves the luxury of such revealing experiments. Instead, they see their empirical task as the pursuit of statistical correlations between the numerical values of “quantifiable” variables.

Toulmin continued his critique and at the same time hinted at a way out of the lamentable situation in which he believed American psychology was. He suggested that the solution is in the integrative human science:

Nobody in the American behavioral sciences has, it seems, the breadth of experience or general standing needed in order to do the *integrative* thinking typical of Luria or Vygotsky. Nobody in the West, for instance, experiments and writes with equal authority – as Luria did – on such diverse topics as the syndromes of aphasia, cross-cultural differences in reasoning patterns, intellectual development in identical twins, and the performances of calculating

prodigies. Few American psychologists, indeed, would even think it worth *trying* to do so.

(Toulmin, 1978)

Toulmin claimed that much of Soviet psychology was of a “cultural-historical” theoretical orientation and that this consistently socio-cultural and developmental orientation was from the onset profoundly influenced by Marxian historical thinking, which enabled Soviet scholars to achieve the high level of interdisciplinary collaboration and intellectual integration that their science demonstrated.¹⁹ Thus, Marxism – dialectical and historical materialism – for Toulmin was primarily a powerful philosophical movement of enormous potential for the development of integrative human sciences that Vygotsky was particularly well aware of:

[L]eaving all political issues aside, the general frame provided by a “historical materialist” philosophy gave him the basis he needed for developing an integrated account of the relations between developmental psychology and clinical neurology, cultural anthropology and the psychology of art – an account that we in the West can afford to take very seriously today.

(Toulmin, 1978)

In conclusion, Toulmin cited the first editor of Vygotsky’s *Psychology of art* (1965), the renowned linguist, Indo-Europeanist, and semiotician Vyacheslav Ivanov, who in his concluding postscript to the volume, remarked that Vygotsky indicated the way to unify biological and social studies and proposed that continuation of Vygotsky’s line of research might be no less significant for science than the deciphering of the genetic code.²⁰

With these programmatic statements Toulmin concluded his review. It is hard to evaluate the relative weight of each and every component of the whole that contributed to the ultimate success of Vygotskian psychology in North America, but what is clear is that following the publication of *Mind in society* and Toulmin’s highly favorable book review from the early 1980s Vygotsky’s popularity in the Western world radically changed. One way or another, two translated, considerably abbreviated, and heavily edited texts, *Thought and language* and *Mind in society* – neither of which he actually wrote in the form they were published in the United States in 1962 and 1978,²¹ respectively – gradually became Vygotsky’s most-cited publications and eventually turned into international bestsellers. Thus, these two events of 1978 – the release of *Mind in society* and the publication of Toulmin’s book review – launched the ‘Vygotsky boom’ that Jerome Bruner already hopefully announced in 1967.

The first wave of the boom of the early 1980s was instrumental in the launch of the first major translated edition of Vygotsky’s collected writings – the six-volume *Collected works of L. S. Vygotsky* published by Plenum Press (eventually sold to Springer Publishers) from 1987 to 1999. This edition remains not just the largest, but arguably the most questionable and unreliable edition of Vygotsky ever published

in English. The subsequent section discusses the problems of translating Vygotsky and illustrates them using the materials abundantly supplied by these *Collected works*.

Typology of Vygotsky's texts and sources of error

What we learn from the history of the 'transnational' and 'exported Vygotsky' is that all the majority knows about this thinker and author is due to available translations and that these translations and publication were all made in a specific context and for specific purposes. As we are reminded by Pierre Bourdieu, whose words are quoted at the beginning of this chapter, as far as translation and transfer of scholarly works is concerned,

it is obvious that there will always be some sort of profit involved. Heretical imports are often the work of marginals in the field, bringing a message, a position of force from a different field, which they use to try and shore up their own position. Foreign writers are often subject to such instrumental use, and forced to serve purposes which they would perhaps refuse or reject in their country of origin.

(Bourdieu, 1999, p. 223)

In other words, a certain amount of 'intellectual violence' and distortion of the author's original ideas – imported to the new social milieu and assimilated there – seems to be the norm rather than an exception; it forms part and parcel of the whole process of transnational and transcultural intellectual exchange. So, distortions of this kind are related to the social positioning of ideas and should not be blamed too much, although they must be carefully monitored. However, there is another danger of intellectual distortion that takes place in the process of knowledge migration, and it is most directly related to those errors and losses of translation that can hardly be forgiven or legitimized. These we are going to discuss in some detail below. In what follows we shall give a brief and incomplete characterization of the currently available translations of Vygotsky's texts and indicate problems that remain to be solved. We shall conclude with a proposal as to how to solve these problems – if not in the presently available, already published texts, then in future translations.

It is important to realize that in translating a historical author there are multiple sources of error and that in the case of Vygotsky the situation was aggravated for ideological or political reasons. The potential sources of error or distortion can be illustrated as displayed in Table 7.1, which shows that there are multiple sources of error. As one can see in Table 7.1, first, a publication may be based on an unpublished manuscript – either prepared for publication or unfinished, abandoned and not considered as publishable by its author – or published articles, or a mixture of both. Second, this publication may be republished one or more times – during the author's lifetime and under her authorization, or posthumously and in a state that the author would hardly approve of had she survived until the date of publication. Third, the text may be translated into another language. Last, a translation can serve

TABLE 7.1 Typology of Vygotsky's texts and translations

Unpublished	Manuscripts, personal notes, paper drafts, future plans, unfinished manuscripts, typewritten stenograms of lectures and public oral presentations, students' notes, etc.
Published by Vygotsky	Scholarly books and articles, book (and theatrical) reviews, conference proceedings, undergraduate textbooks and teaching materials, administrative publications, etc.
Published posthumously	Edited volumes of collected works, journal publications published in the USSR from mid-1930s to 1980s
Translated	Translations into English
Retranslated	'Second-degree' translations

as the source for yet a further translation. All these transitions from one form to another are potential sources of error. In case something goes wrong in the transition from manuscript to book we are mostly helpless, because manuscripts may no longer exist or be accessible. Also, it will be difficult to assess whether changes in the text were part of the normal editorial process or introduced without the consent of the author. However, when books are based on earlier publications we have in principle a possibility of judging the reliability of the book text. That is, although the transition from published article to a book volume forms a potential source of error, it at the same time gives us a means to check the reliability of the final product.

Thus, our ability to verify and potentially correct a translated or republished text depends largely on the availability of original texts. Some of those have relatively recently been republished in the original and undistorted form, that is, allegedly exactly the way they were released – or were planned to be released – by the author (Vygotskii, 1999, 2008). Even more importantly, the miracle of the twenty-first century, the contemporary technologies of the Internet and the so-called Web 2.0, have revolutionized the process of information distribution and scientific publication, and quite a few of the original Vygotsky texts, including the scans of original publications and facsimile editions of the inter-war period (for instance, the original edition of *Thinking and speech* of 1934 as well as other books and various journal publications of the 1920s–30s), are nowadays freely available for downloading. We know about several specialized Russian and international websites with enormous repositories of information and are confident in claiming that this is a rapidly and steadily growing trend in twenty-first-century publishing.

Types of error

To illustrate what was said above, a number of examples of errors in the English translations of Vygotsky's texts will now be given. These errors were detected as early as the 1980s and 1990s and were revealed by a number of researchers using

the means indicated above, that is, comparing publications with the original articles, manuscripts, or books wherever that proved possible. These authors include Brushlinskii (1996), Etkind (1993), Tkachenko (1983), Tulviste (1987), Mecacci (1990), Van der Veer (1987, 1992, 1997, 1998), and Van der Veer and Valsiner (1991). Access to the previously published texts and the ‘archival revolution’ in Vygotskian studies is a precondition of any progress in this respect (Yasnitsky, 2010a). Fortunately, many exciting new opportunities opened up after the series of recent publications uncovering Vygotsky’s private archives (Zavershneva, 2010a, 2010b, 2010c, 2012a, 2013). Thus, we have most recently witnessed a new wave of critical studies devoted to the textological analysis of Vygotsky’s publications (Gillen, 2000; Keiler, 2012; Kellogg, 2011a, 2011b; Kellogg & Yasnitsky, 2011; Mecacci & Yasnitsky, 2011; R. Miller, 2011; Yasnitsky, 2011b, 2011d; Zavershneva & Osipov, 2012a, 2012b) that reveal quite a number of distortions in the Russian texts of the posthumous Soviet editions of Vygotsky. Many of the inadequacies of the English translations go back to inadequacies in these Soviet editions, but translators inevitably added their own share. For clarity’s sake, these errors have been divided into a number of subcategories, such as:

- (1) inaccuracies
- (2) suppression of terms or passages
- (3) suppression of names
- (4) unidentified or suppressed citations
- (5) insertions
- (6) multiple retranslations.

Inaccuracies

Under the heading of ‘inaccuracies’ are included all those changes of the original texts that were unintended or intended with the idea of ‘clarifying’ Vygotsky’s ideas or making him more palatable to contemporary taste. As such they differ from deliberate attempts to falsify the texts as discussed below, although the difference is sometimes small (e.g. the case of Kolbanovskii). As examples of inaccurate efforts to present Vygotsky’s texts, we would first like to mention the abridged versions of *Thinking and speech* (Vygotsky, 1962, 1986) and the compilation of texts in Vygotsky 1978.

That Vygotsky 1962 is unacceptable as a translation has been observed by many and hardly needs arguing. Suffice it to say that the whole book contains a meager 168 pages as compared to the 324 pages of the original. However, as has been argued before (Van der Veer, 1987), Vygotsky 1986 is also unacceptable. As a whole, the 1986 translation of *Thinking and speech* is incomparably better and much more complete than the 1962 edition, yet the translator has “departed from Vygotsky’s text when it repeats itself” and retained large parts of the 1962 translation. The result is that the book still contains many errors and that various phrases and passages have not been translated. Vygotsky’s quotation on the final page of his book from *The German ideology*, for example, has been left unidentified and is rendered very

incomplete (Van der Veer, 1987). Thus, we argue that both translations (Vygotsky, 1962, 1986) are abridged and as such unfit for genuine scientific study.

We know of only one edition that qualifies as a compilation and that is the previously mentioned *Mind in society* (Vygotsky, 1978). This book has enjoyed immense popularity among psychologists interested in cultural-historical theory and it served a very positive role in introducing American readers to Vygotsky's thinking. However, from a historical point of view, it is a very unsatisfactory book. Above we mentioned that the editors "summarized" major theoretical points and "inserted material from additional sources." However, on the basis of the editors' explanation, it proved impossible to identify the historical texts that lie behind the final result. The editors merged several texts by Vygotsky and his collaborators into a coherent and readable whole but failed to do this in a transparent and reproducible way. To consider the result as Vygotsky's text would be incorrect. *Mind in society* thus violates the principle that states that texts of historical authors should be translated in their entirety or, if only excerpts are published, that it should be clearly indicated which parts are left out, where the author's text ends and the text of others begins, and so on.

Under the heading of inaccuracies, we would further like to discuss the need for accurate annotations of the translated texts. Here there is no shortage of examples. The Plenum edition, for example, with the exception of volume 3, is very poorly annotated. Authors are left unidentified, citations are not traced to the original source, scientific terms that have gone out of fashion are not explained, etc. Of course, authoritative translations of historical texts become much more useful if they are properly annotated. That the writing of such notes requires a considerable amount of work and historical knowledge should not prevent us from trying to reach the level of work reached in, say, the Standard Edition of Freud's writings.

Finally, added to the abridged versions, compilations, and inadequate annotations, there are simple translation errors of words, passages, and names.

The fact that Russian often renders foreign names phonetically, as they are pronounced (by Russians), forms another source of errors. An incomplete list of inadequately transliterated names is shown in Table 7.2. Of course, even a cursory consultation of historical psychology books, encyclopedias, and so on, would have prevented these ludicrous mistakes.

The abridged versions, compilations, and inaccurate translations mentioned above were made with the best of intentions. However, many of the existing English translations are based on Soviet editions of Vygotsky's works that are unreliable for very different reasons.

Suppression of terms or passages

The problem is that all of Vygotsky's works were first published in the Soviet Union, where articles and books were subjected to censorship as a matter of routine. The early and later editors of Vygotsky's books were all acutely aware of this system and in their efforts to get Vygotsky's books published they often preventively adjusted his texts.

TABLE 7.2 Examples of inaccurate names in the Plenum edition

<i>given</i>	<i>correct</i>
Charceau	Charcot
Faininger	Vaihinger
Fasler	Vossler
Gettser	Hetzer
Kompeire	Compayré
Ronget	Ronjat
Shvabskii	Von Schwaben
Zelts	Selz
Zigvart	Sigwart

In this respect, the first editor of *Thinking and speech* (1934a), Kolbanovskii, was probably no exception. Elsewhere (Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991, pp. 256–258), it has been argued that Kolbanovskii may have erased all references to the discipline of pedology, which by that time had come under attack. Thus Kolbanovskii, who edited the whole book series, persuaded Vygotsky to give his book the subtitle *Psychological investigations* and probably replaced the terms ‘school pedology’ and ‘pedological’ by, respectively, ‘child psychology’ and ‘psychological’ in chapter 6. In later Soviet editions the subtitle was lost.

In the 1956 and 1982 Soviet editions of *Thinking and speech* we can also witness the suppression of unwelcome passages (Mecacci & Yasnitsky, 2011). Thus, in chapter 1 a lengthy reference to and a (not entirely exact) quotation from Sapir’s *Language* (Vygotskii, 1934a, p. 12) have been omitted (they should appear on p. 49 of vol. 1):

In the plane of instinctive consciousness, where perception and affect reign, only contamination is possible, but not understanding and not communication in the proper sense of this word. E. Sapir beautifully explained this in his works on the psychology of speech. “Elementary language,” he says, “must be connected with a whole group, with a specific class of our experience. The world of experience must be extremely simplified and generalized in order to be symbolized. Only in this way communication becomes possible for singular experience lives in a singular consciousness and cannot strictly speaking be communicated. In order to become communicable it must be put in a certain class which by tacit consensus is considered as a unit by the society.” That is why Sapir considers word meaning not as a symbol of singular perception but as a symbol of a concept.

We can only speculate why this passage was removed. Perhaps it was an attempt to make Vygotsky seem more original in the field of linguistics or, alternatively, positive mention of the name of the ‘bourgeois’ or, in Soviet newspeak, ‘reactionary’ (i.e. as opposed to ‘progressive’) researcher Sapir had become unacceptable.

In chapter 2, on the very first page of Vygotsky's discussion of Piaget's theory, a quite substantial passage containing a citation from Piaget has also been removed. The quotation from Piaget was as follows:

We thus believe that the day will come when the thinking of the child with respect to the adult, normal and civilized thinking, will be placed at the same level as the "primitive mentality" defined by Lévy-Bruhl, as the autistic and symbolic thinking described by Freud and his followers, and as the "morbid consciousness", assuming that this concept that we owe to Blondel will not one day merge with the preceding one.

(translation by the present authors from the 1924
French edition of *Piaget's Judgement and reasoning in the child*)

Vygotsky then continued in a passage approximately twice as long as the quotation from Piaget by saying that the significance of Piaget's books is indeed of the same order as those of Blondel, Lévy-Bruhl, and Freud, and that these authors are by their philosophical nature intimately connected. (The whole passage including the extract from Piaget should be inserted on p. 53 of volume 1 of the Plenum edition, after "this old problem.")

Finally, in chapter 5 of *Thinking and speech*, a passage has been removed that ran as follows:

[A]nd the daily change in different forms of behavior, as has been beautifully pointed out by P. P. Blonsky, essentially repeats the millennia-old history of the development of behavior

This passage was most probably removed because it suggested that Vygotsky agreed with some version of the recapitulation thesis, a thesis that had become unacceptable in the Soviet Union by then. (It should be inserted in paragraph 18, p. 160 of volume 1 of the Plenum edition, after "the most ancient.")

This is by no means a complete list of passages that were removed in later Soviet editions but it suffices to make the point that translations based upon them, such as Rieber & Carton (1987), are highly unreliable.

However, the problem of suppressed terms or passages is not restricted to *Thinking and speech*. Thus, in volume 3 of the Plenum edition, on the penultimate page of *The historical meaning of the crisis in psychology: A methodological investigation* (p. 342), it is said that "The new society will create the new man." This seems a rather plausible sentence, but Tkachenko (1983) has convincingly argued that the original manuscript of *The crisis* contained the phrase "The new society will create a superman" (see also Zavershneva, 2012b; Zavershneva & Osipov, 2012a, 2012b). The term 'superman' has, of course, acquired a rather negative connotation since the Nazi period, which may have been the reason why Soviet editors replaced this term (but see below).

Volume 2 of the Plenum edition (Rieber & Carton, 1993) is not free from problems either. It has been shown, using the original chapter from 1928, that the chapter “The dynamics of child character” originally contained two positive pages and three positive passages about Alfred Adler that have been removed in subsequent Soviet editions of his work (Brushlinskii, 1996). The passages were as follows:

Adler’s theory is often connected – especially in circles of German and Austrian social-democrats – with Marx’s theory [to be inserted on p. 162 of volume 2 of the Plenum edition].

A. Adler’s theory, in particular his theory about character is “a truly revolutionary characterological current”, as A. Zalkind rightly points out [to be inserted in paragraph 2 of the same chapter].

None of the contemporary psychological ideas has such enormous significance for pedagogues, for the theory and practice of education, as this idea of Adler [to be inserted in paragraph 5 of the same chapter].

These passages show Vygotsky referring positively to Adler’s ideas, which was to be expected in that period of his career. Elsewhere (Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991) it has been shown that Vygotsky went through a period of deep enthusiasm for Adlerian theory. Again, we can only guess why these passages were removed. The fact that Adler was a ‘bourgeois’, the fact that he was a former psychoanalytic theorist, the fact that ‘social democrats’ linked his work to Marx, the fact that Vygotsky called his theory ‘revolutionary’ (whereas only Russian Marxist ideas could be truly revolutionary), and an attempt to make Vygotsky seem more original, may all have played a role (cf. Van der Veer, 2000a).

Vygotsky’s *Educational psychology* (1997a) is likewise marred by suppressed passages. Elsewhere, it has been shown that, among other things, three lines of a Blonsky quotation on p. 4, twenty-three lines of a Sherrington quotation on p. 35, and sixty lines on p. 335 were omitted in the English translation (Van der Veer, 1998).

Again, this list of suppressed terms and passages is far from exhaustive but hopefully the point has been made. English translations of Soviet re-editions of Vygotsky’s work are liable to suppressions of substantial passages of the original text. None of the existing Soviet post-World War II editions can thus play a role in the serious scientific study of Vygotsky’s writings.

Suppression of names

It will come as no surprise that author names as well have disappeared in Soviet republications of Vygotsky’s work and its translations into English. Kolbanovskii may have been the first to use this method: In chapter 5 of the 1934 edition of *Thinking and speech* the German psychologist Felix Krueger (cf. Valsiner & Van der Veer, 2000) has become “one of the contemporary authors.” But there are many more examples. In the above-mentioned chapter, “The dynamics of child character,”

Adler's name was deleted various times, as were the names of Lévy-Bruhl, Blondel, and Freud in the second chapter of later editions of *Thinking and speech*. In volume 3 of the Plenum edition, chapter 3 ends with a footnote in which Vygotsky claims that Watson and Lashley had arrived at similar conclusions to him. This footnote was missing in previous Soviet editions and was reintroduced by the translator. Finally, a most interesting suppression of a name occurs in that same volume 3. On p. 120, Vygotsky mentions "several of Freud's critics who are inclined to ..." However, it has been discovered that the original text from 1930 ran "several of Freud's critics (such as Voloshinov) who are inclined to ..." This omission is theoretically most interesting because Voloshinov belonged to the circle of Bakhtin, and theorists have debated the issue as to whether Vygotsky and Bakhtin knew of each other's work.

Unidentified or suppressed citations

We have mentioned above a lengthy passage from Sapir's *Language* that was deleted from Vygotsky's *Thinking and speech*. This was a clear case of a citation that was removed. It has been claimed that Vygotsky's *The psychology of art* contained several citations from Trotsky that have been removed as well. Other citations in other books have become hard to identify because the quotation marks were removed. We have already mentioned the quotation from *The German ideology* on the final page of *Thinking and speech*. Etkind (1993) has pointed out that Vygotsky ended his *Educational psychology* with a long citation from Trotsky. In effect, the entire last page of his book and part of the penultimate page, that is, pp. 350 and 351 from Vygotsky (1997a), starting from "Alongside technology," were borrowed from Trotsky. Likewise, the final page of *The crisis* contains a quotation from Trotsky. That implies that the last four lines on p. 342 of volume 3 of the Plenum edition are Trotsky's and that the aforementioned reference to a "superman" was actually Trotsky's (cf. Rieber & Wollock, 1997). Recent publications by Zavershneva have confirmed these suspicions (Zavershneva, 2012; Zavershneva & Osipov, 2012a, 2012b).

It is most probable that many more of these hidden citations will be identified in the future. Again, in many cases one can only guess as to the reasons for removing the quotation marks or the citations as a whole. The case of Trotsky is simple: political reasons prohibited mentioning his name or quoting his writings, but other cases are less obvious. One wonders whether editors simply removed quotation marks because they were unable to identify the author of the citations. That would be one way to 'solve' a time-consuming historical problem.

Insertions

That Soviet or English editors would make cuts in a historical text is deplorable but to some degree expectable. That they would go as far as to introduce text fragments ('foreign bodies') into Vygotsky's text seems unlikely. Yet this is precisely what happened on several occasions.

Relatively inoffensive minor insertions can be seen in Vygotsky (1997a). The editors or translator have changed, for example, “Lange” into “the Danish psychologist Lange” and “Blonskii” into “Pavel Petrovich Blonskii, the Soviet psychologist and educational reformer.” Such insertions are deplorable, not only because they introduce an additional source of error (e.g. Lange was a physiologist and not a psychologist) and confusion (Vygotsky would never have referred to his colleague Blonskii in this way) but also because it becomes impossible to discern where Vygotsky ends and the editor or translator begins. As has been argued elsewhere (Van der Veer, 1997), in the restoration of old paintings it has become customary to ensure that any changes are recognizable as such and are reversible. In dealing with historical texts we should follow that principle as well.

Simply outrageous insertions have been documented for the above-mentioned chapter “The dynamics of child character.” This chapter, which was originally published in a 1928 book, not only suffers from numerous suppressions but contains insertions as well. For example, two text fragments from the same 1928 book, but authored by Zalkind, have been inserted into Vygotsky’s text. In the Plenum edition these passages run as follows:

Kretschmer’s scheme does not work for the division of characterological traits by age. None of this, however, prohibits us from attempting to elucidate the prevailing predominant specific content of each stage in development. This specific content, not now taken into consideration by any of the existing characterological systems, undergoes extraordinary changes under environmental influences. This is why it is dangerous to attach rigid ‘labels’ to any systems *in the given state of science* [to be removed from p. 154 of volume 3 of the Plenum edition].

Adler’s basic philosophical positions are distorted by metaphysical elements. The characterological interest is limited to Adler’s practice [to be removed from p. 156 of volume 3 of the Plenum edition].

These insertions hardly need comment. Apparently, anonymous editors found it necessary to ‘clarify’ the right position as to Adler’s work. That one had to ‘enrich’ Vygotsky’s text to achieve that goal and thus was effectively rewriting history mattered little. The whole process of deleting and inserting passages in psychological texts is reminiscent of the well-known Soviet practices of removing a *persona non grata* (e.g. Trotsky) from repeatedly published photographs and of adding an imaginary glorious military past to the biography of several of its rulers.

Multiple retranslations

It can be argued that providing a definitive translation of an original source is impossible and that each translation is an act of re-creation of the original text using the language and concepts available at the time of translating. For this reason the

novels belonging to the canon of the world literature must be translated anew every twenty or thirty years. After such a period the old translation seems hopelessly obsolete. In a sense, then, translating a text is like remembering an event: the historical event certainly took place as a concrete reality but is each time reconstructed and related differently, depending on the condition, mood, and age of the protagonist. But if the translation of original sources is complex, this certainly holds even more for translating translations. For this reason the authors share a firm belief in the commandment: thou shalt not translate unless from the original. And yet, we are aware of several instances of published translations of Vygotsky's texts that were not made from the original Russian. Unlike 'first-degree murder', which is a premeditated and deliberate crime, such 'second-degree translation' is relatively innocent and sometimes involuntary, but equally a profound and unforgivable destruction of the original meaning of the text, fully grounded in the translator's *interpretation* of what another translator *believed* the original text might have meant. For the sake of illustration, let us consider the most outrageous and at the same time the most hilarious example of a 'second-degree translation' that the history of the alleged Vygotskian legacy has to offer to date.

Briefly, the story goes like this:

Sometime around 1930, Vygotsky and Luria produced the Russian manuscript *Orudie i znak* (half a dozen variations of the title are known) that was to come out in English translation as *Tool and sign* in a volume on developmental psychology in the United States. For some reason this chapter was not included in the book, and we know nothing about it until the late 1960s/early 1970s, when it re-emerged from behind the Iron Curtain as a typewritten English text that Luria handed over to his former postdoc student Michael Cole for publication in the West. Reluctant to publish the text 'as is', Cole and his colleagues made some fragmentary use of it in the process of creating their cut-and-paste version of Vygotsky that subsequently came out between the covers of *Mind in society* in 1978 (see above). In 1984, an apparently complete version of this text came out in Russian in the six-volume collection of Vygotsky's works (Vygotskii, 1984). Subsequently, in 1994, Luria's English typescript was fully published as a chapter in *The Vygotsky reader* (1994) that came out under the editorship of Van der Veer and Valsiner, who were the first to compare the Russian version of the text of 1984 and Luria's typescript. The comparison revealed an extremely curious feature of the Russian version: first, it missed several important pieces (such as illustrations) but was nevertheless longer, and, second, it contained a number of non-verbatim – but semantically identical – repetitions of text fragments! The editors referred to rumors that the Russian text, as strange as it might look, was in fact translated from English, which still hardly explained the repetitions. No plausible rational explanation was offered at that time, and the whole issue remained a mystery until quite recently.

In 2005, a former student of Alexander Luria's and a prominent neuroscientist and medical doctor, Elkhonon Goldberg, published *The wisdom paradox: How your mind can grow stronger as your brain grows older*, in which he confessed to having participated in what he referred to as a "benign forgery" of Vygotsky's text (Goldberg,

2005). According to Goldberg, it was in the late 1960s that Luria summoned him, when still a university student, and invited him to participate in the preparation of the collected works of Vygotsky. He was told that the Russian manuscript of *Tool and sign* was not preserved – or had not yet been discovered in the archives – and, to Goldberg’s astonishment, Luria invited him to make a Russian translation from the English translation. Apparently, this English translation survived and was subsequently handed over by Luria to Cole, and then, by the latter, to Van der Veer and Valsiner. So, this account by Goldberg confirmed the old rumors that the 1984 Russian text was based on an English manuscript. However, it could not explain the curious repetitions of text fragments in slightly different wordings. To explain that phenomenon one has to know that there actually was a *second* translator who partially translated the same passages. We do not yet know with certainty who that person was but we now understand the repetitions: the work of two (or more) English–Russian translators was uncritically and very unprofessionally inserted in different places in the Russian version of the text. Responsible for this tinkering with a historical text was the editor and censor of the volume, the renowned (some would say, notorious) Soviet psychologist and historian of psychology, Mikhail Yaroshevskii (see discussion in a series of thematic publications by Cole, 2012; Goldberg, 2012; Van der Veer, 2012; Yasnitsky, 2012f).

And yet, the most entertaining and outrageously hilarious – or hilariously outrageous – part of the story, its coda, is still waiting for us. Thus, in 1999, the last volume that concluded the six-volume collection of Vygotsky’s works in English was released. This very volume contained the text *Tool and sign in the development of the child*, the ‘third-degree translation’ into English of Vygotsky’s and Luria’s work (see Table 7.3).

In sum, the presumably lost original Russian text was translated into English, then re-translated into Russian, and then again translated into English, which means that no fewer than four versions of the same text may exist. For illustrative purposes, a fragment of this text was previously discussed in one of our earlier studies and analysed for Russian–English parallels and inconsistencies (Yasnitsky, 2011b, 2011d, 2012g). What we offer here is the comparison of these parallel places in different versions of the English texts, that is, in ‘first-’ and ‘third-degree translations’ published in 1994 and 1999, respectively (see Table 7.4).

An in-depth comparative analysis of semantic and stylistic characteristics of the three versions of seemingly the same – but not literally the same – text is beyond the scope of this discussion. Readers are invited to enjoy the English–English comparison, and experienced translators and bilingual specialists are welcome to further explore the similarities and discrepancies in these three variations (two in English and one in Russian) of Vygotsky’s and Luria’s work. For our present discussion, though, it suffices to note that despite quite remarkable similarities between the two variants of the edition of 1999 (see second and third columns of Table 7.3) – which we attribute to the translator’s (Marie J. Hall) possible familiarity with Van der Veer and Valsiner’s publication of 1994 and their commentaries on the text – several discrepancies are still quite notable and appear to contribute

TABLE 7.3 Four versions of *Orudie i znak* (*Tool and sign*)

<i>Text version</i>	<i>Title</i>	<i>Language</i>	<i>Publication</i>
'Original'	<i>Orudie i znak</i> [Tool and sign]	Russian	Manuscript, lost
'First-degree translation'	<i>Tool and symbol in child development</i>	English	1978 (partly); 1994
'Second-degree translation'	<i>Orudie i znak v razvitii rebenka</i> [Tool and sign in the development of the child]	Russian	1984
'Third-degree translation'	<i>Tool and sign in the development of the child</i>	English	1999

TABLE 7.4 Three versions of the same text as presented in editions of 1994 ('first-degree translation') and 1999 ('third-degree translation')

'First-degree translation': Tool and symbol in child development, 1994, pp. 151–152	'Third-degree translation': Tool and sign in the development of the child, 1999, chapter 1, p. 9 translator A	'Third-degree translation': Tool and sign in the development of the child, 1999, chapter 4, p. 52 translator B
1. Experiments show that both in play and in speech the child is far from consciously realizing the relativity of the sign operation or of the arbitrarily established connection of sign and meaning.	Experiments show that in play and in speech, consciousness of conditionality, of the arbitrariness of uniting sign and meaning, is foreign to the child.	Experiments show that in play and speech, the child is far from recognizing the arbitrariness of the sign operation and is far from recognizing the voluntarily established connection between the sign and the meaning.
2. In order to become an object's (word's) sign, the stimulus finds support in the properties of the designated object itself.	In order to be a sign for a thing, a word must be supported by the properties of the thing signified.	In order to become a sign of a thing (word), the stimulus must be supported by the qualities of the object itself that is denoted.
3. Not 'everything can represent everything' for the child in this game.	Not "everything can be anything" in the child's play.	Not all things are equally important for the child in such play.
4. The objects' real properties and their sign meanings come into complex structural interaction during play.	In play, real properties of the thing and its symbolic significance exhibit a complex structural interaction.	The real qualities of the object and their sign meaning enter into complex structural interrelations in the play.

TABLE 7.4 (*cont.*)

'First-degree translation': Tool and symbol in child development, 1994, pp. 151–152	'Third-degree translation': Tool and sign in the development of the child, 1999, chapter 1, p. 9 <i>translator A</i>	'Third-degree translation': Tool and sign in the development of the child, 1999, chapter 4, p. 52 <i>translator B</i>
5. Thus, for the child, the word is linked to the object through the latter's properties and is incorporated in one structure, common to it.	In the same way, for the child, the word is coupled with the thing through its properties and is interwoven in their general structure.	Thus, for the child, the word is [p. 565] connected with the object through its qualities and included in a common structure with it.
6. That is why the child in our experiments refuses to call the floor a mirror (it cannot walk on a mirror), but has no qualms at [152] transforming a chair into a train, using its properties in play, i.e. manipulating it as if it were a train.	For this reason, in our experiments, the child does not agree that the floor might be called a tumbler ("you could not walk on it"), but he makes a chair a train, changing its properties in the game, that is, treating it as a train.	For this reason, in our experiments, the child does not agree to call the floor a mirror (he cannot walk on a mirror), but converts a chair into a train, which acquires its qualities in his play, that is, he manipulates it as a train.
7. When asked to call a lamp 'table' and vice versa, the child refuses, because one ' can't write on a lamp, or turn on a table '.	The child refuses to change meanings of the words "table" and "lamp" because "you could not write on a lamp and a table would burn ".	The child refuses to call a lamp a table, and vice versa, since "one must not write on a lamp and a table cannot be lit ".
8. To change (or swap) meanings for the child means to change the properties of objects.	For him, to change the name means to change the properties of the thing.	For him, to change the designation means to change the qualities of the thing.

to the aura of a systematically "misunderstood author" that is not infrequently discussed by Vygotsky's numerous admirers and rare critics. Thus, to give just a few examples, we would like to point out that "symbolic significance" is not exactly "sign meaning" and "structural interaction" is not identical with "structural interrelation" (sentence 4); equating a floor with a mirror is quite different from comparing it with a tumbler (sentence 5); similarly, the claims that "a table would burn," "one can't turn on a table," and "a table cannot be lit" are as different as they are confusing (sentence 6). Special mention deserves to be made of sentence 2, in which a substantial terminological mix-up takes place. Thus, according to two versions of the text, a *stimulus* may be a *sign* of an *object* (or a *word*). In contrast, the third version suggests that it is a *word* that might serve as the *object's sign*. The

differences between the two ideas might not be considered as crucial by some, yet they are quite important for our understanding of the author's idea, especially so since the phrase in question addresses the most essential issues of Vygotsky's theory of sign and meaning. What is even more problematic is the fact that this confusion between the four basic terms – *word*, *sign*, *stimulus*, and physical *object* (“thing”) – occurs in the non-verbatim repetitions of the same text fragment created by the two translators of the text and inserted by the editor in chapters one and four: these we can see in the publication of 1999 on pages 9 and 52, respectively. This presents an instance of a contradiction and inconsistency between different parts of the same work of Vygotsky, as we know it in the version of the Plenum edition of 1999.

Conclusion: the “Six Commandments” for the translator

As a summary of the above argument and in order to give an answer to the question “What needs to be done and how?” (cf. Van der Veer & Yasnitsky, 2011), we would like to propose guidelines that might be of help to future translators of Vygotsky's or, for that matter, other international authors' works, and not necessarily from Russian. Thus, translating Vygotsky: how?

(1) *Know thy bias.*

All people believe in something: in Marxism, Communism or socialism; in feminism, social justice, or equality; in family values, careers, and profit; in holism, transnationalism, or integrative science; in cognitivism, behaviorism, or Gestaltism; in tradition, culture, or anti-globalism. Know what you believe in. Realize the limits of your expertise and the extent of your understanding.

Beware of your bias.

(2) *Honor thy author.*

Under no circumstance can you manipulate the original. The author's word and thought is sacred.

Use the most reliable source.

(3) *Thou shalt not testify falsely.*

Tell people exactly what you did: translated, interpreted, or compiled.

Be transparent. If you make changes, additions or insertions, clearly and unambiguously indicate these.

Leave the reader in no doubt as to where the author's words end and additions start. Act like the modern restorer of paintings, who makes sure her additions are both visible and reversible.

(4) *Thou shalt learn and educate.*

Do not assume that you know everything and the reader is perfectly familiar with the context: study the topic, understand it thoroughly, and provide generous comments.

Long live footnotes and square brackets!

(5) *Thou shalt not translate unless from the original.*

Amen.

(6) *Liberate thy mind.*

Be creative and use thy cerebral hemispheres.

The twenty-first century is the era of new technology: remember that.

Bear in mind the exciting new futuristic opportunities such as e-books (or e-translation in general): imagine a translation where you can, with simple clicks, see the original 'behind' the translation as a sort of shadow, see elucidating footnotes, see suppressed or added words, see other renderings of the same text, etc., etc. Colors can, of course, be freely used as well; notes in the margin, clickable references to other texts. World Wide Web rules! All these possibilities far surpass the limitations of old-fashioned typography, of course.

Be bold, and the future will come today!

8

DID UZBEKS HAVE ILLUSIONS?

The Luria–Koffka controversy of 1932

Eli Lamdan and Anton Yasnitsky

Alexander Luria: “Uzbeks have no illusions!”

There is a story well known to those psychologists who were educated in the Soviet tradition and fairly unfamiliar to foreign scholars. According to this story, Alexander Romanovich Luria organized an ethno-psychological expedition to Central Asia in the early 1930s. Luria and his research team studied the psychological characteristics of the local population in the context of the rapid and massive socio-economic changes caused by a ‘cultural revolution’ and the modernization of traditional agriculture. According to Luria and Vygotsky, sensational results were obtained that confirmed their belief in the social origin of psychological processes. In particular, a number of experiments supposedly showed that more educated subjects more often demonstrated abstract thinking based on logical and categorical generalization, whereas the thinking of uneducated subjects was largely tied to concrete situations and personal experiences. This is quite understandable, though, and hardly counts as an unexpected or counterintuitive finding.

However, in addition to research on thinking, Luria’s research team in Central Asia also conducted studies of perception. The experiments on optical illusions produced particularly amazing results: uneducated and ‘uncultured’ subjects – unlike socially active subjects with at least some formal education – hardly succumbed to optical illusions. This discovery provoked a telegram that a triumphant Luria allegedly sent to Vygotsky in Moscow. The legendary telegram literally stated: “Uzbeks have no illusions!”

It is curious that there is no documentary evidence of any telegram of the kind whatsoever, and the plausibility of this episode remains highly questionable, especially given that presumably all known correspondence between Vygotsky and Luria from that period has been published (Vygotsky, 2007). Nevertheless, the story entered the golden fund of Russian historiography of psychology and is traditionally

presented in Russia and, to a notably smaller extent, Eastern Europe, as one of the classic formulations of the essence of the Vygotsky–Luria cultural-historical theory.

This anecdote, however, does not end here. The classic narrative holds that subsequently Luria was heavily criticized for the political mistakes of his research in Central Asia, which determined the fate of the publication of his ‘sensational’ discoveries: for more than four decades the findings were “brutally suppressed” until they were produced from Luria’s archive and finally published in the early 1970s. By then, Luria had already become a living classic and the unquestionable authority in Soviet psychology.

Thus, the results of these expeditions, according to conventional wisdom, can be summed up in two statements:

- (1) “Uzbeks have no illusions!”
- (2) For political reasons, publication was suppressed until the early 1970s.

However, it seems that neither of these statements is exactly true. It is a common view among Russian psychologists that in the early 1930s Luria undertook an expedition to Central Asia in order to carry out psychological studies. Yet, it is far less known that there were actually two expeditions, in 1931 and 1932, and that a scholar of international standing in the field of the psychology of perception, Kurt Koffka (1886–1941) – a German–American psychologist, one of the leaders of Gestalt psychology – participated in the second expedition. Even less known is the fact that a few announcements of the anticipated expedition and brief reports with preliminary findings of both of these expeditions were published in three languages in the first half of 1930. Furthermore, it is in one of these publications that Koffka’s conclusions were publicly and openly presented. According to Koffka, all groups of native Uzbeks, quite in contrast to Luria’s optimism, were found beyond reasonable doubt to have optical illusions!

The historiography of the problem

Italian researcher Luciano Mecacci may have been the first researcher to draw attention to the inconsistency between Luria’s published story about the Central Asian expeditions (cf., e.g., A. R. Luria, 1974, 1976) and Koffka’s account of these events. This problem was discovered in the mid-1970s during the preparation of a reader on the history of Soviet psychology of 1917–36, in Italian (Mecacci, 1976). The discovery of Luria’s English-language publication of 1934 in the *Journal of Genetic Psychology* turned out to be quite a disquieting – if not a disturbing – experience. This paper, characteristically titled “The second psychological expedition to Central Asia,” contained a fragment with a brief report on optical illusion experiments, by Koffka. Although his name was mentioned in a footnote provided by the translators of Luria’s Russian article, who received Koffka’s contribution directly, his co-authorship of the whole article was not acknowledged (A. R. Luria,

1934). Mecacci sought comments from Koffka's correspondent and associate, Molly Harrower, who kindly provided him with a copy of Koffka's letters with a more elaborate, albeit still incomplete, account of the expedition that Koffka sent to Harrower on September 20, 1934. Also, Harrower pointed Mecacci to the collections of the Archives on the History of American Psychology (AHAP, University of Akron, OH), where he obtained copies of the available travel notes, research protocols, and other archival documents – unpublished as they were at that time (Harrower, 1971). Many of these still unpublished documents were eventually published in Harrower's book, in which its author conducted a meticulous study of the manuscript materials that she published along with her extensive correspondence with Koffka and her personal memories (Harrower, 1983).

Then, in 1975, Mecacci contacted Luria to ask for a comment on this episode. In his response, Luria confirmed Koffka's place in the expedition and told Mecacci that Koffka had indeed participated in that expedition with the goal of confirming the universality of the laws of perception in different cultures. In other words, Luria in fact accused Koffka of bias and partisanship that seemingly undermined the scholarly conclusions that he reached in the course of his studies in Central Asia. Besides, according to Luria, Koffka felt very uncomfortable with Central Asian culture and communist society and developed psychosomatic symptoms (such as high fever) and, for these reasons, had to abandon the expedition quite soon. Some of these archival materials were published with Mecacci's introduction in the Italian journal *Storia e critica della psicologia* (Mecacci, 1980). Mecacci did not specify whether Luria provided any explanations of the discrepancies between his interpretation of the studies on optical illusions and that of Koffka as it was presented in the publication of 1934.

Also in 1980, another pioneering publication of much interest was released. This was a paper in a special issue of the journal *Psychological Research* (formerly *Psychologische Forschung*, the militant journal of Gestalt psychologists) dedicated to the memory of Luria. Eckart Scheerer, the journal's editor, published an article titled "Gestalt psychology in the Soviet Union" (1980), in which he made a first attempt to systematically analyze the relationships between Soviet psychologists and the representatives of the Gestalt psychology movement. In the context of the present discussion, of particular interest is Scheerer's statement that Koffka participated in the expedition of 1932, but – having collected some experimental data – fell ill and had to quit and return home. Scheerer pointed out that Koffka did not publish the complete results of his studies of the optical illusions in Central Asia; however, he acknowledged the partial publication of Koffka's main conclusions within Luria's English article of 1934 and referred to the archival collections of the AHAP at the University of Akron. The author also observed that in neither version of Luria's book, which appeared in two languages – first in Russian, then in English – with slight, but notable differences (A. R. Luria, 1974, 1976), was Koffka's participation in the expedition mentioned. Scheerer completed his discussion of this episode with a remark that the history of Koffka's participation in Luria's Central Asian expedition required further investigation (Scheerer, 1980, p. 117).

The next significant attempt to discuss the results of the transnational Luria–Koffka study was made in the classic and programmatic book by René van der Veer and Jaan Valsiner, which remains the best biography of Vygotsky to the present day. The authors devoted an entire chapter to the discussion of the ups and downs of the Central Asian expeditions (Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991, pp. 242–255). Using existing published documents (Harrower, 1983) and various little-known or even unpublished materials – such as Luria’s correspondence with Vygotsky and Wolfgang Köhler – the authors managed to present a quite detailed outline of the story of Luria’s two expeditions to Central Asia. Most importantly, they also discussed Luria’s and Koffka’s conflicting interpretations of the studies of perception and optical illusions. In this context, Van der Veer and Valsiner wrote:

We thus see that Koffka on the basis of his data flatly denied Luria’s initial conclusions: the “primitive” Uzbeks did succumb to optical illusions like the Poggendorf illusion and were able to see perspective in drawings. It is rather unfortunate – quite apart from the value of both Luria’s and Koffka’s conclusions about the cultural and physiological basis of illusions – that Luria (1974; 1976) ignored these conflicting interpretations in his monograph. Discussion of Koffka’s failure to replicate his initial results might have started an interesting debate on the various ways of conducting this type of ethnographic research – Koffka’s remark about the role of the subjects’ attitude toward the experimenter, for example, was quite relevant ... – and would have countered the effects of the beautiful but oversimplified story about the Uzbeks not having illusions and the like.

(Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991, p. 250)

Unfortunately, in their interpretation of the probable reasons for not publishing this study until the early 1970s, the authors relied on the traditional Cold War Sovietological historiography and hence focused almost exclusively on the negative effects of collectivization and industrialization in the period of the First Five-Year Plan. Moreover, Van der Veer and Valsiner notably exaggerated the role of politically inspired criticism of Luria’s research in publications of that time and the real impact of this peer critique (such as in Razmyslov, 1934, 2000) on the strategies of administrative decision-making in the Soviet Union under the dominance of the Bolshevik (i.e. Communist) Party.

Finally, a paper by Victor Nell, “Luria in Uzbekistan: The vicissitudes of cross-cultural neuropsychology” should also be mentioned in this context (Nell, 1999). The author made an attempt at a first investigation of Luria’s research in Central Asia and presented a fairly detailed account of the story supported by multiple references to original publications. However, the author added a great deal of historiographical speculation in the fashion of the ‘oppressed science’ (for some criticism of narratives of this kind see Chapter 3). Yet, as surprising as it might appear, the author not only disregarded the preceding publications by Mecacci (1980), Scheerer (1980), Harrower (1983), and Van der Veer and Valsiner (1991), but

also apparently “did not notice” the very existence of Luria’s second Central Asian expedition in 1932 and, therefore, Koffka’s participation in its work. This omission is particularly amazing, given that Luria’s report that came out in *Science* under the self-explanatory title “The second psychological expedition to Central Asia” (A. R. Luria, 1933c) can be found in the list of Nell’s references. All this, unfortunately, considerably devalues Nell’s study on the history of Luria’s expeditions to Central Asia of 1931 and 1932.

A recent series of publications on this topic has considerably advanced our understanding of this historical episode, its background, and the scientific meaning of its possible interpretations (Allik, 2013; Goncharov, 2013; Lamdan, 2013; Proctor, 2013; Spiridonov, 2013; Yasnitsky, 2013a, 2013b). The discussion in this chapter is solidly grounded in this literature.

The expeditions to Central Asia of 1931 and 1932

The idea of studying the influence of cultural changes caused by post-revolutionary modernization and industrialization on mental processes was likely to have been born during Vygotsky’s trip to Central Asia in the spring of 1929 at the invitation of the Central Asian State University of Tashkent, Soviet Uzbekistan. In early April he left Moscow for Tashkent (Vygodskaya & Lifanova, 1996, p. 131) and stayed there for about a month, until early May.¹ Nevertheless, during this short stay in Central Asia Vygotsky conducted pilot experimental work. “I am doing some experiments and I hope to bring some things” and “We are conducting some experiments, but I do not know whether they will be successful,” Vygotsky wrote in his letters to Luria from Tashkent (Vygotsky, 2007, p. 24).

We still know nothing about either the course of these experiments in Central Asia or their results, but six months after Vygotsky’s trip to Central Asia a continuation of this research project, apparently, took concrete form. Thus, in December 1929, Luria wrote to Kurt Lewin, in Berlin, Germany, that he and Vygotsky had the idea of conducting a psychological study of “primitive people” in Siberia or Central Asia, with the proposal that the major part of the expedition could take place in a little less than two years from then, i.e. in the summer of 1931. However, it seems that at that time Luria and his colleagues did not have a clear notion of which organization might be interested in carrying out and, consequently, funding such an investigation. Luria assumed that the Academy of Sciences of the USSR or the Institute of Oriental Studies would in principle support such a project, but only partially fund it. Apparently, the problem of finding organizational support and funding was one of the most important obstacles in the organization of such a study and Luria asked Lewin whether he knew of any institution in Germany that might potentially sponsor this project, or at least one third of it. Thus, in late 1929 Luria considered support from foreign institutions as a possible way out of the existing difficult financial situation. He hoped to get aid from some German and American institutions or from the Swiss International Bureau of Education

(Bureau International d'Éducation), directed by Jean Piaget. Piaget had recently been appointed to this organization, which eventually became one of the organizational prototypes of UNESCO (founded only after World War II, on November 16, 1945). To facilitate Western funding, Luria pondered which Western scholars should be invited to participate in the project. He turned for advice to Lewin and speculated about inviting European anthropologists Erich von Hornbostel, Richard Thurnwald, or someone from the American team of Franz Boas, for example Otto Klineberg.² At the moment we do not know if Luria actually sent invitations to these scholars, as he planned. What is certain is that Lewin declined the invitation and that the attempts to attract foreign scholars to participate in this expedition did not succeed. Thus, in the summer of 1931 the expedition took place with the participation of Soviet researchers from Moscow and Uzbekistan and with the support of Soviet institutions. In retrospect, this was not really surprising given the stock market crash of October 1929, which signaled the beginning of the ten-year Great Depression that affected all Western industrialized (capitalist) countries.

Apparently, the results of the first expedition seemed to Luria and Vygotsky so interesting and promising that immediately after its end in 1931 they began planning a second study of the cultural development of 'primitive peoples' in the process of collectivization and Cultural Revolution. Luria's enthusiasm about the results of the first expedition is evident from the correspondence between Vygotsky and Luria, to which we will turn below, but also from his correspondence with two scholars who promoted the publication of his first book in the USA, the physiologist W. Horsley Gantt and the philosopher Horace M. Kallen.³ Towards the end of the first expedition, on August 8, 1931, Luria sent a postcard to Kallen, in German. There along with the greetings from Bukhara, the "magic land" (German: *Fabelland*) where "Jews do not speak Jewish," Luria announced "a new book, with many completely new thoughts about the primitive mind, with several experimental series, is already finished in my head." On August 17, 1931, when Luria was still in Uzbekistan, he found time to answer a letter from Gantt. Having discussed some matters relating to the publication of his first book in the United States, Luria wrote about his study in Central Asia:

As far as I know, this is the first experimental psychological expedition organized in order to study structural characteristics of the psyche at different historical stages and I was very glad when it was possible for me to spend three months in the most interesting and peculiar places of our Union. During this time we collected materials of an exceptional interest, forcing us to reconsider several of the most fundamental psychological views, and in the coming years I will turn to you for assistance in the publication of a new book in America. It will be an experimental study of the historically developed structures of the human mind.⁴

The second part of the study was to be held the next summer, in 1932. The preparations for the second expedition to Central Asia were thorough. First, reports

on the success of the first expedition in 1931, with the announcement of the upcoming second psychological expedition to Central Asia, were written by Luria and published in English and German in leading journals such as *Science* (A. R. Luria, 1931b), *Zeitschrift für angewandte Psychologie* (A. R. Luria, 1931c), *Journal of Genetic Psychology* (A. R. Luria, 1932a) and *Character and Personality* (A. R. Luria, 1932b). Luria's objective was fairly clear: the expedition was originally conceived as a large-scale international study with the participation of major Western scholars, so these publications had the purpose of raising publicity and luring foreign experts to participate in the second expedition. In parallel with the publication of the reports, Luria continued an active correspondence with Western scientists, hoping to interest them in the new project and to obtain their agreement to participate. Kallen was the first addressee among those we know of who received a brief summary of the first Central Asian expedition results. In his letter of October 29, 1931, Luria informed Kallen about the places where they conducted their studies – Samarkand, Fergana, the Alay Mountains, and the *kolkhozes* of Andijan – and the scope of the work done by Luria and his fourteen co-workers. He described the topics they studied and again stated his plan to write a comprehensive book about the findings:

The material that we collected (12 themes have been elaborated and appr. 600 exp. protocols have been collected) is really extremely interesting: we studied how these persons count and understand book texts, how they create experimental myths, how they analyze themselves, judge themselves and others, what the laws of their perception are, how their active memory is constructed, how they abstract, compare, what they hold of logic and what the characteristics of their causal thinking are. As you can see, the set of questions was rather large and many things were investigated; I can only add that each chapter really reveals totally novel psychological facts. After all, we were in a region where people measure distances in ... teapots (How far is it to that village? One teapot, i.e., going there requires as much time as needed to finish one pot of tea), where they have a very peculiar attitude toward logic and practice, where people only understand meaningful action and cannot do things that do not make sense, where understanding metaphors (better: conceptual metaphors) is very limited, almost impossible, where I essentially found no (better: only very few) geometrical-optical illusions, etc., etc. I feel that this material enriched us all, and when I can still work with this material – and with the developmental and clinical material – for 1–1.5 years, I hope to write an interesting book about “Historical Changes in Human Mind”.⁵

It is obvious that for Luria it was especially important to cooperate with the leading representatives of Gestalt psychology. As we have seen, he invited Kurt Lewin to participate in the first expedition, but Lewin declined the invitation. Neither could Lewin take part in the second expedition because of an invitation to spend the first semester of the 1932/3 academic year at Stanford University (Marrow, 1969, p. 65). Among Luria's other candidates to participate in the second Central Asian

expedition were both Wolfgang Köhler and Kurt Koffka – German-American scholars and the founders of one of the most influential contemporary psychological theories, Gestalt psychology (Ash, 1995).

In the archival collection of Köhler's writings just two of Luria's letters from that period remain. From these we learn that they got personally acquainted – presumably during the IX Congress of Psychology in 1929 – and were corresponding more or less regularly. In early December 1931, Luria sent Köhler a letter with a very detailed report of his first Central Asian expedition and its preliminary results. Half of the letter was dedicated to the description of the studies of perception and Luria paid special attention to the findings about optical illusions. According to Luria (and Vygotsky) the results indicated that, although Uzbeks do have illusions, among 'primitive', i.e. illiterate and socially inactive, Uzbek individual peasants and Uzbek housewives, these are less common than among uneducated kolkhoz activists and emancipated Uzbek women. The latter had renounced the burqa (also known as chadri or paranja in Central Asia) just two or three months before the experiments began and had basic reading and writing skills. Luria also included the descriptive statistics of his findings.

In the same letter, Luria informed Köhler of his research plans for the near future:

Now I am coming to the practical part of my letter. I would like to make a suggestion. Would you like to participate in the second psychological expedition to Central Asia, in the summer of 1932? I believe that we will manage to organize a second expedition and it will have an international character ... If you would like to join us, you can get two (or more) assistants, a Russian who speaks German (can be Dr. Vygotski or someone from Moscow) and an Uzbek who speaks Russian and who will always be available. The expedition will cost you nothing. Our scientific institutes will assume all costs, partly – the Academy of Sciences of Uzbekistan. You will receive an invitation for 1–2 lectures, for which you will be paid about 1,000 rubles. Then you still have about 1,000 rubles here (I do not know exactly) as a fee for *Gestalt Psychology* (which will be released in the winter) and that will be quite enough for everything. I am quite convinced that – if this expedition will succeed – we will be able to do a lot for psychology. I hope that Mr. Lewin and Mr. Koffka will participate. Perhaps it would also be good to invite Prof. Thurnwald?

However, despite the attractive offer, Köhler, for whatever reason, did not participate in the 1932 expedition. Luria then invited him to participate in the next stage of the research project, a third expedition planned for the summer of 1933. According to Luria, the second expedition was to become, on the one hand, a less important expedition, meant to check the data obtained during the first expedition, and on the other hand, an expedition that would prepare the next, most ambitious third expedition in the summer of 1933.⁶ It is difficult to say whether the invitation to Köhler reflected real plans and arrangements between the scientists and their sponsoring organizations. What is certain is that a large-scale study in 1933 did not take place

and that the second expedition to Central Asia was the last. Although neither Lewin nor Köhler participated, nonetheless the second expedition was truly international and not just because of the mixed Russian-Uzbek composition of Luria's team. In the summer of 1932, Luria's expedition to Uzbekistan included another world-class German-American scientist. It was one of the founders of Gestalt psychology and at that time professor at Smith College in Massachusetts: Kurt Koffka.

Correspondence between Luria and Kurt Koffka prior to the second expedition would give us an insight into the course of negotiations and preparations for the journey to Uzbekistan but it has not been preserved in the archival collections of Koffka's or Harrower's papers. From the correspondence between Luria and Lewin we know only that in the spring of 1932 the issue of the second expedition and Koffka's participation had been resolved, although uncertainties about the location remained. Luria was considering two options, Svaneti in the Caucasus or Central Asia, and, as we know, eventually preferred the second one.⁷ Thus, Koffka took part in the second expedition to Central Asia in 1932.

On his way to Uzbekistan, Koffka stayed in Moscow for a while, where, among other things, he gave a presentation at the local Institute of Psychology on May 29, 1932. The topic was "Die Überwindung des Mechanismus in der modernen Psychologie" (The overcoming of mechanism [i.e. mechanistic philosophy] in modern psychology).⁸ The text of the lecture was published in the journal *Psikhologiya*, although slightly abridged and with a different title, as was characteristic of that period. The new title mentioned another extreme approach in psychology, namely vitalism, and it now read "Overcoming the mechanistic and vitalistic currents in modern psychology" (Koffka, 1932). It was then, during his visit to Moscow, that Koffka, by his own admission, first met Vygotsky. The latter served as an interpreter, because Koffka's talk was presented in German.⁹ The meeting with Koffka clearly made a big impression on Vygotsky and he subsequently mentioned Koffka's lecture at least three times in his talks and written works (see Chapter 9). The correspondence between Koffka and his student Molly Harrower includes rich material that reflects his impressions from the Central Asian expedition. Harrower subsequently published these travel notes and memories in a separate chapter, "The Russian-Uzbekistan expedition," of her book *Kurt Koffka: An unwitting self-portrait* (Harrower, 1983, pp. 143–164). Actually, it is with the help of these rich materials that we managed to reconstruct the chronology and the route of Luria's second expedition to Central Asia in some detail (Yasnitsky, 2013a).¹⁰

The expedition was carried out in June and July 1932. It began with the departure from Moscow to Tashkent on June 1, and after a short delay in Tashkent (June 5–9), stayed in Samarkand for a one-week preparatory seminar (June 9–16). The team consisted of Koffka, three Muscovites – Luria, Shemiakin, and Mordkovich – and an Uzbek group of researchers from the local Pedagogical Academy directed by P. I. Leventuev. After the seminar in Samarkand, the extended research team departed for the remote areas of Eastern Uzbekistan, first to relatively 'civilized' and mostly collectivized Fergana Valley (June 16–July 1) and then to the mountain areas of Shakhimardan, formerly part of Kirgizstan (July 1 to the end of July). Shakhimardan

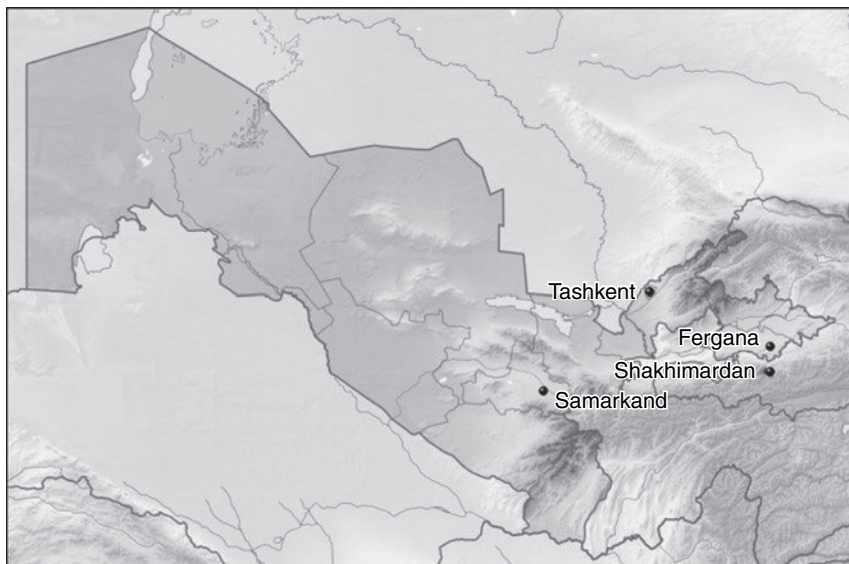


FIGURE 8.1 Luria's expedition to Uzbekistan (Tashkent→Samarkand→Fergana→Shakhimardan, June–July, 1932)

had a predominantly traditional population, which had not been collectivized and actively resisted the economic and social innovations of the Bolsheviks. The data collected in these two areas of Eastern Uzbekistan formed the material for the comparative analysis of the changes in mentality caused by the First Five-Year Plan (collectivization) and the rapid “economic renaissance of Central Asia” (A. R. Luria, 1931b). By late July or early August the members of the expedition had completed the fieldwork and began to return to their homes.

After his return from Uzbekistan, Luria published several articles in which he mentioned his Central Asian expeditions. For example, in 1933 in the journal *Sovietskaia Psikhonevrologiia* (*Soviet Psychoneurology*) Luria published an article, entitled “The paths of Soviet psychology in last 15 years,” in which he referred to the recent expeditions:

The study of higher psychological processes and their structure could not remain within the confines of psychological laboratories and children's institutions. The rapid socialist reconstruction of the peripheries of the country – which determined the transition of those peoples, who preserved the remains of the long ago surpassed socio-economic types [in Russian: *uklad*], to the socialist form of production and social relations – provided new, exceptional opportunities for psychological research. A number of psychological expeditions (among these it is worthwhile to point out the psychological expeditions to Central Asia of 1931 and 1932) accumulated considerable data on the historical reconstruction of thinking and psyche and for the first time

systematically scrutinized the problem of the historical development and change in logical categories, psychological functions and consciousness.

(A. R. Luria, 1933b, p. 34)

In addition, Luria published two international reports on the second Central Asian expedition: a brief note in *Science* (A. R. Luria, 1933c) and a relatively longer review in the *Journal of Genetic Psychology* (A. R. Luria, 1934). Neither of these publications mentioned a third expedition project. Despite the author's assurances that the findings of both psychological expeditions would be compiled and prepared for publication in the next year (A. R. Luria, 1933c, p. 192; 1934, p. 259), such publication of the results of the Central Asian studies was delayed until the 1970s (A. R. Luria, 1971, 1974, 1976). As mentioned before, this delay is usually explained by referring to the criticism that these studies received in the Soviet Union (E. A. Luria, 1994, pp. 66–68; Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991, pp. 253–255).

However, Luria did publish the announcements of the project and the preliminary reports in *Science*, *Zeitschrift für angewandte Psychologie*, *Journal of Genetic Psychology*, and *Character and Personality* in 1931–4, and he continued his foreign publication activities virtually until the very beginning of World War II; for the discussion of the last of these prewar publications, a French paper of 1937, see Lamdan and Yasnitsky, 2013. It is true that in these foreign publications in English and French, published immediately after the expedition, Luria made no mention of the expeditions in 1931 and 1932, or of the supposedly sensational discoveries made in their course. The publications were devoted to entirely different themes, such as the study of twins in the Institute of Medical Genetics and the work in a clinic with oligophrenic children (A. R. Luria, 1935c, 1936, 1937). Nevertheless, it appears safe to assume that, in addition to explicit criticism of Luria's expedition in the Soviet Union, there were several other reasons not to publish full results of this study abroad.

Kurt Koffka: "Uzbeks do have illusions!"

There is another source of knowledge that offers us insights into the course and preliminary results of the expeditions in 1931 and 1932: the correspondence between Luria and Vygotsky. Unfortunately, Luria's letters to Vygotsky of 1931–2 have not yet been found but several enthusiastic letters from Vygotsky to Luria, written during the first Central Asian expedition in the summer of 1931, have survived. Vygotsky wrote them as a reply to the preliminary results of the field studies and they leave no doubt that the members of the Vygotsky–Luria circle considered the first expedition to Central Asia a great success. For example, Vygotsky began his letter from Moscow to Luria in Central Asia from June 20, 1931 in this way:

Dear Alexander Romanovich, your Report no. 2 was just delivered to me. I read it with tremendous delight and am hurrying to send a brief response.

All the things you report are extremely important and interesting; this is now the best part of our work – and a novel part in the best sense in that it does not repeat what we already know but moves all the work forward and raises our older studies (for example, the problem of types of connections in mediated memory and thought) to the highest level.

(Vygotsky, 2007, p. 39)

Vygotsky ended his letter as follows:

That is all. Generally speaking, excellent! The best of the year. The road to the future. It makes up for the six months that were lost. It is our golden reserve of experiments that are opened directly by the theoretical key. Keep up your work and write me. I will read your letter to all. It is a marvelous letter.

(Vygotsky, 2007, p. 41)

Other reports by Luria on the course of the expedition were also greatly appreciated by Vygotsky. In a letter of August 1, 1931, he wrote:

Earlier I sent you letters to Samarkand and Fergana about the enormous, totally incomparable impression that your Reports and records have had on me. This is a huge, decisive, pivotal step in our research toward a new viewpoint. But even in any context of European research, such a survey would be an event. This study will be your trip to Tenerife.¹¹ I am experiencing a feeling of elation – in the literal sense of the word – of being on the brink of a major internal success.

(Vygotsky, 2007, p. 42)

As we have seen from the correspondence between Luria and Köhler (Luria's letter to Köhler dated December 3, 1931), the study of optical illusions, which formed the basis of the legendary telegram "Uzbeks have no illusions!" had already taken place during the first expedition and therefore this hypothetical telegram – if only it ever existed – is most likely be dated to the summer of 1931, not later.

Above we noted that Köhler did not participate in the expedition of 1932 but Kurt Koffka did. Moreover, his studies of perception, conducted during this expedition, led him to a diametrically opposed conclusion. Koffka pointed out that his subjects in Central Asia, with minor and rare deviations, showed the same optical illusions as the subjects in European studies. At the same time, Koffka noticed that deviations were occasionally found in the first expedition, more so than in the second. This phenomenon, Koffka noted, could easily be explained, primarily by the differences in the technique used.

In Koffka's view, more open-minded and socially naive subjects who perceived the experimenter as equal to them and did not consider the experiment as a test of their abilities, without exception showed optical illusions, such as the Müller-Lyer

illusion and the Poggendorf illusion. In contrast, suspicious, distrustful, and hesitant subjects studied the images for a long time before making their verdict and succumbed less to optical illusions, which, according to Koffka, again confirmed previous studies of European psychologists. Koffka formulated his conclusion as follows:

The following results may be considered as proved: With very few exceptions the men and women examined by us succumbed to the optical illusions – of which a great variety was shown – just as we do. Quantitative measurements of the Müller-Lyer and Poggendorf patterns yielded a slightly smaller amount of these illusions than control experiments with European psychologists. The exceptions, which were very rare in this expedition, but had been much more frequent in the first, are easily explained by the attitude of the testees towards the experimenter. Naïve, social subjects who treated the experimenter on a footing of equality and did not regard the experiment as a test of their ability had the illusion without exception. Only when the subjects were suspicious, staring a long time at the patterns before making their judgments, the illusions failed to appear with some though by no means with all patterns, in accordance with well-known facts.

Similarly, it could be proved with several very simple figures like Mach's book, Necker's cube, Schroder's staircase, that plane perspective drawings may compel the perception of a tridimensional object. If the pattern is more complex and has greater representative value, the intended tridimensional effect, as a rule, does not appear, although we see these figures as tridimensional. Thus the opposite report of previous investigators can be explained, according to which Uzbeks, not reached by modern culture, cannot perceive perspective.

Transformation in the organization of a chessboard pattern was always performed, though sometimes with difficulty. The Kohts test manifested great, but not insuperable, difficulties in the abandonment of the originally perceived form.

(Luria, 1934, p. 257)

This brief report of Koffka's research in Central Asia was published only two years after the completion of the expedition, as part of Luria's article published in the *Journal of Genetic Psychology*, and was sent directly to the translators (A. R. Luria, 1934).¹² Nevertheless, it is unlikely Luria first learned about Koffka's conclusions from the publication of this article. Most likely, judging by Vygotsky's letter to Luria of August 17, 1932, Luria and Vygotsky learned about Koffka's critical conclusions immediately. In this letter Vygotsky wrote:

I continue to think and will continue to think, until I am persuaded otherwise, that there is now experimental proof ... for the phylogenetic existence of a level of comprehensive thinking, of a different structure, independent of it, of all the principal systems of the psyche, of all the major types of activity,

and eventually of consciousness itself. Surely, that is not so little as to be dissatisfied with the outcome of the two trips.

(Vygotsky, 2007, p. 45)

In between the lines one can read the awareness of another opinion and an attempt to overcome the doubts seeded by it. And this meant if not the complete failure of the Central Asian studies in 1931–2 then at least a serious reason to cast doubt on the findings of the expedition of 1931 and the need for a critical review of both its findings and its experimental methods. In any case, such epithets as “golden reserve of experiments that are opened directly by the theoretical key,” “huge, decisive, pivotal step in our research toward a new viewpoint,” and the claim that “in any context of European research, such a survey would be an event” now seem quite exaggerated. Koffka, one of the greatest and most reputable European (and American) researchers, the co-founder and leading advocate of one of the most brilliant and influential psychological theories and one of the most prominent experts on the psychology of perception of his time, must have thought the same. This circumstance explains the delayed publication of the findings as well as the suggestion of political censorship (A. R. Luria, 1971). Neither Vygotsky nor Koffka lived until that time, and for some reason neither Koffka’s conclusions nor even his participation were mentioned in Luria’s book (A. R. Luria, 1974, 1976).¹³

At a somewhat general, abstract, and philosophical level of discussion, virtually any phenomenon or event in our lives can be regarded from three distinct – although closely interrelated – perspectives. First, how other people see us and interpret our words and actions. Second, how we make sense of our experiences and interpret the world around us. Three, what we actually see and, therefore, what we fail to see. The three perspectives are foundational and essential. Likewise, in the context of the present discussion three questions are most pertinent to the Luria–Koffka controversy as it appears in light of recent historical investigations, findings, and analyses:

- First: What was the reception of Luria’s Central Asian research in the domestic context? More specifically: why was the study not published in the Soviet Union in the 1930s?
- Second: Why did Luria interpret the data the way he did?
- Third: What did Luria actually see, or rather, what did Luria fail to see in Central Asia in 1931–2?

Why was Luria’s study not published? The reception of Central Asian research in the Soviet Union in the 1930s

Luria’s study in Central Asia was not published in the Soviet Union in the 1930s. One reason may have been that Luria felt reluctant to present the study because of Koffka’s criticism. After all, his main and most triumphant conclusion was considerably undermined by the findings of Koffka, a scholar of great international

reputation, specifically in the field of visual perception. This reason for voluntary non-publication may be termed personal and subjective. Yet, apparently, there were other, objective reasons not to publish. These were directly related to the wider social and political context of the time. This was the period of a change in state policy on national and ethnic minorities in the Soviet Union of early Stalinism. Other major factors to consider were the First Five-Year Plan, the Cultural Revolution, violent deprivatization of agriculture (so-called collectivization), and the industrialization of the national economy. At the same time, major processes in international political affairs – most notably, the Nazi Party's ascent to power in Germany in early 1933 – also played their role in changing attitudes and domestic policies in the USSR. All these had a considerable impact on the fate of Luria's expeditions of the early 1930s – contrary to the original plans, abruptly interrupted in 1932 – and the non-publication of their scientific results for several decades to come.

The question of the rights of nationalities was central for the Bolsheviks from the very inception of the Soviet state (at the very end of 1922) and even before.¹⁴ Bolsheviks could not avoid the issue because of the multi-ethnic nature of the Russian Empire in an era of rising nationalism. The tangle of contradictions between conventional Marxist wisdom on the national question (essentially an internationalist standpoint), the practical needs of governing a multi-ethnic state, the challenge of modernization, and the attempt to attract the sympathy of the various national groups necessitated a federative structure of the Soviet state based on nationally (or ethnically) identified units. Despite the fact that the federative structure was essentially formal, the official policy was to encourage the development of different national cultures within the framework of the socialist state, even in localities where it was impossible to apply the terms 'nationality' or 'national culture'. Although multiple national identities and the 'national revival of minorities' throughout the Soviet Union were encouraged, the identity of the largest ethnic group, the Russians, was actually hushed up or at least minimized. Russian nationalism was viewed as the successor of the Tsarist regime and understood as the greatest danger for the construction of socialism and the stability of a multi-national social structure on the ruins of the empire.

Hence, the Soviet regime from its inception adopted a policy of affirmative action for all non-Russian nationalities and ethnic groups or, as they called it, a policy of *korenizatsiia* (roughly: indigenization). This policy had economic, social, and cultural aspects. In addition to the attempt to provide territorial autonomy, even formally, to as many ethnic groups as possible, the central government encouraged the cultural development of minorities, the official use of local languages, and the promotion of national or ethnic elites in these new territorial units. In addition, the state adopted, at least declaratively, a policy of preferential economic development of the geographical areas populated by 'delayed' nationalities, that is, those who lived, in Marxist parlance, under the conditions of a pre-capitalist, feudal economic system. Affirmative action policies succeeded relatively well in the Western regions of the Soviet Union but encountered many difficulties in its Eastern and southern regions. Justifications for affirmative action policies were different in the West and the East.¹⁵

If in the West the central argument and the rationale for new national policies was indigenization, in the East 'socio-economic retardation' was the preferred argument.

The Great Turn or the Socialist Offensive that began with the First Five-Year Plan in 1929 led to new changes in the national policy adopted by the Soviet leadership. In the republics of the "developed West" where significant local elites were relatively easily established during the period of the 1920s, and where the *korenizatsiia* focused especially on expanding the dominance of the local language, the support to local national elites was stopped or even reversed. To some extent this happened because of the growing centralization of the economy during the period of forced collectivization and rapid industrialization. Perhaps the most notable example of such reversal of national policy in the developed localities is the case of the Ukraine in the early 1930s. In contrast, in the "backward East" the affirmative action in education and employment and the continued attempt to create local elites were well integrated into the process of economic centralization, which determined further support and generous investments in these areas, enhanced with the utopian discourse of the ideology of the Cultural Revolution as part of a large-scale developmental project for the economy and society.¹⁶ A few examples of this attitude can be found in the policies implemented in the context of Soviet republics in Central Asia.

Against this background, ethno-psychological studies blossomed in the Soviet Union. Several of them were conducted within the fairly vague framework of the discipline of the pedology (developmental child psychology and physiology) of national minorities. Psychologists and physicians dealing with ethnic issues under the pedological umbrella profited from the spirit of the time, when social progressivist, transformative, and developmentalist discourse was at its peak, but classical ethnologists found it difficult to integrate Marxist discourse into their work (Slezkine, 1991).

Pedology as an interdisciplinary science, or science in the making, was very popular among the scientific elite of the Soviet Union, thanks, mainly, to its essentially Lamarckian standpoint manifested in the promise to influence the development of the next generation, and to a create a new, improved man by changing the living conditions of children. Therefore, it comes as no surprise that researchers in the Vygotsky–Luria circle grew acutely interested in this area of studies (Yasnitsky, 2013a).¹⁷ Even though Luria's study in Central Asia was not explicitly pedological by its nature – in fact, Luria always clearly identified it as a "psychological" expedition – it definitely was a part of the same trend and shared the same optimistic Lamarckian spirit of the Cultural Revolution.¹⁸ Yet, the social processes of the late 1920s/early 1930s developed very rapidly and dramatically and what was endorsed in an earlier period might turn unacceptable and even forbidden virtually overnight. Thus, the timing of events is crucial.

By the end of 1932, with the end of the Cultural Revolution, the developmentalist trend in national politics was reversed, or at least silenced. Russian identity and Russian culture began to go through a process of rehabilitation, culminating in the second half of the 1930s. From this time, local nationalism was perceived as an equally great or even greater danger than 'great-Russian chauvinism', depending

on the local political context. The various ethnic groups and cultures were declared primordial, and local folklore became a kind of trademark that every nationality should have. The concept of 'the friendship of nationalities' became central in the Soviet discourse, Russians became the first among equals in the family of Soviet peoples, and the term 'backward nations' became politically incorrect.¹⁹

These changes in the policy towards nationalities occurred in parallel, and reflected the changes in the domestic and international situation of the Soviet Union. Domestically, the change in the policy towards nationalities was part of the consolidation process of the results of the Stalinist Great Turn. Internationally, the strengthening of fascism in Europe and the seizure of power by the Nazis in Germany in early 1933 affected the foreign policy of the Soviet Union. As a result, 'anti-fascist' policies and discourse received a great impetus and became particularly sensitive to anything that looked like advocating the superiority of an ethnic or national group (Haslam, 2006).

Under these circumstances, an ethno-psychological investigation like Luria's would immediately become a target of criticism in the Soviet Union of 1932–3. Luria's findings showed – or at least can be interpreted in that manner – that there were still significant psychological differences between peoples in the Soviet Union, which reflected a gap between 'primitive', i.e. economically and culturally backward, nations and 'advanced' ones, i.e., in Marxist terms, those living under the conditions of higher socio-economic stages. Although Luria attributed the psychological 'backwardness' of the local population in Central Asia to the impact of socio-economic factors, his study and – even more so – his terminology (e.g. 'primitive', 'backward') suggested that he was a nationalist, and this naturally triggered accusations of chauvinism, nationalism, colonialism, and Western supremacism. In an era when fascism and, specifically, the Nazis, with their militantly anti-Communist sentiments, came to power in several Western European countries, accusations of 'fascist, pro-Nazi attitudes' equaled charges of 'political mistakes' – a phrase that could lead to fairly grave consequences, especially during periods of social upheaval, unrest, and increased terror. There is no doubt that Luria fell victim to such criticism and had to vigorously fight against all political accusations, defending his 'internationalist' standpoint and explaining the 'culturally progressivist' foundations of his study. To that end, Luria released a couple of publications in 1933 in which he explicitly distanced himself from scientific 'fascism' of any kind and expressed his firm belief in the virtually endless possibility of cultural transformation. In other words, he joined in the rhetoric of that time, which said that the 'socialist remolding' of humans into a new type would be within reach in the future socialist state, despite the limitations of traditional upbringing, biological makeup, and heredity (A. R. Luria, 1933a, 1933b). In the end, the criticisms of 1932–3 did not have a notable impact on Luria's career and might not have precluded him from publishing his Central Asian research results. Yet the situation again changed considerably as another dramatic turn of events took place in the following year.

In early 1934 the XVII Congress of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union was held. During the Congress, informally called "The Congress of the Victors," the

Party leadership triumphantly summarized the outcomes of the First Five-Year Plan and declared the overwhelming success of the Soviet state in terms of its economic growth and cultural development – also in comparison to the declining economies of the major industrialized countries in the era of the Great Depression.²⁰

In order to facilitate the understanding of the remainder of this chapter a brief account of some aspects of the Marxist worldview is in order. According to Marxist social theory, society is based upon *modes of production* that comprise the dialectic unity of *production forces* – that is, human labor power and means of production (such as tools or technologies) – and social and technical *relations of production* that encompass a wide range of social phenomena such as property, power, relations between people and the objects of their work, and the relations between *social classes*. The mode of production is understood as the *basis* of society that determines the *socio-economic formation* of a specific society. Historically, the Marxist model has accounted for five major progressive socio-economic formations. This hierarchy includes (1) primitive classless society (also referred to as “primitive communism”), (2) slavery, (3) feudalism, (4) capitalism and, the highest and the most advanced of the five, (5) socialism. Yet different societies develop unequally, and at any particular period the different types coexist in different national states or even within the same state, such as the extremely diverse and multicultural Soviet Union of the 1920s–1930s.

Indeed, as was emphasized during the IX Congress of the Communist Party, in the early 1920s the economy of the Soviet Union represented the features of five socio-economic types or structures (in Russian: *social'no-ekonomicheskii układ*), roughly corresponding to the historical socio-economic formations. Yet, due to the rapid progress made during the First Five-Year Plan only two of these types had survived in the USSR, which allowed Joseph Stalin to describe the current situation in his opening report to the Congress of the Party as follows:

At the time when the New Economic Policy was being introduced, Lenin said that there were elements of five forms of social and economic structure in our country: (1) patriarchal economy (largely natural economy); (2) small-commodity production (the majority of the peasants who sell grain); (3) private capitalism; (4) state capitalism; (5) socialism. Lenin considered that, of all these forms, the socialist form must in the end gain the upper hand. We can now say that the first, the third and the fourth forms of social and economic structure no longer exist; the second form has been forced into a secondary position, while the fifth form – the socialist form of social and economic structure – now holds undivided sway and is the sole commanding force in the whole national economy.²¹

And even that achievement was to be triumphantly overcome by 1937. The Second Five-Year Plan of 1933–7 that was announced at the Party Congress of 1934 was to finally eliminate the remnants of capitalism and small-commodity production in the country and, by the end of the Second Five-Year period (*piatiletka*) in 1937, lead to the establishment of a fully socialist economy and even classless society.²²

One may wonder how all this political and socio-economic talk is related to Luria's study and the perspective of its publication in the Soviet Union in the 1930s. The answer is: most directly. Indeed, the propagandist victory of the socialist experiment that was declared at the XVII Congress of the Party in January/February 1934 virtually put an end to Luria's hopes of publishing his work on psychological development in times of rapid socio-economic change. In order to understand why, we need to answer the second question posed above, namely:

Why did Luria interpret the data the way he did?

Why did Luria interpret the data the way he did? The case of Vygotsky's and Luria's vulgar Marxism

Much has been written about the influence of Marxism on the work of Vygotsky and Luria. Theirs is usually described as a creative, sophisticated, complex, or "academic" understanding of Marxism.²³ In the context of Luria's psychological expeditions to Central Asia of 1931–2 this assessment is, in fact, highly disputable. Let us see how Luria defined the goals of the expedition in his foreign publications of the time:

The aim of the expedition was to investigate the variations in thought and other psychological processes of people living in a very primitive economic and social environment, and to record these changes which develop as a result of the introduction of higher and more complex forms of economic life and the raising of the general cultural level.

(A. R. Luria, 1931b, p. 383)

This statement is largely consistent with other sources, including Luria's private correspondence with his peers abroad. For instance, in his letter to Kallen of October 29, 1931, Luria wrote:

The basic idea of the expedition was as follows: what we *assumed to be natural* in the human mind is *mostly historical*, i.e. developed in the history of mankind; when a person shows other social forms of behavior, he also thinks differently and the elementary mental functions involved in this thinking also function in another way. So we should certainly find other laws of perception, memory, abstraction, etc. in the mind of people living under primitive conditions. When the social reform is as comprehensive and fast as it is right now here – and particularly in Central Asia – the person will certainly also be rebuilt psychologically, and certain reforms [unclear in original] of the most fundamental psychological systems will certainly come the fore. These questions were never dealt with in a real psychological experiment; I do not have a high opinion of Lévy-Bruhl's material; after all, no single experiment was done and, hence, no single fact was causally explained.²⁴

A closer look at the classification of the groups of subjects, which one can find in Luria's later book and in his correspondence with Köhler, confirms this division into two groups. A first category, following Luria's terminology, can be described as 'primitive' people – *ichkari* (traditional housewives) and *dek-khane* (traditional peasants) – living in the pre-modern, traditional Central Asian socio-economic order. A second category consisted of more 'advanced' or 'progressive' subjects, those on their way to the civilization that had already reached the 'socialist form of social life': women that had completed pre-school courses, *kolkhoz* activists, and women studying at a teachers' training college. Within each of these categories, we can see a hierarchy that suggests a five-stage scale used by Luria in his assessment of the psychological development of the subjects. Thus, in traditional, 'primitive society', men, unlike women, are engaged in *production*, and occupy a higher social position than women. Hence, according to this simplistic Marxist interpretation, men are expected to outperform women during psychological testing. In the second category, the more a person is involved in the socialist institutions created during collectivization and the Cultural Revolution, the better his or her psychological performance is supposed to be. To express this in Marxist terminology, the changes in the socio-economic basis lead directly and almost instantly to changes in mental life, which, in contrast to the *economic basis*, is understood as a part of the *superstructure*. Thus, it is the *mode of production* – specifically, the *relations of production* – rather than the level of education that, according to Luria's studies of the early 1930s, determines the psychological makeup of individuals, specifically, their thinking, perception, personality traits, and self-observation abilities. Indeed, even those subjects of Luria's studies who are included in the most 'progressive' categories have a very low level of education. Furthermore, the range of these 'progressive' types suggests that Luria in fact used a bottom-up scale from the less advanced – that is, less socially active – women with minimal levels of education, through a higher level of uneducated collective farm activists, to the still higher level of students at the teachers' training college. Perhaps it is worth mentioning here that in later texts devoted to the discussion of this historical study, this economic determinism was gradually replaced by the influence of 'culture' and 'education', despite the fact that vulgar Marxist interpretations can still be found in Luria's publications of the 1970s (see, e.g., A. R. Luria, 1974, pp. 19–28). Finally, in the traditional, hagiographic, yet another 'Great Man', scientific biography published by a student of Luria's in the early 1990s, the economic determinism in the interpretation of Luria's Central Asian study design was absolutely absent (Homskeya, 1992).

All in all, Vygotsky's and Luria's apparent fascination with economic determinism and their vulgar Marxist simplistic interpretation of psychological development cost them dear and substantially undermined the chances of immediate publication of these studies in the Soviet Union at the time of the First and Second Five-Year Plans. Indeed, as soon as the Communist Party leadership proclaimed the victory of the socialist mode of production and declared the established fact that, in Stalin's dictum, "the socialist form of social and economic structure now holds undivided

sway and is the sole commanding force in the whole national economy,” it was a serious political mistake to claim – as Luria did in his foreign publications of 1933 and 1934 – that large groups of the population lagged behind psychologically due to “primitive economic conditions which are now undergoing tremendous industrial, political and cultural transformation.” Nor was it wise to state that this economic transformation determined “the very dynamics of the transition from the more elementary psychological laws to the more complex processes” (A. R. Luria, 1933c, p. 191; 1934, p. 255). Such a study, were it published in 1934 or later, would be considered as not in tune with the times, as hopelessly outdated, and of hardly any use given the requirement of the “practicality” of scientific research in the Soviet Union.²⁵

What did Luria actually (fail to) see in Central Asia in 1931–1932? The cultural-historical psychology of Wertheimer and Koffka

Gestalt psychology has long been perceived worldwide, specifically in the United States, as the field of psychological studies of perception. Among other things, this is due to the way these psychologists – primarily the three founders and leaders of this scientific system of thought, Max Wertheimer, Kurt Koffka, and Wolfgang Köhler – presented themselves and their scientific system abroad. This is apparent, for example, from Koffka’s well-known article “Perception: An introduction to the *Gestalt-theorie*,” which was the first presentation of the principles of Gestalt psychology in English (Koffka, 1922).

However, a wide range of other topics outside research on visual perception – including the problem of thinking in a socio-cultural context – played an important role in the development of Gestalt psychology as such and constituted its theoretical and axiomatic foundation. This is particularly notable in the work of Gestalt psychology’s founder and ‘godfather’ Max Wertheimer. Thus, Wertheimer’s programmatic book, *Drei Abhandlungen zur Gestalttheorie* (1925a), has three chapters, of which only one deals with the problems of perception. The other two treat the problems of psychological research on productive thinking and sense of number in concrete historical and cultural contexts, specifically in ‘primitive’ peoples (German: *Naturvölker*). Together with another of Wertheimer’s foundational writings – his paper on the music of the Veddas (Wertheimer, 1910) – these studies constitute the solid basis of what one, in retrospect, might legitimately refer to as ‘cultural-historical Gestalt psychology’.²⁶ Incidentally, the Veddas were considered as one of the most primitive tribes of that time, and Max Wertheimer’s biographers D. Brett King and Michael Wertheimer have suggested that the study of the Veddas was no less important for the development of Gestalt theory than the foundational work on the psychology of visual perception (King & Wertheimer, 2005, p. 96). Thus, this complex of ideas on human mind, value, and culture was at the very foundation of the entire Gestalt psychology and constituted its – not necessarily explicitly manifested – conceptual framework and axiomatic basis.

In light of Wertheimer's foundational thinking about ethno-psychological issues that are at the very heart of the entire Gestaltist project we can better understand Koffka's interpretation of the Central Asian studies as an alternative to Luria's simplistic and militant pro-Bolshevik stance and its impact on what he actually observed – or, for that matter, failed to observe – and understood in the course of his expeditions. Of particular interest in the context of this discussion is Koffka's viewpoint as it is expressed in his book *Principles of Gestalt psychology* (1935), which its author conceived and actually started composing during his trip to Central Asia in the summer of 1932 (see Harrower, 1983, pp. 28–29, cf. also p. 152).

According to Koffka, the situation in psychology had not significantly changed since the split between experimental, 'natural scientific' psychology and the hermeneutic, 'understanding' variations were first discussed. Indeed, Koffka argued that experimental psychology tries to explain scientifically mental phenomena by studying the basic processes and traits of mental life. But it failed to explain the most complex human phenomena such as Caesar's decision to cross the Rubicon or the pleasure one derives from creating art. One cannot explain such phenomena by the laws of sensation, association, or feelings. Therefore, the understanding of such phenomena is left to scholars from the humanities or *Geisteswissenschaften*, which further increases the split between explanation and understanding as the dominant methods of scientific research in this field of knowledge.

According to Koffka, we can find certain regularities in natural phenomena and even formulate some general laws regarding them. However, within the framework of mechanistic and reductionist science these laws allow predictions but will be devoid of meaning. Only if we see the phenomenon as a whole, and are not merely concerned with its constituent parts, but also inquire about their meaning, can we say that we truly attempt to understand it. As Koffka expressed this idea:

[F]ar from being compelled to banish concepts like meaning and value from psychology and science in general, we must use these concepts for a full understanding of the mind and the world, which is at the same time a full explanation.

(Koffka, 1935, p. 21)

The Gestalt ideas on meaning were discussed at considerable length in Willis D. Ellis's *Gestalt psychology and meaning* (1930) and in Köhler's Harvard lectures of 1934–5 that were later published as a book under the title *The place of value in a world of facts* (1938). Another idea, closely interrelated with that of *meaning* as an object of psychological research, is the holistic notion of *field* and its specific variations (for an introductory discussion, see Yasnitsky, 2014a). Thus, Koffka, unlike Luria, interpreted the phenomenon of optical illusions in his subjects taking into consideration the meaning of the entire situation – in other terminology, the meaning of the *psychological field* or the *behavioral environment* – for these people.

Koffka's original report on his part of the experiments that he conducted in Central Asia was extremely brief but one can understand a little more of his

impression of these experiments from other publications. Thus, for instance, in his book of 1935 Koffka briefly discussed the research of Révész, who trained chickens to peck from the smaller of two simultaneously presented containers. Subsequently, the chickens were presented with two equal containers under the conditions of the well-known optical illusion known as the Jastrow illusion – that is, the containers were presented so that one of the two figures appeared smaller. The study demonstrated that in the vast majority of cases the chicken trained to peck from the smaller container in the experimental situation pecked from the one which appeared smaller – apparently, humans and chickens behave alike. Koffka reported on his replication study of Révész's experiment, specifically

an experiment which I made in the summer of 1932 in a small village in Uzbekistan in Central Asia. I had shown the Jastrow illusion, using the pattern of the “Pseudoptics,” to a young native who was the host of the tea house, the one meeting place of the male populace of the village. The man behaved as the hens did, apart from the fact that his reactions consisted not in pecking but in pointing to the larger of the two pieces of cardboard. I then put one on top of the other and gave them to him to handle. I wanted to see what explanation he would give to the curious discrepancy between their previous inequality and their now manifest equality. He said something like illusion, but without much conviction; and when I asked, “So you think they do not *really* change when you take them apart,” he answered “Oh, yes, I believe they *will* change a little.”

(Koffka, 1935, p. 33)

This case seems to illustrate the kind of behavior that both Luria and Koffka observed in the subjects of the ‘advanced’, ‘more developed’ group of collective farm activists, who succumbed to optical illusions. In contrast, in Koffka's assessment, this group was constituted by “naïve, social subjects who treated the experimenter on a footing of equality and did not regard the experiment as a test of their ability.” From the perspective of a contemporary observer – neither blinded by Soviet propaganda nor biased by vulgar Marxist economic determinism – Koffka's interpretation of the given case appears far more convincing than Luria's assertions.

Similarly, Luria and Koffka diverged on the interpretation of those cases when the subjects did not succumb to optical illusions. According to Luria's interpretation, this meant that these individuals were at a lower stage of socio-economic and, therefore, psychological development. Yet again, Koffka's interpretation was completely different: “Only when the subjects were suspicious, staring a long time at the patterns before making their judgments, the illusions failed to appear with some though by no means with all patterns, in accordance with well-known facts.”

Interestingly, these observations and the interpretation of the data by Koffka are reflected in similar observations that Luria recorded in his own travel diary. Several fragments of this diary were published in the biography authored by his daughter Elena. In these notes made in Central Asia, Luria pointed out the relative ease

in establishing contacts with the socially active subjects and the local participants in collectivization and the building of socialism in Uzbekistan. Quite in contrast, those people who resided in the ‘uncivilized’ remote and mountainous regions and preserved the traditional Central Asian lifestyle typically demonstrated distrust and extreme suspicion to the foreigners:

There was no problem getting into contact with the inhabitants of the *kish-laks* of the central regions, who worked in *sovkhozes* [i.e. collective state farms]: “*Sovkhoz* in the steppe. Suddenly, in the middle of nowhere – state bank branch and drinks shop. Conversations about America; they do not know Germany and Europe here, but they do know socialism. We drink tea and talk till late night. *Pilaf* at midnight. We are in one of the most exotic situations. *Namaz*, cushions, and socialism ...” The inhabitants of distant *kish-laks* related to the participants of the psychological expedition with apparent distrust: “They definitely do not want to talk with us! *Chaikhana* and gloomy outrage ...” It was even more problematic to get acquainted with the inhabitants of the mountainous pasturelands: “They are again afraid of us. At our approach they all flee into the mountains. A Kirghiz woman and panic reaction: ‘Do not jinx the baby!’ ...” (“From A.R. Luria’s trip notes, 1932”, preserved in A. R. Luria archive).

(E. A. Luria, 1994, p. 61)

So, the distrustful and hostile subjects from remote mountainous areas of Shakhimardan were observed by both Luria and Koffka and constituted the very same group of ‘primitives’ who allegedly succumbed to a relatively smaller number of optical illusions in the first expedition in the summer of 1931. Luria observed the fear and distrust of his subjects in the mountainous areas of Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan, but apparently never believed these factors might be of any relevance in the context of his research. In contrast, Koffka not only observed the fear and anxiety but also attributed the difference of the performance of the two groups of subjects primarily to the difference in their emotional state during the experiment. Koffka’s conclusion should be confirmed by further experimental psychological studies measuring the correlation between different emotional states with performance. However, from the perspective of our current discussion another question is of considerable interest: Why would the emotional state of the ‘primitive’ subjects be so different, or, in other words, what were they scared of? The answer to this question can be found in the social history of Central Asia during the tumultuous period following Stalin’s Great Break.

Although Luria noticed the great suspicion, fear, and distrust of the local population of the remote areas of Uzbekistan, he definitely did not consider it scientifically significant. Koffka did not give us a detailed report of the situation there but at least he paid attention to details that Luria did not want to or could not pay attention to. In a letter of July 1, 1932, to his former student Molly Harrower, Koffka wrote the following:

Shaki Mordan [Shakhimardan], our next and final station, must be marvelous from all I hear. About 5,000 feet above sea level, a true resting place. Today the president of the Republic, Uzbekistan, and the president of the neighboring Republic, Kirghizstan, are going to spend a few restful weeks there. The president of the GPU [secret police] here is going with us.

(Harrower, 1983, p. 150)

In other words, on their way to the mountainous regions surrounding the border between Uzbekistan and Kirgizstan the team of researchers was accompanied by two presidents of the two Central Asian Soviet republics and by none other than the local head of the secret police GPU (OGPU as of 1932; subsequently NKVD, then MGB, but best known as KGB and its heir FSB in the contemporary Russian Federation). Thus, strangers associated with state authorities and accompanied by a convoy of security forces visited the remote village to perform some kind of scientific experiments. This alone would be enough to cause feelings of suspicion and anxiety in the local population. However, it appears that there was more to it and that these people were not simply distrustful and suspicious but quite hostile to the regime. Indeed, the establishment of Soviet rule in Central Asia was a long and tortuous process. Resistance by part of the local population, the so-called Basmachi movement, existed long after the official end of the Civil War in the early 1920s.²⁷ One of the strongholds of the movement had been Fergana Valley, where Luria and his colleagues performed their ethno-psychological field studies. The Basmachi revolt was overcome only by the middle of the 1920s, though not completely, by a combination of military actions and concessions to the local population. At the same time, national delimitation began in Central Asia. In this process new republics were formed, though not all had originally the status of independent Soviet Republics within the Soviet Union.²⁸ The national delimitation in the Fergana Valley was especially difficult because of the multi-ethnic nature of its population.

By the end of the 1920s, the attempt to deepen the Sovietization of the Central Asian republics, along with the policies of the Cultural Revolution and forced collectivization, led to another outbreak of Basmachi rebellions. Many small groups of Basmachi were formed in 1928, including in the Fergana Valley. In the course of these rebellions Uzbek poet and Bolshevik activist Hamza Hakimzade Niyazi was killed in 1929 for his anti-religious, pro-women liberation activity in Shakhimardan – subsequently, the final destination of Luria's second expedition of 1932. Two bigger attempts of Basmachi incursions from neighboring countries into the Soviet Union were made in the first half of 1931, a couple of months before Luria's first expedition (Pylev, 2007, pp. 84–88). It is highly likely that – judging against this historical background – the arrival of a large group of Soviet officials and international researchers accompanied by a convoy of secret police forces was perceived as an utterly alarming and even potentially life-threatening experience by the local population of the mountainous areas of Southern Uzbekistan, who, by Luria's admission, were afraid of the newcomers and immediately fled to the mountains.

In sum, the Luria–Koffka controversy provides a clear-cut and most curious example of how Luria and Vygotsky, who are commonly considered to be the founders of so-called ‘cultural-historical psychology’, totally missed these cultural and historical components of the psychological research they conducted in Central Asia. Indeed, their study was ahistorical and non-sensitive to the cultural specificity of the local population. They also used normative tests designed for mental testing of subjects in industrially developed countries. Furthermore, the Bolshevik-minded bias of social activism and progressivism – as manifested by the vulgar Marxist economic determinism in their interpretation of the data – makes this study a spectacular example of the possible impact of political factors on scientific research. By a strange and somewhat ironic turn of events, it was also political factors that withheld this research from publication for several decades to come.

In contrast, Koffka was an outsider to the large-scale processes of rapid and epochal transformation of Soviet society and did not share the social activist enthusiasm of his Russian peers. Thus, he was free from the progressivist and developmental axiomatic basis and the vulgar Marxist bias shown by Vygotsky, Luria, and their associates and collaborators. Moreover, as a representative of the integrative and holistic research tradition of Wertheimer’s Gestalt psychology with its requirements of (1) awareness of concrete *cultural specificity* and idiosyncrasies, (2) holistic perspective on the entire *psychological field* of the subjects, and (3) emphasis on the *meaning* (alternatively: value, significance) of a specific life situation for the individual, Koffka could clearly see what Luria failed to see during his trips to Central Asia. First, Koffka was not satisfied with a purely statistical, quantitative approach to mental testing and was interested in the actual *meaning* of the study for the participants. This is why he supplemented his experimental tests with interviews that possibly gave him a better idea of psychological processes hidden from an objectivist approach. Second, from the outset Koffka was alert to the entire *psychological field* of the subjects in his experiments, therefore, unlike Luria, he did not dismiss as irrelevant the social situation of the experiment, but considered it as an utterly essential factor, which allowed him to realize that the emotional state of the subjects of the study – their naivety and carelessness, or, in contrast, their fear, distrust, and anxiety – caused by the larger social context of the study, in a number of instances notably affected their psychological performance.

Overall, this expedition of 1932 is just one episode in the intriguing and largely unknown history of the convergence between the Soviet scholars of the Vygotsky–Luria circle and the German–American researchers who with some reservation can be called ‘cultural-historical Gestalt psychologists’. In the next chapter we discuss the history and some conceptual issues of this intellectual movement.

9

A TRANSNATIONAL HISTORY OF “THE BEGINNING OF A BEAUTIFUL FRIENDSHIP”

The birth of the cultural-historical Gestalt psychology of Alexander Luria, Kurt Lewin, Lev Vygotsky, and others

Anton Yasnitsky

The three luminaries and pioneers of contemporary psychology, Kurt Lewin, Alexander Luria, and Lev Vygotsky, are well known all over the world and are deservedly credited as highly influential scholars in the fields of social, neuro-, and cultural and developmental psychology, respectively. Despite the apparent gap and virtual absence of communication between these subfields of contemporary psychology, as fragmented as it is nowadays, the connections between these three prominent figures have occasionally been pointed out.

Thus, overall, quite a lot has been said about the connections between the Lewin group and the members of the ‘Vygotsky circle’ (Yasnitsky, 2009b, 2011e) – a lot and virtually nothing at the same time. The scholarly literature presents on a number of occasions bits and pieces of anecdotal evidence to the effect of some contacts between the Soviet scholars and their peers in the West, such as Luria’s and Vygotsky’s foreign trips in the summer of 1925, or the personal encounters between Vygotsky and Lewin in Moscow in 1933, or, for instance, Bluma Zeigarnik’s (the discoverer of the classical ‘Zeigarnik effect’) successive collaboration with Kurt Lewin (until spring of 1931, in Berlin) and Lev Vygotsky (from summer of 1931, in Moscow). However, as surprising as it might seem and despite their apparent importance for the historiography and theory of psychology, these contacts, exchanges, communications, and even collaborations have never been scrutinized in a rigorous scholarly study.

Perhaps the earliest observation of the proximity of some of the ideas of the groups of these Russian and German-American scholars can be found in a book written by one of their contemporaries before World War II. This is *Gestalt psychology. A survey of facts and principles* by George W. Hartmann, which appears to be the first major, book-length work on Gestalt psychology authored by an American and published in North America. According to Hartmann’s observation, “the Russian

investigator, Luria, has independently developed a motor and affective theory which bears an extraordinary resemblance to Lewin's position" (Hartmann, 1935, p. 226). And yet, such observations and statements like this were quite rare until relatively recent years.

Among the studies that most closely approached the topic of the exchanges and parallels between Soviet and Gestalt psychologies one would first mention the work of Scheerer, "Gestalt psychology in the Soviet Union," which traces some lines along which interactions developed between the Soviet representatives of the 'Vygotsky circle' and the German-American Gestalt psychologists. Scheerer covers the period of the 1920s until the so-called "reactological discussion of 1931" and generally argues that in the 1930s Gestalt psychology in the Soviet Union was in decline (Scheerer, 1980), which was elsewhere attributed to Ivan Pavlov's negative stance towards Gestaltism (Windholz, 1984). This conclusion is contested in certain other publications, including this study. Thus, in this respect, of certain interest in this context is recent scholarship that sheds new light on the role of dialectical materialism in the history of the life sciences in the Soviet Union, specifically, Ivan Pavlov's physiology of higher nervous processes that was gradually transformed in the 1930s as a result of peer critique from Pavlov's Bolshevik collaborators and associates, who advocated for the unification of Pavlov's atomism and mechanism with Gestaltist holism (Todes, 2014; Todes & Krementsov, 2010).

The earlier pioneering paper by Scheerer was complemented by several other studies conducted by German scholars of the Critical Psychology camp who critically explored the tenets of Gestalt psychology against the background of dialectic-materialist psychology, underlined the fundamental affinity between the principles of Gestalt theory and so-called 'cultural-historical' theory, and discussed how the potential of Soviet psychological research of a 'Vygotskian' type might be instrumental in overcoming certain problems of Gestaltism (Keiler, 1980, 1981; Stadler, 1975). Cumulatively, this research laid the foundation for subsequent studies by German researchers who explored some interlinks between the Soviet psychology of the 'Vygotsky circle' and the German-American Gestalt psychologists (Keiler, 1989; Stadler, 1989).

An interesting analysis of Lewin's theory of his pre-American period (i.e. before 1933) and the history of Soviet post-World War II developments of Lewinian ideas and experimental techniques can be found in Bluma Zeigarnik's book on Lewin's theory of personality (Zeigarnik, 1981). In addition, an account of the history of interwar Lewinian psychology in Germany and in the Soviet Union was presented in Zeigarnik's memoir interview publication, released posthumously (Yaroshevskii & Zeigarnik, 1988). The drawback of these two publications – a short book and an interview – is that neither represents strictly historiographical research and, besides, both are currently available in Russian only. A considerably shorter version of Zeigarnik's reminiscences on the topic of Lewinian ideas in the Soviet Union is, however, available in German (Zeigarnik, 1984a) and in English (Zeigarnik, 1984b), too. Finally, of certain interest is an older discussion about Lewin and Vygotsky as the two "radical and promising

metatheorists" (Lang, 1994) and a more recent attempt to discuss the ideas of Lewin and Vygotsky in social research (Chaiklin, 2011), but neither of these is a historiographical study, so they might only qualify as a mere introduction to the systematic exploration of the interdependence between the ideas of these two scholars.

Most recently, however, a great deal of work has been done in order to uncover the history of communications and collaborations between Soviet and Western psychologies, specifically, between two large circles of psychologists – Soviet cultural-developmental Marxists and German-American Gestaltists. Thus, the present chapter is based on a series of studies that discuss the idiosyncratic Soviet international governmental policies concerning international scientific exchange and scholars' communicative strategies and behaviors. These studies in fact reveal a great deal of international scientific activity between the Soviets and the West that, contrary to widely accepted views, undermines the common notion of Soviet scientific 'isolationism' in the field of psychology and allied sciences during the inter-war period (Van derVeer & Zavershneva, 2011, 2012; Yasnitsky, 2010b, 2011a, 2011c, 2012b, 2012c, 2012h). Our research is solidly grounded in the recent studies in Vygotsky's archives that demonstrated the growing influence of Kurt Lewin on Lev Vygotsky's thought in his last and most mature period of the 1930s (see Chapters 5 and 6 of this book), as well as the findings of studies that have explored the hybrid of 'cultural-historical Gestalt psychology' as it was emerging at the intersection of the two scientific traditions in the 1930s (Yasnitsky, 2012a, 2012c, 2012d, 2012h, 2012i). This chapter is limited by its focus on the history of the emergence and the development of the dense "informal personal network" (M. B. Adams, 2001) constituted by the Soviet scholars of the 'Vygotsky circle' (see discussion in Chapter 2) and German-American Gestaltists in the period between the two world wars. The close interrelations between these two groups of scholars, the numerous contacts, international trips, and migrations of scholars that led to a range of publishing and collaborative projects, not to mention intense intellectual exchange – all these qualify this research as a distinctly "transnational history" (Heilbron, Guillot, & Jeanpierre, 2008).

1925–1929: Vygotsky's and Luria's trips to Europe and their consequences

Vygotsky's first acquaintance with Gestalt psychology took place not later than the end of 1924: it was on December 22, 1924 that he made a public presentation at the Moscow Institute of Experimental Psychology titled "About the new psychological school in Berlin" (A. R. Luria, 1926, p. 251). And yet, Vygotsky's and Luria's first personal encounter with German scholars most likely took place in the summer of 1925 during their trips to Europe. Both Vygotsky and Luria for different reasons and independently of each other traveled to Western Europe and are known to have visited Berlin, the capital of Germany's liberal-democratic Weimar Republic.

On his European trip Alexander Luria accompanied his father, Roman Albertovich Luria, who was a noted medical doctor and professor in the city of Kazan. Luria senior was habitually visiting Western Europe in order to update his knowledge of the most advanced technologies and practices in his profession and to sustain contacts with his European colleagues (E. A. Luria, 1994). In turn, Vygotsky was sent on a state-funded trip to the conference on the education of the deaf that took place in July 1925 in London (Van der Veer & Zavershneva, 2011). In the course of their European trips both Vygotsky and Luria spent some time in Berlin and established personal contacts with local researchers associated with the circle of Gestaltists. At this point the archival documents that could clarify the details of these visits to Berlin remain unexplored; thus, one needs to rely on fragmentary and circumstantial evidence available in various other sources.

In summer 1925 two of the founders and main proponents of Gestalt psychology, Kurt Koffka and Wolfgang Köhler (at that time the former was employed as a university professor in Giessen and the latter was Director of the Institute of Psychology in Berlin), were in the United States. There, they had a series of relatively short-term professional appointments: in 1924/5 Koffka was at Cornell University as Jacob Schiff Visiting Professor in Education (Ash, 1995, p. 210) and lectured in a great many other American universities¹ (Harrower, 1971), whereas Köhler was a visiting professor at Clark University in the spring and summer of 1925; he then taught at Berkeley and Harvard² and returned to Europe only in early 1926 (Jaeger, 1992).³ Therefore, out of all the leaders of Gestalt psychology in Berlin only two were likely to be met in Berlin in mid-1925. These were Max Wertheimer, the ‘god-father’ of Gestalt psychology and, in the absence of Köhler, the interim Director of the Institute, Kurt Lewin, who also taught at the Berlin Institute of Psychology. At this time we do not have documents that would with certainty confirm Luria’s or Vygotsky’s acquaintance with the two scholars as of summer 1925, however, there is indirect evidence that suggests that it was then that this acquaintance might have taken place.

In all likelihood, Luria first met German Gestalt psychologists – specifically, those of Kurt Lewin’s circle – in 1925 and even took part in Lewin’s student Tamara Dembo’s experimental study of “anger as a dynamic problem” (Dembo, 1931, 1976). According to the memoirs of another former student of Lewin’s, Bluma Zeigarnik, Luria as a twenty-three-year-old subject of this experimental study revealed a highly emotional reaction and somewhat threateningly shouted at the experimenter: “Hold on, Tamara Vasil’evna, just come to us with a visit, and we will show you something!” (Yaroshevskii & Zeigarnik, 1988, p. 178). In turn, in her reminiscences Dembo reportedly characterized Luria as “an interesting, if somewhat difficult, subject” of her experimental study and, like Zeigarnik, recalled Luria’s reaction fairly well: “but her clearest memory of the encounter is his invitation to her to visit Moscow, where, he suggested with feigned aggressiveness, ‘We’ll show you a thing or two about anger!’” (Rosa & Wertsch, 1993, p. 6).⁴

Vygotsky also left apparent traces of his personal contacts with German Gestaltists that in all likelihood took place as early as the summer of 1925. Thus, well known

is Vygotsky's unfinished methodological manuscript that he titled, with variations, "(Historical) meaning of the crisis in psychology" and that was posthumously uncritically published as one of Vygotsky's central theoretical works – for discussion see (Zavershneva, 2012b; Zavershneva & Osipov, 2012a, 2012b). In this text Vygotsky made a most curious claim that "the majority of the influential Gestalt psychologists regard themselves as Marxists in their scientific work" (Vygotsky, 1993b, p. 341) – a statement that can hardly be found in any single work published by the scholars of this theoretical orientation, therefore, apparently, a conclusion that Vygotsky reached on the basis of some first-hand personal encounters. Indeed, Vygotsky refers to a "conversation with one of the most educated psychologists," who, according to Vygotsky, said:

What kind of psychology do you have in Russia? That you are Marxists does not yet tell what kind of psychologists you are. Knowing of Freud's popularity in Russia, I at first thought of the Adlerians. After all, these are also Marxists. But you have a totally different psychology. We are also social-democrats and Marxists, but at the same time we are Darwinists and followers of Copernicus as well.

(Vygotsky, 1993b, p. 341)

Vygotsky never left an indication of who his self-proclaimed "social-democrat and Marxist" interlocutor was, but we have every reason to assume that Vygotsky's conclusion – whether right or wrong – about the Marxist sympathies of Gestalt psychologists was based on this or a very similar conversation that took place during his European trip of summer 1925.

There should be no doubt about how different were the relative scholarly 'weights', reputations, and international fame of the most notable of Gestalt psychologists in Berlin and their guests from the Soviet Union as of summer 1925. In 1898, when Max Wertheimer – who would eventually become the founder of Gestalt psychology – started his university studies in his native city Prague, Luria was not yet born and Vygotsky was two years old. In turn, by the time Vygotsky started his university studies in Moscow in 1913, Wertheimer had already defended his doctoral dissertation (University of Würzburg, 1904), and, then, conducted and published his first experimental studies that would lay the foundation of the intellectual movement subsequently known worldwide as Gestalt psychology (Wertheimer, 1912a, 1912b). Finally, by 1925 the group of Gestalt psychologists led by the ambitious, innovative scholars Max Wertheimer, Kurt Koffka, and Wolfgang Köhler had already founded their journal *Psychologische Forschung* (Psychological Research), a specialized publication that from its inception in 1921 served as the major publication outlet and the channel for dissemination of the ideas of the new psychological movement. In addition, by 1925 the group of German scholars not only published a series of books that presented the new psychological theory's main tenets and their experimental findings (Koffka, 1921; Köhler, 1917, 1920, 1921; Wertheimer, 1920, 1925a), but also started their expansion into the English-speaking academic world

that was manifested by a few notable publications in English (Koffka, 1922, 1924a, 1924b; Köhler, 1925).

In comparison to the wealth of first-rate scholarly studies and influential German and English publications that came out under the names of internationally renowned Gestaltist researchers, the academic achievements of Luria and Vygotsky by the time of their European trips of 1925 were modest and best. Thus, it comes as no surprise that the scholarship of their Western peers was highly respected by the younger Soviet researchers and influenced their work. This influence, however, was initially limited to the experimental studies in the footsteps of Wolfgang Köhler, who conducted his seminal research on the use of tools and problem-solving in apes at the Primate Station of the Prussian Academy of Sciences on Tenerife (Canary Islands), located just off the northwest coast of mainland Africa (Köhler, 1917, 1921, 1925). The members of the Vygotsky–Luria research team replicated Köhler’s studies during their ‘instrumental period’ of the 1920s in order to investigate the so-called ‘practical intellect’ in children. Yet, the influence of Gestaltist work was not limited to replication studies. Another important aspect of Soviet–Gestaltist convergence was the beginning of the transnational ‘import’ of Gestaltist ideas in the mid-1920s; the Vygotsky–Luria group were fairly active advocates of this theoretical movement in the Soviet Union.

In 1926, a volume of scientific papers authored by the researchers affiliated with the Moscow Institute of Psychology came out in Leningrad under the editorship of Konstantin Kornilov, Director of the Institute. This volume, characteristically titled *Problemy sovremennoi psikhologii* (The problems of contemporary psychology), contained a section “From new foreign literature” that featured the only paper authored by a non-member of the Institute, furthermore, a foreigner. This was Kurt Koffka’s paper “Samonabludenie i metod psikhologii” (Self-observation and the method of psychology) (Koffka, 1926) that had been presented two years before at the University of Cambridge Psychological Laboratory on February 23, 1924, and then, in October 1924, published as a journal article in the *British Journal of Psychology* (Koffka, 1924a).

Vygotsky and Luria were notable and most active participants in the preparation of this publication. Thus, out of the twelve chapters that constituted the first three sections of the book (titled I. General and theoretical papers; II. Experimental studies; and III. Overviews, smaller papers) three were authored by Vygotsky and another one by Luria (in collaboration with A. N. Leontiev). Besides, in his capacity as scientific secretary of the Institute, Luria wrote an overview chapter titled “Moscow State Institute of Experimental Psychology in 1924” that comprised the whole last section of the book (i.e. VI. Scientific chronicle). These circumstances allow us to assume that the publication of Koffka’s paper, translated into Russian, took place in connection with Vygotsky’s and Luria’s foreign trips of 1925 and upon their initiative. This assumption is partially confirmed by the fact that Koffka’s paper came out with Vygotsky’s introduction (Vygotskii, 1926; Vygotsky, 1993a). This introduction gives us an opportunity to assess the intended meaning of this ‘imported publication’ from the perspective of the Soviet editors of the Russian volume.

In his introduction, Vygotsky presented the author of the paper as "one of the most prominent representatives" of a relatively new current – and the "most influential and interesting of all currents" – in contemporary Western psychological theory, "the so-called Gestalt-psychologie," or "the theory of form, the psychology of form, structural psychology, as it is usually translated into other languages" (Vygotsky, 1993a, p. 82). The meaning and importance of this new psychological theory, as Vygotsky claimed in the idiosyncratic Bolshevik newspeak of his time, is in its contribution to the "most intense and acute war in which everything alive in psychology is involved" (Vygotsky, 1993a, p. 81). This is the war against vulgar empiricism, spiritualistic and idealistic subjectivism, vitalism, physiological positivism, and reductionism. This war is characteristic not only of the seemingly marginal and exotic Marxist psychology in the making in the Soviet Union, but even for the most advanced psychological theories in the West. In this paper, Vygotsky mentions American behaviorism as one such advanced theory at the time of its inception in the 1910s and notes Russian psychologists' temporary alliance with this theory; however, he argues that the time has virtually come for decisive separation from these former "fellow-travelers" in the struggle for the truly dialectical and non-reductionist psychology of biosocial and cultural development:

Being yesterday's allies in the general war against subjectivism and empiricism, they may turn out to be our enemies of tomorrow – in the struggle for the establishment of the foundations of the social psychology of societal man, for the liberation of the psychology of man from its biological captivity, and for the return of its meaning as an independent science rather than one of the chapters of comparative psychology. In other words, as soon as we turn to the construction of psychology as the science of the behavior of social man, rather than that of a higher mammal, the dividing line with yesterday's allies clearly takes shape.

(Vygotsky, 1993a, p. 81)

This publication of a Western, 'bourgeois' author's paper in a collection of works by researchers affiliated with the Moscow Institute of Psychology was somewhat strange, but appears to have performed a quite definite communicative purpose. Koffka's paper in all likelihood was supposed to demonstrate to its readers that psychology as a scientific discipline in the Soviet Union and this discipline in the West were facing very similar problems and were passing through similar phases in their historical development in their opposition to various reductionist psychological theories and the extremes of spiritualism, vitalism, and mechanicism. In his preface Vygotsky argues that the actual problems of Soviet Marxist science were in fact a part of the more general, global process that also involved the most progressive Western theories. Thus, Marxist psychology in the USSR and German Gestalt psychology, according to Vygotsky, developed in parallel towards a really new and revolutionary psychological theory:

[O]bjective immanent driving forces of the development of psychological science act in the same direction as the Marxist reform of psychology. To see this we just have to stop looking at the developing crisis in psychology through the narrow window of our debate with the empiricists and view it on the scale of international science.

(Vygotsky, 1993a, p. 83)

In his introduction to this publication Vygotsky predicted further divergence between Soviet psychology and Gestalt theory that, in his assessment of the mid-1920s, “will grow as both currents develop.” This prediction turned out to be wrong. It appeared that if not all Soviet psychology, then the ‘Vygotsky–Luria circle’ at least continuously converged with the group of Gestalt psychologists, their students, and followers during the second half of the 1920s and, particularly, in the 1930s. Alexander Luria played a very important role in this process as one of the most important and active scientific brokers between Western and Soviet scholars from the 1920s until the last days of his life.

Therefore, the beginning of the encounters and exchanges between the two groups of researchers was in 1925. Subsequently, international connections between Soviet and German–American Gestalt psychologists developed and intensified. Thus, the translation of a Gestaltist scholar’s work into Russian was followed by the publication of Alexander Luria’s paper, in German, in the Gestaltist journal *Psychologische Forschung* (A. R. Luria, 1929a). The European trips of Luria and Vygotsky of 1925 were soon followed by a Gestaltist scholar’s visit to Soviet Russia. This scholar was Kurt Gottschaldt (1902–91), a former student of Max Wertheimer’s who defended his doctoral dissertation in Berlin in 1926 (Ash, 1995) and visited the USSR in the second half of the 1920s, most likely in 1926/7.⁵ During his visit Gottschaldt made official scholarly presentations. Vygotsky accompanied Gottschaldt on his Soviet trip – specifically, in Leningrad – and was so impressed by this meeting with the German scholar and his research that he recalled Gottschaldt’s work several years later, in lectures delivered in the spring of 1932 at the Herzen Leningrad State Pedagogical Institute.⁶

And yet, it seems that full-scale personal and scholarly contacts and interactions between the Gestaltists and the Soviet researchers of the Vygotsky–Luria group did not take place until 1929. However, by the end of the 1920s, the situation dramatically changed, apparently to a large extent due to the impact of the IX International Congress of Psychology that was held in the United States in September 1929.

1929–1930: IX International Congress of Psychology and the “holistic revolution”

The IX International Congress of Psychology, the first psychological congress outside Europe, was organized in the United States in 1929, and Luria took part in it. Thus, his second – and the last prewar – foreign trip lasted several months, from

August–October 1929, during which he attended the Congress in September, for a month or so traveled along the East Coast of the United States, and on the way back to Soviet Russia relatively briefly stayed in Germany, where he met his peers, Gestalt psychologists (for a reconstruction of Luria's trip of 1929 see Yasnitsky, 2012h).

The Vygotsky–Luria group prepared two papers to be presented at the Congress: first, Luria's presentation on the "new method of expressive motor reactions in studying affective traces" (A. R. Luria, 1930c); second, a co-authored work by Vygotsky and Luria on "egocentric speech" and their research method of "double stimulation" (Vygotsky & Luria, 1930). For some reason or other Vygotsky did not attend the congress, so it was Luria who presented both papers in the United States. The Congress was held between September 1 and 7, 1929, and in order to get to the Congress for its beginning Luria left the Soviet Union in mid-August. In principle, he could have met his peers in Germany on the way to America, yet this is quite unlikely given that Luria described the European part of the trip as a "Moscow–Paris–Ocean" transit, which was "furthermore, so fast and hectic" (E. A. Luria, 1994, p. 46). Nevertheless, Luria most certainly met his Gestaltist peers at the Congress, attended, among others, by Wolfgang Köhler, Kurt Lewin, and Kurt Koffka. Thus, Luria was bound to meet Lewin on September 4, when his co-authored paper "The function and fate of egocentric speech" was scheduled for the same session as Lewin's paper "Die Auswirkung von Umweltkräften" (The impact of the forces of environment) (Lewin, 1930).⁷ Lewin presented in German and although, possibly, not everyone in the audience could understand and appreciate all the nuances of Lewin's theorizing, the presentation turned out quite a success due to Lewin's demonstration of his film illustrating all key points of his presentation and his theory (Lück & van Elteren, 1990).

We still do not know when and under what circumstances Luria and Kurt Koffka first met. Thus, from 1924 Koffka mostly worked and resided outside Germany, chiefly in the United States. At the time of the IX International Congress of Psychology, in 1929, Koffka held a professorship at Smith College in Northampton, MA. Yet, it is known that in 1929 they were acquainted, shared accommodation in Worcester, MA, and even made several short trips around the place.⁸ At the end of his North American trip in mid-October Luria left for Europe⁹ and from late October he was in the Old World. If his trip developed in accordance with the earlier plans, then from October 25 to November 5 Luria was in Berlin, where he anticipated meeting his fellow psychologists and noted Soviet film director Sergei Eisenstein, who was traveling across Europe at that time.¹⁰

The new boost that was given to the interconnections between the Soviet and the German–American Gestaltist scholars at the Congress contributed to the establishment of the transnational informal network of researchers that fully developed in the 1930s. The immediate outcome of the activities of this network was a series of 'imported' publications in the Soviet Union that gave considerable exposure to the ideas of the Gestalt theorists in Russian. Among these Russian publications are Koffka's lecture of 1932 that came out in the Soviet journal *Psikhologiya* in 1932

(Koffka, 1932) and translations of important Gestaltist books such as *The mentality of apes* by Wolfgang Köhler (Keler, 1930) and Kurt Koffka's book on child and developmental psychology (Koffka, 1934). The former was translated from German by two of Vygot'sky's close associates at the Defectological Institute: L. V. Zankov and I. M. Solov'ev. The book came out under Vygot'sky's editorship and was supplemented with his introductory chapter (Vygot'skii, 1930a), which is, in fact, virtually identical to his other paper that had been published as a journal article a year before (Vygot'skii, 1929b). Then, Koffka's book came out as an "authorized translation by R. and B. Levin" – the first translator most likely being Roza Levina, yet another of Vygot'sky's and Luria's students and collaborators – proofread by Luria¹¹ and prefaced by Vygot'sky (Vygot'skii, 1934c). These introductions were complemented by yet another of Vygot'sky's publications, with a popular exposition of Gestalt psychology in Russian (Vygot'skii, 1930c). This was his book chapter of 1930 titled "Strukturnaia psikhologiya" (Structural psychology): notably, the Russian word *struktura* (structure) was the quite usual translation of the German word *Gestalt* in Vygot'sky's writings of that period. Subsequently, Luria briefly negotiated the Russian translation and publication in the Soviet Union of Kurt Koffka's and Kurt Lewin's later works such as their books of the mid-1930s (Koffka, 1935; Lewin, 1935a, 1936). These projects, though, were never to materialize.

And yet, perhaps the most immediate effect of Luria's exchanges during the IX International Congress of Psychology was a relatively short-lived but fairly intensive research project that Luria most energetically and enthusiastically launched upon his return home after the Congress. This project had two roots. First, Kurt Lewin's convincing demonstration of the promise and perspectives of video-capturing technology in psychological research (Lück & van Elteren, 1990; Van Elteren, 1992). Second, Luria's friendship with the Soviet movie director Sergei Eisenstein and involvement in his quest for a psychological theory in the practice and emerging theory of cinema production (Bulgakova, 2001). It is at the intersection of these two influences that Luria's new project was founded as a double-sided research on psychology for the cinema and on the cinema for psychology. The impact of psychology on Sergei Eisenstein and his cinematographic experiments has already been presented elsewhere (Bulgakova, 2014) and is beyond the scope of this discussion. On the other hand, the impact of film production on the development of Soviet psychology remains far from clear to this day.

Thus, as early as at the end of 1929 Luria initiated the establishment of an international cinema association and international exchange of films produced for the purposes of psychological research. Luria informed Lewin that he and his associates had founded a laboratory at the Institute of Cinematography in Moscow. According to Luria, this meant that apart from the necessity of delivering lectures and supervising student film directors' projects, they had a valuable opportunity to produce interesting new films.¹² In this context, Luria planned to establish film exchanges between Soviet and German psychologists and even announced the first series of films to be sent to Germany that he produced with his collaborators in their studies of the development of attention and arithmetic thinking in children. In turn, Luria

was hoping to receive from Lewin the films demonstrating Gestaltist research on apes – most likely those produced by Köhler in the course of his research on the Primate Station in Tenerife – and Lewin's movie that showed the little girl Hanna, who attempted to sit down on a stone, which would require turning her back to the object. The two tasks performed simultaneously posed a notable and virtually insurmountable problem for the little girl, which was a major point in Lewin's 'topological' theorizing. This international exchange of films was a far from trivial matter, apparently, for censorship reasons. Thus, although Luria as of early 1930 did manage to obtain official permission to export video materials from the Soviet Union we still have no evidence that anything was in fact sent across the border in either direction.¹³ In any case, film production appears to have become one of the important research tools for the Vygotsky–Luria group. Thus, for instance, as of 1934 a laboratory of film production was a structural unit within the newly founded Department of Psychology at the Ukrainian Psychoneurological Academy in Kharkov (Soviet Socialist Republic of Ukraine), led by its Director, Alexander Luria (Galperin, 1934). No documentary traces of any of these films – reportedly produced during experimental studies by the Vygotsky–Luria group – are known of to date. And yet, several still-frame pictures have been published in at least a couple of sources (A. N. Leontiev, 1931, pp. 85–86, 160, 167; Vygotskaya & Lifanova, 1996, p. 158): pictures that might have been taken from such films, possibly, yet to be discovered.

In the context of this discussion of the possible influences on Luria's (and, probably, Vygotsky's) interest in the potential of film equipment in psychological research it seems that the name of yet another an innovative researcher and thinker should be mentioned, besides those of Eisenstein and Lewin. This is Nikolai Aleksandrovich Bernstein (1896–1966), who considerably enriched both the theory and experimental methods of the Vygotsky–Luria group's research. Bernstein, a mathematician and physiologist, investigated human movements in the natural settings of human functioning in the context of personally meaningful and socially rewarded activity. Bernstein considerably revised the foundations of psychophysiological research and designed a few original and innovative research methods that allowed him and his collaborators, using movie production technologies, to capture human movement with high precision and at extremely short time intervals. We have certain reasons to assume that Bernstein was also instrumental in Luria's (and, presumably, Vygotsky's) efforts to bring together film production and psychological research. The evidence in support of this hypothesis is Vygotsky's photography, likely taken after an experimental study that involved his wife and elder daughter Gita. This photograph was published in his daughter's reminiscences interspersed with historiographical research by Tamara Lifanova. The caption under the picture reads: "After the conclusion of an experiment. (An image from a film produced by Nikolai Aleksandrovich Bernstein. Study participant – the daughter of Lev Semenovich [Vygotsky] – on her mother's lap)" (Vygotskaya & Lifanova, 1996, p. 159). Neither the source of the picture nor the location of the film is presently known.

And yet, apart from Luria's enthusiasm for film production techniques for the purposes of psychological research, the experience of participation in the IX International Congress of Psychology had a considerably more profound impact on the entire course of subsequent empirical research and theorizing in the group of Vygotsky and Luria. It seems quite appropriate to characterize this impact as a 'holistic revolution' of the early 1930s.

Indeed, after his return from the foreign trip of later in 1929 Luria wrote and published several reports on his experiences abroad, most notable of which are two publications: a long paper on the current trends in contemporary psychology in the journal *Estestvoznaniye i marksizm* (Natural sciences and Marxism) (A. R. Luria, 1930b) and a shorter version, titled "International congress of psychologists in America (September 1–7, 1929)" in the journal *Nauchnoe slovo* (literally: Scientific word) (A. R. Luria, 1930a). In the first part of the latter Luria reflected on the experience of his transatlantic trip and presented a detailed overview of the social and research practices of psychologists in a number of leading American research universities, such as Columbia, Yale, Harvard, and Princeton. The second part of this paper is the author's analysis of the state of the art in contemporary psychology as represented at the Congress. Quite in agreement with the contemporary agenda of scientific and philosophical discussions in the Soviet Union, in his analysis Luria put the main emphasis on the contrast between the mechanist orientation of behaviorist psychology, dominant in the United States, and the new, holistic theories of such researchers as Wolfgang Köhler, Karl Lashley – "perhaps, the most prominent American psychoneurologist" (A. R. Luria, 1930a, p. 94) – George E. Coghill, and Kurt Lewin:

All these investigations create a new conceptual system that is considerably different from that habitual to the authors, whose work is grounded in the mechanistic worldview. The notion of behavior as the result of a combination of isolated reflectory acts is substituted in these new studies with a different understanding of behavior that is based on the conception of complex dynamic changes, always more or less integral and structurally different at different developmental stages, distinctly differentiated, but necessarily dynamic. This worldview that in psychology and physiology is apparently overtaking the primitive mechanistic worldview has not fully developed yet. However, the scientific findings that keep coming from various disciplines – from physiology and neurodynamics, genetic [i.e. developmental] and pathological psychology – lead us to a conclusion that international psychoneurology is undergoing a serious crisis and, moreover, that it is starting to overcome this crisis.

(A. R. Luria, 1930a, pp. 95–96)

Luria concludes his overview paper with a comparative analysis of the IX International Psychological Congress in the United States in September 1929 and the I All-Union Congress on the Study of Human Behavior that was held in

Leningrad several months later, in January 1930. Not surprisingly, the author is fully in favor of the centralized, state-funded, and planned Soviet science of the period of the First Five-Year Plan.

The 'holistic revolution' that Luria discussed in his paper had an enormous impact on Soviet science, which was undergoing the process of radical revision of its philosophical, theoretical, and methodological foundations in 1929–32, urged by the struggle (initiated by the Party leadership) on two fronts: against reductionist mechanism and overly abstract 'menshevizing idealism', alienated from everyday social life (Stalin's terminological coinage). Thus, the 'holistic revolution' that Luria imported into the Soviet Union after the IX International Congress of Psychology perfectly suited the current agenda of domestic scientific discussions and suggested new pathways in the human sciences. Vygotsky's case was no exception, and a holistic mindset appeared instrumental in his effort to overcome the numerous drawbacks and limitations of his theory that he acknowledged and on numerous occasions severely criticized (for a discussion of Vygotsky's self-critique see Chapter 4 above).

1930–1931 and later: migrations of German Gestaltists

At the beginning of the 1930s, the students of Kurt Lewin and other Gestaltists from Berlin started massive international migrations. These migrations have not yet been subjected to rigorous scholarly study, the exceptions being as rare as they are laudable (Van der Veer, 2000b; Woodward, 2010). The reasons for these migrations are numerous, including the Great Depression that to a larger or smaller extent involved virtually all economically developed countries from 1929 until the outbreak of World War II; the complexities of the job market for women – even more problematic: Jewish females – in Germany during the Weimar Republic; or the end of the foreign job appointments for Soviet citizens (in diplomatic, trade, etc. organizations), who were the spouses of some students and collaborators of Kurt Lewin's. As a result of all these tribulations, one group of Lewin's students had finished their studies in Berlin and moved to the British Mandate of Palestine (in what is today the State of Israel): thus, for instance, Sara Fajans (*alias* Sara Fajans-Glück) is known to have moved to the future Israel as early as the 1930s.¹⁴ Under yet unknown circumstances a number of Lewin's other students made the same life choice, so that by the mid-1960s a group of Lewinians were settled in Israel. This group included – in addition to Sara Fajans – Sara Fohrer, Sarah Schlossberg (*alias* Sliosberg), and Wera Mahler.¹⁵

The group of Lewin's students in Berlin included a number of female students of Russian origin who conducted their doctoral research studies in the second half of the 1920s and published them in *Psychologische Forschung* in German (Birenbaum, 1930; Dembo, 1931; Ovsiankina, 1928; Zeigarnik, 1927). None of the Russian-speaking associates of Lewin moved to Israel. Yet, for different reasons, all Lewin's 'Russian' students relocated from Germany to other countries: Tamara

Dembo (in 1929 to the Netherlands, in 1930 to the USA), Gita Birenbaum (in 1930 to the USSR), Maria Ovsiankina (*alias* Rickers-Ovsiankina: in 1930, USA), Nina Kaulina (in 1930, USSR), and Bluma Zeigarnik (in summer of 1931, USSR). Thus, from the beginning of the 1930s the core of the American 'Russian group' of Lewin's students was formed by Dembo and Rickers-Ovsiankina. They were soon joined by another female psychologist of Russian origin and with a German doctoral degree in psychology (from the University of Jena), Eugenia Hanfmann.

Hanfmann was destined to become one of the most notable figures in the imported versions of Gestalt psychology and the 'Vygotskiana' in America. Thus, not only did she work together with Tamara Dembo in Kurt Koffka's research laboratory at Smith College upon their arrival in the United States in 1930–32, but also – as a colleague, friend, and co-author of Lewin's two 'Russian' German-American students – she collaborated in several their studies and publications in the Gestaltist vein (Dembo & Hanfmann, 1933, 1934, 1935; Hanfmann, Rickers-Ovsiankina, & Goldstein, 1944). At the same time, she was instrumental in the dissemination of Vygotskian ideas. Hanfmann, along with another American scholar of Russian origin, the medical doctor and psychiatrist Jacob Kasanin, published a series of studies that followed and further developed Vygotsky's research in the USA (Hanfmann & Kasanin, 1937, 1942; Kasanin, 1944; Kasanin & Hanfmann, 1938). In addition, Hanfmann was one of the very first translators of Vygotsky's works into English (Vygotsky, 1939, 1962).

Perhaps, another name should be mentioned in this context. This is another German-American psychologist of Russian origin, Alexander Mintz (his wife, Vera Efron-Mintz, an instructor in Russian at Smith College, was also of Russian origin). Alexander Mintz was the last of Kurt Koffka's students in Germany, and defended his dissertation in the University of Giessen (Mintz, 1928) and then followed Koffka to the United States in order to become his collaborator and assistant at Koffka's newly founded laboratory at Smith College as early as the winter of 1927/8.¹⁶ Koffka and Mintz's – as well as Koffka and Hanfmann's – studies "from the Research Laboratory of Smith College" were published in English in the Gestaltist journal *Psychologische Forschung* in 1930s (Koffka & Hanfmann, 1937; Koffka & Mintz, 1931). Subsequently, during the Cold War era, Mintz was also known as one of the 'scientific brokers' between the East and the West and was apparently considered among the leading specialists in contemporary Soviet psychology (Mintz, 1958, 1959, 1962).

The group of former Lewinians in the Soviet Union was represented by Gita Birenbaum, Nina Kaulina, and Bluma Zeigarnik. Birenbaum and Zeigarnik are relatively well known by their publications. In contrast, Kaulina has remained quite an obscure figure. Indeed, Kaulina belongs to a group of Lewin's virtually unknown students and collaborators who, presumably, pursued their studies under Lewin's supervision, but for unclear reasons either did not finish or never published their works. We know about these individuals from Lewin's overviews of his research, most notably the final chapter of his English-language book of 1935, where he mentions a few researchers (and the topics of their studies), such as Erfurth, Saathop, and Wöhrmann (and their collaborative study on the "speed of satiation in normal

and feeble-minded children"); Köpke ("Substitute satisfaction in normal and in feeble-minded children");¹⁷ Lange ("Action unities in the occupations of the kindergarten"); Rosenfeld ("The ontogeny of experiences of success and failure"), Ucko ("An investigation upon the effect of prohibition"); Wiehe ("The behavior of the child in strange fields" and "Die Grenzen des Ichs" [The boundaries of the ego]) (Lewin, 1935a).

Unlike many of these collaborators of Lewin's, Kaulina is mentioned in his book only once and the topic of her seemingly unfinished study is given only most generally and in relation to somebody else's research: "Zeigarnik attacks the important question of the firmness of form of nonsense systems. (This question is directly investigated in an unpublished work of Kaulina and plays an essential part in that of Schwarz.)" (Lewin, 1935a, p. 244). A little bit more information about Kaulina and her research can be found in a Russian book on Kurt Lewin's theory of personality authored by Bluma Zeigarnik, where in one of her last interviews she gives the full name of the subject – Nina Nikolaevna Kaulina (Yaroshevskii & Zeigarnik, 1988, p. 175) – and describes her work as a study, in Lewin's words, of "nonsense systems" that, according to Zeigarnik, showed that "in those experimental subjects who only observed the course of experiment on the interrupted task, but did not perform any task, the phenomenon of better recall of unfinished actions [i.e. the so-called "Zeigarnik effect"] was not found" (Zeigarnik, 1981, p. 43).

Birenbaum and Kaulina returned to the Soviet Union in 1930 and very soon joined the Vygotsky–Luria group there, and are known to have led a series of research group meetings in 1930–1 with a number of thematic presentations and subsequent group discussions. Thus, Kaulina's presentation "Psychological charge and form in the process of remembering" took place on October 29, 1930. Soon thereafter another 'Lewinian' lecture was delivered: Birenbaum presented her work "On forgetting intentions" on November 9, 1930. Half a year later Zeigarnik arrived from Berlin and virtually immediately joined this research group: her two presentations were reportedly given on June 10 and 17, 1931. In these Zeigarnik presented a range of studies that had been conducted by that time by the members of Kurt Lewin's research team in Berlin (Akhutina, 2012).

It appears that the arrival of these former students of Lewin's made a considerable impact on the work of the Vygotsky–Luria group. A characteristically laudatory account of the encounter with Lewin's students and presentations of their research can be found in Vygotsky and Luria's correspondence, for instance, in Vygotsky's letter to Luria of June 12–16,¹⁸ 1931:

Zeigarnik has arrived. At the laboratory meeting on the tenth [i.e. June 10, 1931], she presented a report on some new studies (*Hoppe's* success and nonsuccess, *Sättigung*, the switching of *Spannung* to other pathways – the problem of *Ersatz* in satisfying needs). It was good. Refined. Clever. A bit of a woman's needlework. Very much in the style of *Lewin*. She's going to present another report to us tomorrow.¹⁹

(Vygotsky, 2007, p. 35)

Moreover, upon their return to the Soviet Union, former Lewin students – Birenbaum and Zeigarnik – found jobs at Moscow's Institute for the Research of Higher Nervous Activity²⁰ and joined the research activities of the Vygotsky–Luria group. The employment and future research options for Kaulina were also considered in the context of the discussion of Zeigarnik's employment. According to Vygotsky's same letter of June 12, there were plans to create a large research team that would include all former students of Lewin's: "What about her [i.e. Zeigarnik's] work? She wants to go (1) to a clinic, (2) to an institute, (3) into pedagogical work ... She wants to work where we are. A true thought: Birnbaum [*sic; recte*: Birenbaum], she, Kaulina + us – now that is a force to be reckoned with"²¹ (Vygotsky, 2007, p. 35). Yet, there is no evidence of Kaulina's participation in the research projects of the Vygotsky–Luria group and their associates until the mid-1930s.

The closest contact and collaboration between Soviet scholars of the Vygotsky–Luria circle and German-Russian psychologists in the tradition of Gestalt theory started, thus, in 1930–1. Yet, this was definitely only the beginning of a much larger process of mutual exchanges and transnational collaborations. In 1932 two events were particularly important from the perspective of the growing convergence between Soviet and German-American scholars.

First, Kurt Koffka made a foreign trip from the United States, via Germany, to the Soviet Union in order to take part in Alexander Luria's second 'psychological expedition' to Central Asia. Koffka's study of optical illusions in the local population considerably undermined Luria's conclusion that "Uzbeks have no illusions" and launched the Luria–Koffka controversy that first emerged in Luria's brief published presentation of the second expedition and Koffka's report on his findings that came out within Luria's paper (Luria, 1934) (for an in-depth discussion of this expedition and the Luria–Koffka controversy, see Chapter 8).

Second, it was also in 1932 that Kurt Lewin, following an invitation from Stanford University, made his foreign trip to the United States, where he spent one semester from mid-1932 until early 1933. On his way back home, Lewin decided to make a return trip from the western coast of the USA to Germany via Japan and the Soviet Union, the two countries where his former Berlin students resided and worked at that time. Thus, Soviet scholars got an opportunity to meet Lewin in the spring of 1933 when he arrived in Moscow. There is anecdotal evidence of Lewin's frequent contacts with a number of Soviet psychologists – Vygotsky, Luria, and Zeigarnik among them. During his stay in the USSR Lewin allegedly gave public presentations of his research and even demonstrated his films to the audience (Vygodskaya & Lifanova, 1996; Yaroshevskii & Zeigarnik, 1988). There is no clarity as to where Lewin was accommodated during his stay in Moscow, yet, according to his telegram of April 30, 1933, he suggested return mail should be sent to Vygotsky's home address in Moscow (Lück, 2001, p. 174).²²

From Lewin's correspondence with his wife and colleagues it follows that he was going to emigrate from Germany after the Nazi ascent to power on January 30, 1933 and the introduction of discriminatory anti-Semitic laws prohibiting Jewish employment in governmental and state-funded positions such as those in

universities. It seems that in spring 1933 Lewin considered several options for emigration including the United States, the Soviet Union, and, presumably, Austria or the Netherlands.²³ Somewhat later, in the mid-1930s Lewin negotiated his move to Jerusalem in order to take a position at the Hebrew University of Jerusalem (Bargal, 1992, 1998). Yet, only one of these plans was to materialize: Lewin spent several weeks in Moscow in April–May, 1933, briefly stayed in Germany to pick up his family, and left the country forever. From then the new period in his life and academic career is inseparable from the United States, the country where he stayed for the rest of life (Marrow, 1969).

Like Lewin, after the Nazi rise to power quite a number of other intellectuals of 'non-Aryan' – i.e. of Jewish – origin left Germany. Sooner or later virtually the whole leadership of German Gestalt psychology moved from Germany, mainly to the United States. These are Kurt Lewin and Max Wertheimer (in 1933, USA), Kurt Goldstein (in 1933, the Netherlands, then, in 1935, the USA), Adhémar Gelb (in 1933, the Netherlands, then Sweden), and many others. In 1935 Wolfgang Köhler – long-term Director of the Institute of Psychology in Berlin, 1922–35, an ethnic German, and one of the founders of Gestalt psychology – left Germany for the United States.

1930s: "holistic revolution" in a Lewinian key

The new, holistic paradigm in psychology – so much in demand in the Soviet Union in the early 1930s – was represented by a number of theories, from which the work of Kurt Lewin and his group was the important one for Vygotsky and Luria. In his correspondence of the early 1930s Vygotsky clearly expressed his excitement about the work of Lewin and the members of his circle.²⁴ Indeed, the influence of Kurt Lewin's thought on Vygotsky was profound. On the one hand, Lewin deeply influenced Vygotsky's thinking in the sphere of the methodology of scientific research understood in terms of Lewin's requirement for the transition from 'Aristotelian' to 'Galileian' modes of thinking in psychology (Lewin, 1931), that is, from an 'instrumental' to a holistic and systemic mindset in Vygotsky's theory. On the other hand, experimental practices in Lewinian studies were another major influence on Vygotsky and his group. These studies were typically conducted by Lewin's students in Berlin and were mostly published in German in the journal *Psychologische Forschung* in 1927–33, including the highly influential studies of Bluma Zeigarnik (1927), Maria Ovsiankina (1928), Anitra Karsten (1928), Gita Birenbaum (1930), Ferdinand Hoppe (1930), Tamara Dembo (1931), and others. Kurt Lewin succinctly surveyed all these studies of his Berlin period in the concluding chapter of his first English-language book, published in the United States in 1935, after his immigration from Germany (Lewin, 1935a).

A number of scholars and research groups – such as the group of clinical psychologists led by Vladimir Miasischev, in Leningrad²⁵ – demonstrated considerable

interest in Lewin's work, Vygotsky's group being one of the most active and devoted followers and, at the same time, critics of Lewin. Several lines of research in Lewin's footsteps done by the members of Vygotsky and Luria's group can be discerned.

First, these are the studies by the former Lewin students Birenbaum and Zeigarnik, who moved to the Soviet Union and joined the Vygotsky–Luria group. These collaborative studies were conducted in clinical settings in Moscow institutions and a few of them were published in the 1930s in Russian. The studies of this strand can be characterized as a more or less successful attempt at theoretical synthesis between Vygotskian and Lewinian ideas. It appears that, unfortunately, none of these publications is available in translation (for an overview see Chapter 2).

A second line of research was pursued at Moscow's Epstein Experimental Defectological Institute (EDI; in the mid-1930s reorganized and renamed Scientific-Practical Institute of Special Schools and Children's Houses of the *Narkompros* of the RSFSR). The only paper dealing with a few replication studies that was eventually published was I. M. Solov'ev's study of will and emotions in mentally retarded children (Solov'ev–Elpidinskii, 1935). The study was solidly grounded in the Lewin group's research and used the experimental method of Anitra Karsten's investigation of the phenomenon of 'mental satiation' that emerges in monotonous, routine, and meaningless activity (Karsten, 1976). Solov'ev's research included three relatively independent studies that were conducted in 1930, 1931, and 1932, respectively. This was the study that was presented during one of the 'internal conferences' of the Vygotsky–Luria group that was held in October, 1932 (for discussion of this topic see Chapter 6).

Solov'ev's study was published as a book chapter in 1935. This book contained two other chapters, one by L. V. Zankov, the other by Vygotsky. Vygotsky's contribution is particularly relevant and important in the context of this discussion. Vygotsky's chapter, "The problem of mental retardation" (Vygotskii, 1935c), in all likelihood was intended as a response to Kurt Lewin's article written for the memorial volume for the Belgian pioneer of educational science Ovide Decroly (1871–1932) (Lewin, 1933), later translated and published in English as a book chapter (Lewin, 1935b). Vygotsky's chapter is of particular interest as it reports three series of post-Lewinian experimental studies conducted by the scholars of the Vygotsky–Luria group. This is how Vygotsky described the themes of these three lines of replication research: "In the first series of experiments, we studied, as Lewin did, the processes of saturation in activities for both normal and retarded children" (Vygotsky, 1993c, p. 237); "In the second series of experiments, we studied, as did Lewin, the tendency to return to an interrupted activity given unrelieved affective inducement. As he did, we established that this tendency appears in no less a degree among mentally retarded children than among normal ones" (Vygotsky, 1993c, p. 238); "Finally, in the third series of experiments, we tried to study, in both normal and mentally retarded children, the character of the substitutions in affective tendencies which occurred in response to interruptions of activities" (Vygotsky, 1993c, p. 238).²⁶

This publication of Vygotsky's is mirrored by Zankov, who authored a book titled *Essays on the psychology of the mentally retarded child* (Zankov, 1935) that not

only provides a discussion of Gestalt theory and, specifically, Lewin's scholarship, but also focuses on a study by Lewin's former student Paul Köpke, who investigated the patterns in resumption of interrupted action in normal and mentally retarded children (see Zankov, 1935, p. 136). Interestingly, Köpke's study has never been published since then. Thus, the author's familiarity with an unpublished work by a Lewinian scholar is a clear demonstration of informal and personal contacts between Soviet scholars of the Vygotsky–Luria group and their peers abroad and yet another piece of evidence of their direct exchanges of publications and even unpublished manuscripts.

Finally, the third line of Lewinian studies in Soviet psychological scholarship was developed in the works of researchers in Kharkov, Soviet Ukraine, at the Department of Clinical Psychology of the Ukrainian Psychoneurological Academy under the supervision of Luria and his closest associate, colleague, and co-author Mark Lebedinskii. The presentation of these studies, published in the second half of the 1930s, was done in the best traditions of post-World War II, idiosyncratic, Cold-War-period Soviet science. Indeed, as amazing as it may appear, the editors of the translated volume 2 of the *Collected works* of Vygotsky acutely observed that "there is no direct reference to any of Lewin's works in any of the six volumes in Russian and so there may be reason to believe that Vygotsky's knowledge of Lewin was obtained through secondary sources" (see editors' footnote in Vygotsky, 1993c, p. 221). Although the editors were wrong in their assessment of Vygotsky's second-hand familiarity with Lewin's work, their comment on the lack of references to the actual published works of Lewin in Vygotsky's texts published in the *Collected works* is quite correct. This tendency to avoid references to the original sources is even further aggravated in the published works of the scholars of the Kharkov group. It turns out that despite apparent borrowings from Western scholarship – for instance, as it follows from the analysis of the research methods of a few works of Lebedinskii and Zaporozhets of the second half of 1930s that were definitely based on experimental techniques of Karsten's study of psychological 'satiation' – the authors not only never refer to the original source, but even fail to mention the names of either Lewin or his student, who actually did the study and introduced the method (see, e.g., Lebedinskii, 1940).

Interestingly enough, Soviet psychological research had a certain impact on Kurt Lewin's associates. Thus, for instance in his correspondence with Luria, Lewin mentioned the great interest that Luria's, Birenbaum's, and Zeigarnik's studies provoked abroad.²⁷ In particular, Lewin alluded to Tamara Dembo's presentation, in which she reported these studies conducted in the Soviet Union.²⁸ As a result of intensive intellectual exchange between the researchers residing in the Soviet Union and the United States, a number of references to Soviet research occurred in American publications in the late 1930s and 1940s. These included references to Vygotsky's foreign publications on the topics of thinking, language, and speech that came out under the supervision and in the English translation of Jacob Kagan and his associates (Vygotsky, 1934, 1939). Furthermore, the co-authored work by Roger Garlock Barker, Tamara Dembo, and Kurt Lewin that was supervised by the latter

and published in 1941 (Barker, Dembo, & Lewin, 1941) features a reference to a publication in Russian: Vygotsky's book *Thinking and speech*, which had been published in the Soviet Union in 1934 (Vygotskii, 1934a). There is also evidence of Vygotsky's indirect influence on Kurt Lewin's former students. Thus, according to the testimony of a former colleague of Maria Rickers-Ovsiankina from the University of Connecticut, Ovsiankina – who was not particularly well trained in the methods of post-positivist quantitative research of the North American scholarly mainstream – was, nevertheless, as a representative of a European academic tradition, fairly instrumental in introducing a few novel ideas that would later become quite popular in America. In particular, the source reports that Ovsiankina familiarized her colleagues with the psychology of Vygotsky (Handler, 1995, pp. 174–175).

1934–1936: Vygotsky *Festschrift* that never was

Vygotsky, the leader of the group of Soviet psychologists and the legendary founder of one of the most remarkable traditions in psychological research in the Soviet Union, died on June 11, 1934. With some delay Luria published in the West two obituaries (Luria, 1935a, 1935b) and the provisionally titled *Psychological development and decline*²⁹ or, according to other sources, *Probleme der Entwicklung und Abfall Psychisches Funktionen* (Problems of development and decline of psychical functions).³⁰ The earliest documents covering Luria's negotiations with potential authors that have been discovered are dated November 1935,³¹ but active correspondence with the contributors is known to have lasted until the fall of 1936. Apparently, this volume was conceived as an important and prestigious publication of international significance that seems to have had no precedents among Russian psychological publications. Indeed, Luria personally invited a number of leading specialists with a request to contribute chapters written specifically for this occasion. As a result, by April 1936 Luria appears to have received manuscripts from the renowned psychologists Frederik Buytendijk, Karl Bühler, Kurt Koffka, Arnold Gesell, and Kurt Goldstein³² and was still waiting for papers from such authors as Adhémar Gelb,³³ Kurt Lewin, Karl Lashley, and Jean Piaget.³⁴ Max Wertheimer was also invited to take part in the project and even sent Luria his paper.³⁵ The whereabouts of this as well as other papers that Luria presumably did receive for the collected volume is not known to date, and their contents are of considerable interest to contemporary psychologists and historians of psychology.

It seems that the last paper that was submitted for the volume was the chapter from Kurt Lewin, which was originally mailed from the United States to the address of the library of the Academy of Sciences of Ukraine,³⁶ but eventually – with considerable delays and distractions – was forwarded to Moscow in August/September 1936.³⁷ According to his correspondence with the author, Luria was impatiently waiting for the paper as early as February 1936. The reason for Luria's impatience was obvious: among all the papers submitted for the volume Luria believed Lewin's chapter to be the most important, the central chapter of the whole volume.³⁸ Indeed,

Kurt Lewin's work was one of the strongest influences on the research of Vygotsky, Luria, and their associates in the 1930s, strongly affected by Lewin's holistic 'topological' theory in psychology.

1936: "Topologische Meeting, Moskau/Charkow"

Around 1936, Luria was planning to organize Russian translation and publication of Lewin's two new books – *Dynamic theory of personality* (Lewin, 1935a) and *Principles of topological psychology* (Lewin, 1936)³⁹ – but for some reason or other these plans did not materialize. Therefore, of enormous interest is another of Luria's unfulfilled projects of 1936 that gives us insight into the kind of research that was done within the remnants of the Vygotsky–Luria circle after Vygotsky's death in June, 1934. Luria's plan was to organize a psychological-topological conference in the Soviet Union in the summer of 1936. The prehistory of this project begins in 1933 in the USA.

According to Kurt Lewin's biographer Alfred J. Marrow, very soon after his emigration from Germany to the United States Lewin attracted a few colleagues, students, and friends – old, European, and new, American ones – who constituted an informal personal network of Lewin's associates and to a smaller or larger extent shared his beliefs and ideas about the methods and goals of psychological research (Lück, 1989, 2001).⁴⁰ The group formed spontaneously in the course of organizing an informal meeting of like-minded individuals that took place on Christmas Eve of 1933 at Smith College, where Kurt Koffka taught and headed the psychological research laboratory. Kurt Koffka, Kurt Lewin, Tamara Dembo, and several others were among those few local and specially invited individuals who came to Northampton, MA on the occasion of this meeting, which turned out as personally pleasant as it was informative and professionally rewarding for the members of this small group. Thus, it comes as no surprise that the next year saw the start of a new tradition of annual meetings of the group, which markedly increased and included old and new participants (1934, Duke University). The following year was a real triumph. In 1935 the Topological Group gathered at Bryn Mawr College and included a constellation of bright scholars such as participants in the first meeting Lewin, Koffka, and Dembo, as well as the 'newcomers' Wolfgang Köhler, Erik Erikson, Margaret Mead, William Stern, David Krech, Edward C. Tolman, and Fritz and Grace Heider. Since then Topology Meetings – which remained informal gatherings of the members of this group of scholars not exceeding thirty-five–forty members – became a regular yearly event that was subsequently held under the aegis of a wide range of American universities and colleges, including Harvard (in 1936) and Cornell (in 1938) (Marrow, 1969, pp. 111–115). Apparently, the news of the success of the Topological Meetings reached the Soviet Union, and their North American peers' example appeared very exciting and tempting for colleagues in the USSR.

The first reference to the anticipated 'Lewinian, 'topological'' seminar in the Soviet Union dates back to the beginning of 1936. A postcard, in German, of



FIGURE 9.1 A postcard in German dated January 25, 1936, signed by Luria, Birenbaum, and Zeigarnik (all in Moscow), addressed to Kurt Lewin, Tamara Dembo, and Maria Ovsiankina, and sent to the United States to Lewin's university address (Kurt Lewin Archive, at The Drs. Nicholas and Dorothy Cummings Center for the History of Psychology, The University of Akron)

January 25, 1936 – sent from Moscow to Iowa, OH, USA and addressed to Lewin, Dembo, and Ovsiankina – was signed by Luria, Birenbaum, and Zeigarnik, who suggested that the next “Topologische Meeting” be held at their laboratory in Moscow (Figure 9.1).⁴¹ An idea that originally might have looked like mere wishful thinking seems to have evolved and crystallized soon, and took shape as a real and, presumably, manageable project. Thus, on February 20, 1936 Luria sent another letter to Lewin that emphasized that their investigations of personality along the lines of Lewin's ‘dynamic theory’ were increasingly intensifying year by year and were represented by a range of research topics and resulted in a series of interesting findings. Luria mentioned the clinical work of Birenbaum and Zeigarnik and their forthcoming major study on thinking and affect – and their impact on behavioral dynamics – in conjunction with neuropsychological research. Luria also mentioned the studies conducted by Aleksei N. Leontiev and his research team in Kharkov⁴² that investigated the structure of behavior and action of children and the changing interrelations between goal, motive, and activity. All these studies gave them a nice opportunity, argued Luria, to organize a small symposium that would focus on the discussion of dynamic theory research and to hold a “Lewin-Konferenz” the forthcoming June, 1936, that would feature presentations by Birenbaum, Zeigarnik, Solov’ev, and Leontiev and his group.⁴³ For some reason these plans, however, soon

changed and the decision was made to change the place (but not the time) of the meeting and organize the small conference – the "Lewin-Symposium" – not in Moscow, but in Kharkov, in June 1936.⁴⁴

Among Lewin's students, even after their return to Soviet Russia, *Birenbaum* and *Zeigarnik* continued fairly consistently using the complex of Gestalt ideas in their research in Moscow, therefore it is quite clear how their work might have suited the program of the forthcoming 'Lewin' or 'topological' conference in the Soviet Union in 1936. A few of their studies give a pretty clear idea of the kind of synthesis between Gestaltist, Lewinian, and, on the other hand, Vygotsky's ideas they might have planned to present, for instance, such as those they had published in 1934–5 (*Birenbaum & Zeigarnik*, 1935; *Samukhin et al.*, 1934; *Zeigarnik & Birenbaum*, 1935). The study by *Solov'ev* in Lewinian fashion is also relatively well known. This was his replication study that he did in the early 1930s and published in 1935 (*Solov'ev-Elpidinskii*, 1935) (see also the discussion of *Solov'ev's* study in Chapter 6). As for *Leontiev* and his group in Kharkov, there is not much clarity on what exactly of the work of this research team was scheduled to be presented at the 'Lewinian' conference, although several of those studies that were published with a certain delay in Soviet Ukraine (in Kharkov) appear quite probable candidates for 'Soviet Gestaltist' or 'Lewinian' research (e.g. *Asnin*, 1941; *P. I. Zinchenko*, 1939). Another possible option for *Leontiev* and his associates' presentation at this Topological Meeting in the Soviet Union was a study that they conducted in Moscow's Gorky Central Park of Culture and Leisure, where *Leontiev's* research team included the former Lewin student *Nina Kaulina*, who seems to have contributed considerably to its distinctly Lewinian flavor. The study of the mid-1930s was never prepared for publication, yet the preliminary report of the study was published several decades later under the names of the two co-presenters of the paper (*A. N. Leontiev & Rozenblium*, 1999).

It appears that Soviet scholars had enough interesting studies to contribute to the 'Lewinian' Topological Meeting that was planned for summer 1936 in the Soviet Union. Yet, it is not quite clear – furthermore, it is fairly questionable – whether all these studies as a whole were leading to a productive synthesis between Soviet and German-American traditions. The potential of their theoretical convergence might be assessed only with the help of first-hand accounts such as *Luria's* statement of his theoretical and empirical research interests around 1936 – the year when the Lewinian conference was planned to be held in the Soviet Union. One such statement was published by *King* and *Michael Wertheimer* in the context of their publication of correspondence of *Max Wertheimer* and *Luria* of 1936. Thus, in one of his letters *Max Wertheimer* inquired about *Luria's* current scientific interests and the course of his research development. In response, in his letter of May 9, 1936, *Luria* identified two major strands of his research (and, by implication, that of his research group in the Soviet Union):

At the moment I am occupied experimentally with two questions; one concerns the general laws of psychological development; we are interested

primarily in how during psychological development the meaningful representation of the world (which we see in the meaning of action and language) evolves, how in the course of the learning process there occurs a reorganization of the world of meaning and of psychological functions, and how learning can lead to a reorganization of the interrelation of the psychological functions. We have succeeded, with artificial intervention in identical twins, in obtaining very interesting displacements of psychological structures.

The second [issue] in which I am primarily engaged is the destruction of the world of meaning and of the construction of psychological functions with brain damage. Here too we succeeded in finding methods of analysis of the meaning of a word, of the living semantic syntax of language, which have become a good indicator of the decline of brain capability and which show a lawful deterioration with brain injuries. The pathological semantics, syntax, and functional structures of the psyche constitute the second part of the problem field with which we are very concerned here.

(King & Wertheimer, 2005, p. 274)

The document presents quite a few typically ‘Vygotskian’ themes, such as the interest in discovering the “general laws of development,” a wide range of which are so frequently discussed in a number of Vygotsky’s writings, and the focus on speech and language, “psychological functions” and interrelations between them, “functional structures” and psychological systems, and the destruction of such composite “structures” and systems that occurs, for instance, as a result of brain damage. In addition, the letter refers to the theme of “semantics” and “meaning” that seem to have been equally important for Vygotsky (most conspicuously, in the second half of his scientific career, i.e. in the 1930s) and the German-American Gestaltists: the latter were always deeply immersed in the problems of meaning (alternatively referred to as ‘value’, ‘significance’, ‘sense’, etc.), but for quite different reasons did not discuss them openly until the second half of the 1930s (e.g. Koffka, 1935; Köhler, 1938).

And yet, no characteristically Lewinian ‘topological’ topics and concepts are mentioned in this letter of Luria to Wertheimer such as ‘field’, ‘life space’, ‘vectors’, ‘forces’, or the like. Furthermore, no published theoretical work – ‘Vygotskian’ and equally ‘Lewinian’, ‘topological’ – of a Soviet psychologist has ever come out. In the absence of a general and, at the same time, sufficiently detailed exposition of the theoretical meaning of the anticipated “Topologische Meeting” for the remnants of the former Vygotsky–Luria group after Vygotsky’s death we are left with many open questions about the actual content of this major theoretical synthesis, although its potential for future psychological theory is beyond any doubt.

Epilogue: “Stalinist science” in action

What seemed to be “the beginning of a beautiful friendship” was to become its end. Indeed, the summer of 1936 eventually turned out the dawn, the highest

peak, and, at the same time, the dusk of 'cultural-historical Gestalt psychology' in its 'topological' version of Kurt Lewin. The correspondence between Soviet and German-American peers came to an end in the end of 1936, followed by the radical decrease in publication activity of Soviet scholars for the period of two years, the notorious Great Terror (or Great Purge) in the USSR. In 1938 a psychological publications boom started in the Soviet Union, but no traces of the union between 'Vygotskians' or 'Lewinians' can be found in the publications of this period: both Lewin and Vygotsky are only occasionally mentioned in the published works of Soviet psychologists during the several years before World War II (see Chapter 3). In 1939 World War II started, and the entire world order underwent major changes, which had profound effects on international communications and the activities of scholars all over the world.

In addition, the 1930s and 1940s brought about painful losses to Gestalt psychology, dramatically undermined by a series of deaths of its most prominent thinkers and advocates, such as Adhémar Gelb (in 1936), Karl Duncker (in 1940), Kurt Koffka (in 1941), Max Wertheimer (in 1943), and Kurt Lewin (in 1947).

On March 5, 1946 the British Prime Minister Winston Churchill delivered his famous Fulton speech reviewing the geopolitical status quo of the time and formulated the new reality of the post-World War II world in terms of the 'Iron Curtain'. Another powerful metaphor and related social reality, the 'Cold War', was to follow soon. The era of the Superpowers and xenophobia started.

All these factors and processes considerably diminished opportunities for transnational projects in psychological research such as Luria's initiatives of the 1930s. Yet the project could possibly have been developed within the confines of the domestic 'national science' in the Soviet Union. One might wonder whether this were in fact so.

In fact, it appears that the 'Vygotskian-Lewinian' trend in Soviet psychology – although preserved in some very general sense – was considerably mutated and transformed. Soviet psychological writings and publications of the post-World War II era notably reduced the number of references to foreign sources and their historical theoretical roots. As a result, a few important ideas, theories, and experimental practices were used and discussed without giving credit to their original authors, or simply lost. On the other hand, Soviet postwar scholarship was enriched by occasional very interesting scholarly theories and innovations such as Nikolai Bernstein's so-called psychophysiology of activeness (*aktivnost'*). Generally, the whole psychological discourse in the Soviet Union underwent considerable change in its foundational terminology and fully assimilated the idiosyncratic slang of the quasi-Marxist newsspeak of Soviet science.

The mutant and hybrid that emerged as a result of all these transformations by the 1960s overtook the entire edifice of psychological science and, under the banner of the so-called psychological 'activity theory', started its reign at the summit of the academic Olympus in the Soviet Union.

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Epilogue

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10

“LOST IN TRANSLATION”

Talking about sense, meaning, and consciousness

Anton Yasnitsky and René van der Veer

If we could conclude this book with a single paragraph, we would choose a brief quotation from William Saroyan’s early essay “Myself upon the Earth”:

I love and worship life, living senses, functioning minds. I love consciousness. I love precision. And life is to be created by every man who has the breath of God within him; and every man is to create his own consciousness, and his own precision, for these things do not exist of themselves. Only confusion and error and ugliness exist of themselves. I have said that I am deeply religious. I am. I believe that I live, and you’ve got to be religious to believe so miraculous a thing. And I am grateful and I am humble. I do live, so let the years repeat themselves eternally, for I am sitting in my room, stating in words the truth of my being, squeezing the fact from meaninglessness and imprecision. And the living of this moment can never be effaced. It is beyond time.

(Saroyan, 1934)

Yet, unfortunately, we cannot do just that. Besides, the quotation would not make much sense to the reader of this book. That is why a somewhat longer Epilogue about meaning, sense, consciousness, and other very important issues is needed.

Contemporary psychological and educational discourse is very much overloaded with mechanist, behaviorist, and cognitivist phraseology concerning ‘knowledge transfer’ or ‘construction’, ‘conditioning’, ‘enforcement’, ‘storing’, ‘processing’, and ‘retrieving information’, multiple ‘intelligences’, and other related *neurospeak* jargon that is very much in fashion these days. As a result, it is highly problematic to talk about ‘consciousness’ as well as other matters widely discussed, for instance, in the European psychological tradition – or, for that matter, in related oriental practices – without giving an impression of being ‘unscientific’, or being grossly

misunderstood. Some examples of such topics include Russian *psikhika* (psyche) as the primary object of psychological research (cf. the fairly special and somewhat derogatory meaning of the English word ‘psychic’ in its contemporary use, such as in the case of ‘psychic reader’) or German *Seele* (soul), which, according to the translators of a classic German psychological volume, they

had thought to translate [it] by “soul”, in the belief that the time was ripe for a reintroduction of the latter word into the technical English terminology of psychology. It seemed impossible that there should be any confusion of the psychological “soul,” deduced as it is from concrete behavior, with the “soul” of theology, the properties of which cannot be derived from or tested by concrete behavior. But a sampling of opinion among American psychologists was against the use of this more accurate translation. It is consequently necessary to point out that “mind” as here used (“the totality of psychical systems”) is not to be taken in any narrowly intellectualistic sense.

(D. K. Adams & Zener, 1935, p. vii)

These lines were written almost eighty years ago, but in a certain sense the situation does not seem to have changed much in North American psychology since then. Indeed, both *psyche* and *soul* still have fairly derogatory – or at best somewhat ‘unscientific’ – connotations in contemporary English from the perspective of what a rigorous scientific vocabulary is supposed to be. Unlike these two, ‘meaning’ (or, sometimes, ‘sense’) is often found in the pages of psychological publications in English nowadays. It was not always so.

Around eighty years ago Kurt Koffka, a prominent German-American scholar and one of the founders of Gestalt psychology, in his book *Principles of Gestalt psychology* (Koffka, 1935) reflected on more than a decade of the triumphant spread of Gestalt psychology over North America. Specifically, Koffka discussed the three foundational principles of the theory and, it seems, rather to the surprise of his North American readers, confessed that one of the basic postulates of the theory had deliberately not been presented to English-speaking audiences until then:

SIGNIFICANCE, VALUE. We turn to the last of our categories: significance. What we mean by that is harder to explain than the two previous concepts, and yet here lies one of the deepest roots of gestalt theory, one which has been least openly brought before the English-speaking public. The reason for this is easy to understand. There is such a thing as an intellectual climate, and the intellectual climate, just as meteorological, varies from country to country. And just as the growth of a plant depends upon the intellectual climate, so does the growth of an idea depend upon the intellectual climate. There can be no doubt that the intellectual climates of Germany and the United States are widely different. The idealistic tradition of Germany is more than an affair of philosophic schools; it pervades the German mind and appears most openly in the writings and teachings of the representatives

of "Geistwissenschaften", the moral sciences. The meaning of a personality prominent in history, art or literature, seems to the German mind more important than the pure historical facts which make up his life and works; the historian is more interested in the relation to the events on the plan of the universe than in his relations to the events on the planet. Contrariwise, in America, the climate is chiefly practical; the here and now, the immediate present with its needs, holds the centre of the stage, thereby relegating the problems essential to German mentality to the realm of the useless and non-existing. In science this attitude makes for positivism, an overvaluation of mere facts and an undervaluation of very abstract speculations, a high regard for science, accurate and earthbound, and an aversion, sometimes bordering on contempt, for metaphysics that tries to escape from the welter of mere facts into a loftier realm of ideas and ideals.

Therefore when the first attempts were made to introduce gestalt theory to the American public, that side of which would most readily appeal to the type of German mentality which I have tried to sketch was kept in the background, and those aspects which had a direct bearing on science were emphasized. Had the procedure been different, we might have incurred the danger of biasing our readers against our ideas. Living in a different intellectual climate they might have taken this aspect of gestalt theory for pure mysticism and decided not to have anything to do with the whole theory before they had had a chance of becoming acquainted with its scientific relevance.

At the present moment, however, when gestalt theory has been taken up as a main source of discussion, it seems only fair to lift the old restriction and expose all its aspects.

(Koffka, 1935, pp. 17–18)

Thus, it is North American pragmatism, positivism, and – in the field of psychological theory – behaviorism as the predominant mindset characteristic of this culture in general – as seen through the eyes of the German-American scholar – that prevented the Gestalt theorists from openly discussing such suspiciously 'idealistic' topics as meaning, significance, or value. And yet, as of 1935, Koffka believed the time was ripe to challenge these traditional views:

The positivistic interpretation of the world and our knowledge of it is but one possibility; there is another one. The question is: Which is really true? Meaning, significance, value, as data of our total experience give us a hint that the latter has at least as good a chance of being the true one as the former. And that means: far from being compelled to banish concepts like meaning and value from psychology and science in general, we must use these concepts for a full understanding of the mind and the world, which is at the same time a full explanation.

(Koffka, 1935, p. 21)

Koffka's attempt to openly use the concepts of 'meaning', 'significance' and 'value' as data of our total experience was concurrent with the work of his long-time associates and collaborators, the founders of Gestalt psychology. Thus, for instance, Wolfgang Köhler delivered a series of the William James lectures on philosophy and psychology at Harvard in 1934–5 that were later released as a volume, *The place of value in a world of facts* (Köhler, 1938). In a similar vein, Max Wertheimer published a series of American essays in 1934–40 on the topics of values and ethics; some of these were later translated into German and released in a book with a special introduction by Albert Einstein and under the characteristic title *Zur Gestaltpsychologie menschlicher Werte* (On the Gestalt psychology of human values) (Wertheimer, 1991). Furthermore, one of Wertheimer's New York students later recalled that in his lecture that he called "Being and doing" Wertheimer explored the ideas of the oriental psychologies of Taoism, Lao-Tze, and Zen Buddhism, and subsequently "promoted his interest in the role of values in human experience" (King & Wertheimer, 2005, p. 300): all these influences seem to have notably contributed to the later work that this former student of Wertheimer's eventually published under the title *Religions, values and peak-experiences* (Maslow, 1964), a book that is considered by many as highly inspirational and influential, but hardly as a contribution to rigorously scientific and experimental psychology.

One might wonder how successful the attempt by Koffka and his associates was to reintroduce the phraseology – and conceptual framework – of meaning and related notions into the Anglo-Saxon scientific and experimental psychology of the time. In order to get a sense of the speed of progress in this direction let us skip a couple of decades. The success of the Gestaltists in restoring meaning to its rightful place as a subject of psychological research can be judged on the basis of the statements of pioneers of post-World War II cognitive science such as the legendary figure in American psychology Jerome Bruner. Thus, in his book *Acts of meaning* (Bruner, 1990) the author clearly states:

Now let me tell you first what I and my friends thought the revolution was about back in the late 1950s. It was, we thought, an all-out effort to establish meaning as the central concept in psychology – not stimuli and responses, not overtly observable behavior, not biological drives and their transformation, but meaning ... Its aim was to discover and to describe formally the meanings that human beings created out of their encounters with the world, and then to propose the hypotheses about what meaning-making processes were implicated. It focused upon the symbolic activities that human beings employed in constructing and in making sense not only of the world, but of themselves. Its aim was to prompt psychology to join forces with its sister interpretive disciplines in the humanities and the social sciences.

(Bruner, 1990, p. 2)

As this makes clear, meaning had not made it into mainstream North American psychology by the end of the 1950s. In retrospect, the attempt of the cognitivists of the late 1950s also seems to have failed.

Bruner hesitated to identify the full set of factors that impacted upon the reception of their theoretical innovation of the 1950s. Yet he mentioned two reasons that might have predetermined the eventual failure of the project, as he assessed the final outcome of the 'cognitive revolution' of the 1960s. First, the membership in the new intellectual movement was too inclusive and too 'tolerant' from a theoretical standpoint. As a result, a great many scholars of positivistic and neobehaviorist persuasions were included, which ran contrary to the original revolutionary impulse of the entire project and in the long run contributed to its taming, domestication, assimilation, transformation, and thus, consequently, failure. All these processes later contributed to the perception of the 'cognitive revolution' as one of the "mythical revolutions of American psychology" (Leahey, 1992). Second, Bruner mentions the characteristic transmutation of the vocabulary used by the new movement. Thus, somehow swiftly the original proposal of *meaning*-oriented research was reformulated – and eventually re-conceptualized – so that 'meaning' as the foundation of new-born cognitive science turned into 'information', or 'knowledge'. The whole revolutionary enterprise – perhaps best understood as a "return to attitudes and trends that were present prior to the advent of behaviorism and that were alive and well outside of the United States, where behaviorism had not developed any coherent support" (Mandler, 2002) – thus boiled down to, in the words of a noted participant and historian of the cognitivist movement, "a contemporary, empirically based effort to answer long-standing epistemological questions – particularly those concerned with the nature of *knowledge*, its components, its sources, its development, and its deployment" (emphasis added; Gardner, 1986, p. 6). Thus, the mindset so common to European scholars brought up in the tradition that values scholarly speculation and puts great emphasis on value, significance, and meaning yet again did not make it into the North American academic mentality.

This episode brings us back to Koffka's discussion of cultural traditions in the pre-World War II human sciences as seen through the eyes of a prominent German-American scholar. Indeed, "the intellectual climates of Germany and the United States are widely different." In a similar vein, Bertrand Russell once famously remarked on the studies of animal intelligence that "one may say broadly that all the animals that have been carefully observed have behaved so as to confirm the philosophy in which the observer believed before his observations began," and, furthermore, "they have all displayed the national characteristics of the observer":

Animals studied by Americans rush about frantically, with an incredible display of hustle and pep, and at last achieve the desired result by chance. Animals observed by Germans sit still and think, and at last evolve the solution out of their inner consciousness.

(Russell, 1927/2009, p. 34)

This remark appears as astute and ironic as it is pessimistic and desperate. Indeed, the situation as Russell described it makes it look virtually impossible for a scientific mindset to be changed from outside until the internal processes within a certain academic culture cause it to change. And even then, there is no certainty that the change involves deeper conceptual strata rather than represents merely superficial, cosmetic changes in line with the fashionable phraseology of the day.

Indeed, meaning appears a somewhat vague concept for the empiricist and positivistic mindset that resists any “unscientific idealism” of the kind. The difficulty of discussing the problems of meaning in the context of North American psychological research is apparent in the book *Gestalt psychology and meaning* by Willis Davis Ellis (1930), who seems to have been the first scholar in the Anglo-Saxon psychological tradition to raise the issue of the Gestaltist attitude to meaning as the object of psychological research. In an attempt to provide a definition of ‘meaning’ that he made in the book chapter characteristically titled “Meanings of meaning,” Ellis made an impressive overview of contemporary scholarly literature and put together a list of such definitions and attributes of ‘meaning’, which occupied three pages of his book. If Google Scholar is of any use in determining the impact of a scholarly publication, then the single citation of this publication retrieved by the Google Scholar search engine is a fairly representative reflection of the resistance to these ideas and the need for theorizing in these topics as perceived by contemporary North American psychologists.

Thus, *meaning* was “lost in translation” – the translation into “cyberspeak,” in the words of the contemporary historian of cybernetics (Gerovitch, 2002). Yet, this was not the only loss, and, perhaps, the other loss was even more profound and fatal. In his recently published memoirs Bruner recalls the history of his encounters with Luria and remarks:

I realized that one of the things that he was telling me about was a battle for *consciousness* in Russia, the parallel of which was starting in the United States in the Center for Cognitive Studies ... But we were somehow wanting to get back to a notion of *mind*.

(emphasis added; Cole, Bruner, & Sacks, 2013, p. 41)

Furthermore, even reference to ‘mind’ or any related ‘mental’ processes seems to have appeared too extreme to some of the founders of the cognitivist movement, therefore, what they would refer to as the “jargon of behaviorism” (G. A. Miller, 2003, p. 141) was gradually replaced with what eventually turned out to be a “cognitivist jargon.” Thus, according to one of the leading figures of the new movement, “If scientific psychology were to succeed, mentalistic concepts would have to integrate and explain the behavioral data. We were still reluctant to use such terms as ‘*mentalism*’ to describe what was needed, so we talked about *cognition* instead” (emphasis added; G. A. Miller, 2003, p. 142). Against this cultural background Bruner’s reference to Luria’s “battle for consciousness” is quite significant.

Luria's use of 'consciousness' can be best understood in the context of the theoretical work of Vygotsky. More specifically, of primary interest in this context is Vygotsky's unfinished – yet still apparently quite promising (Zavershneva, 2014) – theory of consciousness, which he was developing during the last two to three years of his life until his untimely death in 1934. In this tradition 'consciousness' is quite distinct from 'mind' – not to mention 'cognition' – as it is often used in the Anglo-Saxon tradition. The difference can be illustrated by the above-mentioned comment of the translators of Kurt Lewin's German works, Adams and Zener, who warned that although 'mind' is used throughout the book, it is "not to be taken in any narrowly intellectualistic sense" common in its use in scholarly English (D. K. Adams & Zener, 1935). Consciousness, for Vygotsky, is best understood as a dynamic phenomenon, an action rather than a state or an entity. Besides, although it is essentially related to language and speech, therefore, to word meaning, for Vygotsky in his most mature period it is not word meaning, but sense – a special category, broader than verbal meaning that he introduced in his theory in order to discuss the semantics of objects and actions with them – that constitutes the focus of his work on the theory of consciousness. Therefore, from Vygotsky's perspective, there is a very close interlink between semantic, sense-making processes and the workings of consciousness. Overall, this is a fairly complicated issue to be addressed in English, therefore, the idiosyncratic use of 'consciousness' and its derivatives in the Russian tradition and its difference from any narrowly intellectualist and static sense will be further discussed below.

The difference between the two – 'mind' and 'consciousness' – might appear merely terminological and insignificant. Indeed, as often happens in science, words may be virtually unimportant as long as they carry the same meaning. And, at the same time, the pervasiveness of certain metaphors, phrasal constructions, and verbal images may be indicative of foundational categories of thinking deeply engrained in a certain culture and, therefore, resistant to any change. Thus, for instance, both 'meaning' and 'consciousness' appear to be fairly legitimate topics these days for a discussion in a mainstream scholarly journal in the human sciences or at a scientific conference. Yet, the traditional Anglo-Saxon intellectual climate and the intellectual context of the use of these words and related phraseology suggest that the novelty of these discursive innovations tends to be superficial rather than profound and foundational. For an example of such an in essence fairly traditional – mechanist and positivistic – mindset consider the use of 'consciousness' in contemporary 'brainspeak' academic and media parlance.

Similarly, there is a great deal of 'meaning talk' in a range of psychological theories and related publications deeply influenced by semiotics, the science of signs, for instance, within the so-called socio-cultural theories in psychology (Valsiner & Rosa, 2007), or inspired by the humanist tradition in psychology and psychotherapy, such as Viktor Frankl's logotherapy. Notable, however, is the former's emphasis on the symbols, signs, and sign systems that are primarily understood as larger social and cultural entities, chiefly independent of any single individual, which places these theories considerably closer to sociological thinking than to what we traditionally

understand by psychology. On the other hand, humanistic psychological theories and related practices are mostly concerned with individual human beings as unique and self-contained, and to a considerable extent independent of larger social superstructures. It is apparent that both positions present a fairly limited and one-sided view of human psychological functioning as compared with the ideas – however incomplete and theoretically underdeveloped – of European continental psychologists and the Russian and German-American scholars of the 1930s. Perhaps most notably and explicitly, this integrative trend was presented in the work of Vygotsky in the last period of his life and that of his circle, deeply and fundamentally influenced by the cultural and academic tradition of Gestalt psychologists and their associates (Yasnitsky, 2012a, 2012c, 2012d, 2012i).

Yet another major problem of understanding, intercultural dialogue, and scientific innovation is presented not so much by cultural factors, but for purely linguistic reasons. Thus, the two notions that constitute the core of Vygotsky's theorizing during the last two or three years of his life, namely, 'consciousness' and 'sense', provide a really impressive lineage of derivative notions – most of them widely used by Vygotsky and some of his Russian associates – that allow us to effectively operationalize these vague concepts and see these two ideas not only as presumably static phenomena, but also as dynamic processes, goal-directed actions, attributes, or qualities that may be represented, grammatically, by transitive verbs, passive and active participles, adjectives, adverbs, and, finally, action nouns (roughly corresponding to the gerund in English), and quality nouns (for a list of Russian derivatives see Table 10.1). Such a multitude of the derivatives of either 'consciousness' or 'sense' is simply inconceivable in the English language. English-speakers must be surprised to realize that a number of words and expressions that they come across in the translations of Vygotsky's – or some other Russian scholar's – published works, for instance 'to make sense', 'to realize', 'to become aware', 'deliberate' or 'voluntary', 'meaningful' and the like, in the mind of the Russian-speaker are perfectly connected in the same semantic field and are closely associated with each other by virtue of all being derived from either 'consciousness' or 'sense'. For an English-speaker, the implied interconnections that exist for the Russian speaker are typically obscured by the language and the cultural traditions of its use, and remain, thus, "lost in translation." This poses yet another serious threat to any attempt to meaningfully and productively discuss these matters in English.

Interestingly enough, the two rows of words that derive from Russian *soznanie* and *smysl* are far from parallel in their relation to the respective words in the same grammatical category. Thus, root nouns no doubt denote quite distinct phenomena; however, some of their derivatives in the Russian language reveal considerable proximity and may be used in everyday colloquial speech virtually interchangeably. Such is the case of the Russian verbs *osoznat'* and *osmyslit'* that in certain contexts both mean 'to realize', 'to come to terms with something'. The same is true of the adverbs *soznatel'no* and *osmyslenno* that may mean 'deliberately' or 'voluntarily'. Further discussion of these linguistic matters is definitely beyond the scope of this chapter. Yet it is worth pointing out that Vygotsky's decision to introduce the category of 'sense'

TABLE 10.1 Russian words *soznanie* (consciousness) and *smysl* (sense, meaning), and their derivatives

<i>Root noun</i>	<i>Transitive verb</i>	<i>Passive participle</i>	<i>Active participle</i>	<i>Action noun</i>	<i>Adjective</i>	<i>Adverb</i>	<i>Quality noun</i>
soznanie	(o)sozna(va)t'	osoznannyi	(o)soznaiushchii	osoznanie	soznatel'nyi	soznatel'no	soznatel'nost'
smysl	osmysli(va)t'	osmyslennyi	osmyslivaushchii	osmys(h)lenie osmyslivanie	smyslovoi	osmyslenno	osmyslennost'

TABLE 10.2 English equivalents for Russian words *soznanie* (consciousness) and *smysl* (sense, meaning), and their derivatives

Root noun	Transitive verb	Gerund	Adjective	Quality noun
consciousness	(to) cognize (<i>sth.</i>)	cognizing (<i>sth.</i>)	conscious (of) or cognizant (of)	cognizance (of <i>sth.</i>)
sense	(to) make sense (of <i>sth.</i>)	sense-making or making sense ¹ (of <i>sth.</i>)	semantic (e.g. analysis) or meaningful (e.g. activity)	meaningful- ness

(and related phraseology) in his emergent theory of consciousness is not strikingly novel or sensational for a Russian-speaker and in some sense it is already embedded in the cultural norms of the use of the language.

In order to remove the linguistic stumbling block posed by the vocabulary and cultural traditions of its use, a “phraseological toolkit” for the theory of consciousness in English has been designed and was used elsewhere in the discussion of Vygotsky’s theory of consciousness in the making (Zavershneva, 2014). Although the English language resists the effort to fully and consistently reconstruct the amazing lineage of the Russian derivatives, some progress has been achieved (see Table 10.2).

Some drawbacks are still notable. Thus, for instance, English ‘consciousness’ does not have any direct derivative verb and keeps suggesting an image of a static entity. Not much can be done about that from a purely linguistic standpoint. Another example is ‘semantic analysis’, which might often be associated with *semantics*: the subfield of linguistics that deals with linguistic analysis of meaning in human language. Still, in our firm opinion, this choice is considerably truer to the spirit of Vygotsky’s work of 1932–4 – with its acute interest in the personal psychological environment and radical departure from the research on external sign-mediated behaviors of his ‘instrumental’ period of the 1920s – than the alternative of ‘semi-otic’ with its direct links to contemporary postmodernist *semiotics* as the study of signs and sign processes. Therefore, ‘semantic’ as an attribute of ‘analysis’, ‘structures’, etc. should be preferred, especially so since in its contemporary use the term is not narrowly confined to linguistics proper or, for that matter, to any special discipline and is increasingly used in the sense of ‘of or relating to meaning or the study of meaning’. Perhaps another problem is related to the pervasiveness of the word ‘sense’ and its ambiguous meaning in the English language as relating to perceptual (e.g. *the sense of smell*), emotional (manifested, e.g., in such derivatives as *sensual* and *sensuality*), and intellectual (e.g. in *making sense of the world*) domains at the same time. In contrast, ‘meaning’ in its actual use in English is in essence quite similar to what Vygotsky meant by his *smysl* (sense) (see, e.g., Bruner, 1990), but it can hardly be used in this function without a reservation due to the terminological difference – fairly important for Vygotsky in the last two years of his life –between ‘meaning’ understood more or less strictly as a ‘meaning of the word’ in its narrow and special

use in linguistics and the larger category of 'sense' that applies to a wide range of phenomena within the psychological field of a person, such as objects and human goal-directed actions with them. Thus, all these factors played their role in creating the vocabulary of Vygotsky's unfinished theory of consciousness in English so that the links were preserved between the various terms denoting or relating to consciousness and its workings. As an apparently unexpected bonus, English-speakers have the word 'cognizable', which does not find a direct equivalent in the Russian language, but is a really nice addition to the vocabulary of the future Vygotskian theory of consciousness in English.

Now, after this 'linguistic preamble' and all these terminological clarifications nothing prevents us from productive discussion of the issues of meaning, sense, and consciousness in psychological terms following the tradition of the great Russian and German-American scholars of the past. And the future will show if there is a need and demand for such discussion. And, even more importantly, whether it will ever be able to advance further than merely speculative demagoguery, typical examples of which are manifested in the quasi-Marxist, positivistic psychological writings of some Soviet authors, or whether this discussion will eventually contribute to the operational, empirical psychological research and practice that is so long overdue (Galperin, 1969/1995).

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Appendices

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Appendix A

BIBLIOGRAPHY OF VYGOTSKY'S PUBLISHED WORKS

Vygotsky's published works: a(n almost) definitive bibliography

René van der Veer and Anton Yasnitsky

Compiling a bibliography of a scholar's scientific works is traditionally perceived as an auxiliary and relatively low-prestige genre of academic writing, its scholarly merit and pragmatic meaning notwithstanding. Also, preparing an authoritative bibliography of scientific works is a very time-consuming and laborious process, which adds to the relatively low popularity of this type of scholarly research. All this might explain the fact that despite earlier scholarly contributions of the kind, until now we have not had a reliable, comprehensive, and authoritative list of Vygotsky's oeuvre. The present appendix is the first attempt to rectify this situation and to present the rigorous and systematic bibliography of Vygotsky's published works. In compiling this bibliography the authors found a number of hitherto unknown publications and greatly improved the accuracy and reliability of the references mentioned in previous bibliographies.

Several bibliographies of Vygotsky are available in the literature (for discussion of the variety of Vygotsky's known bibliographies see Chapter 4 above). The most impressive and comprehensive lists of Vygotsky's works can be found in Van der Veer and Valsiner's book *Understanding Vygotsky* (1991) and a series of Tamara Lifanova's (née Shakhlevich) publications of the 1970s–1990s. Strictly speaking, Van der Veer and Valsiner's list as such – regardless of how meticulously and carefully it was prepared – was not a bibliography per se. Indeed, the list is only part of the references section of the book; therefore, it is not comprehensive and includes only those sources that the authors found relevant to discuss in their intellectual biography of Vygotsky. Therefore, naturally, quite a few written works do not appear on the list, which is particularly true of Vygotsky's earlier, "pre-scientific" newspaper and journal publications on theater and literature. In contrast, Lifanova's work gives the impression of an extended properly bibliographic work that started sometime in the 1970s until it was eventually concluded with the fullest list of Vygotsky's works, which came out in two virtually identical versions in 1996. And yet, there are a number of problems with Lifanova's bibliography – critically discussed at some length in Chapter 4 – that make this work hardly a reliable source of information. The main problem with Lifanova's list is the fact that it comprises actual published works as well as archival materials. Given that comprehensive in-depth philological and historical work was never done with the archival materials, we still do not know what exactly all these diverse documents are in terms of their origin, whether they represent distinct scientific works (as opposed to variations of the same texts, possibly published under different titles, if any), what was the chronology of their composition and the social context of their generation and intended publication.

For this reason, at this point we excluded all unpublished and archival documents and limited our bibliography to those works that were actually published in the interwar period, i.e. in the 1920s–1930s. These were mostly published on Vygotsky's initiative and with his authorization during his lifetime, but the list also includes several posthumous publications that were not necessarily finalized by their author, not to mention their unclear status in terms of authorial approval for publication.

The whole corpus of Vygotsky's published works is divided here into several sections, according to their chronology, themes covered, and the internal logic of a specific period.

Publications of 1916–1923

All of Vygotsky's publications of the period 1916–23 can be divided into two major groups: those before the Bolshevik Coup in October, 1917 and post-Revolutionary ones. Thus, the publications of 1916–17 typically came out in the weekly periodical edition of and for the Jewish intelligentsia *Novyi Put'* (*The New Path*), where Vygotsky served as technical secretary, and in the leftist monthly magazine *Letopis'* (*Chronicles*), edited by the popular Russian writer Maxim Gorky and devoted to the topics of literary, political, and artistic studies and the like. At the same time, Gorky also edited the newspaper *Novaia Zhizn'* (*New Life*) and Vygotsky appears to have published at least one article there. This was a paper on the prominent Russian literary scholar and critic Yulii Aikhenval'd that Vygotsky referred to in his book manuscript *The psychology of art*. In a footnote to the text of this manuscript Vygotsky mentioned several papers that provided the basis for his book. Unfortunately, the posthumous publications of *The psychology of art* apparently misrepresented the intended punctuation in this quotation. Thus, on a few occasions the editors of the book seem to have mistaken colons for semicolons and vice versa. The intended punctuation is restored in our translation in square brackets:

Printed: in Gorky's "**Letopis'**" in 1916–17 on new theatre, on the novels of [Andrei] Belyi, on Merezhkovskii, V. Ivanov, etc.[:] in "**Zhizn' iskusstva**" in 1922[:] on Shakespeare[:]; in "**Novaia zhizn'**" in 1917[:]; on Aikhenval'd[:]; in "**Novyi put'**" in 1915–1917.

(Vygotskii, 1968, p. 504; emphasis added)

With very few exceptions, the authors have all the entries of the bibliography in their possession. The few pieces on the list that they were unable to retrieve (such as the papers "on the new theatre," "on Aikhenval'd," and unknown publications of 1915 in *Novyi Put'*), are included in the bibliography, but with tentative titles indicated in square brackets and in English, in agreement with Vygotsky's statement of their main topics.

The above-mentioned journals and newspapers were discontinued after the Bolshevik uprising in 1917, which naturally put an end to Vygotsky's publications in these publications. It is possible – although by no means sure – that Vygotsky virtually ceased publishing journal and magazine articles for a period of four years, for we know about only two publications that came out during the post-revolutionary period of the Civil War (i.e. from 1918 to 1921). First, Vygotsky's essay "Revolution and theatre", published in a small volume of poems and essays on the problems of post-revolutionary art that came out under the title *Stikhi i proza o russkoi revoliutsii* (*Poems and prose on the Russian Revolution*) in Kiev in 1919. We might assume that this was the paper Vygotsky – possibly, mistakenly – referred to as his unknown publication "on new theatre" in Gorky's *Letopis'* of 1917, but we are unable to either confirm or disconfirm this assumption at this point. Second, his essay on Leo Tolstoy's criticism of Shakespeare's work printed in the literary, theatrical, and artistic daily newspaper *Zhizn' iskusstva* (*The Life of Art*) in Petrograd in 1920.

Subsequently, a major outburst of publishing activity took place in 1922 and 1923 with a series of theatrical and, more rarely, literary reviews and essays on related topics that were published in Vygotsky's native town Gomel'. After his graduation in Moscow, Vygotsky moved back to Gomel' and at some point became a Bolshevik activist, working in a range of cultural and educational establishments, in particular in the middle-level position of a governmental employee in charge of theatrical entrepreneurship in the Gomel' region. These publications started in the local weekly political and literary newspaper *Nash ponedel'nik* (*Our Monday*) that came out in Gomel' in 1922–3. It was discontinued in September 1923 in order to be merged with another local title, *Poleskaia Pravda* (*The Truth of Poles'e*), where Vygotsky continued publishing his essays and reviews until his final move from Gomel' back to Moscow in early 1924. Another of Vygotsky's publications is known to have come out in a literary journal, *Veresk* (*Heather*), published on the initiative of Lev Vygotsky, his friends and associates in Gomel', a new but short-lived title that seems to have been discontinued after the publication of just two issues, both in 1922.

The authorship of a few of these publications is somewhat questionable. The reason is that many of them were signed only with the author's initials, for instance, "L. S.," "L. V." or even, in one instance,

TABLE A1 Vygotsky's known publications from 1916 to 1923

Journal/Title	1916	1917	1918	1919	1920	1921	1922	1923	Total
<i>Novyi Put'</i>	5	7	—	—	—	—	—	—	12
<i>Letopis'</i>	3	2	—	—	—	—	—	—	5
<i>Novaia Zhizn'</i>	—	1	—	—	—	—	—	—	1
<i>Stikhi i Proza o Russkoi Revoliutsii</i>	—	—	—	1	—	—	—	—	1
<i>Zhizn' Iskusstva</i>	—	—	—	—	1	—	—	—	1
<i>Veresk</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	1	—	1
<i>Nash Ponedel'nik</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	14	42	56
<i>Polesskaia Pravda</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	20	20
Total	8	10	0	1	1	0	15	62	97

"L. -skii." What further complicates the task of identification of the real author (or authors) of these essays is the fact that there were at least three people in Gomel' in the early 1920s with this family name, who were active in the field of arts and literary criticism and related publishing enterprises. These were Lev Vygotskii (born Vygodskii) and two of his cousins: the well-known translator and literary critic David Vygodskii and his brother Lev Vygotskii. Thus, for a while there were two people – furthermore, of roughly the same age and from the same family – named "Lev Vygodskii" in Gomel', the only difference between their full names being their patronymics: "our Vygodsky" was Lev Semenovich Vygodskii, whereas his cousin was Lev Isaakovich Vygodskii. This might explain why "our Vygodsky" was likely to have often signed his essays with the first letters of his name and patronymic, i.e. "L. S." And yet, there is no final certainty about the authorship of publications that were not explicitly signed by their author with full initials (e.g. L. S. Vygodskii or, later, L. S. Vygotskii) and even less about those that were printed unsigned. Given the multitude and variety of ways Vygotsky signed his early publications and so as not to further complicate the issue we made a decision to uniformly preserve the traditional spelling of his name as it is widely known in post-World War II Russian-language scholarship, namely as "Vygotskii, L. S.," which does not necessarily reflect the way a specific piece was originally signed.

The statistics of Vygotsky's publications in the period 1916–23 are summarized in Table A1, followed by the complete list. Yet, one needs to be quite cautious in interpreting the total numbers of publications per specific edition or in a certain year since what these calculations reflect is the author's agency and social activism. No information on the length of these publications or their relative historical or theoretical importance, if any, can be found in the table.

1916

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1916). Traurnye stroki. *Novyi Put'*, 27, 28–30.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1916). M. Yu. Lermontov (k 75-letiiu so dnia smerti). *Novyi Put'*, 28, 7–11.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1916). Vykup (Iz knigi Khadisov M.I. Berdichevskogo). *Novyi Put'*, 39, 37–40.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1916). Literaturnye zametki. [Review of] A. Belyi, Peterburg. *Novyi Put'*, 47, 27–32.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1916). Mysli i nastroeniia (Stroki k Khanuko). *Novyi Put'*, 48–49, 49–52.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1916). [Review of] V. Ivanov, Borozdy i mezhi. *Letopis'*, 10, 351–352.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1916). [Review of] A. Belyi, Peterburg. *Letopis'*, 12, 327–328.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1916). [On new theater]. *Letopis'*. [This item is included in this bibliography as it was reported in Vygotskii, 1965, 1968, but we were unable to confirm that publication in fact ever took place.]

1917

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). [About Aikhenval'd]. *Novaia Zhizn'*. [This item is included in this bibliography as it was reported in Vygotskii, 1965, 1968, but we were unable to confirm that publication in fact ever took place.]
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). [Review of] L. Merezhkovskii, Budet radost'. *Letopis'*, 1, 309–310.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). [Review of] I. S. Turgenev, Pop': Poema. *Letopis'*, 5–6, 366–367.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). Na ulitsakh Moskvy: Vpechatleniia. *Novyi Put'*, 9–10, 19–23.

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). Otkliki provintsial'nykh tsentrov. *Novyi Put'*, 9–10, 39.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). Avodim hoinu. *Novyi Put'*, 11–12, 8–10.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). Vybory v Gorodskuiu Dumu. *Novyi Put'*, 24–25, 30–31.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). Provintsial'nye zametki. *Novyi Put'*, 29, 29–31.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). Konferentsiia s.–d. *Novyi Put'*, 29, 31.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1917). L. O. Gordon (K 25-letiiu so dnia smerti: 1892–1917). *Novyi Put'*, 30, 29–32.

1918

[none]

1919

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1919). Teatr i revoliutsiia (pp. 1–12). In *Stikhi i proza o russkoi revoliutsii. Sbornik pervyi*. Kiev: Sovremennaia Mysl'.

1920

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1920). Tsar' golyi. *Zhizn' Iskusstva*, 613–615, 1.

1921

[none]

1922

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Gastrol'i E. V. Gel'tser. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 3, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Gastrol'i Solovtsovskoi truppy. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 3, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Prestuplenie i nakazanie. Zolotaia osen'. Na dne. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 4, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Oktiaabr' v poezii. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 6, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Dekabristy i ikh poeziia. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 7, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Otkrytie sezona. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 7, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Gastrol'i operetty. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 7, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Revizor. Flavia Tesini. Tsena zhizni. Pevets svoei pechali. Ovod. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 8, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Durak. Khamka. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 9, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Chernaia pantera. Volch'i dushi. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 10, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Ne sovsem retsenziia. Kovarstvo i liubov'. Sokoly i vorony. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 11, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Uriel Acosta. Groza. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 12, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Khorosho sshityi frak. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 13, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Orlenok. Uchenik d'iavola. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 14, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1922). Redaktsionnaia stat'ia. *Veresk*, 1, 7.

1923

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Ne sovsem retsenzii. Dve sirotki. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 21, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Ne sovsem retsenzii. Nedomerok. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 21, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Ne sovsem retsenzii. Deti solntsa. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 21, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Ne sovsem retsenzii. Zapozdalye otzyvy. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 21, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Ne sovsem retsenzii. Tsarevich Aleksei. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 21, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Ne sovsem retsenzii. Meshchane. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 21, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). K zakrytiiu sezona. 1. Poslednii spektakl'. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 28, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). K zakrytiiu sezona. 2. V babushkinoi biblioteke. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 28, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). K zakrytiiu sezona. 3. Bez rulia i bez vetril. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 28, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). K zakrytiiu sezona. 4. Malen'kie kusochniki teatra. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 28, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). K zakrytiiu sezona. 5. Kakoi shchastliveishii den' vashei zhizni, ili Vosklitsatel'nyi znak! *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 28, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). K zakrytiiu sezona. 6. Ob avtore 'ne sovsem retsenzii'. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 28, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Evreiskii teatr. Sil'va. A mensh zol men zain. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 30, 3.

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Pervaia lastochka. 'Dybuk' v postanovke Rubina. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 32, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Evreiskii teatr. Koldun'ia. – Dos ferblonzene sheifele. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 33, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Evreiskii teatr. Bar Kokhba. – Der eshiv bokher. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 34, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). O detskom teatre. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 35, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Evreiskii teatr. Benefis S. I. Eidel'man. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 36, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli truppy Azagarovoi. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 37, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Izuchenie isskustva za gody revoliutsii. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 37, 3. [UNSIGNED]
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). O letnikh gastroliakh. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 37, 3. [UNSIGNED]
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Reformator russkogo baleta Fokin. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 37, 3. [UNSIGNED]
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Teatr i zhizn'. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 37, 4. [UNSIGNED]
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Zametki o evreiskom teatre. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 37, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Krasnyi Fakel. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 38, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli truppy A. Ya. Azagarovoi. Roman – Gubernator – Obladanie. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 38, 3–4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli 'Krasnogo Fakela'. Sverchok na pechi. – Sobaka na sene. – Okean. – Pobeda smerti. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 39, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Beseda s rukovoditelem "Krasnogo Fakela". *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 39, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli Krasnogo Fakela. Zelenoe kol'tso – Mladost' – Monna Vanna. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 40, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Belorusskii teatr (k gastroliam v Gomele). *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 40, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli Krasnogo Fakela. Shut na trone. – Igra interesov. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 41, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli Belorusskogo teatra. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 42, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Akademicheskie gastroli. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 44, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Akademicheskie gastroli. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 45, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). [Ot ponedel'nika do ponedel'nika]. Akademicheskie gastroli. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 46, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). [Ot ponedel'nika do ponedel'nika]. Gastroli Utesova i Foreggera. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 46, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli Utesova i Foreggera. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 47, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Khar'kovskii balet. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 48, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). V antrakte mezhdru gastroliami. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 49, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). O muzee im. Lunacharskogo. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 50, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli vtoroi studii MKhAT. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 51, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli vtoroi studii MKhAT. *Nash Ponedel'nik*, 52, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Petr III i Ekaterina II. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1006, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Ved'ma. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1008, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Dzhentel'men. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1009, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Vlast' t'my. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1010, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Revizor. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1011, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Vecherniaia zaria. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1014, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Zolotaia kletka. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1018, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Korolevskii bradobrei. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1025, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Komediia dvora. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1029, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Koroleva i zenshchina. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1036, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Slesar' i kantsler. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1038, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Stakan vody. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1053, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Kogda zagovorit serdtse. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1056, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Blagodat'. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1057, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Nechaiannaia radost'. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1058, 4.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). O Dem'iane bednom, muzhike vrednom. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1063, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Bol'shoi narodnyi pisatel'. K iubileiu Serafimovicha. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1069, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). Gastroli Maksimova. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1072, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). O belorusskoi literature. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1075, 3.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1923). 10 dney, kotorye potriasli mir. *Polesskaia Pravda*, 1081, 3.

Publications of 1924–1933

This cluster of Vygotsky's publications constitutes his main lifetime contribution to psychological science. We have every reason to believe that the vast majority of these texts were finalized and prepared for publication by their author, and therefore represent his thought virtually as their author intended. Not all of these publications are of equal importance, however. Thus, quite a few of Vygotsky's works were written to earn money to augment his miserably low salary as a university teacher. Those chapters or articles were of a more popular character and intended for a general and, often, barely educated reader. They were probably quickly written and contain no original ideas. Indeed, on several occasions Vygotsky extensively borrowed from existing publications by other authors. For that reason, Vygotsky did not count these publications among his important theoretical works and never included them in his bibliographies of scholarly publications (for further discussion, see Chapter 4). Another group of his publications of this decade consists of programmatic or speculative papers, mostly of a political nature, that arguably also are of minimal relevance to contemporary scholarly research in psychology and allied sciences. In assessing the total number of Vygotsky's publications of this period one should also keep in mind that on a number of occasions Vygotsky used a technique that can be conditionally referred to as "self-plagiarism," meaning that the same passages were published over and over again and/or were included – possibly, with minimal changes – in other, larger publications without ever mentioning the original source. An example is Vygotsky's (1930) Introduction to the Russian translation of Köhler's book *The mentality of apes*, which was identical to a journal article in *Estestvoznaniye i marksizm* (*Natural Science and Marxism*) published one year before. This idiosyncrasy of Vygotsky's publication activity has been noted on a number of occasions, but has never been subjected to thorough investigation. Until in-depth research of the kind has been done we are unable to identify the number of original contributions published in 1924–33.

All publications of this period are organized chronologically and, further, divided into several categories that we somewhat loosely termed:

- (1) prefaces, reviews, entries [in dictionaries, encyclopedias, etc.]
- (2) proceedings
- (3) articles
- (4) book chapters
- (5) books.

A comment is needed on these five groups of publications as we understand them.

Prefaces, reviews, entries include a wide range of publications that are typically of relatively minor importance in terms of their theoretical impact and scholarly merit, such as book reviews, information letters, "responses to journal readers," encyclopedia entries, an obituary, etc. Similarly, *Proceedings* include abstracts of conference presentations, mostly very brief and relatively uninformative. In other words, these are typically such publications that the authors of this bibliography would not consider worth translating from Russian and republishing in a psychological volume unless for purely historical reasons. That said, the group also includes a few fairly important theoretical works of Vygotsky's that most often came out as book prefaces. Generally, the length of a publication of this kind is a fairly reliable predictor of its scholarly weight and importance.

Books as a publication category, perhaps quite counterintuitively, is the most problematic group of Vygotsky's publications in terms of its academic value and scholarly integrity. Indeed, judging by mere numbers, Vygotsky appears to have produced a lot of books, which seems to indicate a high level of scholarly achievement. Yet a closer investigation of the actual publications reveals the striking reality: only a few of Vygotsky's books qualify as academic treatises with theoretical merit. Thus, the majority of Vygotsky's book publications fall under one of the following categories: (a) edited volumes (including those with no written contributions by Vygotsky whatsoever); (b) educational materials – basic and introductory textbooks, readers, a dictionary, etc.; or (c) popular books written for the enlightenment of the general reader in the post-revolutionary Soviet Union of the 1920s–1930s rather than for a scholarly audience. Finally, the fourth subcategory of Vygotsky's books is: (d) theoretical treatises, which generously includes collections of Vygotsky's papers, written at different time periods and on different occasions. For specific titles that belong to this subcategory see the following section of this bibliography. It is with a certain degree of

TABLE A2 Vygotsky's book publications, 1924–1933

	1924	1925	1926	1927	1928	1929	1930	1931	1932	1933	Total
Edited volumes	1	–	–	–	–	–	1	–	–	–	2
Educational materials	–	–	1	2	1	2	1	2	–	–	9
Popular books	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	–	–	–	2
Theoretical treatises	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	0
Total	1	0	1	2	1	2	4	2	0	0	13

doubt and upon considerable reflection that we made the decision to include all diverse book publications in our list. As a result, the mere figure of thirteen book publications might be mistaken for an indication of considerable theoretical impact, but in fact it is primarily evidence of Vygotsky's social activism and agency in the sphere of public enlightenment. Thus, the distribution and the number of Vygotsky's book publications in 1924–33 across these subcategories is presented in Table A2:

Finally, *Articles* and *Book chapters* are in essence quite similar and include Vygotsky's actual scholarly writings that came out in a wide range of journals and books. Journal publications – theoretical and research articles as well as minor entries – cumulatively constituted the majority of these publications of 1924–33; for statistics see Table A3. Note that all publications included in this section comprise domestic publications within the Soviet Union only. For the list of foreign publications see the following section on posthumous and foreign publications.

1924

Prefaces, reviews, entries

Vygotskii, L. S. (1924). Predislovie (pp. 5–23). In A. F. Lazurskii, *Psikhologiya obshchaia i eksperimental'naia*. Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1924). Predislovie (pp. 3–4). In L. S. Vygotskii (Ed.), *Voprosy vospitaniia slepykh, glukhone-mykh i umstvenno-otstalykh detei*. Moscow: Izdatel'stvo SPON NKP.

Articles

Vygotskii, L. S. (1924). Anketnyi metod psikhologicheskogo issledovaniia uchaschikhhsia. *Na Putiakh k Novoi Shkole*, 6–7, ?–?. [This article was listed in the bibliography of Vygotsky's works that was published in the first edition of his *Thinking and speech* in 1934 (see p. 322). We have been unable to confirm that publication ever actually took place, yet, with considerable reservations, we made the decision to include the entry in this bibliography.]

Book chapters

Vygotskii, L. S. (1924). K psikhologii i pedagogike detskoi defektivnosti (pp. 5–30). In L. S. Vygotskii (Ed.), *Voprosy vospitaniia slepykh, glukhone-mykh i umstvenno-otstalykh detei*. Moscow: Izdatel'stvo SPON NKP.

Books

Vygotskii, L. S. (Ed.) (1924). *Voprosy vospitaniia slepykh, glukhone-mykh i umstvenno-otstalykh detei*. Moscow: Izdatel'stvo SPON NKP.

1925

Prefaces, reviews, entries

Vygotskii, L. S. (1925). O vspomogatel'noi shkole. [Review of] A. N. Graborov, *Vspomogatel'naia shkola. Narodnoe Prosveshchenie*, 9, 170–171.

Vygotskii, L. S., & Luria, A. R. (1925). Predislovie k russkomu perevodu (pp. 3–16). In S. Freud, *Po tu storonu printsipa udovol'stviia*. Moscow: Sovremennye Problemy.

TABLE A3 Vygotsky's journal publications, 1924–1933 (figures in italics and in brackets indicate the number of minor publications: reviews, information letters, etc.)

<i>Journal Title</i>	1924	1925	1926	1927	1928	1929	1930	1931	1932	1933	<i>Total</i>
<i>Na Putiakh k Novoi Shkole</i>	1	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	1
<i>Narodnoe Prosveshchenie</i>	—	2(1)	—	—	2	—	—	—	—	—	4(3)
<i>Narodnyi Uchitel'</i>	—	—	—	1	—	—	—	—	—	—	1
<i>Sovetskoe Iskusstvo</i>	—	—	—	1	1	—	—	—	—	—	2
<i>Voprosy Defektologii</i>	—	—	—	—	1	3	—	2	—	—	6(3)
<i>Pedologiia</i>	—	—	—	—	1	3(1)	2(1)	2	—	—	8(2)
<i>Estestvoznamanie i Marksizm</i>	—	—	—	—	—	4(2)	—	—	—	—	4(2)
<i>Iskusstvo v Shkole</i>	—	—	—	—	—	1	—	—	—	—	1
<i>Khochu Vse Znat'</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	3	—	—	—	3
<i>VARNITSO</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	1	—	—	—	1
<i>Detskii Dom</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	1	—	—	—	1
<i>Psikhotekhnika i Psikhofiziologiia</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	1	1	1	—	3(1)
<i>Truda (1928–31) / Sovetskaia Psikhotehnika (1932–4)</i>											
<i>Robitnycha Osvita</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	1	—	—	—	1
<i>Psikhologiia</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	1	—	—	1
<i>Sovetskaia Nevropatologiia, Psikhiatriia i Psikhogigiena</i>	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	1	—	1
Total	1	2(1)	0	2(1)	5(2)	11(7)	8(4)	6	2(1)	0	37(16)

Articles

Vygotskii, L. S. (1925). Printsipy vospitaniia fizicheski defektivnykh detei. *Narodnoe Prosveshchenie*, 1, 112–120.

Book chapters

Vygotskii, L. S. (1925). Soznanie, kak problema psikhologii povedeniia (pp. 175–198). In K. N. Kornilov (Ed.), *Psikhologiia i marksizm*. Moscow: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo.

1926*Prefaces, reviews, entries*

Vygotskii, L. S. (1926). Predislovie (pp. 5–23). In E. L. Thorndike, *Printsipy obucheniia, osnovannye na psikhologii*. Moscow: Rabotnik Prosveshcheniia.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1926). Grafika Bykhovskogo (pp. 5–8). In A. Bykhovskii, *Grafika*. Kazan: Sovremennaia Rossiia.

Vygotskii, L. S. & Luria, A. R. (1926). Predislovie (pp. 3–5). In R. Schulze, *Praktika eksperimental'noi psikhologii, pedagogiki i psikhotehniki*. Moscow: Voprosy Truda.

Book chapters

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1926). Metodika refleksologicheskogo i psikhologicheskogo issledovaniia (pp. 26–46). In K. N. Kornilov (Ed.), *Problemy sovremennoi psikhologii: Sbornik statei sotrudnikov Moskovskogo gosudarstvennogo instituta eksperimental'noi psikhologii*. Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1926). Problema dominantnykh reaktsii (pp. 100–124). In K. N. Kornilov (Ed.), *Problemy sovremennoi psikhologii: Sbornik statei sotrudnikov Moskovskogo gosudarstvennogo instituta eksperimental'noi psikhologii*. Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1926). O vliianii rechevogo ritma na dykhanie (pp. 169–173). In K. N. Kornilov (Ed.), *Problemy sovremennoi psikhologii: Sbornik statei sotrudnikov Moskovskogo gosudarstvennogo instituta eksperimental'noi psikhologii*. Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1926). Po povodu stat'i K. Koffka o samonabliudenii: Vmesto predisloviia (pp. 176–178). In K. N. Kornilov (Ed.), *Problemy sovremennoi psikhologii: Sbornik statei sotrudnikov Moskovskogo gosudarstvennogo instituta eksperimental'noi psikhologii*. Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1926). Printsipy vospitaniia fizicheskii defektivnykh detei (pp. 7–22). In S. S. Tizanov & P. P. Pochapin (Eds.), *Puti vospitaniia fizicheskii defektivnogo rebenka*. Moscow: Izdatel'stvo SPON NKP.

Books

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1926). *Pedagogicheskaiia psikhologiiia: Kratkii kurs*. Moscow: Rabotnik Prosveshcheniia.

1927*Prefaces, reviews, entries*

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1927). [Review of] M. Ya. Basov, *Metodika psikhologicheskikh nabliudenii za det'mi. Narodnyi Uchitel'*, 1, 152.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1927). Biogeneticheskii zakon (pp. 275–279). In O. Yu. Shmidt (Ed.), *Bol'shaia Sovetskaia Entsiklopediia* (Vol. 6). Moscow: GIZ.

Articles

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1927). Sovremennaia psikhologiiia i iskusstvo. *Sovetskoe Iskusstvo*, 3(8), 5–8.

Book chapters

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1927). Defekt i sverkhkompensatsiia (pp. 51–76). In Ya. R. Gailis, L. V. Zankov, & S. S. Tizanov (Eds.), *Umstvennaia otstalost', slepota i glukhonemota: Psikhofiziologiiia, pedagogika i profilaktika*. Moscow: Doloi Negramotnost'.

Books

- Artemov, V. A., Bernstein, N. A., Vygotskii, L. S., Dobrynin, N. F., & Luria, A. R. (1927). *Praktikum po eksperimental'noi psikhologii*. (K. N. Kornilov, Ed.). Moscow-Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe izdatel'stvo.
- Artemov, V. A., Vygotskii, L. S., Dobrynin, N. F., & Luria, A. R. (1927). *Psikhologicheskaiia khrestomatiia*. (K. N. Kornilov, Ed.). Moscow-Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe izdatel'stvo.

1928*Prefaces, reviews, entries*

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1928). Pedagogicheskie osnovy raboty s umstvenno-otstalymi i fizicheskii-defektivnymi det'mi (pp. 391–398). In A. G. Kalashnikov (Ed.), *Pedagogicheskaiia Entsiklopediia* (Vol. 2). Moscow: Rabotnik Prosveshcheniia.
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- Vygotskii, L. S. (1928). Voliuntarizm (pp. 589–590). In N. A. Semashko (Ed.), *Bol'shaia Meditsinskaia Entsiklopediia* (Vol. 5). Moscow: GIZ.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1928). Volia i ee rasstroistva (pp. 590–600). In N. A. Semashko (Ed.), *Bol'shaia Meditsinskaia Entsiklopediia* (Vol. 5). Moscow: GIZ.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1928). Pamiati V. M. Bekhtereva. *Narodnoe Prosveshchenie*, 2, 68–70.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1928). Itogi s"ezda. *Narodnoe Prosveshchenie*, 2, 56–57.

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- Vygotskii, L. S. (1928). Razvitie trudnogo rebenka i ego izuchenie (pp. 132–136). In A. B. Zalkind (Ed.), *Osnovnye problemy pedagogii v SSSR (po tezisam pervogo vserossiiskogo pedagogicheskogo s"ezda 27/XII-1927 g.-3/I-1928 g.)*. Moscow: Izdanie Orgbiuro S"ezda.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1928). Instrumental'nii metod v pedagogii (pp. 158–159). In A. B. Zalkind (Ed.), *Osnovnye problemy pedagogii v SSSR (po tezisam pervogo vserossiiskogo pedagogicheskogo s"ezda 27/XII-1927 g.-3/I-1928 g.)*. Moscow: Izdanie Orgbiuro S"ezda.

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- Vygotskii, L. S. (1929). K voprosu o dlitel'nosti detstva umstvenno otstalogo rebenka. *Voprosy Defektologii*, 2(8), 111.
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- Vygotskii, L. S. (1929). Osnovnye polozheniia plana pedagogicheskoi issledovatel'skoi raboty v oblasti trudnogo detstva. *Pedologiya*, 2(3), 333–342.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1929). K voprosu o plane nauchno-issledovatel'skoi raboty po pedagogii natsional'nykh men'shinstv. *Pedologiya*, 2(3), 367–377.

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rabota pedfaka i instituta nauchnoi pedagogiki 2-go Moskovskogo universiteta. Tom 1. (pp. 77–106). Moscow: Rabotnik Prosveshcheniia.

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Vygotskii, L. S. (Ed.) (1929). *Predmet i metody sovremennoi psikhologii*. Moscow: Izdanie Biuro Zaochnogo Obucheniia pri Pedfak 2 MGU.

1930

Prefaces, reviews, entries

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Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Vydaiushchaia pamiat'. *Khochu vse znat'*, 19, 553–554.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Vozmozhno li simulirovat' vydaiushchuiu pamiat'? *Khochu vse znat'*, 24, 700–703.

Vygotskii, L. S., & Pechatnikov, A. (1930). Plan sozyva konferentsii po natsmenpedologii. *Pedologii*, 4, 529–530.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Eksperimental'noe issledovanie vysshikh protsessov povedeniia (pp. 70–71). In A. B. Zalkind (Ed.), *Psikho-nevrologicheskie nauki v SSSR (Materialy 1 Vsesoiuznogo s"ezda po izucheniiu povedeniia cheloveka)*. Moscow-Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Meditsinskoe Izdatel'stvo.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Issledovanie kul'turnogo razvitiia rebenka: 1. Razvitie vysshikh form povedeniia v detskom vozraste (pp. 138–139). In A. B. Zalkind (Ed.), *Psikho-nevrologicheskie nauki v SSSR (Materialy 1 Vsesoiuznogo s"ezda po izucheniiu povedeniia cheloveka)*. Moscow-Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Meditsinskoe Izdatel'stvo.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Kul'turnoe razvitie anomal'nogo i trudno-vospituemogo rebenka (pp. 195–196). In A. B. Zalkind (Ed.), *Psikho-nevrologicheskie nauki v SSSR (Materialy 1 Vsesoiuznogo s"ezda po izucheniiu povedeniia cheloveka)*. Moscow-Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Meditsinskoe Izdatel'stvo.

Articles

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Sotsialisticheskaiia peredelka cheloveka. *VARNITSO*, 3(9–10), 36–44.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Novoe v oblasti pedagogicheskikh issledovani. *Detskii Dom*, 7, 22–27.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Problema vysshikh intellektual'nykh funktsii v sisteme psikhotekhnikheskogo issledovaniia. *Psikhotekhnika i Psikhofiziologiia Truda*, 3, 374–384.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). O sviazi mezhdu trudovoi deiatel'nost'iu i intellektual'nym razvitiem rebenka. *Pedologii*, 3(5–6), 588–595.

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). K probleme razvitiia interesov v perekhodnom vozraste. *Robitnycha Osvita*, 7–8, 63–81.

Book chapters

Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Strukturaia psikhologiia (pp. 84–125). In B. A. Fingert & M. L. Shirvindt (Eds.), *Osnovnye techeniia sovremennoi psikhologii*. Moscow-Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo.

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Eidetika (pp. 178–205). In B. A. Fingert & M. L. Shirvindt (Eds.), *Osnovnye tekhnii sovremennoi psikhologii*. Moscow-Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Psikhika, soznanie i bessoznatel'noe (pp. 48–61). In K. N. Kornilov (Ed.), *Elementy obshchei psikhologii: Osnovnye mekhanizmy chelovecheskogo povedeniia*. Moscow: Izdanie Biuro Zaochnogo Obucheniia pri Pedfak 2 MGU.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). Son i snovideniia (pp. 62–75). In K. N. Kornilov (Ed.), *Elementy obshchei psikhologii: Osnovnye mekhanizmy chelovecheskogo povedeniia*. Moscow: Izdanie Biuro Zaochnogo Obucheniia pri Pedfak 2 MGU.

Books

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- Vygotskii, L. S. (1930). *Vobrazhenie i tvorchestvo v detskom vozraste: Psikhologicheskii ocherk*. Moscow: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo RSFSR.
- Vygotskii, L. S., & Luria, A. R. (1930). *Etiudy po istorii povedeniia: Obez'iana, primitiv, rebenok*. Moscow-Leningrad: GIZ.
- Azbukin, D. I., Vygotskii, L. S. & Zankov, L. V. (Eds.) (1930). *Pedologiia umstvenno-otstalogo i fizicheskii-defektivnogo detstva*. Moscow: GIZ.

1931

Prefaces, reviews, entries

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). Predislovie (pp. 6–13). In A. N. Leont'ev, *Razvitie pamiaty: Eksperimental'noe issledovanie vysshikh psikhologicheskikh funktsii*. Moscow-Leningrad: Uchpedgiz.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). Predislovie (pp. 3–5). In Ya. K. Tsveifel', *Ocherki osobennosti povedeniia i vospitaniia glukhonemogo rebenka*. Moscow-Leningrad: Uchpedgiz.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). Myshlenie. In N. A. Semashko (Ed.), *Bol'shaia meditsinskaia entsiklopediia* (Vol. 19, pp. 414–426). Moscow: Sovetskaia entsiklopediia.

Articles

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). K voprosu o pedologii i smezhnykh s neiu naukakh. *Pedologiia*, 4(3), 52–58.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). K voprosu o psikhologii i pedologii. *Psikhologiia*, 4, 78–100.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). Pedologiia i smezhnye s neiu nauki: Pedologiia i psikhologiia, *Pedologiia*, 4(7–8), 12–22.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). Psikhotehnika i pedologiia. *Psikhotehnika i Psikhofiziologiia Truda*, 2–3, 173–184.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). Kollektiv kak faktor razvitiia anomal'nogo rebenka I. *Voprosy Defektologii*, 1–2, 8–17.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). Kollektiv kak faktor razvitiia anomal'nogo rebenka II. *Voprosy Defektologii*, 3, 3–18.

Books

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). *Pedologiia podrostka. Chast' III. Psikhologiia podrostka. Chast' IV. Sotsial'nye problemy pedologii perekhodnogo vozrasta. Zadaniia 9–16*. Moscow: Gosudarstvennoe Uchebno-Pedagogicheskoe Izdatel'stvo.
- Varshava, B. E., & Vygotskii, L. S. (1931). *Psikhologicheskii slovar'*. Moscow: Uchpedgiz.

1932

Prefaces, reviews, entries

- Vygotskii, L. S. (1932). Problema razvitiia rebenka v issledovaniakh Arnol'da Gezella: Kriticheskii ocherk (pp. 3–14). In A. Gesell, *Pedologiia rannego vozrasta*. Moscow-Leningrad: Uchpedgiz.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1932). Problema rechi i myshleniia rebenka v uchenii Zh. Piazhe: Kriticheskoe issledovanie (pp. 3–54). In J. Piaget, *Rech' i myshlenie rebenka*. Moscow-Leningrad: Uchpedgiz.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1932). Predislovie (pp. 3–10). In E. K. Gracheva, *Vospitanie i obuchenie gluboko otstalogo rebenka*. Moscow-Leningrad: Uchpedgiz.
- Vygotskii, L. S. (1932). [Review of] E. L. Thorndike, E. O. Bregman, J. Tilton, & E. Woodyard, *Psikhologiia obucheniia vzroslykh*. Sovetskaia Psikhotehnika, 1–2, 145.

TABLE A4 Vygotsky's book publications, 1934–1936

	1934	1935	1936	Total
Edited volumes	—	1	—	1
Educational materials	1	1	—	2
Popular books	—	—	—	0
Theoretical treatises	1	1	1	3
Total	2	3	1	6

Vygotskii, L. S., & Leont'ev, A. N. (1932). Predislovie k knige A. N. Leont'eva "Razvitie pamiati" (pp. 2–11). In Nauchno-issledovatel'skii sektor AKV, *Prilozhenie k knige A.N. Leont'eva*.

Articles

Vygotskii, L. S. (1932). K probleme psikhologii shizofrenii. *Sovetskaia Nevropatologiia, Psikhiatriia i Psikhogigiena*, 8, 352–364.

1933

Prefaces, reviews, entries

Vygotskii, L. S. (1933). Predislovie (pp. 3–4). In L. V. Zankov, M. S. Pevzner, & V. F. Schmidt (Eds.), *Trudnye deti v shkol'noi rabote*. Moscow-Leningrad: Uchpedgiz.

Book chapters

Vygotskii, L. S. (1933). K probleme psikhologii shizofrenii (pp. 19–28). In P. B. Gannushkin, V. A. Giliarovskii, M. O. Gurevich, M. B. Krol', N. I. Propper, & A. S. Shmar'ian, *Sovremennye problemy shizofrenii: Doklady na konferentsii po shizofrenii v iune 1932*. Moscow-Leningrad: Medgiz.

Posthumous (i.e. 1934 and after) and foreign publications

This section of the bibliography combines two different sets of Vygotsky's published works: those that came out in the Soviet Union around Vygotsky's death in June, 1934, and his publications abroad. Despite many differences, the two categories have something very important in common: they were promoted by a third party (i.e. other than the author and the publisher), without Vygotsky being actively involved in their publication. The most important names of these "third party" mediators between Vygotsky and the publishers were Zhozefina Shif, Daniil El'konin, Mira Levina (all in Leningrad), Leonid Zankov, Viktor Kolbanovskii, and Roza Levina (all in Moscow, after Vygotsky's death) and Jacob Kasanin, Eugenia Hanfmann and, in a somewhat limited way, Horace Kallen (in North America). An interesting trend in Vygotsky's publications of this period is the first release of his theoretical book-length treatises, published posthumously in 1934–6 (see Table A4 and compare it with Table A2).

In the case of foreign publications, given that Vygotsky most likely never wrote anything in a language other than Russian, the most direct and evident consequence of the third-party involvement was that of translating and editing. The terminology of Vygotsky's works – as inconsistent and unsettled as it was during his lifetime – is perhaps the most vulnerable component of his discourse, and since we have no evidence that Vygotsky ever approved any of these translations before their publication abroad, the third-party activities significantly undermine the reliability of these translated texts as presumably authentic writings. Yet our bibliography of Vygotsky's works published abroad before World War II demonstrates a record of eleven publications in five languages (see Table A5) that provides some preliminary data on the social formation of the image – or rather, different national images (cf. Table A6) – of "Vygotsky" in different cultural environments in Europe and North America.

Furthermore, in the case of posthumous Russian publications the third party's involvement was even more profound. Not only is there no certainty as to the phrasing or even, more generally, the contents of those posthumous publications – not unlikely they were substantially edited by Vygotsky's former associates in charge of publication of his works after his death – but also the choice of the texts themselves

TABLE A5 Vygotsky's foreign publications, 1920s–1930s

	1925	1926	1927	1928	1929	1930	1931	1932	1933	1934	1935	1936	1937	1938	1939	Total
English	1	–	–	–	1	1	–	–	–	1	–	–	–	–	1	5
German	–	–	–	–	2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	2
French	–	–	–	–	–	1	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	1
Spanish	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	–	–	–	–	2
Polish	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	1	–	–	–	1
Total	1	0	0	0	3	2	0	0	0	1	2	1	0	0	1	11

TABLE A6 Different spellings of "Vygotskii" in his foreign publications, 1920s–1930s

	1925	1929	1930	1934	1935	1936	1939
English	Vygotsky	Vygotski	Vygotsky	Vigotsky	–	–	Vigotsky
German	–	Wygotski	–	–	–	–	–
French	–	–	Vigotski	–	–	–	–
Spanish	–	–	–	–	Vigotski	–	–
Polish	–	–	–	–	–	Wygotski	–

remains fairly questionable. Thus, there is considerable evidence that Vygotsky did not finalize a number of texts that were published after his death, and even, in certain instances, did not intend to publish them. This means that Vygotsky as an author (a) did not actually finish these texts, or, alternatively, (b) never actually wrote them, which is true of his lectures and public presentations, recorded (i.e. typed up by a secretary simultaneously with the oral presentation) and later published without the revision required in accordance with the standards of written scholarly discourse, and (c) failed to enter references and bibliography.

In sum, Vygotsky's posthumous and foreign publications are problematic in many respects. Yet they give us an important insight into the legacy of the Vygotsky–Luria group at the most advanced stage of theory development. Virtually all of these publications are in our possession, yet in several instances publications were reported in the secondary literature (including Vygotsky's published works) and remained outside our reach. In these cases the authors had to rely on their judgment – rather than on the results of rigorous scholarly historical, bibliographical, and textological studies, which are virtually non-existent at this point – in making a decision on including specific publications, questionable in terms of their authorship or actual existence. This implies, of course, that even this bibliography will necessarily have to be updated as new data become available and that compiling the bibliography is an ongoing process.

Finally, overall numbers of Vygotsky's publications were counted and are presented in Table A7.

1934

Prefaces, reviews, entries

Vygotskii, L. S. (1934). Problema razvitiia v strukturnoi psikhologii (pp. ix–lvi). In K. Koffka, *Osnovy psikhicheskogo razvitiia*. Moscow–Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Sotsial'no-Ekonomicheskoe Izdatel'stvo.

Proceedings

Vygotskii, L. S. (1934). Psikhologiya i uchenie o lokalizatsii (pp. 34–41). In *Pervyi vseukrainskii s'ezd nevropatologov i psikhiatrov. Khar'kov, 1934, 18–24 iyunya: Tëzisy dokladov*. Kharkov: Gosmedizdat USSR.

Articles

Samukhin, N. V., Birenbaum, G. V., & Vygotskii, L. S. (1934). K voprosu o dementsii pri bolezni Pika. *Sovetskaiia Nevropatologiya, Psikhiatriia i Psikhogigiena*, 3(6), 97–136.

Book chapters

Vygotskii, L. S. (1934). [Chapter] 4. (pp. 18–28). In L. S. Vygotskii, V. A. Giliarovskii, M. O. Gurevich, M. B. Krol', A. S. Shmar'ian et al., *Fashizm v psikhonevrologii*. Moscow–Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo Biologicheskoi i Meditsinskoi Literatury.

Books

Vygotskii, L. S. (1934). *Osnovy pedagogii*. Moscow: Izdatel'stvo 2-go Moskovskogo Meditsinskogo Instituta.
 Vygotskii, L. S. (1934). *Myshlenie i rech'*. *Psikhologicheskie issledovaniia*. Moscow–Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Sotsial'no-Ekonomicheskoe Izdatel'stvo. [Contains prefaces Vygotskii (1929). [Review of]

TABLE A7 Vygotsky's scientific publication record, 1924–1936 (foreign publications indicated in italics and in parentheses)

	1924	1925	1926	1927	1928	1929	1930	1931	1932	1933	1934	1935	1936	Total
Prefaces, etc.	2	2	3	2	6	8	7	3	5	1	1	1	–	41
Proceedings	–	1	–	–	2	–	5(2)	–	–	–	1	–	–	9(3)
Articles	1	1	–	1	3	7(3)	5	6	1	–	2(1)	–	–	27(4)
Book chapters	1	1	5	1	2	3	4	–	–	1	1	3(2)	2(1)	24(3)
Books	1	–	1	2	1	2	4	2	–	–	2	3	1	19
Total	5	5(1)	9	6	14	20(3)	25(2)	11	6	2	7(1)	7(2)	3(1)	120(10)

C. and W. Stern; Vygotskii (1932). Problema; Vygotskii (1935). K voprosu; article Vygotskii (1929). Geneticheskii; and lengthy fragment from book Vygotskii (1931). *Pedologiya*]

1935

Prefaces, reviews, entries

Vygotskii, L. S. (1935). K voprosu o razvitií poniatii v shkol'nom vozraste (pp. 3–17). In Zh. I. Shif, *Razvitie nauchnykh poniatii u shkol'nika: Issledovanie k voprosu umstvennogo razvitiia shkol'nika pri obuchenii obshchestvovedeniiu*. Moscow–Leningrad: Gosudarstvennoe Uchebno-Pedagogicheskoe Izdatel'stvo.

Book chapters

Vygotskii, L. S. (1935). Problema umstvennoi otstalosti (opyt postroeniia rabochei gipotezy) [The problem of mental retardation (An attempt at a working hypothesis)] (pp. 7–34). In L. S. Vygotskii & I. I. Daniushevskii (Eds.), *Umstvennootstalyi rebenok*. Moscow: Uchpedgiz.

Books

Vygotskii, L. S. (1935). *Osnovy pedagogii*. Leningrad: Gosudarstvennyi Pedagogicheskii Institut Imeni A. I. Gertsena. [Identical to book Vygotskii (1934). *Osnovy*]

Vygotskii, L. S. (1935). *Umstvennoe razvitie v protsesse obucheniia*. Moscow–Leningrad: Uchpedgiz.

Vygotskii, L. S. & Daniushevskii, I. I. (Eds.) (1935). *Umstvennootstalyi rebenok*. Moscow: Gosudarstvennoe uchebno-pedagogicheskoe izdatel'stvo.

1936

Book chapters

Vygotskii, L. S. (1936). K voprosu o psikhologii tvorchestva aktera (pp. 197–211). In P. M. Yakobson, *Psikhologiya stsennicheskikh chuvstv aktera*. Moscow: GIZ.

Books

Vygotskii, L. S. (1936). *Diagnostika razvitiia i pedagogicheskaiia klinika trudnogo detstva*. Moscow: Izdatel'stvo Eksperimental'nogo Defektologicheskogo Instituta.

Foreign publications

1925

Proceedings

Vygotskii, L. S. (1925). Principles of social education for deaf and dumb children in Russia (pp. 227–237). In *International Conference on the Education of the Deaf*. London: William H. Taylor and Sons.

1929

Articles

Vygotski, L. S. (1929). The problem of the cultural development of the child II. *Journal of Genetic Psychology*, 36, 415–434. [Translation of article Vygotskii (1928). Problema]

Wygotski, L. S. (1929). Die genetischen Wurzeln des Denkens und der Sprache. *Unter dem Banner des Marxismus*, 3(3), 450–470. [Translation of article Vygotskii (1929). Geneticheskii, first part]

Wygotski, L. S. (1929). Die genetischen Wurzeln des Denkens und der Sprache. *Unter dem Banner des Marxismus*, 3(4), 607–624. [Translation of article Vygotskii (1929). Geneticheskii, second part]

1930

Proceedings

Vigotski, L. (1930). Le problème des fonctions intellectuelles supérieures dans le système des recherches psychotechniques (pp. 332–341). In *Anal's d'orientació professional, Vol. 4: VIIª Conferència Internacional de Psicotècnica (Recull dels treballs presentats)*. Barcelona: Escola de Treball. [Translation of article Vygotskii (1930). Problema]

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Vygotsky, L. S., & Luria, A. R. (1930). The function and fate of egocentric speech (pp. 464–465). *Ninth International Congress of Psychology. Proceedings and Papers. New Haven, September 1–7, 1929*. Princeton: Psychological Review Company.

1934

Articles

Vygotsky, L. S. (1934). Thought in schizophrenia. *Archives of Neurology and Psychiatry*, 31, 1063–1077. [Translation of article Vygotskii (1932). K probleme]

1935

Book chapters

Vigotski, L. S. (1935). El método de investigación reflexológica y psicológica (pp. 97–118). In K. N. Kornilov (Ed.), *Los problemas de la psicología moderna*. Madrid: Aguilar. [Translation of book chapter Vygotskii (1926). Metodika]

Vigotski, L. S. (1935). El problema de las reacciones dominantes (pp. 191–216). In K. N. Kornilov (Ed.), *Los problemas de la psicología moderna*. Madrid: Aguilar. [Translation of book chapter Vygotskii (1926). Problema]

1936

Book chapters

Wygotski L. S. (1936). *Nowe kierunki psychologii, Vol. 1: Psychologia strukturalna*. Lwów: Gubrynowicz i Syn. [Translation of book chapter Vygotskii (1930). Strukturalna]

1939

Articles

Vygotsky, L. S. (1939). Thought and speech. *Psychiatry*, 2, 29–54. [Translation of chapter 7 from book Vygotskii (1934). *Myshlenie*]

Appendix B

VYGOTSKY'S AND SOVIET PEDOLOGICAL PUBLICATIONS, 1924–1936

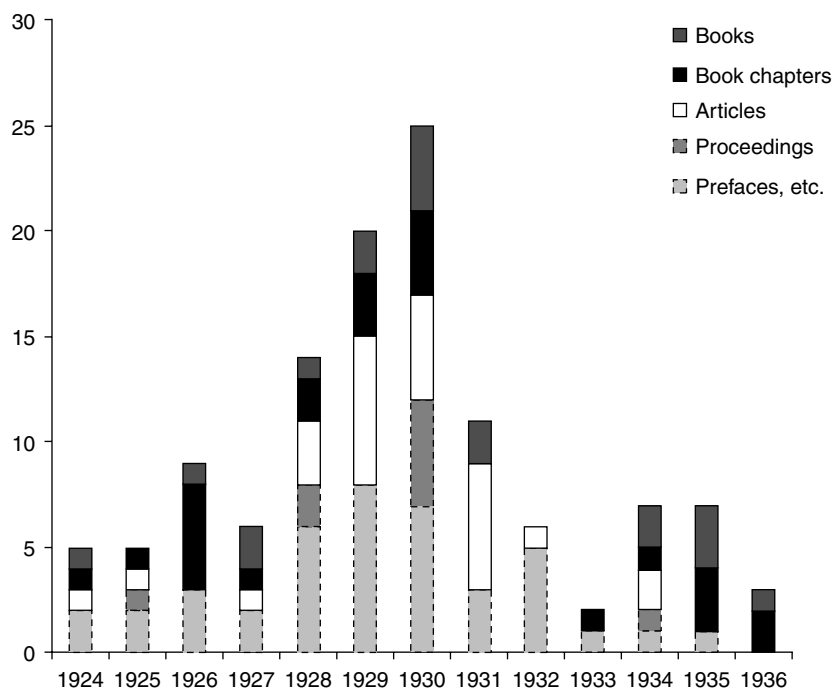


FIGURE A1 Vygotsky's publications, 1924–1936

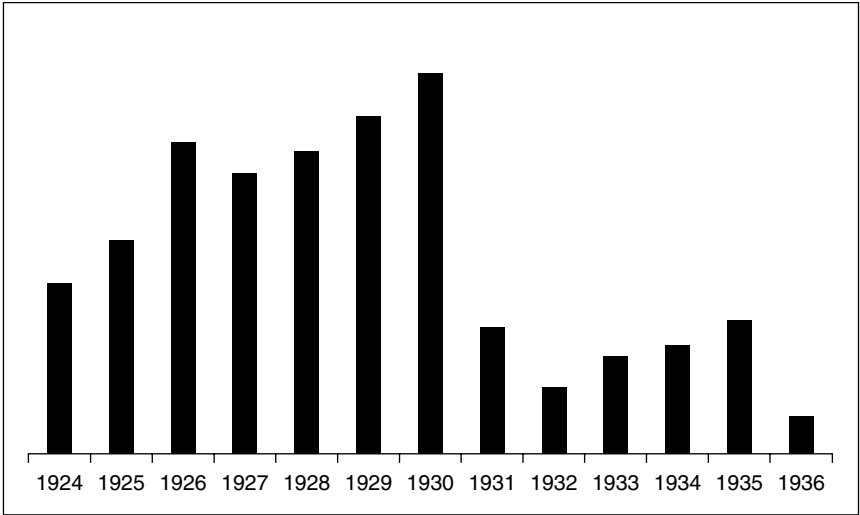


FIGURE A2 Soviet publications within the field of pedology, 1924–1936 (reconstructed on the basis of Minkova, 2012)

Appendix C

VYGOTSKY–LURIA CIRCLE

Key protagonists

Note: the list does not include some of Luria's collaborators of the 1920–30s and those members of the Kharkov group of researchers – as important as any of them might have been – who did not work directly with Vygotsky or possibly joined the group after Vygotsky's death, such as *Mirenova, Anna Nikitichna* (1901–45), *Rozenblium, Anatolii Il'ich* (1900–38), *Asnin, Vladimir Il'ich* (1904–56), *Zinchenko, Petr Ivanovich* (1903–69), *Gal'perin, Petr Yakovlevich* (1902–88), *Yudovich, Faina Yakovlevna* (dates of birth and death unknown), and others.

Averbukh, Roza Abramovna (1883–1940) – medical doctor (Bern, Geneva, Kazan); along with Luria, a member of Kazan Psychoanalytical Society in early 1920s; when Luria left Kazan in 1923, followed him to Moscow where they joined Russian Psychoanalytical Society; later joined Vygotsky's team, and, in collaboration with *Eidinova* (see *Eidinova, Marina Borisovna*), conducted research on “hypoboulisic mechanisms” (unpublished study, referred to by Luria in 1960); according to Vygotsky's notes, participated in the group's research meetings in October 1933 with a presentation on the topic of “Environment – experiencing (*perezhivanie*) – character.”

Bassin, Filipp Veniaminovich (1905–92) – medical doctor (Kharkov, 1931), along with *Luria, Lebedinskii* and others worked at the Clinical Psychology Department of the Ukrainian Psychoneurological Academy, where, following Vygotsky's research on thinking in schizophrenia, he conducted a study on the alteration of word meanings in schizophrenia (unpublished manuscript of 1935); in 1936 moved to Moscow, worked in All-Union Institute of Experimental Medicine (VIEM); collaborated with *Bernstein* (see *Bernstein, Nikolai Aleksandrovich*).

Bernstein, Nikolai Aleksandrovich (1897–1982) – prominent physiologist and psychotecnic, Vygotsky's collaborator at the Institute of Psychology in mid-1920s, with whom Vygotsky co-edited and co-authored a textbook in 1927, and whose work was one of the main inspirations for most of Vygotsky's followers' research from the end of the 1930s onwards.

Bein, Esfir' Solomonovna (1906–81) – neurologist, defectologist, under Vygotsky's supervision conducted research on pathology of speech and perception.

Birenbaum, Gita Vasil'evna (1903–52) – former Berlin student of Kurt Lewin (see *Lewin, Kurt*), returned to Soviet Union around 1930; under the supervision of Vygotsky conducted experimental and theoretical studies in clinical settings in Moscow in early 1930s, after Vygotsky's death in collaboration with *Zeigarnik* (see *Zeigarnik, Bluma Vul'fovna*) and *Samukhin* (see *Samukhin, Nikolai Vasil'evich*) published several papers that creatively integrate Vygotsky's and Kurt Lewin's theoretical work.

Boskis, Rakhil' Markovna (1902–76) – medical doctor (Kiev), in 1931 moved to Moscow; under Vygotsky's supervision conducted research on thinking and speech in deaf children at the Defectological Institute in Moscow.

- Bozhovich, Lidia Il'inichna (1908–81) – Vygotsky's student at Pedological Department of the 2nd Moscow State University (1925–30), member of the *piaterka* (“the five”) of his students; research on children's imitation in late 1920s (in collaboration with Slavina, Lia Solomonovna), various research projects in Moscow, Kharkov, and Poltava in 1930s.
- Daniushevskii, Izrail' Isaakovich (1890–1950) – Vygotsky's collaborator of Gomel' period and in Defectological Institute in Moscow, later, a relatively high-ranking official in the *Narkompros* of the RSFSR and Director of Moscow Defectological Institute; defectologist, co-edited with Vygotsky a posthumously published book on defectology (1935).
- Eidinova, Marina Borisovna (dates of birth and death unknown) – medical doctor, neurologist; around 1930, in Vygotsky's research team, conducted studies on degradation of mental functions in hysteria and, in collaboration with Averbukh, on “hypoboulc mechanisms” (unpublished study, referred to by Luria in 1960); later, research on cerebral palsy in children and its treatment.
- Eisenstein, Sergei Mikhailovich (1898–1948) – Soviet film director and film theorist; peripheral participant of Vygotsky–Luria circle from 1925/6 onwards.
- El'konin, Daniil Borisovich (1904–84) – former student and associate of prominent psychologist M. Ya. Basov (Leningrad), Vygotsky's student and collaborator in Leningrad Herzen State Pedagogical Institute (in 1931–4); research on children's play.
- Fradkina, Frida Isaakovna or Iosifovna (dates of birth and death unknown) – Leningrad student and collaborator of Vygotsky; research on children's play and speech development.
- Gellerstein, Solomon Grigor'evich (1896–1967) – Vygotsky's collaborator at the Institute of Psychology in mid-1920s, with whom Vygotsky co-authored two textbooks in 1927; Vygotsky's, Luria's, and Leontiev's colleague at All-Union Institute of Experimental Medicine (VIEM) in 1930s.
- Geshelina, Lia Solomonovna (1892 – date of death unknown) – medical doctor, member of Russian Psychoanalytic Society (up to 1930); Vygotsky's collaborator in 1930s; around 1930 conducted a study of visual thinking and perception; in 1930s worked with Vygotsky in clinical settings.
- Kaulina, Nina Nikolaevna (dates of birth and death unknown) – former Berlin student of Kurt Lewin (see Lewin, Kurt), returned to Soviet Union around 1930, possibly took part in pathopsychological studies in Moscow along with Birenbaum (see Birenbaum, Gita Vasil'evna) and Zeigarnik (see Zeigarnik, Bluma Vul'fovna), after Vygotsky's death participated in “topological” psychological research in Gorky Park in Moscow along with A. N. Leontiev (see Leontiev, Aleksei Nikolaevich), A. I. Rozenblium, L. I. Bozhovich (see Bozhovich, Lidia Il'inichna), and others.
- Koffka, Kurt (1886–1941) – German-American Gestalt psychologist, whose research was a major influence on experimental and theoretical work of the Vygotsky–Luria group; participant in Luria's expedition to Central Asia of 1932.
- Kolbanovskii, Viktor Nikolaevich (1902–70) – medical doctor (Moscow, 1927) and philosopher by training, Director of the Institute of Psychology in Moscow (1932–7), Vygotsky's supporter and the editor of the first edition of his *Thinking and speech* (1934).
- Konnikova, Tatiana Efimovna (1909–75) – Vygotsky's student and collaborator in Leningrad Herzen State Pedagogical Institute (1931–4), doctoral research on “The transitional stage in the development of children's speech (autonomous speech)” conducted under the supervision of Vygotsky and his associate Levina (see Levina, Mira Abramovna).
- Kotelova, Yulia Vladimirovna (1903–80) – specialist in industrial psychology; in collaboration with Pashkovskaia (see Pashkovskaia, E. I.) and under supervision of Vygotsky continued studies on concept formation (1927–30) after Sakharov's death (see Sakharov, Leonid Solomonovich).
- Lebedinskii (Lebedinsky), Mark Samuilovich (1895–1980) – medical doctor, neurologist, Vygotsky's and Luria's collaborator in Moscow (from mid-1920s) and in Kharkov (from 1931), where he conducted and supervised a wide range of developmental, psychogenetic, and clinical psychological studies, mainly on aphasia and schizophrenia.
- Levina, Mira Abramovna (dates of birth and death unknown) – former student and associate of prominent psychologist M. Ya. Basov (Leningrad), Vygotsky's collaborator (1931–4) in Leningrad Herzen Pedagogical Institute, where she was Head of Pedological Department; edited Vygotsky's posthumous book *Foundations of pedology* (Leningrad, 1935).
- Levina, Roza Evgen'evna (1908–89) – Vygotsky's student at Pedological Department of the 2nd Moscow State University (1927–32), member of the *piaterka* (“the five”) of his students; research on

the planning role of “egocentric speech” (late 1920s), “autonomous speech” (early 1930s), and speech pathology (from mid-1930s onwards).

Leontiev, Aleksei Nikolaevich (1903–79) – Vygotsky’s close associate, along with Aleksander Luria (see *Luria, Aleksander Romanovich*), member of the *troika* (“the three”); research on the development of mediated remembering and attention (late 1920s, under the supervision of Vygotsky, book published in 1931); various research projects of the 1930s.

Lewin, Kurt (1890–1947) – German-American Gestalt psychologist, whose research was a major influence on experimental and theoretical work of the Vygotsky–Luria group; research supervisor of *Birenbaum* (see *Birenbaum, Gita Vasil’evna*), *Kaulina* (see *Kaulina, Nina Nikolaevna*), and *Zeigarnik* (see *Zeigarnik, Bluma Vul’fovna*); peripheral participant in Vygotsky–Luria circle from 1925/6 onwards.

Luria, Aleksander Romanovich (1902–77) – Vygotsky’s closest associate and collaborator, the co-creator of the “theory of the cultural-historical development of higher psychological functions”; along with Aleksei Leontiev (see *Leontiev, Aleksei Nikolaevich*), member of the *troika* (“the three”).

Morozova, Natalia Grigor’evna (1906–89) – Vygotsky’s student at Pedological Department of the 2nd Moscow State University (1925–30), member of the *piaterka* (“the five”) of his students; various research projects under the supervision of Vygotsky and Luria.

Pashkovskaia, E. I. (full name and dates of birth and death unknown) – in collaboration with *Kotelova* (see *Kotelova, Yulia Vladimirovna*) and under supervision of Vygotsky continued studies on concept formation (1927–30) after Sakharov’s death (see *Sakharov, Leonid Solomonovich*).

Pevzner, Maria Semenovna (1901–89) – medical doctor (in Saratov), psychiatrist and defectologist, in 1931 moved to Moscow in order to study psychopathic disorders in children under Vygotsky’s supervision in Experimental Defectological Institute.

Sakharov, Leonid Solomonovich (1900–28) – Vygotsky’s student, and initiated studies on concept formation using modified method of Narziss Ach (1871–1946), presently known as the method of “double stimulation” or “Sakharov–Vygotsky method.”

Samukhin, Nikolai Vasil’evich (dates of birth and death unknown) – researcher at All-Union Institute of Experimental Medicine (VIEM), conducted a series of clinical studies on dementia, published a research paper in collaboration with Vygotsky and *Birenbaum* (see *Birenbaum, Gita Vasil’evna*).

Shein, A. A. (full name and dates of birth and death unknown) – Vygotsky’s collaborator around 1930; research on the transition from external to internal speech; edited Leontiev’s book *Development of memory* (1931).

Shmidt (Schmidt), Vera Fedorovna (1889–1937) – the wife of academician O. Yu. Shmidt, active member and secretary of Russian Psychoanalytical Society, worked at Psychoanalytical Institute in Moscow (experimental psychoanalytical boarding school and research laboratory closed down in 1925), provided research data for Vygotsky and Luria’s *Studies on the history of behaviour* (1930), from around 1930 employee of Defectological Institute and a member of Vygotsky’s defectological research team.

Shif, Zhozefina Il’inishna (1904–78) – Vygotsky’s graduate student and collaborator in Leningrad Herzen State Pedagogical Institute (1931–3) and Moscow Defectological Institute (1933 onwards), doctoral research on thinking and scientific concept development in children, defended in Leningrad in 1933, published as a book in 1935 with Vygotsky’s introduction of February 1934; co-edited (with *Kolbanovskii, Viktor Nikolaevich* and *Zankov, Leonid Vladimirovich*) the posthumous edition of Vygotsky’s *Thinking and speech* (1934).

Slavina, Lia Solomonovna (1906–88) – Vygotsky’s student at Pedological Department of the 2nd Moscow State University (1925–30), member of the *piaterka* (“the five”) of his students; research on children’s imitation in late 1920s (in collaboration with *Bozhovich*).

Solov’ev (alias *Solov’ev-El’pidinskii*), *Ivan Mikhailovich* (1902–86) – defectologist, Vygotsky’s graduate student (1925–9) and, along with Zankov (see *Zankov, Leonid Vladimirovich*), collaborator from mid-1920s; notably, under Vygotsky’s supervision in early 1930s replicated Anitra Karsten’s study on satiation (*Sättigung*) that was originally done by Berlin group of Kurt Lewin (see *Lewin, Kurt*).

Varshava, Boris Efimovich (1900–27) – Vygotsky’s collaborator in 1920s and co-author of *Psychological dictionary* (published in 1931, after Varshava’s death).

Veresotskaia, Ksenia Ivanovna (dates of birth and death unknown) – defectologist, around 1930 conducted research on voluntary attention and voluntary remembering, visual thinking and eidetic memory; Vygotsky’s collaborator in Defectological Institute in 1930s.

Zankov, Leonid Vladimirovich (1901–77) – defectologist, Vygotsky’s graduate student and, along with Solov’ev (see *Solov’ev, Ivan Mikhailovich*), collaborator from mid-1920s; most notable research conducted under Vygotsky’s supervision is a series of studies on memory and remembering in normal and mentally retarded children; co-edited (with *Shif* and *Kolbanovskii*) the posthumous edition of Vygotsky’s *Thinking and speech* (1934).

Zaporozhets, Alexander Vladimirovich (1905–81) – Vygotsky’s student at Pedological Department of the 2nd Moscow State University (1925–30), member of the *piaterka* (“the five”) of his students; various research projects under the supervision of Vygotsky and *Luria* in Moscow, and *Luria, Leontiev*, and *Lebedinskii* in Kharkov; Head of Department of Psychology of the Kharkov State Pedagogical Institute (from 1938) and the leader of the Kharkov group from mid-1930s.

Zeigarnik, Bluma Vul’fovna (1900–88) – former Berlin student of Kurt Lewin (see *Lewin, Kurt*), returned to Soviet Union in 1931; under the supervision of Vygotsky conducted experimental and theoretical studies in clinical settings in Moscow in early 1930s, after Vygotsky’s death in collaboration with *Birenbaum* (see *Birenbaum, Gita Vasil’evna*) and *Kaganovskaia* published several papers that creatively integrate Vygotsky’s and Kurt Lewin’s theoretical work.

ABBREVIATIONS AND ARCHIVAL AND DOCUMENTARY SOURCES

Abbreviations

AHAP Archives of the History of American Psychology at The Drs. Nicholas and Dorothy Cummings Center for the History of Psychology, the University of Akron, OH

AJA American Jewish Archives, Cincinnati, OH

APN Akademiia pedagogicheskikh nauk [Academy of Pedagogical Sciences, Moscow]

APS American Philosophical Society, Philadelphia, PA

ARAN Arkhiv Rossiiskoi akademii nauk [Archive of the Russian Academy of Sciences, Moscow]

ASSR avtonomnaia sovetskaia sotsialisticheskaia respublika [autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic]

GA RF Gosudarstvennyi Arkhiv Rossiiskoi Federatsii [State Archive of Russian Federation], Moscow, Russia

GIZ *see* Gosizdat

Gosizdat Gosudarstvennoe izdatel'stvo (State Publishing House)

JHMI Johns Hopkins Medical Institutions Archives, Baltimore, MD

MGU Moskovskii gosudarstvennyi universitet [Moscow State University]

Narkompros Narodnyi komissariat prosveshcheniia [People's Commissariat of Enlightenment]

RSFSR Rossiiskaia sovetskaia federativnaia sotsialisticheskaia respublika [Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic]

SSSR Soiuz sovetskikh sotsialisticheskikh respublik [Union of Soviet Socialist Republics, USSR]

YIVO YIVO Institute for Jewish Research, New York

Archival and documentary sources

Dembo archive: Clark University, Worcester, MA (occasionally used in this study in relation to issues in the biographies of Lewin's female students)

Luria–Gantt correspondence: W. Horsley Gantt Collection, JHMI

Luria–Kallen correspondence: The Horace M. Kallen Collection, AJA and The Papers of Horace Meyer Kallen, YIVO Archives

Luria–Koffka correspondence: Koffka archive, Harrower archive, AHAP

Luria–Köhler correspondence: Köhler archive, APS; also, several letters have been published in Russian in E. A. Luria, 1994 and in English in Van der Veer & Valsiner, 1991

Luria–Lewin correspondence: Lewin archive at AHAP; also published in Métraux, 2002

Luria–Wertheimer correspondence: Wertheimer archives in New York Public Library (NYPL) and University of Colorado, Boulder, CO; published in King & Wertheimer, 2005

Vygotsky's correspondence with his collaborators and associates in the Soviet Union was published in Russian (Vygotskii, 2004) and in English (Vygotsky, 2007); available also in bilingual German–English edition (Rückriem, 2009)

NOTES

1 The archetype of Soviet psychology: from the Stalinism of the 1930s to the “Stalinist science” of our time

- 1 On Russian utopianism, the Nietzschean tradition in Russian culture, and medico-biological “revolutionary experiments” in the first third of the twentieth century see Kremmentsov, 2013; Rosenthal, 1986, 1994, 2002; Stites, 1989.
- 2 For the history of these disciplines in the West see S. Cohen, 1983, 1999; Depaepe, 1998, 2012; Depaepe, Simon, & Gorp, 2003; Hofstetter, 2004; Nisbet, 2002; Quen, 1977.
- 3 On Bolshevik modernization in the Soviet Union and its essential similarity with modernization processes in the West see Hoffmann, 2011.
- 4 This chapter was in fact the printed version of Pavlov’s keynote speech that he had given at the IX International Congress of Psychology at Yale University in 1929 (Todes, 2014).
- 5 An overview of the publication activity of Soviet scholars in the interwar period can be found in Yasnitsky, 2011c.
- 6 The list of representative publications includes Berman, 1939; Dewey, 1984, 1990; McFarland, 1935; Schultz & McFarland, 1935; Viteles, 1938; Williams, 1934a, 1934b; Zacharoff, 1931.
- 7 The reader of this chapter who is not entirely familiar with this topic and not particularly interested in the processes in the Soviet economy or politics during the “Great Break” period might want to get acquainted with the concurrent “Cultural Revolution” of 1928–31 in the classics of the “revisionist historiography” of the Soviet Union; for introductory reading see Fitzpatrick, 1978 and the somewhat newer account of the topic by the same author, Fitzpatrick, 1992.
- 8 For a list of the Dean’s various positions and cross-appointments see Moscow University website at http://www.psy.msu.ru/people/zinchenko_yp.html.
- 9 Original expression: “Они – как одесские фарцовщики.”
- 10 For literature on the “isolationism” – or, for that matter, the lack of isolationism – of pre-World War II Soviet psychology see Yasnitsky, 2010b, 2011a, 2011c, 2012b, 2012c, 2012h.
- 11 Characteristic critiques of Soviet publications and their notorious incompatibility with Western standards can be found in a number of sources; for an illustrative selection of such criticisms see Berlyne, 1964; Meacham, 1977; Reese, 1999; Wender, 1967.
- 12 For a similar analysis of the structural and stylistic idiosyncrasies of Soviet scientific memoirs see Dmitriev, 2012.

- 13 For representative publications that discuss the “Vygotsky cult” and advocate for its critical revision see González Rey, 2014; R. Miller, 2011; Yasnitsky, 2010a, 2012i.

2 Unity in diversity: the Vygotsky–Luria circle as an informal personal network of scholars

- 1 For the remarkable and astonishing history of the loss of the original Russian manuscript, its publication in English, the retranslation from English into Russian, and the subsequent publication of this, in the words of Elkhonon Goldberg, “benign forgery” see a series of recent publications: Cole, 2012; Goldberg, 2012; Van der Veer, 2012; Yasnitsky 2011b, 2012f. For related discussion see also Chapter 4 of this book.
- 2 The list of research and biographical literature on the life and work of Sergei Eisenstein is virtually endless. For introductory reading on this subject, though, see, for instance, an English biography of Eisenstein (Bulgakowa, 2001).

3 Deconstructing Vygotsky’s victimization narrative: a re-examination of the “Stalinist suppression” of Vygotskian theory

- 1 Bruner is referring to Leontjew & Luria, 1958.
- 2 This is an original comment of Bruner’s.
- 3 We have been unable to find evidence that would confirm Bruner’s presumed participation in this 1980 conference.
- 4 The USSR did not get its second Nobel Prize until 1956, when Nikolay Semyonov was honored for his groundbreaking research in chemistry.
- 5 For a revisionist interpretation of Stalinist science systems, whereby a mutually beneficial symbiosis exists between science and the state, please refer to Kojevnikov, 2004; Krementsov, 1997.
- 6 Although Stalin’s government did launch a political campaign against those who were seen to be “kowtowing to the West,” “cosmopolitanism” was a condemnatory term that was introduced in Soviet “newspeak” at the very end of the 1940s and was usually reserved for Russia’s Jewish population during the Cold War era, as this social group was often criticized for maintaining large-scale international communication networks (on Soviet scientific “newspeak” see Geroovitch, 2002). The majority of written accounts of the Vygotsky ban fail to acknowledge this terminological distinction.
- 7 Inconvenient parts included those passages that (1) contained propaganda against the Soviet regime, (2) divulged military secrets, (3) stirred up public opinion through false information, (4) aroused nationalistic and religious fanaticism, or (5) were considered to be pornographic (Ermolaev, 1997, p. 3).
- 8 Soviet newspeak euphemism for a “death sentence.” See S. F. Cohen, 2011, p. 68.
- 9 For a further discussion of Vygotsky’s enthusiastic support of Leon Trotsky see Yasnitsky, 2014b.
- 10 The “major works” mentioned here refer to Vygotsky’s *History of the development of higher mental functions* and *Tool and sign in child development*.
- 11 Later renamed “Ministries.”
- 12 See the materials of the Harvard Project on the Soviet Social System (1951) Schedule A, vol. 25, case 493 (interviewer R. S., type A4). Female, 55, Great Russian, Teacher. Widener Library, Harvard University, Cambridge, MA.
- 13 The text of this resolution was published in English translation under the title “On Pedological Distortions in the Commissariats of Education: A Resolution of the Central Committee of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union, July 4, 1936,” in Wortis, 1950, pp. 242–245.

- 14 This is indicated in Zelenov, 2000, where the author states that the cleansings of libraries are closely linked with the policies of the Central Committee of the CPSU(B). For example, after the Central Committee's Decree on "Pedological Perversions in the System *Narkompros'es*," among the local organs of censorship a list was distributed of 121 textbooks, educational, and methodical manuals on pedology, issued since 1926, all of which had to be withdrawn and relocated to *spetskhran*.
- 15 As aptly noted by Arlen Blyum in his *A self-administered poison* (2003), the pettiness and pathological captiousness displayed by Glavlit officials were, very often, not in the least activated by any possible 'danger' posed by a text totally lacking in subversive intent. But that is the whole point: totalitarian censorship makes no distinction between the important and the unimportant, the material and immaterial. It seizes equally on a 'criminal', anti-Soviet text, and on a trivial misprint in a crossword or an odd turn of phrase in a translation.
- 16 The Stalin Prize was the highest honor that could be bestowed by the Soviet state in recognition of a single piece of work in science or culture. This award included a large monetary prize of 100,000 roubles. For more information on the Stalin Prize, see Johnson, 2011.
- 17 A. R. Luria's *Traumatic aphasia* was a particularly prominent book within the field of psychology. Not only was it the first major publication of his neuropsychological work (translated into English in 1970), but it was often informally referred to as the "bible" of Soviet neuropsychology.
- 18 This was a booklet of a popular lecture created for the thirtieth anniversary of the October Revolution, with over 100,000 copies published. To put the publication numbers in context: only 10,000 copies of each of the titles – Vygotsky's original *Thinking and speech* (1934a), Rudneva's *Pedological distortions of Vygotsky* (1937), or Rubinstein's *Foundations of general psychology* (1940) – were circulated within the Soviet Union.
- 19 It was only in early 1955 that the new leader of the country, Nikita Khrushchev, eventually got full control over the Party and the state.
- 20 The official launch of the new journal was authorized by the Presidium of the Academy of Pedagogical Sciences of the RSFSR on November 11, 1954 (Shchedrina, 1995); the first issue came out the following year, in 1955.
- 21 See *Svodnyi spisok knig, podlezhashchikh isklucheniui iz bibliotek i knigotorgovoi seti* [Cumulative List of Books Subject to Removal from Libraries and Book Retail Stores]: Part II, 1961; available online: <http://www.opentextnn.ru/censorship/russia/sov/libraries/catalogue/>.
- 22 Half a decade later this volume came out in English translation (Vygotsky, 1971).
- 23 For various testimonies on this major publication of Vygotsky's works anticipated to come out in the second half of the 1960s or early 1970s see Vygotskaya & Lifanova, 1996. Also see recent reminiscences of these events in Goldberg, 2005, 2012.
- 24 To Luria's credit, though, it is absolutely necessary to point out that his endless efforts and persistence in publishing Vygotsky's works in English translation outside the Soviet Union can hardly be overestimated. Also, it is worth mentioning that, according to anecdotal evidence, Zaporozhets was quite enthusiastic about the Russian publication of Vygotsky's work and significantly contributed to it; see discussion of Shchedrovitskii's memoirs below.
- 25 The two sources – otherwise obscure and hardly accessible – are available online: see http://www.consultlib.nm.ru/gp_jvbi.htm and <http://www.anleontiev.smysl.ru/vospomin-i-zinch.htm>.

4 Vygotsky the published: who wrote Vygotsky and what Vygotsky actually wrote

- 1 Archival document GA RF f. 4-482, op. 41, d. 644, l. 6-9, "Lichnyi listok po uchetu kadrov."

- 2 See document scan and transcript at <http://psyhistorik.livejournal.com/34909.html> (alternatively: http://www.voppsy.ru/journals_all/issues/1996/965/965122.htm) and <http://psyhistorik.livejournal.com/69790.html> respectively.
- 3 These are the publications we used as a source of quotations in this chapter, in a number of instances with our corrections of inaccuracies and mistakes of translation.
- 4 Original: Мы отлично сознаем все неизбежное несовершенство того первого шага в новом направлении, который мы пытались сделать в настоящей работе, но мы видим его оправдание в том, что он, по нашему убеждению, продвигает нас вперед в исследовании мышления и речи по сравнению с тем состоянием этой проблемы, которое сложилось в психологии к моменту начала нашей работы, раскрывая проблему мышления и речи как узловую проблему всей психологии человека, непосредственно приводящую исследователя к новой психологической теории сознания. Впрочем мы затрагиваем эту проблему лишь в немногих заключительных словах нашей работы и обрываем исследование у самого ее порога.
- 5 Original: Мы не можем в заключение нашего исследования не остановиться в немногих словах на тех перспективах, которые раскрываются за его порогом. Наше исследование подводит нас вплотную к порогу другой, еще более обширной, еще более глубокой, еще более грандиозной проблемы, чем проблема мышления – к проблеме сознания.

5 Vygotsky the unpublished: an overview of the personal archive (1912–1934)

- 1 SPON stood for Sotsial'no Pravovaya Okhrana Nesovershennoletnikh, i.e. the socio-legal protection of minors.
- 2 This seems to be an allusion to the New Testament, Matthew 7:7, “Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it shall be opened unto you.”
- 3 It should be mentioned that at approximately the same time Vygotsky wrote several articles in which he analyzed Adler's ideas and their significance for modern psychology and defectology. Adler's notion of supercompensation was a sort of disquieting idea that required explanation and thereby allowed a progressive shift in Vygotsky's scientific research program.
- 4 Potebnia, Aleksandr Afanas'evich (1835–91). Philosopher, linguist. Known for his theory of the inner form of the word, which represented a reformulation and concretization of Wilhelm von Humboldt's psychological viewpoint. For discussion see Bertau, 2014.
- 5 Shcherba, Lev Vladimirovich (1880–1944). Linguist who exercised a great influence on the development of psycholinguistics, lexicography, and phonology.
- 6 Bakhtin, Mikhail Mikhailovich (1895–1975). Philosopher, linguist, leader of the philosophical group known as the Bakhtin circle. A number of his ideas show affinity with those of Vygotsky; in particular, the idea of the dialogical nature of consciousness. It remains unclear whether Vygotsky ever directly quoted Bakhtin or knew him personally – in none of the notes did we find a reference to Bakhtin or his texts. However, in the reconstruction of the authentic text of “Psyche, consciousness, the unconscious,” it was found that the editors had deleted a reference to *Freidizm*, a book written by Bakhtin's close colleague Voloshinov. Who exactly wrote this book remains unclear but Bakhtin's participation seems beyond doubt.
- 7 Political animal (Greek). Classic definition of man in which ‘political’ refers to ‘polis’ as the rational arrangement of people's social life.
- 8 Published in 2014. See online at: <http://gefeter.ru/archive/11094>; http://assets0.gefeter.ru/Vygotsky_notebook.pdf.
- 9 Intellect and will are one and the same (Latin). Cf.: “God's intellect, God's will, and God's power, are one and the same” (*The ethics*, Prop. XVII 17, Scholia).

- 10 Twice in *The psychology of art* Vygotsky writes about this principle: (1) “There exist two positions among psychologists as to whether emotions increase or decrease under the effect of affective concepts ... if we apply to this question the principle of monophasic energy expenditure as introduced by Kornilov in interpreting rational processes, we will see that in emotions as well as in thoughts, an increase of the charge at the center leads to a weakening of the charge in the peripheral organs”; (2) “I feel that this delay and weakening of inner organic and external manifestations of emotions should be regarded as a particular case of the general law of monophasic energy expenditure due to emotions. As we have seen, energy flows out from one of two poles, either at the periphery or at the center; and an increased activity at one pole leads immediately to a decrease at the other. It seems to me that only from this viewpoint can we approach art which appears to stir very strong feelings in us, which feelings are not specifically expressed. The enigmatic difference that exists between artistic feeling and ordinary feeling may be explained as follows: Artistic feeling is the same as the other, but it is released by extremely intensified activity of the imagination” (Vygotsky, 1971, pp. 48, 211).
- 11 Marr, Nikolay Yakovlevich (1864–1934). Russian and Soviet orientalist, philologist, historian. His Japhetic theory of language, created in the early 1920s and accepted as the only true Marxist theory of language, was officially defended until the late 1940s.
- 12 According to Vygotsky, complexive thinking, or thinking in complexes, was a form of pre-conceptual thinking. See ch. 5 of *Thinking and speech*.
- 13 Bozhovich, Lidia Il'inichna (1908–81). Psychologist, collaborator with Vygotsky, specialist in the field of child psychology and personality, co-founder of the Kharkov school of psychology.
- 14 The manuscript was first published in three parts, in Russian in 2006; available online; see: <http://psyjournals.ru/kip/2006/n1/Bozhovich.shtml>, <http://psyjournals.ru/kip/2006/n2/Bozhovich.shtml> and <http://psyjournals.ru/kip/2006/n3/Bozhovich.shtml>.
- 15 Therefore, consequently (Latin).
- 16 Russian original: “Ustareet to, chto ot zloby dnia (ya pishu ee ne na vysotakh dukha, a v zlobe dnia.” The phrase “evil of the day” is an allusion to Matthew 6:34: “Take therefore no thought for the morrow: for the morrow shall take thought for the things of itself. Sufficient unto the day is the evil thereof” (King James version). This seems to be a reference to the personal and professional crisis that Vygotsky experienced in the early 1930s (for discussion of the crisis see Chapter 4).
- 17 Vygotsky is apparently referring to Hamlet’s phrase about his father: “He was a man, take him for all in all” (Hamlet, act I, scene ii). In the Russian translation of P. P. Gnedich (1917), this phrase was rendered as “On chelovek byl v polnom smysle slova!” (literally: “He was a man in the full sense of the word!”).
- 18 Behold (the) man (Latin). Words used by Pontius Pilate in the Vulgate (Latin) translation of John 19:5.
- 19 Semic (or semasiologic) analysis is a method of investigating consciousness as a conscious – i.e. cognized, aware, deliberate – relation to the world. In the literature one frequently sees a reduced use of this method, which is then called semantic or semiotic. This is just one of several possible interpretations and it does not exhaust the content of this method, which, ultimately, was not operationalized in Vygotsky’s work but just proclaimed. For further discussion of sense, meaning, awareness, and consciousness, and their Russian and English derivatives and possible uses in the discourse of the human sciences, see Chapter 10 of this book, “Lost in translation.”
- 20 This brings to mind Wilhelm von Humboldt’s famous maxim that language is not product, *ergon*, but process, *energeia*. In his analysis of the interrelation between thinking and speech, Vygotsky clearly followed Aleksandr Potebnia (1835–91), the author of a highly influential book *Mysl’ i iazyk* (*Thought and language*) (Kharkov, 1862). Thus, Potebnia insisted that thinking is not merely revealed, reflected in speech, but is objectivized in verbal discourse, and hence, actually becomes thinking in its highest human forms (e.g. in generalized concepts). For further discussion of the profound impact of the Humboldtian tradition on Vygotsky’s legacy see Bertau, 2014.

- 21 In the Russian original, literally “Oblako – myshlenie?” (Cloud – thinking?). Quite likely, this is an allusion to Victor Hugo’s phrase in his analysis of “Hamlet”: “la pensée est nuage, la volonté est vapeur, la résolution est crépuscule, l’action souffle à chaque instant en sens inverse, la rose de vents gouverne l’homme” (Victor Hugo, *William Shakespeare* [Paris: Lacroix, Verboeckhoven, 1864], p. 310). For the context, see the following quotation, in English: “This drama is stern. In it truth doubts, sincerity lies. Nothing can be vaster, nothing subtler. In it man is the world, and the world is zero. Hamlet, even in full life, is not sure of his existence. In this tragedy – which is at the same time a philosophy—everything floats, hesitates, shuffles, staggers, becomes discomposed, scatters, and is dispersed. Thought is a cloud, will is a vapour, resolution a twilight; the action blows every moment from a different direction: the mariner’s card governs man” (Victor Hugo, *William Shakespeare* [A. C. McClurg, 1891], pp. 233–234).
- 22 / = division sign.
- 23 Sudden understanding or awareness (French). Term introduced by Edouard Claparède.
- 24 Names of two forms of syllogism (actually: Barbara, Celarent).
- 25 The title of the note, *Symposium, December 4, 1932*, indicates the exact date of this internal conference.
- 26 Leontiev’s choice of words betrays hostility caused by the fact that he was not very happy with the new turn cultural-historical theory was taking. For a discussion of the varieties of the Vygotsky–Luria circles and the diversity of their research agendas – quite often in conflict with and, presumably, hardly comprehensible to Leontiev and his research team – see Chapter 2.
- 27 Two years later, in 1934, a version of this paper was published as “Thought in schizophrenia” in *Archives of Neurology and Psychiatry*, in English translation by Jacob Kasanin, M.D. and his associates; see Vygotsky, 1934, 1994a.
- 28 Zaporozhets, Aleksandr Vladimirovich (1905–81). Soviet psychologist, specialist in the field of general psychology, psychology of perception, psychology of emotions, and child psychology. One of the leaders of the Kharkov school of psychology.
- 29 Khlebnikov, Velimir (1886–1922). Avant-garde poet, founder of Russian futurism, innovator in poetic language.
- 30 The research plan proposed by Leontiev.
- 31 I can do what I want to do (German).
- 32 For discussion of Vygotsky’s notion of the extent of commonality between concepts see Zavershneva, 2014, pp. 82–85.
- 33 Superordinate concept and subordinate concept (German).
- 34 Zaks and Kogan were patients suffering from Pick’s disease, who were seen by Vygotsky personally. They figure as the patients Z and K in the paper devoted to that disease by Samukhin, Birenbaum, and Vygotsky (1934).
- 35 Fluid (German). Vygotsky seems to refer to Kurt Lewin’s work on psychological dynamics. Cf.: “Man kann ... von einer verschiedenen dynamischen Weichheit, Elastizität, Härte, Sprödigkeit oder Flüssigkeit des seelischen ‘Materials’ sprechen” (Lewin, 1933) (quoted in the edition of 1982, p. 236; see text online: <http://www.th-hoffmann.eu/archiv/lewin/lewin.1933.pdf>). Thus, according to Lewin, dynamics can be described in terms of a number of characteristics: “one may speak of a varying dynamic softness, elasticity, hardness, brittleness, or fluidity of the psychical material” (Lewin, 1935b, p. 207).
- 36 Very important (German).
- 37 It does not correspond with the unit of meaning: there are two interfering systems of units in thinking (Vygotsky’s remark).
- 38 Strongly (German).
- 39 Unique, independent, of its own kind (Latin).
- 40 Schmidt, Vera Fedorovna (1889–1937). Soviet psychoanalyst, pedagogue, secretary of the Russian Psychoanalytic Society, wife of Otto Schmidt. From 1930 she worked in the Experimental Defectological Institute.
- 41 Azbukin, Dimitrii Ivanovich (1883–1953). Soviet psychiatrist. Dean of defectology at the Lenin Pedagogical Institute in Moscow; Basova, Antonia G. (dates of birth and death

- unknown). Soviet specialist in the education of the deaf; Pochapin, Pavel Pavlovich (dates of birth and death unknown). Soviet specialist in the education of the blind.
- 42 Chuchmarev, Zakharii Ivanovich (1888–1961). Soviet psychologist, specialist in general psychology, psychophysiology, and the psychology of labor.
- 43 After death (Latin).
- 44 Refers to a famous passage in Tyutchev's *Silentium*:
How can the heart express itself?
How shall another understand?
Will he understand what it is that you live by?
A thought once uttered is a lie.
- 45 This refers to Anitra Karsten of the Berlin group of Kurt Lewin's students (see Chapters 6 and 9)
- 46 By the same token, of itself (Latin)
- 47 Averbukh, Roza Abramovna (1883–1940). Medical doctor, psychoanalyst. From 1901 to 1909 studied at universities in Bern and Zurich. Graduated from the medical faculty of Kazan University (1911). In the early 1920s a member of the Kazan Psychoanalytic Society (with Luria). Lived in Moscow from the mid-1920s, where she was a member of the Russian Psychoanalytic Society (with Luria and Vygotsky), and also worked in the Institute of Experimental Psychology and, presumably, in the Experimental Defectological Institute.
- 48 Pevzner, Maria Semenovna (1901–1989). Soviet psychologist, psychiatrist, defectologist, and pedagogue; from 1931 worked in the Experimental Defectological Institute.
- 49 Arrago, Roman Semyonovich (1883–1949). Russian citizen, who studied mathematics in Paris and biology in Liège. Unable to find a job, he decided to exploit his amazing numeric skills in the theater. Bazhenov, Serbskii, and Beliaev were among the professors who studied his skills. Arrago is also mentioned in Alfred Binet's *Psychologie des grands calculateurs et joueurs d'échecs* (1894), a book that Vygotsky quoted repeatedly.
- 50 Non-existence (German).
- 51 From Fet's poem *Kak moshki zareiu ...*:
But anxious memories of the past
Keep sneaking into my heart ...
O, if the soul could express itself
Without the word!
- 52 See note 34.
- 53 The liar's paradox in Eubulides' variant: "The Cretan Epimenides said: all Cretans are liars."
- 54 Love of one's fate (Latin). In this form the expression became known thanks to Friedrich Nietzsche, who frequently used it in his writings; e.g. *The gay science*, section 276, or *Ecce homo*, section 10.
- 55 The reference is to *Pedology of the adolescent* (Vygotskii, 1931d) and the results of studies with the Vygotsky–Sakharov method.
- 56 Citation from Pasternak's poem *Marburg*:
And when in your room I fell to my knees,
Embracing this mist, this perfection of frost
(How lovely you are!), this smothering turbulence,
What were you thinking? "Be sensible!" Lost!
- 57 It was around that time that William Herschel discovered Uranus with the help of calculations based on irregularities in the orbits of neighboring planets, i.e. through the indirect method.
- 58 Kolbanovskii, Viktor Nikolaevich (1902–70). Soviet scientist and official, by training a neuropathologist (1927); graduated from the Institute of Red Professors (1932), director of the Psychological Institute (1932–7); known for his active support of the publication of Vygotsky's ideas and writings in the period from the 1930s to the 1950s. Shemiakin, Fedor Nikolaevich (1899–1980). Soviet psychologist, participant in the Central Asian expeditions with Luria and Koffka in 1931 and 1932 (see Chapter 8). Vedenov, Aleksandr

- Vasil'evich (1901–70). Soviet psychologist, active participant in the reactological discussion of 1931.
- 59 At the end 1933 Otto Schmidt undertook a second attempt to follow the Northern Sea route in the SS *Cheliuskin*. However, the ship got stuck in the ice and sank on February 13, 1934. A state committee headed by V. V. Kuibyshev directed an operation to save the crew, adrift in the ice. The sick Schmidt was transported by aircraft to Moscow, where he arrived on April 11, 1934.
 - 60 Actually, *pro domo sua*: in defense of one's house, for oneself (Latin). Words supposedly spoken by Cicero to recover the right to practice the profession of a lawyer and to recover his house.
 - 61 Hamlet's last words.
 - 62 For a discussion of the idiosyncrasies of Soviet censorship and self-censorship, the history of social construction, and the reception of Vygotsky's legacy in the Soviet Union after his death see Chapter 3.

6 "The way to freedom": Vygotsky in 1932

- 1 The psychophysical problem in the broad sense of the term is the problem of the place of mind in nature; in the narrow sense it is the problem of the relation between psychological and brain (nervous) processes. In the latter case 'psychophysiological problem' would be the more exact term. Vygotsky mainly used the first term even when he wrote about the problem of the localization of psychological processes and their connection with brain structures. This was because it was important to him to solve the problem at the highest theoretical level and because he considered the problem of localization as a special case of this broader understanding. In this analysis we will stick to Vygotsky's use of the term.
- 2 Asya Vygodskaya (1930–80) was Vygotsky's youngest daughter.
- 3 Potebnaya's words.
- 4 A line from Afanasy Fet's poem *Kak trudno povtoriat' zhivuiu krasotu*.
- 5 His contemporary Andrei Platonov had similar ideas.
- 6 Remarkably enough, the last chapter of *Thinking and speech* repeats the text of this note almost verbatim but leaves out the reference to and the quotations from Boris Pasternak.
- 7 The reference is to the experiments by Lewin's student Tamara Dembo (1902–93), who studied the dynamics of anger (see Dembo, 1931, 1976). Dembo presented the subjects with a task that had two more or less clear solutions. When they had found them, she suggested there was a third solution. This solution, however, did not exist and the experiment studied the emotional reactions of subjects in a hopeless situation. The topological interpretation was that the quasi-need to solve the problem was not fulfilled and became transformed into anger, for example, against objects in the field. However, some subjects did not regress to physical destruction but tried to find imaginary solutions, resorting to clever but phantastic solutions that could not be realized in real life. Still others 'left the field' or liberated themselves from the field: for them the task lost its motivating force and their failure did not cause anger. Some of them just lost interest but others tried to restructure the task, engaging in conversations with the experimenter and testing her patience. For Vygotsky these experiments were interesting, because they showed, first, the connection between will and affect, and, second, the subject's capacity for volitional behavior, for the deliberate change of a meaningless and hopeless situation. That he mentioned Kurt Koffka (1886–1941) in connection with Dembo is explained in Vygotsky's *Lectures on psychology*: "About Dembo's experiments with meaningless actions ... I recently heard when Koffka was in Moscow. The subject is given a number of meaningless tasks and it is studied how he reacts to that. It is interesting to see that [subjects have] ... a very strong tendency to attribute meaning to these tasks and to create a new situation, by changing the psychological field, in which their action would be meaningful rather than meaningless" (Vygotsky, 1987,

- p. 356). As is known, at the time Koffka gave a lecture in Moscow (Psychological Institute, May, 1932) and Vygotsky served as his interpreter (see Chapter 9).
- 8 Intellectual love for God (Latin), a term used by Spinoza.
 - 9 A citation from Friedrich Engels's *Anti-Dühring* (1878).
 - 10 The quotation is not verbatim and not complete. See original (Wertheimer, 1925b) and an English translation: "It becomes rapidly evident that only we Europeans, at a late stage of culture, have hit upon the idea of separating the physical and psychic of many physical processes in this way. Think of someone dancing. In his dance there is joy and grace. How is that? Does it represent on the one hand a display of muscles and movement of the limbs, and on the other hand psychic consciousness? No. But that does not solve our problem; it only sets the task" (Wertheimer, 1944, p. 96).
 - 11 Anitra Karsten, a student of Lewin's, investigated the process of psychological satiation with the following setup. The subjects were presented with a monotonous task (e.g. to draw circles on a sheet of paper) with the instruction to carry on as long as they wished. When the subjects after a while asked whether they still had to continue for a long time, the instruction was changed and the subjects were told it was a test of their stamina. As a result, subjects who already showed signs of satiation (the need to fulfill the task was almost satisfied), resumed the task with new vigor. According to Lewin, this meant that the various need systems communicate with each other and exchange energy: when they developed a new quasi-need (now it was no longer a boring task but a test of their endurance), energy was taken from another system. Incidentally, some subjects changed the rules of the game and tried to wear down the experimenter by continuing the task endlessly (Karsten, 1928, 1976). From Vygotsky's point of view, the 'energetic' explanation was not sufficient: "Satiation has different functions in meaningful and meaningless activity: in one case work slows down, in the other it becomes faster (to get rid of it as soon as possible). In other words, the structures of satiation = subordinate aspects in the structure of the higher processes" (*Notebook. October, 1932*) (Vygotskii, 2007).

7 Translating Vygotsky: some problems of transnational Vygotskian science

- 1 In the original: "Leontiev se fait un devoir de rompre le silence et me déclare alors que je peux l'y aider. Le dégel est lent et incertain. Il faut profiter du climat actuel et accélérer les choses en publiant à l'étranger des oeuvres de Vygotski. Ainsi on peut espérer que les éditeurs soviétiques devront suivre" (Zazzo, 1989), p. 7.
- 2 In the original: "Il s'agissait de trouver un éditeur, en usant des relations que j'avais en Amérique. Luria prit le relais quelques mois plus tard. Et il réussit où j'avais échoué. Des textes de Vygotski parurent en 1955 aux Etats-Unis. Un an plus tard, ces mêmes textes étaient publiés en URSS. C'était l'effet escompté" (Zazzo, 1989, p. 7). See also Zazzo, 1982.
- 3 According to the volume of published conference proceedings, the papers were: "La nature et la formation des propriétés et des processus psychiques de l'homme" (A. Léontiev), "The higher nervous activity and the problems of perception" (E. N. Sokolov), "Switching in the higher nervous activity" (E. A. Asratyan), and "Types d'activité nerveuse supérieure" (B. M. Teplov).
- 4 In the original: "Ivanov-Smolenski, depuis vingt ans, n'a fait que du travail verbal sur une physiologie verbal" (Leontiev); "Je déteste qu'on m'explique les phénomènes complexes (de la vie psychique) par la schéma du reflexe conditionnel" (Teplov); "Dans l'immense domaine de la psychologie, Pavlov n'a étudié qu'un petit morceau" (Luria); "La pédagogie peut se développer que sur la base de la paidologie" (Smirnov).
- 5 In the original: "A la fin de ce très long entretien, Leontiev me dit: 'Nous comptons sur vous pour aider nos camarades français à mieux comprendre ce que nous faisons et à corriger certaines de leurs attitudes (... concernant notamment) le problème de la psychologie et du pavlovisme'" (Zazzo, 1982, p. 540).

- 6 Luria's first documented post-World War II trips were to Norway (August, 1956), to the International Congress of Psychology in Belgium (July, 1957), and to the United Kingdom (October, 1957). See E. A. Luria, 1994, pp. 161–164.
- 7 See also online: <http://archive.org/details/roleofspeechinre00luri>.
- 8 For a bibliography of Luria's foreign publications in English, French and German see Scheerer and Elliger, 1980.
- 9 According to Viach. Vs. Ivanov, Jakobson made trips to the Soviet Union in 1956, 1958, 1962, 1964, 1966, 1967, and, for the last time, in 1979; see Ivanov, 1999a, 1999b), also online: <http://magazines.russ.ru/zvezda/1999/7/ivanov.html>; in English: Ivanov, 2010.
- 10 The history of the spread of Vygotsky's psychology across the world has already been discussed in a number of publications that sketch the history of Vygotskian ideas in different countries. Thus, there are accounts of the dissemination and development of Vygotsky's ideas in Italy (Mecacci, 2006, 2012); the Netherlands (van Oers, 2012); France (Zazzo, 1982, 1989); Argentina (García, 2012, 2013; Moll & Rosa, 1985; Silvestri, 2004); Brazil (da Silva & Davis, 2004; Prestes, 2010; Souza, 1995); Greece (Dafermos, Kontopodis, & Chronaki, under review) (available online: <http://mkontopodis.files.wordpress.com/2010/04/dafermkontopchronaki2012schpsychologytravel.pdf>); Iran (Ghassemzadeh, 2009), etc. For the history of English-language publication of Vygotsky's works see also an excellent historical reconstruction by Jaan Valsiner (1988, pp. 150–162), whose book was of great help to us in this study.
- 11 On Roman Jakobson's meeting with Luria and Leontiev during his Moscow trip in 1958, see Ivanov 1999b, also online: <http://magazines.russ.ru/zvezda/1999/7/ivanov.html>. On Luria's trip and his early contacts with Bruner, see Bruner, 1983, pp. 143–145.
- 12 See Bruner's account of the story in Bruner, 1983, p. 139.
- 13 Recently, Piaget's original French pamphlet was recovered and retranslated into English with elaborate comments by Leslie Smith; see Piaget, 1995, 2000.
- 14 See *Soviet Psychology*, 5:3, spring 1967.
- 15 See Vygotskii, 1972. The original work was written in 1934.
- 16 See *Soviet Psychology*, 15:3, spring 1977; 17:4, summer 1979; and 18:1, fall 1979.
- 17 The original source is Vygotskii, 1935d.
- 18 See Toulmin, 1978, n. 12.
- 19 Interestingly, at the same time Toulmin noted that certain processes in Soviet society, politics, and science caused a “generation gap” in the teaching of Soviet psychology among Vygotsky's followers, and that consequently “some informed American observers consider that his ideas are likely to be developed and exploited more effectively in the US during the years ahead – by such people as John Flavell of Stanford and Ann Brown of the University of Illinois – than in the Soviet Union. By some intellectual version of Gresham's Law, just as Western psychology is beginning to escape from its earlier positivism, Russian academic psychology is, ironically, beginning to look more like the American experimental psychology of the intervening forty years!” (Toulmin, 1978, n. 6).
- 20 For the most recent of Ivanov's assessments of the contemporary state of the art of integrative research along the lines of Vygotsky and Luria, see his chapter in *The Cambridge handbook of cultural-historical psychology* (Ivanov, 2014).
- 21 That is, Vygotsky, 1962 and Vygotsky, 1978.

8 Did Uzbeks have illusions? The Luria–Koffka controversy of 1932

- 1 Vygotsky's letter to Leontiev of April 15, 1929: “I will be in Moscow on May 1–5” (Vygotsky, 2007, p. 22). Vygotsky's undated postcard sent to Luria from Uzbekistan: “I intend to go to Moscow no later than May 2, so expect me two to three days after receiving this postcard” (Vygotsky, 2007, p. 24)

- 2 Luria's letter to Lewin of December 12, 1929, AHAP.
- 3 Horace M. Kallen (1882–1974) was an American-Jewish philosopher and Zionist activist. He first met Luria during his visit to the Soviet Union in 1927 (see Kallen, 1929) and their relationship deepened during Luria's trip to the IX International Psychological Congress in New Haven in 1929. Kallen was the person who brought Luria into contact with his American publisher Liveright, with whom Luria's first monograph, *The nature of human conflicts*, appeared in 1932 (A. R. Luria, 1932c). W. Horsley Gantt (1892–1980) was an American physician and physiologist, a student of Ivan Pavlov and the founder of Pavlovian research in the USA. He translated many books from Russian and Luria's was one of them.
- 4 Luria's letter to Gantt of August 17, 1931, Gantt Papers, JHMI.
- 5 Luria's letter to Kallen of October 29, 1931, Horace M. Kallen Papers, MS-1, Box 19, Folder 18, AJA.
- 6 See Luria's letter to Köhler of March 6, 1932, APS, sent from Kharkov (the letter written on the letterhead of the Ukrainian State Psychoneurological Institute).
- 7 See Luria's letter to Lewin, dated April 9, 1932, AHAP.
- 8 The text of the lecture is preserved in the archival collection of Kurt Koffka Papers, AHAP.
- 9 See Koffka's letters to Molly Harrower of May 30, 1932 and of July 29, 1934, AHAP.
- 10 See Open Access publication online: <http://www.psyanima.ru/journal/2013/3/2013n3a7/2013n3a7.pdf>.
- 11 Vygotsky means that their study was comparable in importance to the world-famous investigation of the behavior of anthropoids conducted by Köhler on Tenerife.
- 12 The translators of the report were J. Kasanin and F. L. Wells (A. R. Luria, 1934).
- 13 Interestingly, Luria recalled Koffka's participation in the second expedition in a lecture at the meeting of the Moscow branch of the Psychologists' Society in the Institute of Psychology of the USSR Academy of Pedagogical Sciences of the USSR in Moscow in March, 1974. Its full text was published in the early 2000s. He described Koffka's participation as follows: "Koffka participated in the second of these expeditions and it was my big mistake that I invited him, because he understood nothing. I invited him to take part in that expedition, because he published shortly before it a book on mental development but I had not figured out from what position this book was written. It was from the position of Gestalt psychology" (A. R. Luria, 2003b, p. 274). As we can see, this remark concealed more than it revealed.
- 14 There is an extensive literature on this subject. A broad overview can be found in Smith 2006. The discussion in this chapter primarily follows the work of Terry Martin (2001).
- 15 It should be noted that the terms "West" and "East" are not geographic concepts. In Soviet newspeak these categories were related to the level of modernization or to the educational level of the particular population. Actually, the pair of opposites east/west had the same meaning as the pairs traditional/modern and delayed/developed. For example, Crimean Tatars were categorized as an Eastern nationality, while the Volga Germans, who lived more eastward geographically, were defined as a Western nationality.
- 16 The literature on these topics is enormous. As an introductory reading on the Cultural Revolution of the period of the First Five-Year Plan in the Soviet Union in 1928–31 see the classic volume under the editorship of Sheila Fitzpatrick (1978).
- 17 This is an Open Access publication, available online: <http://www.psyanima.ru/journal/2013/3/2013n3a6/2013n3a6.pdf>.
- 18 For a discussion of a similar array of topics concerning optimism about the possibility of a radical change in the biological nature of the human being in revolutionary human and experimental medico-biological sciences in the Soviet Union in the 1920s–1930s see, e.g., Gasparov, 1996; Krementsov, 2011, 2013.
- 19 These developments, presented here in a nutshell, have various interpretations in the historiography of the Soviet Union. See Smith (2006).
- 20 As a matter of fact, the First Five-Year Plan was considered victoriously fulfilled in early 1933. Thus, according to Stalin's speech of January 7, 1933, characteristically titled "The

- results of the First Five-Year Plan,” in which he summarized the outcomes of the preceding period, “results of the five-year plan have shown that it is quite possible to build a socialist society in one country; for the economic foundations of such a society have already been laid in the U.S.S.R.”; see full text online: <http://www.marxists.org/reference/archive/stalin/works/1933/01/07.htm>.
- 21 Full text of Stalin’s speech “Report to the Seventeenth Party Congress on the Work of the Central Committee of the C.P.S.U.(B.)” of January 26, 1934 online: <http://www.marxists.org/reference/archive/stalin/works/1934/01/26.htm>.
 - 22 In fact, the establishment of socialist society in the Soviet Union was officially inaugurated at the end of 1936. Thus, according to the first article of the new Constitution of the Soviet Union that was launched on December 5, 1936, “The Union of Soviet Socialist Republics is a socialist state of workers and peasants.”
 - 23 See such classic works as Graham, 1987; Joravsky, 1989. On Soviet “academic Marxism” in the 1920s and 1930s, see Dmitriev, 2007.
 - 24 Luria’s letter to Kallen of October 29, 1931, Horace M. Kallen Papers, AJA.
 - 25 For further reading on the issues of the interrelation between science, politics, and power, specifically, for a discussion of the party-state-science hybrid in the Soviet Union see classic studies by Krementsov and Kojevnikov (Kojevnikov, 2004; Krementsov, 1997).
 - 26 Wertheimer’s work on the Phi phenomenon and his novel interpretation of it is usually presented as the beginning of Gestalt psychology, whereas his cultural psychological work on thinking is usually ignored.
 - 27 The nature of the Basmachi movement is very controversial among historians. What matters for our purposes is the very existence of armed resistance from part of the population. For various perspectives, see Haugen, 2003; Pylev, 2007; Zevelev, Poliakov, & Chugunov, 1981.
 - 28 In 1924, on the territory of two states of the Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic (RSFSR), the Kirgiz (Kazakh) Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic (ASSR) and the Turkestan ASSR, and two formally independent states, the Bukhara People’s Soviet Republic (PSR) and Khorezm PSR, two new Soviet (Union) republics were created – Turkmen SSR and Uzbek SSR – and three autonomous republics – Kazakh ASSR, Kirgiz ASSR (within the RSFSR), and Tajik ASSR (within the Uzbek SSR). The latter became a Union republic in 1929 and the former two in 1936. On the process of nation-building and national delimitation in Central Asia, see Haugen (2003).

9 A transnational history of “the beginning of a beautiful friendship”: the birth of the cultural-historical Gestalt psychology of Alexander Luria, Kurt Lewin, Lev Vygotsky, and others

- 1 Furthermore, there is documentary evidence to the effect that in midsummer 1925 Koffka was still in the United States, where he made a number of public presentations: on July 2 at the University of Chicago (paper titled “Philosophical aspects of the Gestalt theory” that was read at the university’s Philosophy Club); on July 16 Koffka delivered another presentation titled “Mental development” (Koffka Archive, AHAP) (Harrower, 1971, pp. 143 & 145).
- 2 Thus, according to a brief announcement titled “Faculty to acquire scholars of renown. Kohler, Ape Expert, to Teach Gestalt Psychology–Ferguson, Morison, and More Will Also Join Teaching Corps” that was published in the *Harvard Crimson* on May 1, 1925, “Professor Wolfgang Kohler, who will join the Department of Psychology, is a figure upon whom the eyes of all students of psychology are turned. At the early age of 38, he has done work of the most brilliant sort in experimental psychology and has been the leader of ‘Gestalt Psychology’, a new and radical development in the field ... He is spending one year in the United States and is at present at Clark University in Worcester.

- During the first half of next [academic] year he will give a seminary in psychology on the subject of ‘Gestalt Psychology’.” See the source online: <http://www.thecrimson.com/article/1925/5/1/faculty-to-acquire-scholars-of-renown/>.
- 3 See the source online: <http://journals.zpid.de/index.php/GdP/article/view/416/451>.
 - 4 Given that Dembo’s research was published in 1931 and that Luria made two foreign trips – in 1925 and in 1929 – one might assume that their acquaintance might have also taken place during Luria’s second visit to Germany. However, it is known that Dembo’s study was conducted in 1925–8 (Dembo, 1931, p. 10; 1976, p. 327), and the first report of Dembo’s studies that Luria published in Russian not only came out before Dembo’s German publication, but also preceded his second trip to Europe (A. R. Luria, 1928). Therefore, the option of Luria’s first personal encounters with Lewin’s students occurring during his trip of 1929 must be dismissed.
 - 5 Gottschaldt’s visit took place not later than the end of 1928. See a fragment of Vygotsky’s letter of December 2, 1928 to Vladimir Vagner, in Leningrad: “I would be delighted to meet you in person and to talk with you. I once had the chance to visit you in Leningrad together with Dr. Gottschaldt from Berlin” (Rückriem, 2009, p. 223; Vygodskaya & Lifanova, 1996, p. 369).
 - 6 From shorthand note of Vygotsky’s lecture on memory read in spring 1932: “Many of you remember Gottschaldt’s report at the Institute of Psychology in Moscow which he followed with a presentation on a special portion of his work” (Vygotsky, 1987, p. 304).
 - 7 The chair of this session on child development was Karl Bühler, and other scheduled presenters, besides Luria and Lewin, were Arnold Gesell, Luton Ackerson, Florence Goodenough, as well as a Japanese researcher, Hoken Kiriara, who apparently did not attend the Congress (Cattell, 1930, p. xxii).
 - 8 From Luria’s letter to Lewin of September 20, 1929, AHAP, written on the letterhead of Clark University (Worcester, MA): “Ich bin jetzt in Clark und fahre morgen nach Harvard. Zwei Tage verbrachte ich bei Koffka in dem Dachzimmer, das Sie gut kennen, und wir machten reizende Ausflüge.”
 - 9 Several letters dated October 11, 12, and 13, 1929 have been preserved in the Luria archive. All these were written during his transatlantic trip to Europe on board SS *Statendam* (E. A. Luria, 1994, pp. 51–55).
 - 10 From Luria’s letter to Eisenstein (the letter was published in Luria’s biography by his daughter, though the date of the letter was not identified): “I am writing to you believing in my luck: I hope this letter will reach you in Berlin. You will get it from my friend – Prof. Lewin from the Institute of Psychology in Berlin. We talked with him a lot here in America, and he got extremely interested in your ‘spiral’; he is specially working on the problem of human movement under the influence of the forces originating from within and from the impact of environment, and he managed to experimentally come up with something that confirms your hypotheses. I am sure that he will be very interesting to you (and you will be interesting to him, too). Ask him to show you those episodes of his films where he captured experimentally induced spiral (!!) movement of a child. I hope I will meet you in Berlin, and am looking forward to this meeting very much. I will be there between October 25 and November 5” (E. A. Luria, 1994, pp. 122–123). Also, from Luria’s letter to Lewin of September 20, 1929: “Ich hoffe Sie ende Oktober in Berlin zu sehen.”
 - 11 Luria’s letter to his wife L.P. Lipchina of September 18, 1933, from Kharkov to Moscow: “... workload is just enormous: (1) lectures, (2) chemistry, (3) Koffka’s galley proofs, (4) administrative and research work” (E. A. Luria, 1994, p. 85).
 - 12 From Luria’s letter to Lewin of November 22, 1929, AHAP: “Ueber die Internationale Film-Assoziation habe ich mit Prof. Schatzki gesprochen. Er ist bereit in dieser Arbeit teil zu nehmen; es wäre aber am besten, wenn der Generalsekretär an ihn persönlich schreiben möchte. Ich bin überzeugt, dass er ausserordentlich interessante Films liefern konnte. ... Ich bekam heute Ihr Schreiben über die Films und werde in nächsten Tagen alles in Ordnung bringen. Ich hoffe Ihnen in der nächsten Zeit das Film über

das Kindliche Zählen und die Aufmerksamkeit zu senden und werde auf den Affen und Hanna film warten. Mein Laboratorium ist jetzt mit dem Kino-Institut verbunden, wir gründen dort ein spezielles Psychol. Laboratorium, mein Assistent hat dort Vorlesungen und Leitung der Doktor-Arbeiten (das heisst: Filme, die als Doktor-Arbeiten für Studenten des Regisseur-Abteilungen bestimmt sind), und wir hoffen jetzt [ein] p[a]r schöne Filme zu machen.”

- 13 From Luria's letter to Lewin of December 12, 1929, AHAP: “Heute bekam ich die Lizenz für die Einführung der 300 Meter Film, die wir austauschen wollen; unser Film über die Entwicklung des Zählens ist teilweise im Druck, teilweise in Montage und ich hoffe es Anfang Februar zu senden. Die Lizenz liegt in Berlin, Russische Handelsvertretung, Kino-Abteilung, bei Marianow; es wäre am besten, wenn Sie ihn anrufen möchten.”
- 14 See, for instance, the letter of October 26, 1935 from Fajans-Glück to Lewin that was mailed from Jerusalem with a return address in Tel-Aviv: “Rehow Schenkin 15” (Lewin Archive, AHAP).
- 15 See Tamara Dembo's letter to Alfred Marrow. In her letter of February 19, 1965 Tamara Dembo wrote in response to Alfred Marrow, who had asked her for any information on the whereabouts of Lewin's students. Dembo suggested that Marrow should contact Sarah Schlossberg (Sliosberg) at her address in Haifa, Israel, and ask her for the addresses of another three of Lewin's students – Wera Mahler, Sara Fajans, and Sara Forer, all four residents of Israel at that time (Kurt Lewin archive, AHAP).
- 16 See *Smith Alumnae Quarterly*, 19, November, 1927: <https://archive.org/stream/smithalumn2728alum#page/n229/mode/2up/search/mintz>.
- 17 In his book, Lewin does not provide the title of Köpke's unpublished work. The title is quoted here from the manuscript that was translated into English and is presently kept at the Archives of the History of American Psychology (AHAP).
- 18 The letter was started June 12, but was finished several days later, on June 16, 1931, so that the following quotation belongs to the second part of this letter.
- 19 Italics added in order to highlight words originally written in Latin characters.
- 20 Full title: Institut po izucheniiu vysshei nervnoi deiatel'nosti pri Sektzii estestvoznaniia Kommunisticheskoi Akademii; later the Institute was reorganized and included in the Vsesoiuznyi Institut Eksperimental'noi Meditsiny (VIEM). For the documentary records of Birenbaum's and Zeigarnik's employment and the range of activities in these institutions see their personal files in the archives of the Russian Academy of Sciences: “Lichnoe delo G.V. Birenbaum, starshego nauchnogo sotrudnika Instituta po izucheniiu vysshei nervnoi deiatel'nosti,” ARAN, f. 350, op. 3, d. 282, ll. 163–168ob; “Lichnoe delo Zeigarnik B.V., nauchnogo sotrudnika Komakademii,” ARAN, f. 350, op. 3, d. 293, ll. 84–86: <http://isaran.ru/?q=ru/fund&ida=1&guid=3EF20DDB-AC73-5D8F-4BFF-BFD74A011357>.
- 21 In the published version of this letter the name of Kaulina was erroneously interpreted and presented as “Kazmina.”
- 22 See the text of the telegram of April 30, 1933, somewhat vague in its meaning, that Lewin sent to Fritz Heider from Moscow to Northampton, MA, USA: “GERTILAZ [sic] IMPOSSIBLE STOP ARE POSSIBILITIES THERE WIRE QUESTION TO BORING LASHLEY TOLMAN OGDEA [sic; recte: Ogden] MACDOUGALL STAY TILL MAY SIXTH WITH VYGOTSKI SERPUCHOVSKAIA 17/1 = LEVIN.”
- 23 See Lewin's letter to his wife Gertrude Lewin from Moscow also dated April 30, 1933; AHAP, Kurt Lewin Papers, Box M2933, Folder 41.
- 24 For instance, this is what Vygotsky wrote in his letter to Luria of June 12–16, 1931: “I am still beset with thousands of petty chores. The fruitlessness of what I do greatly distresses me. My scientific thinking is going off into the realm of fantasy, and I cannot think things through in a realistic way to the end. Nothing is going right: I am doing the wrong things, writing the wrong things, saying the wrong things. A fundamental reorganization is called for – and this time I am going to carry it out. I received a book on Aristotle's and Galileo's thinking in psychology from Lewin. He has an amazing mind” (Vygotsky, 2007, p. 36). In addition, in a letter to Roza Levina that was dated June 16, 1931, Vygotsky elaborated on the news of the new Lewin group's work and his excitement at this research

project: “The last meeting of the laboratory and tomorrow’s meeting are devoted to a discussion with Zeigarnik on studies at the University of Berlin. I received Lewin’s new book on the methodological problem of psychology. Everything I see tells me that something great is happening in (world) psychology before our very eyes. To fail to sense this or to belittle the importance of what is going on in these passionate, tragic attempts to find the pathway to the study of the mind, which lie at the heart of the crisis (e.g., to simply speak of confusion in psychology, to say that it is not a science, etc.) is to take a Philistine view of things and of the history of human thought” (Vygotsky, 2007, pp. 37–38).

- 25 Along with Miasischev, the group included R. I. Meerovich, E. E. Plotnikova, K. M. Kandaratskaya, E. S. Averbukh, V. I. Butorin, and T. Ya. Khvilivitskii, affiliated with the V. M. Bekhterev Institute of the Brain in Leningrad, who conducted their studies on the will, affect, and action in patients with nervous and psychiatric disorders. These studies were carried out in the footsteps of Lewin and his group and closely followed their experimental techniques. These Soviet ‘Lewinian’ papers were mostly published in the mid-1930s.
- 26 The psychological mechanisms of substitution (*Ersatz*) in various forms were investigated in a series of experimental studies by Zeigarnik, Ovsiankina, Birenbaum, Hoppe, Dembo, Mahler, Jucknat, and Fajans. However, the study that best fits Vygotsky’s description is the research project that was realized by Paul Köpke. This study was never published.
- 27 From the conclusion of Lewin’s letter to Luria of June 14, 1936, AHAP: “Dembo ist ganz entzückt über die Arbeiten von Gita und Bluma. Sie wird hier darüber berichten. Man macht viel von Ihrem Test Gebrauch. Herzliche Grüsse und hoffentlich auf Wiedersehen diesen Sommer!”
- 28 From Lewin’s letter to Luria of October 1, 1936, AHAP: “Gruessen Sie bitte Bluma und Gita schoen. Tamara wird bald über ihre psychopathologische Arbeit im Seminar berichten.”
- 29 Luria’s letter to Max Wertheimer of February 20, 1936 (King & Wertheimer, 2005, p. 271).
- 30 Luria’s letter to Lewin of November 15, 1935, AHAP.
- 31 See Lewin’s undated letter written in response to Luria’s letter of November 7, 1935 as well as Kurt Koffka’s reference to his ongoing work on the article for the Vygotsky *Festschrift* that he made in his letter of November 26, 1935 to Molly Harrower, AHAP.
- 32 From Luria’s letter to Lewin of April 4, 1936, AHAP: “Buytendijk, Buhler, Koffka, Gesell, Goldstein haben schon ganz interessante Vorträge zugesandt.”
- 33 Gelb was seriously ill at that time, and died on August 7, 1936. This gives us every reason to believe that his chapter was never actually written, and Luria, therefore, never received his chapter in Moscow.
- 34 From Luria’s letter to Max Wertheimer of February 20, 1936, from Moscow, originally in German, but cited here in the English translation of King and Michael Wertheimer: “Many of our disciplinary colleagues knew him [i.e. Vygotsky] personally and loved him deeply; many of them – [Kurt] Koffka, [Kurt] Lewin, [Karl] Lashley, [Jean] Piaget, and also [Adhémar] Gelb, [Arnold] Gesell, [Karl] Buhler, etc. will contribute to the memorial volume” (King & Wertheimer, 2005, p. 271).
- 35 Wertheimer’s letter of July 16, 1936 to Luria, sent from New York (King & Wertheimer, 2005, p. 275).
- 36 Lewin’s archive contains a fragment of correspondence between Lewin, his secretary Mrs. Butterfield, and an academic library in Kiev (Soviet republic of Ukraine) that sheds some light on the complexities of this unfortunate episode.
- 37 From Luria’s letter of September 7, 1936, AHAP: “Nun endlich habe ich Ihre Arbeit erhalten. Ihre Sekretärin hat das Manuskript mit einer falschen Adresse abgesandt, und zwar nach den Ukrainischen Akademie für Psychoneurologie, und die Sendung spaziert Zwei Monate durch das ganze Land (denn ein Teil der Adresse war in Charkow, der zweite – Frunze 13 – in Moskau).”

- 38 Luria's letter to Lewin of February 20, 1936, AHAP: "Ich habe von Ihnen noch nichts bekommen, aber wir warten mit grossten Spannung auf Ihre Arbeit, die in dem Memorialband einen zentralen Platz haben soll."
- 39 Lewin's *Principles of topological psychology* came out in English in 1936 in the translation by Fritz and Grace Heider. The book was dedicated to the Hebrew University of Jerusalem. The text of the book is available online free of charge as a full book scan at <http://www.archive.org/details/principlesoftopo011804mbp>.
- 40 See also online: http://mhp-journal.ru/rus/Issues/2010_v5_n3_05.
- 41 This is how the idea was formulated in this postcard of January 25, 1936: "Besten Dank und herzliche Grüsse an Herrn Lewin, liebe Tamara, Frl. Ovsiankina! Wir hoffen, dass der nächste topologische Meeting doch in unserem Laboratorium in Moskau stattfinden wird!"
- 42 On the research of the 'Kharkov group' of Luria and Leontiev see Yasnitsky & Ferrari, 2008a, 2008b. See also Chapter 2.
- 43 From Luria's letter to Lewin dated February 20, 1936, AHAP: "Wir arbeiten hier ganz tüchtig, und ich muss sagen, das die Dynamischen Studien von Personality werden hier vom Jahr zu Jahr intensiver. Sehr gute Arbeit über die Pathologie der Spannungen ist von Bluma und Gita durchgeführt, ich hoffe, dass sie beide eine grössere Arbeit über Denken und Affekt [abschließen?]. Der Abfall des Gehirns scheint ein ausgezeichnet geeignetes [= geeignetes] Material zu sein für das Studium der generellen Schicksal der Verhaltensdynamik, und ich hoffe Sie werden Freude haben an der Arbeit der Beiden. Auch Leontiev in Charkow hat eine grosse Reihe Studien ueber die Verhaltens – u. Aktions-strukturen im Kinderalter angefangen. Die Aenderungen der Relationen von Ziel-Motiv-und Taetigkeit steht hier in Vordergrunde. Das alles machte uns möglich einen kleinen Symposium zur dynamischen Studien zu machen, und im Juni wird eine solche kleine Lewin-Konferenz stattfinden (mit Vorträgen: Birenbaum, Zeigarnik, Solovjev, Leontjew und seine Gruppe)."
- 44 From Luria's letter to Lewin of April 4, 1936, AHAP: "Unser Lewin-Symposium wird, wie ich hoffe, im Charkow in Juni sein: dort arbeitet jetzt Leontiev sehr viel mit der Analyse der Struktur der Aktivität der Kinder. Wir werden natürlich Ihnen darüber schreiben."

10 "Lost in translation": talking about sense, meaning, and consciousness

- 1 For a historical precedent for similar use of this expression see, e.g., Bruner & Haste, 1987.

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